

A woman's face is the central focus, looking directly at the viewer with a calm expression. Her hair is replaced by a dense, intricate arrangement of green moss, purple flowers, and various animals. A large, moss-covered lion's head is the centerpiece of the headpiece, flanked by a stag's head with antlers on the left and a smaller animal head on the right. A Venus flytrap is visible near the lion's mouth. The entire composition is set against a dark, lush background of green foliage and purple flowers. Two dragonflies and two butterflies are also present, adding to the fantastical theme.

COLLEEN HOUCK

New York Times Bestselling Author

TERRAFORMER

Deadly toxins can be hidden inside the most beautiful flowers.

Terraformer

By

Colleen Houck

OceanofPDF.com

TERRAFORMER

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A Poison Tree

by William Blake

I was angry with my friend;
I told my wrath, my wrath did end.
I was angry with my foe:
I told it not, my wrath did grow.

And I waterd it in fears,
Night & morning with my tears:
And I sunned it with smiles,
And with soft deceitful wiles.

And it grew both day and night,
Till it bore an apple bright.
And my foe beheld it shine,
And he knew that it was mine.

And into my garden stole.
When the night had veiled the pole;
In the morning glad I see,
My foe outstretchd beneath the tree.

Dedication

For Rob and Shara
Who love science fiction
As much as I do

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Terraformers

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Prologue

Pathogen Detected

I opened my arms and stretched my fingertips, feeling leaves and branches unfurling along my limbs. Looking up, my neck elongated, becoming thick, strong, and pulsing with life. My toes dug into the rich soil and sank down, down, until they drank deeply from underground rivers.

Leaves around me shifted in the breeze like a gown. Flowers erupted in the grassy carpet all around me. A thick limb brushed my shoulder and I looked down and smiled at my brothers and sisters who locked arms with me.

We swayed together in storms, springs, and ice, growing resilient, growing...aware. Spreading our seeds on the wind, we populated the planet, and then others across the cosmos. Branches split off, creating new life forms, but we guided the simple-minded fauna, yoking them to our will. We blew our breath into the night sky and tasted the mineral freshness of space.

Then, many of our younglings went dark.

It was an omen. A portent.

A sign of danger.

Then, we sensed it.

Something was coming. A ship.

Bringing a plague.

Another bringing salvation.

The first one drew close.

I was the leader.

They were my offspring. My responsibility. I couldn't let my loved ones suffer and die.

Stretching farther than I ever had before, I lifted the thinnest of my branches, whipping my canopy fiercely until it penetrated the atmosphere.

Then I took hold of that scourge-filled ship and crushed it between my limbs, hurtling it into the second sun, the red one that gave me strength.

But I was too late.

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Chapter 1

Just Breathe

My body jerked. *Where was I?* A glass dome covered my body. I shifted my arms but they barely moved. Trying again, one arm thumped the side of my metal coffin. *Breathe.* My mouth opened but my lungs wouldn't move. It was my most common nightmare and my worst reality.

Little spots danced across my vision. I blinked through the fog and saw the red light in the corner of the glass and the message that was scrolling across the screen.

STASIS POD WARNING
HYPERBARIC CHAMBER OXYGEN SYSTEMS COMPROMISED
BACKUP SYSTEM FAILURE
ATMOSPHERIC PRESSURE DESTABILIZING
VENTING OUTSIDE AIR
TRIGGERING NEUROMUSCULAR ELECTRICAL STIMULATION

The thick vapor filling the chamber dissipated as it washed over me. It had enrobed me, saturated my skin during hypersleep, giving my body what it needed to survive in transit. But something had gone wrong. Maybe a breach in the containment system.

I heard a series of clicks and a whirring, then precious bursts of vacillating oxygen were pulled in through the vents. Now I was fully alert. The system had done its job in resuscitating me, but I still couldn't move, couldn't breathe. The problem with my respiration wasn't the pod's fault. It was mine. The facts were evident. My own body was failing me, and if I couldn't kickstart my own system, I was going to die.

Alone.

In space.

A tiny shock, the first in a series to reinvigorate my muscles, started my heart pounding faster, making my need to take in air even more desperate. Little pinpricks ran down my spine, warming my limbs enough for me to move my arms. Finally able to move, I pounded on my chest, once, twice, a third time, and then a rush of gas inflated my lungs. My chest muscles relaxed and I exhaled a green fog before taking in a breath of sweet-tasting, recycled air.

Vision clearing and moving less clumsily now that my muscles were waking up, I touched the glass above me, scrolling through the message again, then pressed my palm against the dome.

“Crew member Astra Meador, Stasis Pod 0041—confirm.” My voice sounded husky and I coughed.

YOU ARE CONFIRMED- CREW MEMBER MEADOR.

The computer spoke in a pleasant female voice that sounded a bit too much like my mother, who’d been left behind on Earth.

“How many other pods have failed?” I asked, my voice growing stronger.

YOUR POD IS THE ONLY ONE COMPROMISED AT THIS TIME.

The glass flashed red again.

PATHOGEN DETECTED

WARNING...

PATHOG...

The alert flashed again, flickered, and then went out. I tapped a few buttons and the glass moved aside with a pneumatic hiss. My mother had warned me before we even boarded that my serum might register with the stasis pod as a pathogen, but the green gas quickly dissipated, settling on my skin, drawn to it as if by a magnet.

My mother’s theory was that my body reabsorbed the medicine, the cells of my skin capturing it and feeding on it like a leaf does with sunshine. Her hypothesis wasn’t backed by any evidence other than the fact that my exposed skin seemed revitalized after every dose. The skin scrapings she’d

done showed no similarity to plants whatsoever. I never expected otherwise. But my mom was the best biophysicist in all the worlds, and if she compared everything to plants, that was just par for the course.

I always rolled my eyes when she made plant comparisons to everything, but then laughed when my dad teased her. He'd say her egghead was showing, but he liked the way she combed her hair over it.

The alarm cut off. Even if it hadn't, my mom, prepared as she was for every contingency, had taught me how to bypass the computer system. After all, she'd been the one to create the lists of pathogens the computer regularly searched for anyway. Still, waking as I did, my lungs immobile, hadn't been something we'd prepared for or a possibility we'd discussed.

Luckily for me, my chamber, pod 0041, had been specially modified. It functioned differently than the others, using a special hyperbaric lining, because I *was* different from everybody else. Ironically, my mother's modifications, which were secretly completed before we left Earth, must have triggered a technological breakdown. In essence, we'd somehow blown a fuse.

I swung my legs off the bed and rolled my feet at the ankles before gingerly setting them down on the deck of the ship. Once I felt secure enough, I stood, careful to keep a solid grip on the pod. Nausea swept through me. Clicking a button on the medical cabinet by the exit, I said, "Give me something for a queasy stomach." The light on the cabinet turned blue and a slot opened, pushing out a thin wrapper.

Pinching it between my fingers, I pulled it out, peeled off the paper, and slapped the medicine square on my neck. The chemical did its work quickly and my stomach settled. Heading over to a work station, in the data center of that deck, I lowered myself slowly into a chair and tried to figure out what had gone wrong and, more importantly, how far along we were into our journey to Crillian IV.

The glass rose from the desk, triggered by my presence, and I touched my palm to the table.

"Request computer access, Crewman Astra Meador."

ACCESS GRANTED- CREWMAN MEADOR.

A series of blue rings slipped over my thumb and first two fingers, and I lifted my hand, twitching my fingers to swipe through data until I found the

map detailing our course. We were less than a month away from landing. I let out a long breath, berating myself for holding it in the first place, almost hearing my mother's warning voice reminding me not to. As I sucked in shallow, quick breaths, allowing my sensitive lungs to recover, I wondered what happened.

Now that I wasn't worried about being awake for six months to a year by myself, my thoughts turned to my mother. A quick scan confirmed she'd never boarded the ship and I had no idea why she'd been taken. The terraforming conglomerate security officers pulled her away just as we were preparing to enter hypersleep.

I checked for messages from her on our secret channel and found nothing. Scanning through news files from the last year, I desperately tried to search for anything to indicate what had happened to her. *Is she still being investigated? Living alone in our house? Sick? Back to work? At a conference?* What could possibly be so important that they'd pull the top biophysics expert in the world off a terraforming assignment? Especially one where her family members were all passengers.

That they'd waited until my father and brother had entered hypersleep was telling. They didn't want trouble. If my father had still been awake, none of us would have come, and the terraforming team specialists couldn't have that, could they? *Every person is essential.* That was the slogan they drummed into us during testing over and over again to make sure we did our best.

It took me the better part of three hours and I had to break in to the classified reports to find it, but there it was. My mother had been incarcerated for the duration of our flight with no immediate release in sight. I scanned through the brief report again to make certain I wasn't missing anything.

AINSLEY MEADOR

BIOPHYSICIST

DETAINED AT AMAZONIA PRISON

CHARGES: SMUGGLING CONTRABAND FLORA

SABOTAGING THE SUCCESSFUL TERRAFORMING OF CRILLIAN IV

REMOVED FROM THE SHIP THE VENTURE

The blood drained from my face. My mother was in prison. And it was my fault. My fault. My fault.

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Chapter 2

As Silent as the Grave

The only reason my parents even signed up for the terraforming mission was as a last resort. It was the only way I could live a life unlimited by the sanctions placed on those who were born with less than perfect DNA.

That included very few people. In fact, as far as I knew it was only a couple of radical groups who raised their children off the grid, a population I admittedly knew very little about, and then myself and my brother. Unfortunately, it wasn't possible on Earth to mingle in normal society without absolutely perfect DNA. Not anymore.

Sure, we were given certain liberties as children due to my parents' status, but time was running out. My brother and I were approaching the age when we'd have no choice but to assimilate and my special condition would be discovered. My mom had hoped to find a cure.

Fixing our DNA would have meant staying on Earth. Avoiding prison.

Now she was gone. In prison, anyway.

She wouldn't even have those plants if it weren't for me. The special green medicine made with those plants kept me alive and breathing. I pressed my head in my trembling hands. Then I quickly pushed away from the desk and ran to the locker where my personal things were stored, passing through the large hangar where the rest of the crew slept.

It was eerie seeing rows and rows of pods filled with unmoving bodies. The sounds of my bare feet smacking against the cold metal floors of the various decks echoed down the long corridors, and the hum of life support kicking on when my heat signature registered on the computer was creepy. I felt like I was being followed by some kind of heavy-breathing monster.

When I got to the personal locker storage area and keyed in the code I'd programmed, the drawer popped open. Inside I saw the full box of serum and let out a breath. At least they hadn't checked my personal things. Apparently, they'd been looking for plants, not serum. I had enough to last

me a month. I'd have to make more after that unless the serum my father and brother stored was still on board. Either way, my mom had overprepared as usual. She'd hidden versions of the miracle plant all over the ship in every form, even seeds.

With my most immediate needs met, I sighed, closed the drawer, and headed back to the data center, taking a new route to avoid the inert bodies of the crew. When I sunk down in the chair, I erased my history on the computer, something my mother had trained me to do in my very first lessons. That I hadn't done it before checking my locker showed just how traumatized I felt.

Wiggling my heel back and forth nervously, I bit my thumbnail. *How would I tell my brother and dad that Mom was in prison and it was my fault?* I tapped the chrome desk and set aside that worry, knowing I'd at least have a few weeks to figure that out. To distract myself, I turned my attention to another problem. *Why had I woken early?*

It was a great relief to know that we were less than a month out from the planet. I didn't know what I'd do if we were only the first month into our journey. Crillian IV was a yearlong trip. That I'd awoken with only a few weeks left was so incredibly lucky as to be nearly suspicious.

"Pull up schematics on Stasis Pod 0041," I said.

Once an image of my pod appeared, I used my fingers to narrow in, peeling back the layers of instrumentation, opening the different systems to ascertain the damage.

"All right. Now let's try and figure out where you got your wires crossed, shall we?"

It felt better somehow, talking out loud. It made me feel less alone. It took the better part of a day and a lot of help from the glitchy computer to find it, but I eventually discovered the problem—one of the modifications my mother installed prevented the secondary systems from kicking on.

When I brought up the other forty-nine pods on the ship, I saw they were all running on secondary power except for two—Pod 0001 and 0002, which belonged to those meant to wake first. Those two pods belonged to Thane, who, like me, was one of the strangely and disproportionately high number of young apprentices on the ship, and his father, Seren Tremere.

Seren was the mission leader, so it made sense that his pod would function separately from the group. I supposed that he pulled strings to have

his son's stasis chamber placed alongside his. Whatever had happened to cause the failure, it seemed I was the only one who had been brought out of hypersleep.

Exhausted, I headed to the nearest sleeping chamber, where we'd be assigned bunks in groups after landing on the planet. Eventually, the ship itself would be broken down and turned into the first buildings of a colony. The lab, bunkrooms, the galley, even the command center were designed to come apart in sections that would retain their integrity. It meant that we had to choose our landing site carefully. Once we set down, there would be no turning back. Even the propulsion systems would morph into energy generators. Other ships that would come later were designed differently. They could come and go as necessary, but ours would become a permanent fixture on the landscape.

The next morning, or evening, I wasn't sure we even had mornings and evenings in space, I headed back to the data port. I worked for a half hour or so, then swiped the large glass screen. When it disappeared, a smaller handheld version popped out. I picked up the transparent tablet and kept working, thumbing through files, as I headed to a food station. I was light-headed and I knew food would help ground me after hypersleep.

Positioning myself over the pad on the floor, I said, "Scan." The floor lit up, encasing me in a blue glow. Once the device had read my weight and the nutritional deficiencies in my body, a panel opened. A tray slid out with a large container of water and a dense food bar.

I frowned, picking up the bar and nibbling. It tasted something like chalk mixed with indiscernible dehydrated fruit. I snapped the water bottle onto my belt, humming as I ate, and headed back to the pod bay. "I am so looking forward to the day when the team begins harvesting fresh vegetables and fruits on our new planet. I call the first strawberries," I said to the floor full of pods. Of course, there was no response.

A few hours later, I discovered what happened to cause the power loss. We'd nearly been hit by an asteroid. It had trailed a thick cloud of frozen projectiles in its wake, and now a sticky substance clung to one side of our ship. Cameras zoomed in on it and external arms took a scraping for me to analyze later in the lab. It was a narrow miss. We were lucky.

Just to be certain all was well with the rest of the crew, I decided to check out all the pods, one by one, and run a diagnostic to make sure everything would function properly for the next few weeks. If the

secondary systems failed too, I'd have to make certain the pods woke everyone up or we'd risk losing people. *Every person is essential*, I echoed in my mind. *We can't afford to lose anyone. Anyone except Mom*, a little voice in my mind said.

Swallowing the threatening sob, I clicked another button on the desk.

Mom had always loved gardening. Her fruits and vegetables were the most succulent, the most tender, the most flavorful. So much better than the artificial stuff grown in vats and cut into perfect squares. There was nothing like a real heirloom tomato, fresh off the vine. I loved that each one was lumpy and bumpy in weird ways. The tomato squares were nothing like the heirlooms. The texture and flavor were off. Sometimes, even when they weren't ripe yet, I'd pluck a real tomato and bite into it, not even caring that seeds and juices were running down my chin.

Sipping my water, I scanned through the tablet and decided my dad and brother were going to be the first on my list. I headed toward pod 0042, my brother, and 0043, my father, while scanning through their data on my tablet. Though their pod numbers were subsequent to mine, they were the first on a new row on the opposite end of the chamber.

NASH MEADOR
ADOLESCENT #24
AQUASYSTEMS TRAINEE

DR. HUDSON MEADOR
TEAM LEADER
AQUASYSTEMS SPECIALIST

Reaching my brother first, I pressed my hands against the glass and stared at his face. Hypersleep smoothed his features, making him look even younger than his fifteen years. His hands were folded neatly over his stomach. The pose reminded me of my grandmother after she died. She'd looked just like that before her body had been slid into the cremation furnaces. I shuddered and tapped the glass. "Hello, Nash," I murmured as I checked his vitals.

His nails were smoothed and buffed, which wasn't at all his norm. The doctors ensured we went into our stasis chambers as clean and perfect as newborns. It wouldn't do to carry any bacteria into hypersleep with us. There was always the chance that a certain strain wouldn't sleep and we'd wake to discover half of our bodies had been eaten away by a particularly virulent bug. Mom's descriptions of such things gave me nightmares for an entire month before departure.

I grimaced to think of all the cracks and crevices they'd cleaned on me. Luckily, I'd been asleep when it had happened. My mother had arranged for our good friend, Dr. Jordan, to personally prepare my body. Anyone else would have discovered the little secret I kept next to my breastbone, the serum pump hidden just beneath my skin that Dr. Jordan had installed when I'd been a baby. If it hadn't been for him, I would have been left behind with my physical exam flashing... FAILED.

I swiped at the condensation my breath made on the glass and brought up a picture of our mother on my handheld screen. "So, I've got some bad news, Nash. Mom didn't make it on the ship."

Sinking down on the floor next to the pod, I traced a finger over my mother's picture. It was the personnel shot. The photo taken for the trip. It had her name and stats, but beneath that, it just said, *Removed*. Everyone said I looked more like my mother though I had my father's olive skin tone. She had a slight frame but her arms and legs were strong from squatting over plantings, digging in the soil, and taking cuttings.

My mother was one of the most renowned scientists in all the worlds, but you wouldn't know it to look at her. She did spend a great deal of time in the lab, but she was out among the greenery at every possible opportunity. As a result, her arms were nearly as brown as mine and my dad's.

My brother and I had practically been raised outside in her extensive testing gardens. Never once had we even so much as gone for a walk without her bending over a leaf or plucking a flower, crushing the petals and smelling it before rubbing the oil on her fingertips. She loved her job. My father did too, but it wasn't the same. For her it was a passion. For him it was knowing that he was solving important world problems, providing clean water and the systems to carry it.

I flipped to the next passenger and saw a photo of Nash. He was a year and a half younger than me but he was large for his age. Most people thought I was the younger sibling, if they could even guess we were related. My brown wavy hair was a startling contrast to his blond straight hair. Where I mingled easily with others, he tended to stay aloof, preferring the confines of his room to interacting with people, even his own family.

The only thing we had in common was our green eyes. It was strange, our eyes. In public, when someone commented on it, my mother said it was a genetic trait handed down from a distant great uncle, but at home we

knew our eye color was an abnormality brought on by the drug she took to become pregnant. At least it was an easily overlooked one.

She never told us much about it. All we knew was the drug was a prototype based on one of her own formulas and it was made from a very rare plant discovered on a nearby world. Her formula was never brought to human trials and she quietly set aside her research on it after we were born. I could see how much it pained my parents to speak of it, so I never pressed them for more information, though I was intensely curious, especially since I was specializing in the same work as my mother.

I flipped to the next photo, which should have been my dad, but it was the passenger in pod 0044 instead. Scanning back took me to Nash again.

Pressing my thumb on the pad, I asked, "Who is in pod 0043?"

NO ONE IS CURRENTLY HOUSED IN POD 0043.

I frowned. "Then where is passenger Hudson Meador?"

PASSENGER HUDSON MEADOR IS NOT ON BOARD *THE VENTURE*.

"What do you mean?" I asked in a panicked voice, scrambling to my feet. "Did he never come aboard?" I hurried to pod 0043, but like the computer said, it was empty.

PASSENGER HUDSON MEADOR WAS ABOARD *THE VENTURE*.

Ignoring the computer, I scanned quickly through the pod stats. "No," I whispered, thumbing through the data. "It can't be."

PASSENGER HUDSON MEADOR PERISHED TWO MONTHS INTO THE JOURNEY.

HIS BODY WAS EJECTED INTO SPACE.

"No! No! No!" I slammed my hand against the dome of the empty pod until my hand stung. Fat tears streaked the glass as I slid down to the floor. Pulling my knees to my chest, I sobbed for my father, for my mother, and for myself.

When I was exhausted and lay slouched against Dad's pod, my body numb, I mumbled, "How? How did he die?"

PLEASE REPEAT THE QUESTION.

“How did my father, Hudson Meador, die?” I asked through the fabric of my sleeve.

HUDSON MEADOR PERISHED DUE TO...MALFUNCTION.

“Do you mean the pod malfunctioned?”

POD 0043 DID NOT MALFUNCTION.
HUDSON MEADOR MALFUNCTIONED.

“Bring up visual recording just before time of death.”

CANNOT COMPLY.

“Why not?”

RECORDING...MALFUNCTIONED.

“There seems to be a *lot* of malfunctioning.”

YES.

I threw my tablet across the floor and screamed in pain and rage. Time passed. How long, I didn't know. After scraping my palms against my stinging eyes, I got up, retrieved my tablet, and moved numbly on to the other pods. Whatever mysterious malfunction killed my father might have killed others too. I headed back to 0001 and moved up from there.

The work helped, and through the red fog in my mind, I categorized the information I learned, dimly noting that there were electricians, farmers, doctors, scientists, biologists, civil and mechanical engineers, and even men trained in hunting and weaponry. As I cataloged, I thought it strange again how many of the so-called “experts” were young people. Yes, there were always some children who journeyed with their families, but many of those on board who I would expect to be traveling with parents had no familial ties.

I was familiar with a few of them as we'd met briefly in the orientation, but most of them were strangers to me. And not one of them was as important to me as the one I lost. I corrected myself, *ones* I lost.

Scanning through their dossiers, I checked their stasis chambers and marked them off the list one by one as I went, only noting on a personal level that every person my age had a strange designation—Adolescent twenty-eight, aged sixteen years, or adolescent seventy-two, aged eighteen years.

Why would they need to label us separately from the main group? What difference did our ages make? I wondered if I would be friends with any of them. Or if I would I come to love one of them someday. I would imagine there would be at least a few pairings after a year or two on an isolated planet. That thought led me back to my parents, who were as devoted to one another as any couple I'd ever seen. If I sent a message to my mother, would they even deliver it? At least it was a comfort to know that I had Nash. When he woke, we'd mourn Dad together and try to figure out what to do about Mom.

The back of my throat stung just thinking about it.

At the very back of the ship, I was checking on the last stasis chamber, pod 0300, when a door slid open.

Chapter 3

A Ghost in the Machine

It quickly shut and then shifted back and forth a few times, as if it were broken, the light inside flickering red.

When I palmed the screen on the door, it said...

*STORAGE LOCKER SIX
EMPTY*

Doors were only triggered when sensing a human's body temperature. Perhaps the doors were reacting to my presence. I sighed, adding another item to the lengthening list of malfunctioning things. Curious, I stepped closer, peering inside, and was surprised by what I found. It wasn't empty at all. Behind various panels, coils of wire, dehydrators, farming equipment, and a set of impressive-looking rovers, there was a stasis pod. At first, I thought it was just an extra one, but in the flickering light, I saw that the cover was open and that it had been broken. Shards of glass littered the bed and the floor. Bending down, I picked up a small piece and saw a brownish stain.

"Hello?" I said, staring into the dark recesses of the room, but the chamber was indeed empty. Touching the pod screen, I brought up its data but found nothing except the number—pod 0301. There was no name or stats. If someone had been sleeping in the chamber, I would have been able to bring up the person's heart rate, blood pressure, brain function, and muscle stimulation records.

The door closed as I exited and I made a note of the pod on my screen as well as the faulty door. When I was finished, I sat down at the desk again and recorded a brief video message detailing what had happened and that I was determined to just wait out the time by myself until the others woke. We'd all been trained on what to do in such an emergency.

I played it back to myself and decided I looked like a very haggard passenger indeed. Every emotion inside me had been carved deeply into my face. Never in my life had I felt so wrung out. Misery and grief and fear settled into me in a way that I wasn't sure I'd ever be able to evict.

It wasn't a pleasant thing to be alone on a ship even without all the terrible things that had happened, which was why no one under the age of fifteen was allowed on board. My brother had just made the cut. I wondered if it might be easier to just go to sleep again. All I wanted to do was lose myself in oblivion and forget everything I'd discovered since waking.

The problem was, I had no engineer experience. There was no way to fix my pod myself. Even if I could, I wasn't sure I'd trust my skills enough to risk going back to sleep. No. It was better to just wait it out. *It won't be that bad*, I told myself. *I can survive this*. But as I stared out the window into the blackness of space, I wondered if that was true.

For three days, I did little more than drowse in my bunk and cry. But when I did sleep, strange dreams haunted me. Visions of standing on Crillian IV, the sun on my back, warming me, or whispering voices that told me to scuttle the ship. Those scared me worst of all. Once I'd even found myself waking next to the command panel. I'd been touching buttons but, thankfully, hadn't done anything that wasn't easily fixed.

I slapped a sleeping patch on my neck but for some reason it didn't work. Tired of my dark thoughts and the belated sense of sadness over grieving a parent who'd died ten months before and another who'd been taken away, I finally left my bunk, determined to distract myself. My mother's motto was always that when life got difficult, and you didn't like what you saw in the world around you, the best thing to do was blind yourself with science. I figured I could mourn my father while being busy or mourn while doing nothing, so I might as well work.

Sipping some herbal tea, my dad's favorite blend, I brought up the files of plant samples stored on board. For two days, I catalogued all the species, checking off the inventory, and was pleased to see that my mom's secret seedlings were still on board. They were filed under a fake name no one would ever search for—Astralabe—it was her own personal joke. She named the plant after me, saying I was the celestial body the plant bestowed upon her and my dad.

Then, inevitably, Dad would make some lame and embarrassing comment about Mom having a celestial body and she would say he was

barking up the wrong tree. Then dozens of horrifically bad plant jokes would be traded. I was always mortified when they did this. Strange that now I'd give anything to hear them banter like that just one more time.

Turning my focus back to my work, I pressed on. Once we arrived at the planet, we'd be working round the clock to make it habitable for us, so completing the inventory early would make the job go much faster.

That afternoon, knowing I was getting low on serum, I checked my stores. "Computer, access personal storage, Crewman Astra Meador." When it asked for my keycode, I thumbed it in.

The computer matched my voice print, the light changed from red to green, and my storage locker slid open. Inside, I ruffled through the few things I'd been allowed to bring with me on the trip. Apart from the standard-issue clothing—work boots, thick socks, sweaters, soft, thin tee shirts, cargo pants, coveralls, etc.—we were allowed up to twenty extra personal items, the total weight of which couldn't be more than five kilograms.

Unfortunately for me, my serum took up most of my allotted weight. My parents had also given up some of their personal space to smuggle my serum. Luckily, since we were related, we could access one another's storage units. Mom's assigned locker was empty, but Dad's belongings were still inside his, including my serum vials.

Taking one of Dad's sweaters, I pulled it over my head and lifted out the medicine box. I pressed my thumb to the locked box and it opened. A light fog escaped and a round disk popped out. Tugging down the neckline of my shirt and Dad's gaping sweater, I touched my fingertip to the raised skin on my breastbone. The implant was about the same diameter as a circular slice of lime. The large ring vibrated against my bone, telling me it was time for a refill.

Made from Teflon and silicone, the ring had five small connecting cylinders, each one holding enough serum for two days, longer if the days were good ones. Quickly, I activated the new ring. It glowed green. The same color as my eyes. I pried open the synthetic skin covering the disk and pushed in slightly. The old ring lifted out and I swapped in the new one. I smeared some antibacterial cream around the edges where my real skin connected to the synthetic and then clicked the cover back into place. Once I swiped my chest with a cloth, I set the used ring into a sterilizer.

I traced the outline of the ring in my chest. It wasn't visible to the naked eye, but if someone touched my skin, just there, they could feel it. When we'd done our body scans before hypersleep, my implant had been removed. I'd been asked about the synthetic skin, but that was easy enough to explain away. Most wounds were now repaired with synthetic skin. Some burn victims had large percentages of their skin replaced.

They accepted my answer and I was moved along to processing. When I met up with Dr. Jordan, he handed me a new implant. Since we'd be in hypersleep, I wasn't supposed to need my serum. At least, not a lot of it. That much proved true. After putting away my serum, I took out a necklace my mother had given me. The charm was a tiny bottle and inside was a living seed. She'd said that she'd loved me even when I was that small, that I was the most precious thing in her life, and that I was a miracle.

I don't know if I would call my defective self a miracle, but I was glad that my parents had thought of me that way. After clipping back my hair, I closed the storage lockers, waiting for the light to turn red, indicating that it was locked, and then headed back to the lounge with my tablet. When I passed a dark hall, I heard a clank. It sounded like a tool had been dropped.

"Hello?" I said, heading down the hall. The lights turned on as I went and dimmed when I passed beyond their sensors. "Is someone there?" I said.

A door opened and I stepped inside the galley. Cool air brushed my arms and they erupted in goose bumps. I heard a metallic thump and saw a water bottle wedged beneath a cabinet. "Where did you come from?" I said, picking up the bottle.

Placing the bottle on the sensor pad, I said, "Computer, identify DNA. Who does this bottle belong to?"

WORKING...

DNA ON THE WATER BOTTLE DOES NOT MATCH ANY OF THE CREW
MEMBERS.

"Was it left by any of the workers before we left Earth?" I asked.

WORKING...

THERE IS NO RECORD OF THIS DNA IN OUR SYSTEM.

How strange. I set the bottle in the recycler and was about to turn to leave when another thought occurred to me. “Computer?”

YES, CREWMAN ASTRA MEADOR?

“Is anyone else awake?”

CLARIFY.

“Are all crew members accounted for?”

ALL CREW MEMBERS ARE IN THEIR STASIS PODS EXCEPT ASTRA MEADOR
AND THE DECEASED HUDSON MEADOR.

“Yes, but is there anyone else on board? Is there someone moving about the ship other than me?”

WORKING...

SENSORS ON THE SHIP INDICATE...

MALFUNCTION...

WORKING...

SENSORS INDICATE THERE IS...ISN'T...IS SOMEONE ON BOARD.

“Who is it?” I asked. “The other person on board.”

MALFUNCTION...

THERE ARE TWO HUNDRED AND NINETY-NINE CREWMEN ON BOARD.

MALFUNCTION...

“I know that. I want you to tell me if there is someone else here. Someone who isn't supposed to be on board.”

ALL INDIVIDUALS CURRENTLY RESIDING ON *THE VENTURE* ARE
ACCOUNTED FOR.

“Are you sure? Or are you malfunctioning?”

I AM SURE. I AM MALFUNCTIONING.

I chuckled wryly. “I can see that. Better run a self-diagnostic.”

A COMPLETE DIAGNOSTIC WILL TAKE APPROXIMATELY FIFTY-SIX HOURS.

“Well, it’s not like you need to sleep. Better get to it then.”

YES, CREWMAN MEADOR.

Later, when my eyes were too tired to work, I headed back to the small quarters I’d adopted as my temporary home and dropped wearily down on the bunk, looking forward to the time when the rest of the crew would wake and I could at least be with my brother. I closed my eyes, but sleep had a hard time finding me. Then, when it did, I dreamed the ship was haunted.

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Chapter 4

Spaced Out

I was standing between pod 0001 and 0002 when the system triggered our team leader and his son to wake. Eyes trained on my tablet, I scanned their vitals as the ship slowly roused them from hibernation. Unsurprisingly, the son, Thane, was recovering more quickly. Most younger people did.

The pod emptied of the nourishing vapors and I finally got a good look at our leader's son. I'd read on his file that he was eighteen, a year older than me. His personnel photo showed me a handsome boy with slicked-back brown hair, brown eyes, and a somewhat cocky smile, which I supposed he deserved.

The list of achievements below his name was quite impressive for his age. I bit my lip, imagining all the young people on board were erudite by necessity and, most likely, in peak physical condition as well. As much as my mother had trained with me over the years, I knew I'd never measure up to the others when it came to strenuous physical activity. And if this young man was any indication, I'd be stretching myself mentally as well.

His designation was Adolescent one. I wondered if that just meant he was first in line for hypersleep or if the *one* meant something more—like he was the valedictorian of our class, for example. The young man inside the pod stirred, blinking his brown eyes, and then turned them in my direction. A ghost of a smile played on his lips, like he was waking from a pleasant dream.

I gave him a little wave and a thumbs-up sign through the glass and then turned to check on his father. Behind me, I heard the snick of a retreating dome but didn't turn. The leader of our mission blinked once, twice, and then, unlike his son, his eyes focused on me sharply. There was no dreamlike quality to his gaze. In fact, what I saw was alarm. This man knew I didn't belong there. That he should have been the one to wake first.

A hand touched my shoulder and I turned, giving a tight nod to the son, who was now sitting up, stretching his limbs.

“And who might you be?” the son, Thane, asked. The twist of his lips was a practiced move. One meant to persuade, tantalize, and appeal, but it didn’t reach his eyes. It reminded me of the window models working in the garment districts and cosmetic salons, how they enhanced their stride, the contours of their faces, the shapes of their bodies and struck perfect poses to sell products.

“Astra Meador,” I replied. “My pod malfunctioned and the ship woke me a few weeks ago.”

“Ah, yes,” the team leader said, swinging his legs over the pod bed. “The Meador family. Shame about your mother,” he said, his assessing gaze as sharp as a razor’s edge. “I was told about her...situation right before we were put into hypersleep. We really could have used such a renowned scientist’s assistance, but I suppose we’ll learn to make do. I’m Mission Leader Seren Tremere, and this is my son, Thane.”

Seren stretched out his hand, and when I placed mine in it, he squeezed it. Not so tightly that I would protest, but with enough of a grip for me to feel totally captured. His smile, unlike his son’s, was prunish at first, but then, as he studied me, it widened into something sticky, calculating, and oversweet.

“You must tell me how you kept yourself occupied,” he said, standing and balancing against the bed as he gained his equilibrium.

“Are you nauseous?” I asked, glancing at both men.

Thane nodded and I held out a med patch.

“Would you mind?” Thane asked, craning his neck, his white teeth scraping past his lips again in a too-easy grin.

“Sure.”

I placed the patch on his neck, patting it a bit roughly on purpose, and offered the second to his father, but Seren waved his hand, indicating he’d suffer through it.

“So,” said Seren, “you mentioned a malfunction. What is your report?”

“All the other pods are running on secondary power. There was a glitch that shut down all the main systems.”

“Indeed?” Seren put his hands behind his back, clasping them as he stared down at me over the bridge of his nose. His eyes were a piercing

blue. Icy and cold. Even after just waking from hypersleep, his salt-and-pepper hair was smoothed back, just like his son's had been in his personnel photo. Thane's, on the other hand, looked charmingly mussed. "Then why did *you* wake?" he asked.

"My backup system never kicked on. It seems there was a technical malfunction with my pod. I attempted a repair and I believe it is now in working order, but we were so close to landing, I felt it would be better to simply wait out the hours."

Seren's brows lifted. "I wasn't aware that you possessed the skills of a ship's mechanic."

Shrugging, I said, "I had a lot of time on my hands. The schematics were in the computer."

"I see. It's nice to know we have someone so adaptable. That will come in handy on a mission like this one."

I actually fixed my pod because I knew there would be an investigation. Even if we weren't going to use the pods again, they would want to understand the malfunction to prevent it from happening in the future. So, I removed all the enhancements my mother had arranged to be added to my pod. Once that was done and all the pieces had been recycled, it was a simple tweak to get the pod up and working again.

I'd checked my father's stasis pod too, trying to find out what went wrong. I managed to pull up all the files up until the day before his death, but from that time to the exact moment my father's body was ejected from the ship, they were gone. Irretrievable. In fact, it seemed to me that they'd been erased, though a computer wouldn't do that on its own.

To erase a file, a human had to be present, and I was the only one awake as far as I could tell. I'd scanned the history of our trip, and no one else had risen from hypersleep after launch. Everyone who was supposed to be there was accounted for and sleeping during the time of my father's death. Besides, the computer had said my *father* had malfunctioned, not the pod, though it couldn't tell me why.

On the vid screen it showed exactly twenty-six hours thirty-three seconds were missing. One blip he was there, sleeping peacefully, and the next, his pod was empty. His body expelled. I wondered then if someone had killed him before we even left. It was possible. A knife through a

kidney would do the trick. Cut someone a death blow just after entering hypersleep and it would take weeks to bleed out completely.

It was interesting to me that I never even considered that my father had died of natural causes. I knew some people didn't respond well to hypersleep, and death occurred from time to time, but something felt off. My father was healthy, strong. He'd experienced hypersleep before with no side effects. It didn't make sense that his body would simply fail of its own accord.

No, it was too much of a coincidence that the vid files surrounding his death had been erased. My father had been murdered. But by whom? And why? Until I understood more, I'd have to watch my fellow passengers carefully. With my mother imprisoned and my father killed, the success of the mission was gravely compromised.

"There's something else," I said. "My...my father, Hudson Meador, has died. Ship's records only say he malfunctioned and his body was ejected."

Thane sucked in a breath while his father's face tightened with sympathy. "Oh, my dear. How terrible. That you should wake early and discover this with no one to console you...well...you're a brave young woman. I promise you I will do my best to get to the bottom of this. Obviously, the mission prep team was sorely negligent with our systems. You can be sure I'll be composing a sternly worded report to the terraforming board back home."

"Thank you," I mumbled. My lips formed the words but my entire face felt numb. A sternly worded report? Was that all my father deserved?

"Perhaps, when the others wake, we can arrange a small memorial service?" Thane added as if reading my mind.

"Of course," Seren replied. "A short service won't impact landing preparation too much." He smiled and patted my shoulder. "Now I'm afraid there is a great deal for me to do. Thane, if you could debrief the young lady, I'll get started."

"Yes, sir," Thane said, inclining his head toward his father as he left.

Thane's posture and expression relaxed considerably after his father departed. He turned twinkling eyes on me. "I don't know about you but I'm famished. Care to take a stroll to the galley?"

"Sure."

As we walked, Thane began talking excitedly about the mission and the work he wanted to do. I only half listened. Instead, I was wondering why our illustrious leader didn't seem too upset about losing his top two scientists. It didn't make sense. Then the idea that he wanted our mission to fail popped into my mind, which led to the next disturbing possibility. Maybe it didn't end with Seren. Maybe there was someone on Earth who wanted us to fail.

Time passed quickly and Thane and his father kept me busy. We checked reports, cataloged files, and prepped the ship for the crew's waking. Thane was a pleasant enough companion. He had a winning laugh and a brazen wink. His easy charm and quick wit were sharp and he wielded both like a whip. Sometimes I glanced up, stung at his clever barbs, but then he grinned and cocked an eyebrow as if waiting for my retort.

I wasn't skilled at verbal games, only my parents' cheesy one-liners came to mind easily, but I was a quick study. When I landed a particularly shrewd observation or quip, I'd earn a deferential nod and a slow clap. It made me feel proud, but at the same time, there was a niggling suspicion that he was laughing at me, not with me. In all our conversations as we sat side by side going over inventory lists and crew assignments, I couldn't help but feel I was coming off as banal to his enigmatic. And even when he seemed carefree and happy, his shoulders never relaxed, especially when his father was close.

Even so, it was a welcome change, having a handsome young man as my companion, rather than being left alone with my own thoughts. Inevitably, I drifted to the mystery that was my father's death. When I brought it up to Thane, he acted interested, but then before I realized it, he deftly steered the conversation away from my family. He didn't like it when I was melancholy, much preferring the light banter and teasing instead.

His father left us alone most evenings, and we spent them talking of our studies on Earth or with me asking Thane all about his exploits and adventures around the world. He'd even been off world before. I was jealous.

"But surely with your mother being who she was..." he began.

"My mother was fiercely protective," I explained. "She had trouble getting pregnant in the first place. Once my brother and I were born, she rarely left the planet."

“I suppose she had a difficult time leaving her garden,” he said. “I would, too, if I had such beautiful specimens to gaze upon.”

Thane winked at me and I suddenly knew he wasn't talking about my mom's plants. I'm certain I blushed more furiously than my mom's cherry tomatoes, but Thane just laughed and suggested we play a game of chess again. It was my father's favorite game and we were closely matched. He claimed I only won because my beauty distracted him, and I teased him that he must be looking at himself reflected in the glass of the ship.

I looked forward to our time together, and though I knew he thought highly of himself, he seemed to accept it as a fault and acknowledged it amiably when I pointed it out. Soon I began to consider him a friend.

When it was time for the crew to wake, Seren triggered the system to wake the young people first and assigned me to go with Thane to greet them, one by one. I'm not sure why that was necessary or why they needed to wake in order. I pulled up their records and checked their vitals on my tablet while Thane stood over them, his hair glossed back, a sticky smile on his face that I now knew well.

His voice sounded smooth and caring, but behind the sweet surface layer, there was just a touch of conceit that made me roll my eyes. As he welcomed each young member of the mission, praising their achievements and promising that success would come only with their efforts, he always managed to slip in a tiny undercut, something that, at a glance, seemed innocuous but left those astute enough to recognize it with a slight bitter uncertainty. I was surprised to note that it served to make many of the young people eager to please, which was an interesting side effect.

I raised an eyebrow when we approached my brother Nash's pod, and Thane pursed his lips and shook his head, giving me a wink that said he'd be on his best charming behavior. Before the ship woke Nash, I noticed his sleep was disturbed. There was some unusual activity in his brain, reminiscent of REM sleep. He was dreaming. How strange.

“What do you make of this, Thane?” I said, pointing to the tablet.

“Huh. Well, he can't be dreaming. It's not possible.”

“But the evidence says he is.”

“Evidence doesn't always lead to only one conclusion.”

I bit my lip, remembering my own dreams. Maybe there was something in our DNA, something that made my family susceptible to dreaming while

in hypersleep. I made a mental note to recheck my father's data to see if he'd experienced something similar.

When the system didn't AutoStart, Thane frowned and placed his hand over the pod. "Stimulate wake cycle, authorization Thane Tremere, assistant mission leader."

Assistant mission leader? I didn't realize Thane was second-in-command. I'd assumed he'd woken with his father simply because his father wanted his family with him. The gases inside my brother's pod were pumped out and the tiny stimulation wires lifted out of the bed and embedded in his skin, giving him a shock. His body jerked violently once, twice, and then his eyelids flew open and he began convulsing. Then he went still and his heart rate flatlined.

"Nash!" I shouted. "Thane, help him. Please! I can't lose my brother too."

Thane forced open the dome and began pushing buttons on the inside of the pod. I smoothed back my brother's hair, begging him to breathe as, again and again, the system shocked him. Then, all at once, Nash's eyes opened. He stared straight ahead as he slowly exhaled. It might have been my imagination, but I thought his breath, which condensed on the glass nearby, was slightly tinged green, much like mine was when I received a dose of my medicine.

"Nash?" I said. "Can you hear me?" I leaned close and touched his cheek. His pod smelled strange, but familiar too. It reminded me of my mother's garden compost. It was sweet and rotten at the same time, like a peach that had ripened too much.

His chest rose while mine contracted as I let out a nervous sound of relief. Reaching in, I wrapped my arms around my still-unmoving sibling. "I thought I lost you," I said.

"Give the young man room to breathe," Thane said behind me, touching my shoulder.

I backed away and my brother turned his green eyes, the same shade as mine, in my direction. "I am not lost," Nash said, "but found. And by my dear sister. How fortunate." I frowned. Nash didn't sound like himself. His dear sister? He had never been one for poetic language. I wasn't even his "dear" sister on my birthdays. Maybe whatever had gone wrong on his pod

had affected his brain somehow. Hopefully it would clear up once he had revived completely. “Come, help me up,” he said.

Immediately, I took his hand. When he was sitting up, Thane began his usual welcome, but Nash interrupted him. “Tell me,” he said, taking both my hands in his larger ones. “What is it, Astra? I can see something terrible nibbling the edges of your eyes.”

A part of me broke. “It’s...it’s Mother. And Father.”

Nash nodded. A lock of his white-blond hair slid over one eye. As I explained what happened to our mother, I kept my emotions in check, but the moment I shifted over to our father, the despair was so sharp my eyes burned with tears that blazed hot trails down my cheeks. Nash pulled me close and patted my back gently even though I could feel his shoulders shaking. Despite the fact that I was the older sibling, Nash had always been protective of me. He was the healthier of the two of us, and Mom and Dad had always cautioned him to watch out for me. “You need to stay calm,” he said, voice cracking. “Take some deep breaths.”

I did and got back under control much more quickly than he did. “We have to stick together now,” he said, gripping my shoulders. “Our parents would have wanted that.”

“Yeah.” I nodded and wiped my cheeks.

Nash nodded stiffly and straightened, clearing his throat. “Thane?” I called out.

“The young man moved down the row to wake the next young person.”

“Oh, right,” I said, pleased that Thane left us to our reunion but also disappointed that he didn’t stay to help me through the difficulty of telling my brother about our parents. “So,” I said as Nash stepped around the pod bed, “I’m supposed to be assisting Thane but I’ll go tell him I’m going to spend some time with you instead.”

“No, Astra,” Nash said. “You’re delicate. You don’t need to be going through all the emotional turmoil again. If you don’t mind, I just want some time alone to process all this for a while. Okay?”

“Nash, I can help. You said yourself that we’re in this together.”

“We are. Just...just give me some space, Astra. I’ll meet up with you later.”

“Some space?”

“Yeah. I need to wrap my head around this.”

As he turned to go, I said, “Hey, Nash?”

“Yeah?” he replied, looking back.

“I’m glad you’re here.”

“Me too, sis,” he replied, giving me a wide smile that would have seemed very wrong if it weren’t for his tear-stained face. “I’m glad we’re here too.”

He disappeared before I could ask him what he meant by that.

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Chapter 5

The Lie of the Land

I hurried back to Thane's side, and together we woke the rest of the young people, giving each of them a bunk assignment and instructions to rest, eat, and hydrate. Though there was a wide variety of hair colors and cuts—everything from pink ombre spirals to brunette crewcuts to green bobs shaved on one side—the predominant style was bedhead. They came in all sizes too—tall, short, compact, big, burly, full-figured, and gangling.

We finally finished the last of the teen members of the crew and Thane kept his politically pleasant mask on for every waking except one. The last boy was no more remarkable than anyone else. He had no visible tattoos, piercings, or specially colored hair. His credentials weren't particularly exceptional. In fact, I wouldn't have even noticed him over anyone else except that when the young man, named Jax, woke, Thane's glossy smile faltered. In fact, he looked almost hostile when Jax sat up.

Since Thane didn't go through his usual spiel, I picked up the slack. I held out my hand, helping him sit up, and said, "My name's Astra Meador. We're on schedule with a landing to take place in three days. I see here that you're the engineer's assistant. Brilliant. Glad to have you aboard."

Jax pumped my hand once and smiled, showing a dimple in his right cheek. "Thanks for that, Astra," he said, sliding off the pod bed and running a hand through his dark hair, mussing it even more.

He gave Thane a look, and both boys nodded stiffly to each other, then Thane took my arm while Jax looked down at Thane's hand and frowned. "We'd best get back and report in, Astra," Thane said.

"Right." Turning back to Jax, I said, "The galley's down the corridor to your right. Here's a med patch to help with nausea.

I pressed it into his hand and Jax's fingers folded over mine softly. "Appreciate it."

Giving him a tight smile, I allowed Thane to pull me back to the bridge of the ship.

“Did you know him?” I asked. “There seemed to be some tension between you two.”

“Nothing I can’t handle,” Thane said. “Let’s just say that crewman Jaxson Preston was recruited against my father’s wishes.”

“Is he not qualified?” I asked, thinking that most of the young people were short on experience.

“On the contrary. He’s exceptionally qualified. He’s done quite well, considering.”

“Considering what?”

“Considering his background. His parents were anti-stabbers. Jax is proof that though it’s very rare indeed, sometimes the apple can roll far enough away from the tree to be useful. My father leans toward denunciation when it comes to those types. He considers them the dregs of society, unworthy of our attention. I’m more of an open-minded sort. I’ll let him prove to me that he belongs here.”

If Thane was the open-minded version of his father, then I questioned the success of our mission. I didn’t know much about those who lived off the grid, but now I was curious to find out more. I made a mental note to read up on Mr. Jaxson Preston.

Thane glanced at my face, probably recognizing that I was about to tell him off, and then gave me his quirky grin. “Don’t you worry about him, Astra. He’ll be kept busy. You can be sure about that.”

I gave him a glare and he left before I could get in a word edgewise.

While Thane reported in, I excused myself to check on my brother. He’d agreed to meet me in one of the small recreational areas where I’d often played chess with Thane. Nash had always beaten me at the game and I was surprised when he turned me down when I suggested we play.

“Are you sure?” I teased, wanting a bit of normalcy in an otherwise very abnormal situation.

“I’m sure,” he said.

“Chess just doesn’t seem very important anymore, does it?” I asked.

“I suppose not.”

I clicked the button on the table and the virtual game disappeared. Tucking my leg beneath me, I sat back on the cushions and looked at my

brother. His blond hair was spiked messily. One leg was crossed over the other and his arms were spread out along the back of the couch. He was watching me. His green eyes focused. "How are you feeling?" he asked gently.

"Okay, all things considered."

"And your...situation...is the same?"

"Yes," I said, dragging out the word with a frown. "Why? Did you think space would change something?"

He didn't answer for a moment. Then he asked, "Did anything strange happen when you woke? Did you hear voices?"

"Voices? Yes. Come to think of it. For a while I thought the ship was haunted." I laughed, but then he leaned forward, eyebrows raised.

"Tell me about it," he said with all seriousness.

I shrugged. "There's not much to tell, really. There were some lights going on and off, and there was a rolling water canister." Sighing, I said, "Look, Nash, don't you think we should talk about Mom and Dad? I mean, what are we going to do? We're going to be all alone on this planet."

"We're not alone, Astra. Just get that out of your head right now. We're a family. We're a part of something that can't be broken, no matter what. We'll make a new home and figure out a way to be happy, to fit in. I promise."

Just then our tablets pinged with our new bunk assignments.

I was placed with Delenna, an apprentice biologist, who was a short girl with thin braids all wound up and pinned on top of her head, and Nash was placed with Jax, a fact I was pleased with. I told Nash what Thane had said about Jax, and he assured me that he didn't care one way or another about Jax's past. I was pleased knowing my brother wouldn't treat him with disdain as others on the ship might.

His eyes drifted to the transparent glass and the stars outside the ship. "I can't help but think there's something out there, waiting for me," he said. "There's something I'm headed toward. Something that beckons me. A future." He sighed. "I can't wait to rid myself of the past."

Thinking of our past, and of our parents, I murmured softly, "I just...I just don't want to be a burden on you again. I know it was my fault you were held back from doing all the things you wanted to do on Earth. My

physical limitations are the reason we came on this mission and now you're going to be trapped here with me."

My mom had always been my main caretaker. Not that I needed much taking care of. If an emergency happened, she was always by my side to make sure I got a needed dose of medicine. Now Nash would probably have to take on that role. Would he resent me for that? Most likely. He'd always run ahead of us despite my mom's frequent admonitions to wait for me to catch up.

Since the time he could outrun, outswim, outclimb, and outdistance me, he'd made a point of doing so. I couldn't imagine things would be different on this new world. Now that I didn't have my parents to look out for me, would Nash step up? I'd done fine on my own these last weeks. Maybe I could manage on my own now.

Nash was quiet for a moment. "It's not your fault, Astra. Mom and Dad chose the life they did. Just because they held us back, kept us secret, doesn't mean they didn't love us. Just because I wanted to live my life in the open and take risks doesn't mean I don't love you or wanted to hurt you. I just want a little independence. I'm here for you, Astra. I just want a little freedom to be my own person. Can you give me that?"

"Yes," I said, my eyes filling with tears.

"I need to figure out what I am apart from being a Meador."

"Apart from being a Meador," I echoed.

I guess for me that meant for the first time in my life I was going to have to learn how to live with my disability without a support person on a new planet.

With that, my brother left and I was cast adrift in space.

Alone.

Again.

Delenna was quiet, loved reading, and spent most of her time studying. She loved fresh food as much as I did, and we spoke at length about the Earth dishes we missed the most. Despite her best efforts, there was always one braid that came loose from the others, and I learned that one of her nervous tics was constantly trying to tuck it back in with the others. Though she'd come with her mother, the young people all bunked together. It was nice seeing the families take meals together though, and her mother took

both me and my brother, Nash, under her wing, fussing over us like we were her children.

True to Seren's word, once the crew had wakened, we had a small remembrance ceremony for my father. Only me, Nash, Thane, his father, Delenna, her mother, and Jax, Nash's bunkmate, attended. An investigation was done but nothing more was found than I had discovered for myself. And Seren said that erased records were not that uncommon on long journeys such as ours. I glanced at Nash upon hearing this and he took my hand and squeezed it, something I appreciated.

Before I knew it, landing day was upon us. The crew was excited to finally arrive on our new planet. There was much to be done, and each team met frequently to organize and prepare for the hard months of work ahead. Since Nash and I were on different teams, we didn't see each other as often as I would have preferred, but being busy helped.

Thane invited me to the bridge when we arrived and I got my first look at Crillian IV. The red sun was just setting, the arc kissing the edge of the green planet as the yellow sun rose. "It's beautiful," I said, my eyes scanning the double-ringed planet covered by thick clouds. Peeking through the clouds, I saw green land masses and verdant mountains. I bit my lip. Something was wrong. There shouldn't be that much green.

"So there's abundant vegetation on Crillian IV?" I asked. "I thought the planet was nearly barren."

"Not exactly," Seren said.

Thane gave me a serene smile. "This isn't a typical terraforming world," he explained. "We are here to tame the waters and vegetation, but rest assured, there are no intelligent species to contend with. We will be the sole masters of this new world."

"I see." Turning back to the view on the wallscreen, I let out a breath as we dipped beneath the clouds and I saw the vast forest stretched out across a continent so large the Americas could fit inside it twice and still have room for Australia.

As Seren prepared for landing, I wondered if my mother had known about all the flora we'd be destroying to make room for our own and if she would have gone along with it. There was no question Crillian IV was lovely and a prize of a planet, but this mission wasn't going at all how my parents described it.

Leaning forward, Seren touched a finger to the ion glass desk.

“Attention, all crew,” he said. “Prepare for landing in ten...nine...eight...”

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Chapter 6

Alien Invasion

I was wondering where, exactly, Seren intended to land the ship. Other than the large bodies of water, there was no clearing in sight. Trees larger than our tallest skyscrapers on Earth dominated the land. Then, right when Seren said, “Seven,” he pushed another button, and a missile, one loaded with a biological control agent, detonated right beneath us, raining its deadly toxins down on the forest in a large radius.

My vision went dark and I slumped into a chair. My stomach churned like I was going to be sick. Then something snapped in my mind like a cable had been cut. I blinked and the blurry display focused again.

“There we go,” Seren said. “You see, Thane? It works perfectly.”

Horried, I watched as the gas cloud hit. Huge trees shook and then dissolved before my eyes. The corrosive agent broke down all organic matter it touched within the time span of a few seconds.

“And you’re certain it won’t affect us after we land?” Thane asked his father.

“Absolutely. I was part of the first team to test it out. We just have to wait the designated time. In this case, the chemical agent has a half-life of only one hour. This is vastly improved over the last terraforming mission. They had to orbit the planet for a week.”

Seren’s voice stretched and pulsed, his words became garbled, and my vision blurred. I pressed my palms over my eyes, digging into them as strange echoes of screams filled my mind. My head throbbed, and my limbs shook. This couldn’t be happening. “What...what have you done?” I asked, feeling sick.

Thane turned to me, concern etched on his face. “What is it?” he asked. “You know we needed to clear part of the forest to set up camp.”

“Yes...but so many? Those trees might’ve been thousands of years old.”

At least five square kilometers of vegetation had become oozing puddles that quickly soaked into the soil.

“Don’t worry,” Thane said. “The chemicals won’t damage the soil long-term. We should be able to begin planting within the week. In fact, you’ll be part of the team taking the soil samples.”

“Three, two, one,” Seren finished, and I heard the stabilizers kick on to steady the ship as it touched down.

“Wait!” I said. “I thought we couldn’t land yet.”

“We’re fine as long as we remain in the ship for the time being.”

The door to the bridge slid open and Jax rushed in. “Good, I’ve found you,” he said.

Thane stepped forward. “Only those with clearance or who are specifically invited are allowed on the bridge,” he said.

Jax ignored him. “It’s your brother,” he said. “Something’s wrong. You’d better come with me.”

I rushed out after him. Thane called my name, but I didn’t turn back. Jax took my hand, and together we ran through the corridors until we got to Nash’s bunk. We found him kneeling on the floor, his hands pressed over his ears, rocking back and forth.

“Nash?” I crashed down next to him and put my arm around his back. His blond hair hung down, covering his face. “Nash, what’s wrong? Are you hurt? Did you fall during landing?”

“He didn’t fall,” Jax said. “One moment we were on our bunks, laughing, and the next he groaned, clutched his stomach, and rolled off the bed.”

Squeezing Nash’s shoulder, I wondered if he was suffering from the same thing I had been. I’d gotten over it quickly enough. “Maybe it’s space sickness or a reaction to the planet’s gravity.”

I heard a hoarse whisper. “Al...aliens,” Nash said. “Invaders. Conquerors.”

“That’s no reaction to gravity,” Jax said.

“What are you talking about, Nash?” I asked gently. “Did he hit his head?” I directed the second comment to Jax.

“Not as far as I know.”

Jax leaned down on the other side of Nash. “Come on then,” he said gently. “What do you say we get you back in your bunk? Then Astra can sit

with you while I fetch the doctor.”

He looked over Nash’s head at me and I nodded gratefully. Together we helped my brother back to his bed and he rolled to the side, drawing his knees up to his chest. I put his head on my lap and stroked his hair away from his forehead while Jax headed to the door.

“I’ll be right back,” he said.

“Thank you.”

Jax gave me a shy smile and headed out.

As I waited, I told Nash that we had landed and about how Seren had cleared away a large section of native jungle. I told him there were large bodies of water he’d get to work with and tried to speak with excitement about the tasks that lay before us.

“They used one of Mother’s poisons,” Nash said quietly.

I hadn’t noticed until he spoke that his trembling limbs had gone still. “What do you mean?” I asked.

“There’s a fine line between creation and destruction,” Nash continued. “Mother was adept at both.”

“She never would have condoned the use of that missile,” I said. “She can’t have known this world had a thriving ecosystem.”

“Didn’t she?” Nash said bitterly. “There was a lot our parents never told us.”

I sighed. “You’re just angry that she’s not here. We both know it was my fault. She wouldn’t have had any contraband if it weren’t for me. I don’t blame you for being angry, but direct it at me, not at Mom. She’d be here if she could.”

“It would be better for you to accept the facts. We aren’t going to see Mom again.”

I shook his shoulder. “Don’t say that. We will. It’ll just take a while for her to catch up to us, that’s all.”

Nash rolled away from me and sat up. He looked pale and sweaty. Perhaps he had a fever. “You’re my sister,” he said. “And that’s all I need. Even if they let Mom come here at some future time, we will be different. It will never be the same again, Astra. We’ll never be a family again. Not like we were. It’s time you got used to the idea.”

He got up to leave, only staggering for a few steps, and placed his hand on the doorjamb, resting against it for a moment. “Tell Jax thanks when he

comes back, but I'll be fine. I don't need to see the doctor."

He took a step, the door slid open smoothly, and he was gone.

I drew my legs up and wrapped my arms around them. My baby brother had always been stubborn. Once he fixed an idea in his mind, no argument, no matter how logical, could dissuade him.

The door slid open and Jax entered. "The doctor is coming," he said before stopping midstride and noticing I was alone. "Where's Nash?"

"He left. Nash wouldn't tell me what's wrong. He said to tell you thanks and that he didn't need to see the doctor."

"Oh. Well, then." He touched his palm to a wall panel. "Inform Dr. Zaius his visit with Crewman Meador is cancelled."

YES, ASSISTANT ENGINEER JAXSON PRESTON.

"That's right. Your real name is Jaxson. I read it on the file when we woke you."

"Yep. Is Astra short for anything?"

"No. My parents don't"—I winced—"didn't, believe in nicknames. My mother was always a stickler about using the proper designations for things."

"Ah." He shifted uncomfortably. "Nash told me about your parents. For what it's worth, I'm sorry."

I dropped my head, unsure of what to say. Jax lowered himself to his bunk, opposite of me.

"Can I ask you a question?" he said.

"Go ahead."

"Are you and that Thane guy an item?"

I laughed. "No."

"Really? He seems rather possessive of you."

Shrugging, I said, "I don't think I'm his type regardless."

"I don't think we'll get to be that picky about types on this planet," Jax said. "You might not have noticed, but our dating pool is a little bit small."

"Yeah. I noticed. But to be fair, there are a lot more young people on this mission than usual. I came because I wanted to be with my family. My mother's expectation was that we'd be here between five to seven years,

then we could leave. I wasn't looking to build a lake house and stay, let alone pair off with someone. What about you?"

Jax's face tightened. "I was supposed to come with my uncle but he... didn't pass the testing phase. I wasn't planning to come without him, but when I was accepted, he insisted it was a good opportunity for me, that I'd learn enough to be a team leader someday. I suppose Crillian IV isn't going to be my final destination either. Guess I get to grow up early without a parent, along with you and your brother."

"Guess so." I gave him a smile and he reciprocated. His blue eyes locked on mine and warmed slowly like twin glaciers melting into deep pools that beckoned me to dive in.

"Well, it's nice to finally get to talk with you, Astra."

"You too. I suppose we'd better get busy."

He slid off the bed and offered me his hand. After he helped me up, I headed to the door, turning to wave goodbye, when my smile slid off my face like organic butter off a hot ear of my mother's heirloom blue corn. My lungs seized.

"Astra?" Jax said with a frown and came closer.

Waving a hand, I hurried out the door. When it slid closed behind me, I quickly pressed the button on my breastbone. A puff of green gas inflated my lungs. Slowly, I exhaled, blowing the green cloud away, and watched it drift back to me, settling on my hands. Not a second later, Jax came out and stepped around me, concern etched on his face. I panicked, thinking he'd seen the vapor rising over my head. I coughed into my fist, delicately, and said, "What is it?"

He took hold of my shoulders. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine. Just worried about Nash. Speaking of which, I'd better go find him."

Those blue eyes peered down at me, his gaze tickling my skin, as he tried to discern my secrets. Gently, he patted my shoulder and nodded. "Okay. I'll see you around then, Astra. And don't worry too much about Nash. We all have to see the doctor before disembarking anyway. The doctor will figure out what's wrong with Nash if anything."

Swallowing dryly, I said, "I sincerely hope so. See you then, Jaxson." I tittered nervously and headed away from him. *We all have to see the doctor?* I started breathing quickly and had to force myself to calm down. A

frosty sweat crept down the back of my neck and trickled into the collar of my flight suit. Lifting my hair away, I wound it in a messy bun and fastened it with a slap tie I kept on my wrist.

How am I going to pass a physical exam? I'll be discovered! Nash. I needed my brother to help. Surely, we weren't going to be seen at the same time. I'd simply remove my implant, go through the physical exam, and then meet up with Nash right after and put my implant back in. We'd done it before with no harm done.

The crew members were busy, tending to their various tasks. When I brought up my own assignments on the tablet, I groaned. I'd been so preoccupied with my brother and helping Thane that I'd ignored the summons of my new team leader, the woman replacing my mother as head botanist.

I knew Madlyn McGivers by reputation. She was a contemporary of my mom's, but she tended to research with a rake while my mother preferred more delicate tools, such as tweezers. Dr. McGivers took shortcuts and was often at odds with my mom. It didn't bode well for our future relationship.

As I was perusing my schedule, a new notice appeared. I tapped on the message.

CREWMAN ASTRA MEADOR SCHEDULED PHYSICAL EXAM WITH DR. ZAIUS AT
1300 HOURS.



I clicked accept and swept the appointment into my schedule, where it shifted other things and then settled into place. Next, I pulled up my contacts list. My team members popped up first. I closed that group and clicked on the one that said family members. When I touched my finger to Nash's name, his profile appeared along with a blinking dot that told me he was in the locker area.

After stopping by the galley to grab my nutritional supplement of the day, I headed in that direction, munching on the strange-flavored bar as I

did so and pocketing the second. It was peculiar that the system determined that I needed more calories today than I normally did. I didn't feel hungrier than usual. When I got to the locker area, I nodded to several crew members, but Nash wasn't among them.

Checking my tablet again showed me that he was definitely in the area. "Nash?" I called out as I wandered through the lockers. "Nash, are you in here?"

No one replied. Zooming in on his signal, I searched more carefully and then found his tablet stuck between two lockers. Carefully, I pulled it out and sighed. He'd probably placed it on top of the lockers and knocked it over when he left. "Guess I'll have to look for you later," I said, slipping my brother's tablet into my bag. Meal finished, I headed to the conference room where my team was meeting. I'd be late but hopefully they'd understand since my brother had been sick.

They didn't.

When the door slid open, every eye turned to me. Some frowned, a few gave me small smiles, but the woman standing at the front, pointing at images of the forest on the planet below us, scowled openly and said loudly, "Time?"

THE TIME IS ELEVEN SIXTEEN HOURS, DR. MCGIVERS.

"And what time did our team meeting begin?"

YOUR TEAM MEETING WAS SCHEDULED FOR ELEVEN HUNDRED HOURS.

"And what is the consequence for team members arriving late?" she asked, examining her nails.

I rolled my eyes and crossed my arms over my chest.

TEAM DISCIPLINE IS DETERMINED BY THE TEAM LEADER.

"As it should be. Very well, Miss Meador. You may sit and I will decide your consequence later."

I pulled out a chair and sat heavily.

"And I'd lose the attitude. As far as I'm concerned, you're only here because your mother pulled strings."

I froze for a second, wondering if she knew about my secret, but then I realized she just meant my mom pulled strings to get me on the botany team. Maybe she did. But I was no novice either. I'd been studying alongside the greatest biophysicist in all the worlds. Dr. McGivers had always been jealous of my mother's achievements, and now she had the daughter of her longtime competitor under her thumb. Of course she wanted to beat me down.

Swallowing my pride, I said, "I apologize, Dr. McGivers. My brother collapsed this morning and I had to see to him."

I heard a tsk and a middle-aged woman sitting across from me gave me a smile and a friendly nod. "Welcome to the group," she said. "We're all sorry to hear about your father, and it's a real shame not to have your mother along."

"Her detainment was just a misunderstanding," I said, coming to the defense of my mother.

"Whatever the case," Dr. McGivers said, "Ainsley Meador is not here and there *is* work to be done. Shall we continue?"

The meeting went by quickly, and since I was only an apprentice and late at that, I kept my mouth shut and listened. The team didn't seem at all surprised that there was a vast forest on the planet and seemed to harbor no qualms about eradicating it in favor of our own plants. Finally, I couldn't keep silent any longer and raised my hand.

"But why must we destroy all of it? Surely, we should be taking samples, cataloging the different species. What if we find the cure for the common cold? Or a new edible fruit?"

Dr. McGivers sighed. "Obviously, we will be doing that, but we must pave the way for the settlement first. It appears you are operating under the mistaken assumption that this planet is held in usufruct. It is not. There is no intelligent species here to stake a claim, so we have claimed it for ourselves. This is part of forming a new terra—a habitable world. Now, we have gone past time. Please see to your given assignments, and we will meet again tomorrow on the new planet. Promptly at eleven hundred hours," she added, giving me a stern look.

She offered a serene smile to the rest of the group, saying, "You may leave." I rose with the others but then she said, "Miss Meador, if you will stay behind for a moment?" Her barely there smile had slipped off her face.

I stood, nervously shouldering my bag. “Yes?” I said as she approached.

“The job we have ahead of us is formidable. I expect all the members of my team to give one hundred percent.”

“I understand, Dr. McGivers. I won’t let you down.”

“See that you don’t. Now, according to my records, you woke early and catalogued all the inventory that will be used for our department?”

“I did,” I said, happy that she’d noticed.

“Good. Then, since you’re familiar with the placement of everything, it should go much quicker for you the second time.”

“The second time? I’m afraid I don’t understand.”

“Don’t you? I’m asking you to inventory everything again.”

“But...why?” I stammered.

“Partially to teach you a lesson about arriving late and partially to teach you a lesson about double-checking your work. Your mother taught you the importance of such a thing, I would think.”

“She did,” I said stiffly.

“Then best get to it. I’ll expect a preliminary report tonight.”

“Yes, ma’am,” I replied a bit huffily and headed out the door, my hands twisting the strap of my bag mercilessly. Tears stung the backs of my eyes. I missed my mother. How could I do this without her?

I finally located Nash an hour later and handed him his tablet. “You left this by the lockers,” I said and sank down onto the chair across from him. He was eating lunch, so I pulled out my second nutritional bar and sipped from my thermos to keep him company. “Are you feeling better?” I asked.

“Marginally,” he said.

“Did you see the doctor yet?”

“Just finished.”

“What did he say about your...er...episode this morning?”

Nash rolled his thermos of water between his hands. “He said whatever it was had nothing to do with waking from hypersleep. When I described what happened, he said he believed it was a belated reaction to Father’s death.”

“Really? How strange.”

He pointed to a patch on his neck. “He gave me something to help with the nightmares.”

“Nightmares?” I took his hand. “But, Nash, I’ve been having them too. I hear screams in my head, even when I’m awake.”

“Yeah?”

He seemed interested but he wouldn’t meet my eyes.

“Well, maybe it’s something genetic,” he said. “He’ll probably ask you about them too. I’d suggest keeping quiet if you don’t want to be medicated.”

“What’s the patch supposed to do?” I asked.

“Oh, you know, it gives you a nice little dusting of delirium to cover the acres of distress beneath the surface.”

I glanced down at his tray as he continued to shovel food into his mouth. Not only did he have three nutrition bars but he also had some kind of a vegetable stir-fry with what looked like tofu. As far as I knew, the ship wasn’t programmed for fresh vegetables. “Where did you get that?” I asked, pointing at his lunch jealously.

He shrugged. “The galley must have thought I needed it.”

“Huh. Well, I hope it thinks I need it for dinner. I’m sick of nutrient bars.”

Looking up and seeing my grimace, he sighed and scooped a healthy portion of his stir-fry on my tray. “Here. Consider it an apology for earlier. I’ve been out of sorts lately, but when it comes to my sister, my bark is worse than my bite.”

“Thanks,” I said around a mouthful of tofu. “I owe you one.”

He smirked. “Don’t forget that, big sis.”

Nash agreed to meet me just before my physical. When it was time, I snuck into an alcove near the doctor’s office, gave myself a puff of green gas though I didn’t really feel like I needed it, and then popped the ring out of my chest. I wiped it down and closed the skin, then stood outside the office, nervously palming my precious medicine.

Dr. Zaius opened his door just as Nash ran up. I gave him a look that said he almost didn’t make it and I’d kill him later and handed him my bag and tablet, slipping the medicine ring into the outside pocket. “I’ll wait for you outside, here, sis, then walk you back to your room after your appointment.”

“Sounds good, Nash. We won’t be long, will we, Doctor?” I asked.

“Not at all,” Dr. Zaius replied. “Not at all. Shall we get started, then?”

The doctor was a friendly sort. When he smiled, his puffy cheeks drew up into fleshy mounds large enough to hide oranges. It made his small mouth look even smaller, especially with his round chin. Great. Now I was thinking of juicy, ripe oranges. Even with the accelerated growth serums my mother had developed, it was unlikely I'd be tasting an orange for at least six months.

"Now, if you'd be so kind as to step on the pad," the doctor said.

I did, and the light came on underneath, encompassing my body. It brought up a holographic image of my body that the doctor immediately began to examine.

"Musculature," he said, and the computer peeled away my skin, showing only my muscles. I flinched, not wanting to see such an up-close and personal view of my insides. "Good. Now nervous system."

The muscles peeled back to show my brain. Little lights fired, sending pulses down my spine. This one I didn't mind so much. It was an electric light show. I saw flashing points moving down my arms and legs to my fingertips and toes. He went on, checking my cardiovascular system, and then he spent some time on my bones. He checked through the files cataloging my various blood enzyme and chemistry levels.

Finally, he turned to me. "Everything looks good physically," he said. "You've got a slight trace of muscular deterioration in your legs since you've been awake longer than us on a ship with less gravity than you're used to, but that should stabilize once we're on the planet. Its gravity is just the tiniest bit denser than Earth's. It's likely to make you feel tired at first, so I'm telling everyone to take it easy. On the plus side, there's lots of oxygen due to that forest out there.

I gave the doctor a weak smile. "So, can I go then?"

"Not yet," he said. "Here, take a seat."

Lowering myself into a chair, I crossed one leg and wrapped my hands around my knee. My chest was tickling. If I coughed, I'd need my medicine. It would become very obvious to Dr. Zaius that something was wrong. I swallowed, praying whatever was irritating my nose would stop, and breathed through my mouth instead.

"Your brother mentioned that he's having nightmares. What about you? Anything similar?"

"Not since I've been awake," I said, then winced.

The doctor tilted his head and stroked his bearded cheek. “Do you mean to say you had bad dreams during hypersleep?”

I bit my lip and nodded. “I dreamed I was a tree spreading seeds across the universe.”

“How strange,” he said, and pressed a button on his tablet recording the conversation. “Tell me more.”

After I rehashed the dream to the best of my recollection, the doctor said, “Well, that does seem to be very vivid. I can tell you that dreaming or hallucinations during suspended animation are an impossibility. However, it has been well documented that patients entering hypersleep with some kind of trauma at the forefront of their minds might have what we call a dream capture, an image or series of images that will cycle over and over, skipping and repeating. My guess is that the trauma of seeing your mother taken away caused you to think about her just before going under. These snapshots are likely mental echoes of your work with your mother in her gardens at home.”

“That makes sense, I guess.”

“If it bothers you, I’m happy to offer you a med patch to help. It’s a terrible loss you and your brother have suffered.”

My lungs were now burning. I needed to cough, badly.

“Can...can I think about and let you know?” I rasped.

“Of course.” Dr. Zaius rose. “Come see me again soon, Astra.”

“I will.”

I made it all the way to the door and gripped the handle before I coughed. The moment I did, my lungs seized. Stumbling out, jerkily, I fluttered my hands at my brother, who drew me aside. Quickly, I tugged aside my shirt and opened the flap of skin while Nash dug through the bag.

“I don’t see it!” he said. “Where is the blasted thing?” He shoved aside the few items I carried, tossing my thermos to the ground, where it banged and rolled down the hall. “Finally!” he said. He pressed the ring into my hand, and I touched it to my chest, adjusting it until it clicked into place, and then pressed the trigger. A stream of gas entered my lungs, and I breathed deeply and bent over, recovering.

“Thanks,” I said. When I stood up, I froze, seeing Jax standing behind Nash, clutching my thermos. Nash, his back to Jax, quickly reached out and

slid my artificial skin in place, then nodded as I adjusted my shirt. Together we turned to Jax, pasting what we hoped were innocent smiles on our faces.

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Chapter 7

Nature Abhors a Vacuum

“I...I think you dropped this,” Jax said slowly, offering Nash the thermos.

“Yeah. Thanks,” Nash replied, taking the cylinder. “Well, I’ll catch you later, sis,” Nash said, stowing my thermos in my bag and making a quick exit.

I scowled at his retreating form, mumbling under my breath, “Thanks a lot.”

“You okay?” Jax asked.

“I’m fine,” I sighed. “Just finished my doctor’s appointment.”

“And I assume it went well?” he asked with concern, but then shook his head. “Never mind. It’s none of my business. I shouldn’t have asked.”

“No, it’s fine. Yeah, it went well. Healthy as a horse,” I said, rocking back and forth on my heels. Those blue eyes of his were altogether too discerning.

“Good,” he said. “So...I was going to ask you, umm...” He palmed the back of his neck. “The engineering team is heading outside tonight after dinner to do a preliminary walk to examine the ship and the surrounding area. We’re all assigned a section. I was wondering if you’d like to come with me as I check up on mine. Assuming, of course, that you aren’t otherwise engaged.”

“Oh! I’d love the chance to get off the ship. I’ve been cooped up on it longer than anyone. Do we need to wear suits?”

Jax shook his head. “Nah. The atmosphere is stable. Might get your boots muddy though. This area is a bit tropical. Might have some rain.”

“No problem. So, meet you at...”

“Eighteen hundred at the back hatch by the lockers. Will that work?”

“Yes. Great!” I said, backing away. He smiled, and when I turned, I found myself smiling too. “And Jax?” I called over my shoulder.

“Yeah?”

“Thanks for asking me.”

“Anytime.”

During the next few hours as I worked on inventory, again, I thought about how I’d be stepping out on the surface of a new planet. I wasn’t sure if my enthusiasm was entirely for the planet or if I was also excited about seeing it with Jax. Being around him felt comfortable. It was how I felt when I was with Nash. Like there were no secrets and I could be completely myself. I knew I was just kidding myself, that it wasn’t exactly true. Telling Jax my secret was not at all on my list of things to do, but still, there was a sense of trust when I was with him.

I finished about one third of the inventory and sent Dr. McGivers my preliminary report, then headed to dinner. Nash had a heaping salad and a large glass of what looked like apple juice. My stomach growled and I hurried over to the galley assessment circle, stepping onto the ring. Light shone around my body as the system hummed. A list of deficiencies appeared on a translucent screen. I frowned, thinking I must be working harder than I thought.

The nutrient wave machine dinged, and out slid a plate of the stir-fry vegetables. It was smaller than what Nash had gotten at lunch, but I wasn’t going to complain. Hurrying back to the table, I displayed my dinner proudly, but Nash just grunted and tucked into his salad. My roommate, Delenna, sat next to me with a nutrient bar and a thermos of water.

“Aw! No fair,” she grumbled. “How’d you guys score that meal?”

“Not sure,” I said, chewing blissfully and talking with my mouth full. “Seems we’re vitamin deficient.”

Delenna wrinkled her nose. “Must be a genetic thing then.”

Nash shrugged and downed his juice. “Guess so,” he said as he rose. “Oh, Astra?” he said. “Thane was looking for you. He said it was urgent.”

I frowned. “Wonder what he wants?”

“Don’t know, but he said to find him after dinner.”

“After dinner? But I have a...have a meeting,” I finished lamely.

“Whatever. Just remember who runs this boat.”

“Yeah. I guess,” I said glumly, stirring my veggies while my bunkmate watched jealously. I glanced in her direction, sighed, and slid my tray over to her. “Trade you,” I said.

“Seriously?”

“Yep. Apparently, I’ve got to meet Thane.”

She lifted a forkful of glazed carrots, baby corn, and bok choy to her mouth and chewed with her eyes closed. “Mmm,” she said, dragging out the *m*’s and licking her lips. “So good. But then I guess the idea of meeting Thane means you have an appetite for other things,” she said with a suggestive wink.

I snorted. “Right,” I finished and headed off. If I could meet up with Thane and see what he wanted quickly enough, I’d be just a little late to rendezvous with Jax.

I wasn’t sure if I should send a message to Jax saying that I’d be a bit late. It was possible his invitation wasn’t strictly team approved, and I wanted to go badly enough I didn’t want to risk missing out. Every message on our tablets was monitored. The computer searched for any unsanctioned communications and notified our supervisors, which was why I never messaged Nash unless it was about ship’s business.

Of course, if Dr. McGivers was really wanting to check up on me, she had access to the ship’s onboard cameras and audio feeds, but as long as our work was being done properly, there was no need to police the crewmen on that level. The alerts sent by the computer were typically sufficient, though I wouldn’t put it past my supervisor to give me her special attention.

Bringing up Thane on my tablet, I found he was in his room. I knocked on his door and waited. When it slid open, he was only wearing his flight trousers. The upper portion of his flight suit hung down from his hips and dragged on the floor. He was drying his chest with a towel. Though he’d obviously just showered, his hair was already slicked back and perfectly parted.

He leaned in the doorway, one eyebrow lifted along with the practiced smile. It was like he knew he was attractive and that he was doing me a favor by letting me see his sculpted chest. “Astra,” he said. “Thanks for meeting me.”

“Er...sorry for interrupting your shower.”

“Not at all. Come in.” He offered his hand and I took it as he led me into his room, gesturing I should sit on the empty bunk.

“Don’t you have a roommate?” I asked as I sat.

Thane replied, “Didn’t want one. I like my privacy.”

“Who doesn’t?” I muttered. When he turned, I asked, “What was it you wanted?”

Being alone with Thane in a room wasn’t at all like being with Jax. I felt cornered with Thane, like I was a mouse and he was the cat, toying with me.

He turned to a mirror and combed his already perfect hair. “My father has gotten the results of our mental testing and some of our assignments are being adjusted.”

“Really?” I asked, surprised. “I thought all the test results were tabulated before we left.”

“Most were. Some required further exploration. Because of this, you and I are to be trained together.”

“Trained to do what?”

“Trained to govern the new colony.”

I sucked in a breath. “Does this mean I’ll no longer be on the botany team?”

“You’ll still apprentice with them. After all, a leader should know a little bit about everything.”

“But why me? Surely there are more obvious choices.”

“Not to my father.”

“But isn’t it a waste of time to train me to lead when your father is here?”

“The number one rule you should always remember when considering space travel and colonizing new worlds is”—he came closer and touched the tip of his forefinger to my nose, tapping it to emphasize each word—“always...have...a...backup...plan.” He turned away, tugging up the sleeves of his flight suit. My eyes fixed on the thin trail of dark hair that began in the center of his chest and trailed down to his navel.

“Even so,” I said nervously, “I can’t be the one. My brother and I weren’t planning to stay more than seven years at the most.”

His eyes studied my face. Then he smiled almost to himself and leaned down to slip on his shoes. “Doesn’t matter,” he said. “It won’t hurt to train you, whatever your future plans may be.”

“I suppose that’s true enough,” I said.

“Good.” He stood up. “Then it’s settled. We’ll begin training together tomorrow. I’ll message you the times and work it out with your supervisor.”

Sliding off the bed, I turned to the hatch. “Well, if that’s all...”

Thane stepped toward me until my back hit the door. I realized it wasn’t going to slide open until he unlocked it. He placed a hand on the door, beside my head, and exhaled softly. “That’s all...for now,” he said, and touched a curl of my hair that had slipped out of the messy bun, then he palmed the door lock and I almost stumbled out as it opened with a hiss. He’d turned away already, as if I no longer registered in his mind, and the door closed between us.

I felt winded, like I had just run a mile. Collecting myself, I palmed my tablet and saw it was eighteen nineteen hours. I groaned and moved quickly through the corridors until I stopped at the lockers, wheezing. Before I sought out Jax, hoping that he hadn’t left without me, I took a puff of gas, smoothed back my hair, and fixed a smile on my face.

“Jax?” I called.

After wandering the lockers and not finding him, I headed to the hatch leading outside and found an old-fashioned handwritten note, folded in two with my name on the outside. “Paper?” I said, stroking the rare and precious thing. “Where did he find paper?” Lifting it to my nose, I inhaled. It still had the musty scent of the tree that had long ago been cut down to make it. Flipping it over, I read.

Use your tablet to find me. I’ll be waiting.

Folding it over again, I wondered again where he’d gotten it, let alone a pen. Maybe he’d brought it with him as part of his personal cargo. Whatever the case, the paper was so rare I didn’t dare leave it behind. Instead, I tucked it into my bag and palmed the lock on the door. It opened with a noisy grinding of gears and a ramp extended.

Fresh air surged into the ship. A sultry breeze brushed my arms and face and the warm light of the yellow sun kissed my cheeks. The air smelled amazing, like a combination of jasmine and honeysuckle. But then, I looked at the barren land surrounding the ship and felt shame for what we’d done to the planet. The soil was rich and dark, but not a green thing grew in the place where we’d touched down. We’d destroyed it.

My booted feet sunk into the soil and I shielded my eyes from the setting sun so I could get a good look at the forest. The trees were so tall, the area beneath them was already dark and foreboding with coming night. If I closed my eyes, I could almost hear the leaves whisper to me, accusing me of hurting them. The paper evidence of their Earth cousins' destruction in the pocket of my bag didn't help with my guilt.

Bringing up Jax's position on my tablet, I headed in his direction and found him halfway up the side of the ship. "What on earth are you doing up there?" I asked.

"Took you long enough," he answered as he adjusted a panel. After closing it and stowing a tool on his belt, he stepped off the ladder built into the side of the ship and slid down quickly, cupping the ladder with his hands and feet. When he landed in the dirt beside me, a puff of dust staining the bottom of his flight suit, he clicked on his tablet and the ladder disappeared, the rungs shifting and becoming flush with the ship itself.

"A panel was loose," he explained.

"Ah, well, what else do we have to check?"

"I've already done a diagnostic on my assigned section. Everything else looks to be in order. I thought we might explore a bit of the forest. We can't go too far, but we're allowed to check the perimeter. Come with?" he asked, holding out his hand.

"Absolutely," I replied with a grin and placed my hand in his.

We hiked across the barren section of land, our boots sinking into the dirt. I went slow since the gravity was slightly denser than I was used to and I didn't want to overexert myself and need a puff of serum, at least not in front of Jax. He seemed happy to go at my pace, and when we got to the line of trees, I looked up and up and up and still couldn't see the top.

"They're much larger than I imagined," I said, taking a few photos of the leaves and undergrowth with my tablet. "Look at this!" I said, pointing to a cluster of what looked like phosphorescent mushrooms growing on the side of one of the larger trees.

"Stellar," Jax said and stretched out his fingertips.

"Don't," I said, grabbing his hand and pulling it toward me. "They might be poisonous. We're going to have to carefully catalog everything."

Jax glanced down at our clasped hands and squeezed my fingers. "Okay, tree girl."

“I don’t think tree girl is a flattering designation,” I said, drawing my hand away.

“Right,” he said, rubbing his jaw. “How about botany babe?”

“Cut it out,” I said, grinning and punching his arm lightly.

“Sprout?” he said as we continued walking through the trees.

I grimaced. “Really?”

“Poison Ivy?” He laughed at my expression. “Everyone needs a nickname, Astra. If you won’t choose one, I’ll have to pick one myself.”

Rolling my eyes, I crouched down next to a lovely plant that looked like a cross between a fern and a bearded lily and was about to take a series of pictures when I heard a whispering in the trees. I looked up and stood slowly. “Hello?” I called.

“What is it?” Jax asked, looking around.

“Don’t you hear that?”

“Hear what?”

A strong wind blew through the tops of the trees, causing the large trunks to creak and sway. The leaves rustled, and the whispering grew louder, the voices cutting through the wind like sharp, stabbing scissors. Whatever or whoever they were, they were angry. Murderous. I spun in a circle, trying to pinpoint where the voices were coming from. Gooseflesh peppered my arms and legs. I could feel it through the thick fabric of my flight suit.

The ground rumbled, and I grabbed on to Jax’s hand. “Something’s happening,” I warned.

“We’d better head back to the ship,” Jax said.

I nodded and followed him through the underbrush. Just as we emerged from the forest, my boot got tangled up in a root. Jax bent to help me dislodge it and both of us felt the ground move. Gravity shifted. The loose strands of my hair lifted along with my body. Jax rose in the air and I grabbed tightly to his hands as I screamed, “What’s happening?”

Behind him the soil of the land we’d just cleared started floating up and away. I saw crewmen’s bodies, Jax’s team members, tumbling in the sky. Men were shouting, wondering how gravity had suddenly disappeared. For a few seconds, everything hung suspended, the air full and expectant, then the sky opened its hungry mouth.

A funnel of powerful wind sucked the screaming men up, up, and away. All the loose dirt around the ship whipped upward in a violent torrent, and the ship itself rocked back and forth. Panels ripped off the sides and warning lights pulsed. We should have been able to hear the alarms, even from where we were, but no sound penetrated the clearing.

Jax's leg extended out, away from the tree line. His boot and sock were sucked clean off his foot. Screaming, I tugged him closer and he wrapped his arms around me. We held on to each other as tightly as we could. Roots held both of my boots now and I was grateful for my clumsiness. If not for tripping in the roots, we would have both been sucked away into the whirlwind along with the poor engineering team working on the outside of the ship.

I glanced beneath Jax's floating body and saw the ship deploy the anchors. Rods shot deep into the rock now exposed around the clearing. It was just in time, too, as the ship was being dragged back into space. Slowly, the anchors drew the ship back down, and it settled onto the ground, damaged but secure.

Suddenly the trees around us sighed, the wind dropped off, and the storm was over. My ears popped, and the Klaxon warning alarms of the ship were loud enough to be heard for quite a distance. Leaves and dirt scattered around the clearing, which now resembled a rocky crag with little to no useable soil. The ground was so uneven and destroyed that I knew we wouldn't be able to build a settlement there, let alone grow anything.

Jax dropped on top of me and both of us crashed to the ground. I began wheezing violently and my lungs seized. Jax scrambled away.

"Astra? Astra, did I hurt you? Are you okay? What can I do?"

I pointed down to my feet, hoping he'd take some time to free them from the roots while I pressed the button on my breastbone. Just as the gas filled my lungs, he looked up.

"Your feet are free," he said. "Does your ankle hurt?"

My lungs were bursting. I needed to exhale. So, I wrenched my body to the side like I was going to be sick and let the green gas trickle from my lungs. I coughed and Jax put his hand on my back. "Take deep breaths," he said, rubbing in little circles.

If he noticed the green cloud rising around me, he didn't say anything. Maybe he couldn't see clearly anyway, now that dusk had fallen. I hoped

that was the case. Breathing more easily now, I turned back to him and obliged him by rotating my ankles and bending my knees.

“Nothing’s broken,” I said. “Though keeping you anchored to the ground might have made me grow a few inches,” I added, wincing at my sore biceps.

“About that,” he said. “Thanks. I owe you my life.”

“You’d have done the same,” I replied, shrugging it off and looking for the roots that tripped me in the first place. They were gone.

“What do you think that was?” I asked. “A freak storm?”

Jax stood up and reached for me. “A storm that just happened to hit the spot where we landed?” he asked. “A storm the computer didn’t give us any warning about?”

“Yeah.” We both stood there, looking at the exposed rock. “Jax?” I asked after a minute.

“Hmm?” he said.

“What happened to the soil?”

“That’s not the right question,” he said.

“Then what’s the right question?”

“What happened to the bodies?”

I turned to look at Jax but his face was angled up to the darkening sky above us. It couldn’t be what he was implying. Had they been sucked up into...into space? Was that even possible? I’d never heard of such a thing, not on any planet. Then another thought occurred to me. Was it a natural phenomenon or was it a weapon? And if it was a weapon, then who was wielding it? I licked my lips, sober at the thought.

We stood there for several minutes, not knowing if it was safe to go back. Then we heard a stomping in the brush behind us. Jax’s tablet was gone but I looked around and found mine wedged between a plant and a thick tree root. The person called out and we replied, “We’re over here!”

Jax thought it might be one of the men caught in the storm, but I knew it wasn’t. Even without glancing down at my tablet to see who was outside with us, I already knew who it was—Nash. He shouted my name loudly enough that we could clearly hear it.

“Astra?”

As he made his way toward us, I grabbed Jax’s hand and pulled him along the edge of the clearing. The route was much more treacherous now

with shelves of rock at various levels instead of thick, rich soil. Nash rushed out through the brush to meet us, giving his roommate the once-over when he got close enough.

Nash wrapped his arms around me and hugged me tightly. "I thought I lost you," he said.

"You nearly did," I replied. "What happened? Why are you outside?"

Nash shrugged, said, "It doesn't matter now that I know you're safe," then he stepped between Jax and me, angling me behind him.

Something was going on. My brother was hiding something from me. Perhaps he just felt uncomfortable telling me what it was around Jax.

"You brought my sister outside," Nash said matter-of-factly.

"I did," Jax replied.

"My sister is fragile," Nash said. "I'll thank you to leave her out of anything that could even have a remote possibility of danger."

I was shocked, and my mouth fell open. I didn't even know where to begin to protest. How dare Nash act the part of my protector when he'd basically left me on my own and then hint at the fact that something was wrong with me? He knew better than that. "Nash!" I began.

Jax held up a hand. "No, Astra. He's right. I wasn't thinking of the danger." The corner of his mouth twisted up in a sad smile. "I was only thinking of how I could get to know you better without everyone else on the ship watching."

I felt my cheeks turn pink. Then Jax said to my brother, "You should know that she's not at all fragile. In fact, she saved my life. If it weren't for your sister, I'd be dead right now."

"Yes, well, let's get you back inside, sis." Nash scanned the trees with his green eyes that were so like mine. "I'm not sure we're ready to spend the night in the forest just yet."

Shivering at the thought, I followed Nash and Jax back to the ship. When we finally boarded, we found Thane standing just inside the hatch, waiting for us. "Are you all right?" Thane asked, looking directly at me.

"I'm fine," I said. "Thanks for checking on me."

"I'll always be checking on you," Thane said. "You can count on that." He nodded to Nash and glared at Jax. "Your team will have to be restructured," he said to Jax. "I wouldn't count on indulging in a lot of free time in the future," he said. "Especially where Astra is concerned."

Jax looked at me and then gave Thane a tight nod.

“I’ll escort you back to your room,” Thane said softly, taking my arm.

“I’d prefer to escort myself, thank you,” I replied, pulling away from him.

“As you wish,” he said, his jaw tight. “I’ll see you bright and early in the morning, then,” he finished.

I glanced behind me as I left and saw the three young men conversing as Thane closed the hatch for the night. Over the sound of their voices came the same susurrations I’d heard before in the trees. When the hatch sealed shut, the whispers abruptly stopped. The sudden silence frightened me and I glanced back often, feeling like I was being watched.

Chapter 8

A Total Eclipse of the Heart

My sleep wasn't sound, to say the least. When I wasn't tossing and turning, I was dreaming about trees with grasping roots and clutching branches. After I woke, I showered quickly since the water recycler was now working nonstop and water was scarce. With nearly three hundred people showering and drinking, we'd be in serious conservation mode until my brother and his team set up an aquasystem for the new colony. They'd be hard-pressed to get it done on schedule without my dad.

I swallowed the sob that came every time I thought of my dad, and not for the first time, I wondered if he'd been aware that he was dying. I hated the idea that he might have felt alone. More than anything, I wanted to solve the mystery of his death, but nobody on board seemed to be as concerned about it as I was. Not even Nash. Every time I brought it up, he just said it was time for us to move on and embrace our new home.

The problem was, I didn't consider Crillian IV my new home, not even with my brother near. Home was my parents. Maybe I'd never have a home again. It was a morose thought and one I dismissed quickly. Mom was still alive, and if she wasn't on the next ship, then I'd figure out a way to get back to her, even if it meant an abrupt end to my future career.

As the computer counted down the seconds for my rinse cycle, I scrubbed quickly, trying not to step on the suction tube that roared beneath my feet. It pulled the water away from the glass and my body, leaving my skin pocked with goose bumps. It was definitely an incentive to hurry through a shower.

I'd been lucky to have the onboard recycler all to myself while everyone else was in hypersleep. It was a luxurious option, being able to turn off the suction until after I was finished. Now that everyone else was awake, the computer turned it on immediately so not a drop of water would be wasted, and if your water was cut off before you rinsed, then your options were to

either use your drinking water rations or walk around all day with shampoo in your hair and soap scratching your skin beneath your flight suit.

I understood the purpose of the water rationing, but it was still sad that my not-long-but-long-enough hot showers would now be a thing of the past. Too bad I'd taken them for granted then. Just like I'd taken time with my parents for granted.

Sliding open the purifying bin, I blinked at the puff of steam that rose from the upper drawer. I pulled out my freshly cleaned and repaired flight suit. I'd programed it to color my suit blue, but it wasn't quite the shade I'd had in mind. Still, the warmth of the fabric and the scent of freshness was welcome. My boots were in the bottom drawer, stored upside down so they could be cleaned of the mud and debris from being outside.

When I was dressed, I pushed the button indicating the bin should send the detritus from my clothes cleaning to be analyzed by the ship's computer. We'd be cataloguing everything about our new planet, from spores and pollen picked up outside to types of soil and leaves. It couldn't hurt to get a head start. Though sending my samples to the computer would send a red flag to my supervisor, telling her that I'd been outside, I thought more could be gained from discovery than I'd lose in privileges. Besides, we had a lot more to worry about than a young crew member sneaking off with a boy, especially since that boy was one of only a few remaining engineers.

It turned out there was more for me to lose than I thought. The moment I powered on my tablet, my supervisor's voice echoed in my room.

YOU HAVE A MESSAGE FROM DR. MADLYN MCGIVERS.

A red box flashed, not allowing me to access anything else until I acknowledged it.

PRIORITY ATTENTION VIDEO FROM
DR. MCGIVERS TO CREWMAN ASTRA MEADOR.
UNLOCK TO PLAY.

Sighing, I said, "Crewman Astra Meador. Play video."

VOICEPRINT IDENTIFIED. VIDEO UNLOCKED. RUNNING...

The video began and Dr. McGivers's eyes pierced me as well on video as they did in person. "Miss Meador," she began. Her voice spat my name crisply, like forming my name with her lips was something she found detestable. "I have been made to understand that your priorities have been shifted. Be that as it may, I fully expect you to pull your weight in our department, and I have been given autonomy to use any of your free hours as I see fit. As such, you will spend the afternoon continuing to catalog the succulents section of our inventory. I'll expect a full report at sixteen hundred hours. And I want that report in person. I've heard about your illicit excursion outdoors and there are some things I wish to discuss."

When the video ended, the computer beeped, offering me two options.



Acknowledge
& Accept

Watch
Again

I clicked the acknowledge button, though I really didn't want to, and shook my head, wishing that my mom was in charge instead of Dr. McGivers. Finally, my tablet unlocked and I was able to access my schedule. After the new appointment with my supervisor was added, I noticed I was to meet with Thane and his father, Seren Tremere, for the first session of a daily training in less than ten minutes.

Once I arrived at the bridge, I hesitated only long enough to take a puff of green medicine and to calm my breathing, then I palmed the access screen and heard the computer say, "You may enter, Crewman Meador."

The door swept open and I headed inside, my newly washed boots squeaking on the floor.

Seren stood with a satisfied smile. "There you are, my dear. We've been waiting."

Thane nodded and indicated the seat next to him. As I sank into it, ignoring Thane, Mission Leader Tremere took one opposite of us. When he touched his desk, a translucent panel emerged and he began pulling up files. "I thought you'd like to see the results of your testing," he said, slipping his

fingertips into access rings and quickly swiping through documents at speeds too fast for me to follow.

“Excuse me, sir,” I began. “Shouldn’t our training take a back seat for now? I assume you have a lot on your plate, what with figuring out the cause of the violent storm yesterday that killed several crewmen.”

“Yes, that,” Seren said, his eyes still trained on the computer. “It is of no consequence.”

“No consequence?” I glanced at Thane and his face was impassive. The only indication he heard me was a raised eyebrow.

“Correct. It will delay our progress a bit, but these things happen.”

“Yes, I would agree with you if this was a typical storm. But how do you account for the fact that the computer didn’t predict it? That it targeted only the area around our ship?”

“I believe you are mistaken, Miss Meador. The storm targeted much more than our ship. Content yourself that I am on top of such things and steps have been taken to prevent such squalls in the future.” There was a pause and then an “Ah, here it is. Take a look for yourself.”

He angled the screen to show me my marks on the mental testing.

“As you can see, indicated by this section and then this one farther down, your brain is firing on a level that is simply astonishing. Of course, I expected nothing less, seeing as you are the daughter of two renowned scientists. How marvelous that you were schooled by both of them.”

I glanced at the screen and saw that my numbers were indeed high, but I didn’t feel any more intelligent than the people around me. In fact, I’d always believed that Nash was the brighter of the two of us. Gripping my chair, I said, “What about Nash? Were his numbers equally high?”

“Nash is your brother?” Seren asked. When I nodded, he brought up Nash’s scores. “Oh, he did well enough. Certainly well enough to be admitted on board, but you are something of a rarity. These tests, you see, do not simply measure basic knowledge, they measure potential. And you’ve got it in spades. This is why I’ve paired you up with Thane.”

“Father,” Thane hissed.

Seren waved a hand. “Paired you up to take these leadership courses,” he amended. “Shall we begin?”

“This is as good a time as any,” I said, wondering to myself if Nash purposely tested lower than he normally did or if my parents had tampered

with his scores somehow. When my parents administered his tests, they were always shocked at how high his results were. In fact, they often tested us together and my scores, though very good, could never match his. Nash almost never had to study, either, while I spent hours cramming for exams. His exceptional skills both mentally and physically were one of the reasons he resented being held back by my parents.

But both of them knew that if Nash had taken standard testing, his genetics would've come under question and they would have been sanctioned. Their work would have been called into question and both Nash's and my opportunities would have been even more limited than they'd already been. I'd done the best I could when it came to testing for the terraforming mission, trying to compensate for my slightly-less-than-average physical exams. I made a mental note to ask Nash about it later. Perhaps he knew, perhaps he didn't. It was entirely possible my mother tampered with our applications. Whatever the case, Thane and Seren believed I was exceptional enough to warrant their attention. I couldn't disappoint them.

"Excellent," Seren said. "Computer, give Thane and Astra access to the main computer systems, levels B through Z. All ship's resources will be at their command. Authorization Seren Tremere, mission leader."

My eyes bulged. "All ship's resources? Do you mean I can program the water recycler and select my own meals?"

Seren laughed. "Yes. Of course, you might not want to take advantage of your new status when the other crew members are around. It might cause them to ask too many questions. But when you are alone in your cabin, feel free to shut off the suction tube of the recycler. You can even request new flight suits if you wish. I trust the two of you to be frugal with our resources."

"Th...thank you." I paused a moment and then said, "But I would prefer to only use the same resources the other crew members have. With the exception of the computer access, that is. I suppose we'll need access to all the files there."

"I'll do the same, Father," Thane said after giving me a long look.

"Very well. The two of you will still have access should you change your minds or need something specific. If you have questions, ask Thane.

He's had this access since our arrival, so he knows how to get around the systems and make everything appear fair and equitable."

"Right." I glanced at Thane, who gave me a strange sort of smile.

He leaned closer and murmured, "You do keep me on my toes, Astra Meador, don't you?"

I didn't know what to say to that and his father began talking so I didn't have to respond.

"We'll start off with some lessons I've preprogrammed followed by practical assignments. The first of these should take around three hours. I'll follow up with you tomorrow on your progress."

"Sounds good," I replied.

Seren stood to leave. "Oh, and Thane?"

"Yes?"

"Why don't the two of you make use of my personal galley here on the bridge? Make a lunch date of it. I'd love for the future colony leaders to feel...comfortable working together."

Thane turned to me. "Is your lunch hour free?"

I shrugged. "Why not?" My mind was suddenly caught up in the possibilities. Maybe they'd have strawberries or peaches. Mouth practically watering, I didn't even notice when Seren left. Then I remembered my new resolve to eat like the crewmen. Sometimes sacrifice sucked.

Taking over the computer, Thane pulled it to face us and slid his fingers into the rings. "Begin lesson one," he said, and as he twitched his fingers, a man's voice began speaking.

MARS. THE FIRST OFF-WORLD COLONY.

A series of videos and photos appeared as the man narrated the rise and fall of the Mars colony. Every few minutes or so, we were asked to answer certain questions or research further to find the answers. I was shocked that there was much more to the history than was shared with most citizens.

As students we were taught that the failure on Mars was due to the problems with early oxygen processors, but here, the evidence pointed clearly to sabotage. "Is this true?" I asked Thane.

"It's true. Most of what my father has given us access to has been classified over the centuries. I'm sure you understand that this information

can't leave the bridge." When I nodded, he went on. "Explosives were placed near the synthetic supports of the Mars dome. When the dome cracked, everyone died."

The images of the dome interior with giant picture screens showing a false sky flickered and then all the oxygen was sucked out.

"Bodies floated inside the dome for weeks," Thane said as we watched the classified video.

The graphic images made the people look like broken dolls. It reminded me of the storm Jax and I had barely survived and the bodies of his teammates floating in air. My hands shook. "It's horrible," I mumbled.

"It is. If this video had been released to the general public, it's likely that colonizing missions would have been set back for decades."

His fingers flicked, and we began the second part of the lesson, watching the colony based on Europa, one of Jupiter's moons, being taken down with particle beams from space. We were then challenged to discover who was responsible. Thane worked on the desk computer while I used my tablet. I quickly scanned through the potential suspects.

Thane swiftly came up with a terrorist organization on Earth, one opposed to space colonization. Though it wasn't the answer taught in school, it still seemed too easy a conclusion. The group he targeted was vocal, but they had no monetary backers. My fingers danced in the air near the screen, moving faster and faster. Thane suggested the possibility of another group and I instantly dismissed it. The motive wasn't there. That group protested peacefully for religious purposes.

Where is it? I thought. *It has to be here somewhere. I just need a clue.*

Then, my screen flickered and turned green. Frowning, I checked the power source and saw Thane's computer was still running normally. A moment later, my screen cleared, but it was on a new page. Scrolling through the list of businesses that now appeared, I drew up specs on a small company that had proposed not a colony but an operation to harvest the ice on Europa. Doing so using their method would have made the moon completely uninhabitable.

The proposal was immediately shot down and no one gave the powerless company a second thought, but something didn't sit right. I checked further into it and found the group had been immediately dissolved by its parent company, a very large organization called the Interplanetary

Water Works Association, also known as IWWA, which just happened to be the one that my father worked for.

Accessing my father's records using his company password, I went back three hundred years into the IWWA archives and found encrypted files. I stopped there, knowing this went beyond my abilities. Sucking in a breath, I was about to tell Thane what I'd discovered when I heard a humming in my mind. The hairs on the back of my neck and my arms stood up. My heart beat once, twice, then my fingers twitched involuntarily. I blinked and then the numbers faded before my eyes. The answer was suddenly clear. I knew how to break through the encryption.

The complicated coding melted away, and I found the long-hidden documents that proved who was the real culprit behind the Europa colony's destruction. I also discovered records describing how the ice was harvested from the moon gradually enough so as to not raise suspicion. Alarmed, I glanced at Thane to see if he'd been watching my progress, but he was as immersed in his research as I'd been.

"What did you find?" I asked him.

"All my research points to this terrorist group."

"Mine too," I answered quickly, waving my hand to turn off my screen. "Shall we knock off for the day and have lunch?"

"Sure. What'll it be?" he asked, fingers hovering over the wall screen.

"Let's see," I sighed. "Nutrient bar one or two." Lifting my arms over my head, I stretched and then squeaked when I smelled strawberries and teriyaki. He set down a tray. "What happened to eating like the rest of the crew?" I accused.

He shrugged, sat next to me, and lifted a forkful of teriyaki chicken and veggies to my mouth, blowing on it lightly so I felt his breath kiss my cheeks. "I figure we're still conserving if we share."

With his eyebrows raised, he waited, his mouth lifted in a teasing smile. It did smell good. Resolve melting, I took a bite. It wasn't that I was leery of sharing germs with him—we'd been inoculated to protect us from everything from pink eye to bronchitis to solar fever—it was more the way he watched my mouth as I ate. His glance was almost tangible, and I wanted to slap it away or at least distract him so he couldn't pin me in place with his eyes any longer. Sharing that meal was the most intimate thing I'd

ever done with another person, and I felt like we'd now crossed a line that meant we were somehow now just a bit more than friends.

When lunch was over, I picked up my tablet, scanning my schedule, and groaned when I saw the one free hour I had was now filled with testing soil samples. Waving goodbye to Thane, I headed out the door to begin my busy afternoon. Unfortunately, the hours flew by too quickly, and soon it was time for the meeting with my supervisor. Palming her office door, I heard the chime echo on the other side. "Come in," I heard her voice say. The door slid open.

"You wanted to speak with me, Dr. McGivers?" I asked.

Setting her tablet down on her desk, she slipped off her access rings and gestured to a chair. "How was your training this morning?" she asked.

"Enlightening," I replied.

Drumming her fingers on the table, she stared me down, like she was silently challenging me to speak further on the subject. I didn't bow to the pressure except to glance down at my flight suit and brush off some lint.

"Have you finished working on the soil samples?" she finally asked.

"Nearly. I expect it will take me another half hour or so."

"Very good. I'll add that on to the end of your day."

I couldn't control my expression and she gave me a testy look.

"Fine," I said, grudgingly, thinking if I hurried through dinner, I might be able to finish it then. My bunkmate, Delenna, would be spending the evening hours with her parents, and I wanted to spend some more time investigating the files I'd found that morning. I also wanted to go over my father's death again and my mother's arrest. Now that I had nearly complete access to the ship's files, I thought I might be able to discover more than I was able to before.

"Anything else?" I asked.

Her eyes narrowed. "Surely you aren't forgetting your unauthorized trip outdoors."

"Right. I apologize for that. One of the engineers invited me to tag along as he inspected the ship. I'm sure you understand how difficult it was for me to be trapped inside alone while the rest of you were in hypersleep. I didn't see any harm in getting a tiny bit of fresh air."

"You're lucky you weren't harmed," she said. "Many engineers perished in that sudden storm."

“I know. I saw it.”

“Saw it? How?” she asked, leaning forward.

“I was at the tree line, exploring the forest when the storm hit. If my boot hadn’t caught under a root, I’d be dead right now.”

“I see. And the young man who invited you outside?” she asked.

“He made it.”

“Good. Captain Tremere stopped by today to remind me that every person on this ship is crucial to our mission’s success, especially you young people.”

That’s strange, I thought. When I spoke with him about the incident, his response was, “These things happen.” Instead of voicing my thoughts, I said, “I never told you he was one of the younger crewmen.”

The corner of her mouth lifted condescendingly and I squirmed under her gaze.

“You are operating under the misassumption that I am unaware of your actions,” she said. “Suffice it to say, there will be no more unsanctioned excursions outdoors. Am I making myself clear, Crewman Meador?”

“Perfectly,” I answered. My fingers tightened on the edge of my chair.

“Now, as to the samples you sent in from your boots, the results are waiting to be analyzed. Consider that your priority for tomorrow. After Captain Tremere has finished with you, that is.”

“Yes, Doctor.”

“Very good. It’s unfortunate that we lost the soil surrounding the ship. It was full of nutrients we could have used to get a jump start on the new crops.”

“You mean the nutrients we created from destroying the forest?”

“It’s better to use the soil than have the organic matter go to waste, don’t you think?”

I folded my arms. “I’m not sure you really want to know what I think.”

She frowned. “Unfortunately, with the soil gone, we’re going to have to detonate another bomb to create more viable ground so we can plant crops. You’ll be helping the team scout out the best location near the clearing.”

“Isn’t that dangerous?”

“Not as long as we remain inside the ship. You *are* aware that I helped created the weapon they used.”

“I am. And I’m also aware that my mother was against the use of such weapons.”

She laughed wryly. “You are your mother’s daughter, aren’t you, Astra? If you’re not careful and don’t learn when or how to temper your attitude, you may end up in the same place as your mother.”

“Was it you?” I asked quietly.

“Me, what? Are you insinuating that I am responsible for your mother’s incarceration? Surely you’ll recall that I was already in hypersleep when she was taken.” She leaned over the desk. “I empathize with your situation, Crewman Meador. I, too, forged my own success without the aid of parents. If I’m hard on you, rest assure that it’s no harder than my superiors have been on me.”

I ground my teeth, angry with her and with my situation, digging around inside of me, looking to put down roots.

“You may go now,” she said.

Shifting, I tried to stand but my fingers appeared to be stuck to the chair with a gummy substance. I pulled and strings of the stuff snapped away. When I rubbed my fingers together, studying it, the gum melted away like water droplets.

“Is something the matter?” Dr. McGivers asked.

“Umm, no,” I said, rubbing my fingertips on my sleeve before picking up my tablet. “Just something sticky on the chair. Do you have a tissue?”

She pressed a button on the dispenser near her desk and said, “Towelette please.” The compartment slid open and she removed a small stack of cloth handkerchiefs—one wet and two dry. Taking the top one, I scrubbed the moisture from my hands and tossed it back into the open-mouthed dispenser. It caught on the edge, preventing the system from closing.

“Just get on with it,” Dr. McGivers said impatiently as she nudged the cloth back in so the fabric would be sanitized and refreshed.

“I’ll send you my report tonight,” I promised.

“Fine, fine,” she answered distractedly.

Nodding briskly, I left and breathed a sigh of relief when the door slid closed behind me. *I really don’t like that woman*, I thought. Tomorrow they were going to detonate a second weapon and destroy even more of the forest. It wasn’t right. Somebody should do something to stop her. Mom

would have. Unfortunately, I wasn't as brave as Ainsley Meador. Sighing, I headed to my next task.

Between Dr. McGivers and Captain Tremere, I was kept so busy that I not only didn't have any free time to spend studying on my own but I barely saw Nash, and a full week went by before my path crossed with Jax again.

"Hi," Jax said, leaning next to my locker just as I was pulling out a new serum ring.

Quickly, I palmed it, closed my locker, and stood with a smile. "Hi," I replied, my breathing just a bit too swift.

"So, I was wondering if you wanted to get a bite to eat together?" he said. "I know nutrient bars aren't as exciting as a walk outdoors, but I hope to provide some stimulating conversation to make up for it."

He brushed back his hair nervously, and I wanted to take a step closer and close the distance between us. My breathing quickened and I recognized a telltale tiny wheezing in my lungs. "I'd love to," I said. "I already ate lunch though. Dinner?"

"I've got a late shift. I'll be working through dinner. Do you have a free hour tomorrow morning?"

"No. I've got training with Thane."

"Oh. I see."

A veil went down over his eyes, cutting off the warmth and leaving me cold. I touched his arm, my fingers brushing the sleeve of his flight suit. "Let me look through my schedule and I'll find a free hour somewhere."

Jax took my hand and scraped the pad of his thumb across my knuckles. "I hope so," he said as he squeezed me fingers and let me go. "I'll see you when I see you, Astra."

Turning, Jax strode away and I watched him go, ignoring the hitch in my breath. Hurrying to my bunk, I closed the door behind me and quickly changed out the medicine ring in my chest. I took a puff of air, and though my breathing steadied, my heart still fluttered. As I went about the rest of my day, I kept rubbing my fingers over my knuckles where Jax had touched me and smiled when I thought about him. Even when my supervisor sent me a video message asking for another meeting at six hundred, my inner happiness wasn't dimmed.

At least not until my tablet woke me from a nightmare. It was five thirty and I'd dreamed of running through the forest with something chasing me.

My feet sunk in the mud as I ran, and finally I collapsed, unable to breathe. Sitting up, I took a puff of green-tinged air, got dressed, and headed to Dr. McGivers's office, where I found her slumped over her desk, dead.

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Chapter 9

Hitch Your Wagon to a Star

I stood there, shocked, staring at her open, unblinking eyes. Finally, I was able to move. “Doctor?” I said softly, nudging her shoulder. Her arm fell heavily from the desk and swung limply. Not knowing what else to do, I sent an urgent summons to Thane. His reply popped up immediately.

“Be right there.”

When he entered the room, I was still standing in the same spot, frozen. He took my arm and pulled me back, away from Dr. McGivers. From a distance I heard him talking with his father through his com link, and when he was done, he wrapped me in his arms and stroked my back.

“Are you okay to wait here with me until my father arrives, or do you want me to walk you back to your room?”

“I...I can wait,” I said, pressing my forehead against his chest so I wouldn’t have to see anything. “There’s no blood,” I mumbled.

“No. It’s probably something subtle. Something the doctor missed after the hypersleep checkups.”

Mission Leader Tremere arrived with the doctor following close on his heels. The doctor studied his tablet as he passed over Dr. McGivers’s body. I turned my head and saw the in-depth scan. It showed her stilled heart. He swiped through after confirming her death and layers of tissue and skin pulled back and away, recording everything down to surface cell damage. Once done, he mumbled to himself as he perused the data. Finally, he looked up. “Let me just scan the room as well,” he said, and began taking images of the room and the body from different angles.

“This is a rather unfortunate turn of events,” Seren said to his son quietly so as not to disturb the doctor as he worked. “Perhaps it would be best if you and Astra skipped your lessons today and spent some time... er...comforting one another instead.”

I lifted my head, looking at Thane. “Did you know her well?” I asked.

Thane's eyes were locked on his father. He seemed irritated. "No," he replied, only then glancing at me. "I didn't. But my father's right, we should take some time this morning. Your department will be in chaos anyway as we shuffle around the staff and select a new team leader."

Numbly, I nodded.

"She'll be our first Crillian IV burial," I heard Seren say to the doctor. He seemed almost pleased with the notion. "Perhaps we can gather a few native flowers to put on her grave. Won't that be a nice distraction?" he asked, glancing at me with eyebrows raised.

"I guess," I replied.

"I trust you can handle such an assignment?" he asked Thane.

When Thane nodded stiffly, his father seemed satisfied that all was as it should be and prepared to leave.

"Wait," I said, grabbing the sleeve of his flight suit to stop him. "What killed her?"

The doctor lifted his head. "You mean *who* killed her."

I gasped. "You mean she was murdered?"

He shrugged. "I'll need to give it some further study, but all the signs point to poison—a variety I've never come across before. It's possible the toxin was native to this planet and someone inadvertently tracked it aboard."

After slipping on a pair of gloves, he shifted the body so her head turned to the other side. There on her cheek was an obvious handprint—the flesh raised and puckered with droplets of a sticky yellow secretion that slowly oozed out.

"I believe this was the point of entry," the doctor said, gesturing to the handprint. "I'll quarantine the room," he said to Seren, "and then I'll give you my report as soon as possible. Until we look at the room recordings, we won't know if this was malicious or accidental."

"Very good, Doctor," Seren said. "I believe the two of you should leave the doctor to his work. In the meantime, I have another funeral to plan."

Thane took my hand and guided me out of the office. The door slid shut behind us, leaving the doctor with the dead body. After Seren headed off, I told Thane I'd like some time to myself, and he walked me back to my room. When he left, I collapsed onto my bed and sunk my head into my hands. Only then did I remember something I'd failed to process before.

There'd been muddy boot prints on the floor in Dr. McGivers's office.

Reaching for my tablet, I used my special access to open the video logs. Just like with my father, there was a large chunk of data missing. The video went to static between 0423 hours and 0440 hours. I studied the video before and after her death carefully and noted a few interesting things.

She'd been sitting at her desk working on her computer. Her hair was in its tidy bun and she was already dressed for the day. Dr. McGivers appeared to be reading a message on her computer. She frowned and then her mouth fell open and she pressed a hand against her cheek, just where the doctor had found the handprint.

In the after video, the chair across from her had been pulled out. There were indeed muddy boot prints on the floor, and her computer had been swept aside. It had crashed to the floor. The fact that she was still sitting meant that she hadn't risen to face her attacker, which led me to believe it was an unexpected assault.

Next, I scanned through all the personnel data. Only around ten percent of the crew was up and about during the time of her death. I told the computer to compile a list of names, and then I read through them, noting those who might have had contact with Dr. McGivers. Among the names were Thane, his father, Seren, and Nash. When I got to the end of the list, I was surprised to see Jax's name at the bottom. He wasn't in his bunk asleep at the time of the doctor's murder either.

Thinking through what I'd learned, I paced my room, wringing my hands as I did so. My palms were sweaty and my heart was racing. My breath hitched and I touched my fingers to my breastbone, releasing a hit of medicine. After I felt more stable, I messaged Jax and asked if we could meet for breakfast. He agreed and I headed out.

Once we both had our morning water and food allotment, I told him I'd been given permission to look for flowers. I knew I was supposed to meet Thane for such an excursion, but I thought doing so with Jax might give me a chance to ask him some questions. When he asked why, I pulled him down an empty corridor. With no one to overhear us, I took his arm and explained what had happened while we walked, searching his face for any sign that he knew about the death of my supervisor.

"Wow, Astra, that...that's crazy. I just saw her late last night," he admitted.

I bit my lip. “Really? Why? What time?” I demanded.

He scraped a hand through his hair. “I don’t know, around 0200 or 0300.”

“What were you doing up so late?” I asked. “And why would you meet with her? She wasn’t a part of your department.” My voice sounded high and accusatory but I couldn’t help it.

“I was working the late shift, remember? I was getting ready to head to my bunk when you messaged me.”

“Right, but you don’t work with her directly.”

“No, but she asked me to consult with her on building a greenhouse. She wanted to baby her seedlings before planting.”

“Oh. I see. And she would need an engineer for that.”

“Not really. A greenhouse isn’t that complicated a build, but I told her I’d help her come up with something.” He paused. “It’s just so crazy to think she’s gone.”

“Yeah. Crazy,” I muttered. “So, do you need to catch some sleep or can you head out with me to gather some flowers?”

Jax gave me a quizzical look. “I can go for a few hours. I haven’t been sleeping well recently anyway.”

We headed down through the locker section side by side. I carried myself stiffly. My strides were long. My booted feet came down too hard on the ramp and I jostled it. Jax caught my arm. “Careful there,” he warned. “The ramp still needs some work after the storm nearly tore the ship from the ground.”

“Right. Sorry,” I said. “So, have you been outside since the...”

“Since the storm?” he finished. “Yeah. We had to do a lot of reinforcing. Our team had to add three new anchors just in case something like that happened again.”

“Huh.” That would explain the muddy boots in Dr. McGivers’s office. Not knowing what else to say, I sipped my water and ate my nutrient bar, wishing for the rehydrated peach oatmeal I’d had the day before with Thane.

“Are you okay?” Jax asked as we strode ahead in silence. “I know the death of your supervisor must weigh on you, but I didn’t think the two of you got along.”

“What makes you say that?” I asked abruptly.

He shrugged. “Just a feeling, I guess. She seemed rather demanding and a bit hard on you.”

I frowned. “Have you been checking up on me?”

Jax stopped. “I’ll admit, I looked up your schedule and saw how full it was. You weren’t lying when you said you had no time for me. I wouldn’t do that normally. Checking up on a girl like that feels like a breach of privacy and we have little enough of it on the ship as it is. I just...I’m just interested in you and wanted to know if you felt the same or if you were trying to spare my feelings. I apologize and I promise not to spy on you again.”

Guilt filled me. If anyone should feel bad about spying, it was me. I’d done much worse than just look up a schedule. I’d used my access to track Jax as well as several other people. In fact, Thane and I had even been given an assignment to spy on the different teams to see who was working the most effectively. Even when we weren’t working on that project, I often used the ship’s cameras to check up on Jax.

What I’d done was so, so much worse than what Jax did. Seeing the sincerity on his face twisted my insides. Something was wrong with me. Terribly wrong. I saw duplicity and conspiracies everywhere I looked. I rationalized that it was probably all the leadership training I’d been assigned during the week. It was Seren’s fault. Thane and I were constantly searching for strategies and ways to become successful no matter the cost. It was making me too hard, and I realized I was becoming the kind of person I didn’t want to be.

Offering him a smile, I apologized and told him it had just been a hard week. He offered his hand good-naturedly and we stepped past the clearing and into the trees. The moment we entered the shade of the forest, my breathing, which I was constantly aware of, seemed to lighten to the point where I couldn’t feel any pressure at all. I inhaled deeply and closed my eyes, feeling the air moving easily in and out of my lungs.

It was such an amazing thing that I was surprised I hadn’t noticed it earlier. I suppose it was my proximity to Jax the first time around that prevented me from recognizing the gift of easy breathing. The abundance of trees and absence of pollutants in the atmosphere allowed me to breathe in a way that everyone else took for granted every day.

The clouds overhead moved as slow as grazing cows, content to nibble on the tops of the giant fir trees. Lacy, purple-gray lichen trailed from the long tree limbs, swaying like the ghostly veils of forsaken brides. I wondered if they were parasitic plants that slowly leached the nutrients from the host tree until it died. I took a sample and tucked it into a zippered pocket. The wind blew one toward me and it touched my cheek.

Quickly, I drew back, thinking of the unknown poison that had killed my supervisor. Jax stopped to watch as I held up my tablet to study the lichen. "It's not toxic," I murmured with relief.

"It does seem to like you though," he said, pointing to another tendril that had wrapped around my wrist.

I removed it carefully and let it go, rubbing my wrist afterward. There was a tingling sensation where it touched me, and my blood hummed beneath the skin. "Strange," I said, placing my hand on the tree. I could almost sense the same pulsing in the trunk that had been in my wrist. "I think the lichen helps the tree. Perhaps the relationship between them is symbiotic."

Jax waited patiently while I took a few notes and then we moved on. I caught a scent on the breeze. "Let's go this way," I said.

It didn't take long to find a flower. The perfume was so strong I was shocked when Jax said he smelled nothing, at least not until we got close to the blossom. Though it smelled lovely, I knew the lone blossom couldn't possibly be responsible for the heavy perfume in the air. We pressed on, and when we came to a large tree that looked almost like a *Salix babylonica*, also known as a weeping willow, he held back a branch thick with leaves so I could pass beneath it. The leaves curled up when he touched it, reminding me of the *Mimosa pudica* plant, commonly called the touch-me-not plant on Earth.

He asked if it was dangerous and I shook my head. "I doubt it. The Earth version isn't. Then again, the Earth version is a creeping plant, not a tree."

"If you ask me, all the trees here have a certain creep factor."

I laughed. "That's just because you're not used to them yet. I'll bet there are thousands of botanical discoveries to be made just in this part of the forest alone."

“Maybe like that one?” he asked, pointing through the tunnel of foliage he held back.

Peeking through the thick brush, I gasped. Ahead was a clearing full of knee-high growth topped with lovely purple and white flowers. They looked like a cross between a rose and an orchid, and the fragrance was more powerful than either. Jax went to pluck one and I held up a hand. “Let me scan them first.”

It only took a moment for me to catalog them and add them to our Crillian IV database. After checking through and comparing with Earth flowers, I felt fairly confident the flower was safe. “Go ahead,” I said. “Just watch out for thorns.”

After taking a pocketknife from his flight suit, he quickly sawed through the stem and then held it out to me. “Lovely,” I said, lowering my nose to the petals. “Have you ever smelled anything like it?” I asked.

“Can’t say I have,” Jax answered with a soft smile. “Smells a bit like...”

“Like strawberries,” I filled in. “Chocolate-dipped strawberries.”

I took pictures while Jax gathered a large bouquet. “So, what will you call them?” he asked.

“Call them?” I lifted my head. The red and yellow suns bathed Jax in their combined light, turning his brown hair into a halo. He strode toward me through the field, his sculpted lips turned up into the sweetest of smiles. The air around us was dotted with gold, and I noticed he had a gilded streak staining his cheek. When he drew near, I lifted my hand to wipe it away with my thumb. The gold stuck to the pad of my thumb, and I rubbed my fingers, only ending up transferring the powder to all of them.

“Pollen,” I said.

Jax tucked a flower in my hair. “I figure you get to name them since you were the one to discover them.”

“Technically, you discovered them,” I said, my eyes locked on his face. He was standing close, so close I could feel the warmth of his body. His scent mingled with the flowers and I found myself even more intoxicated than before. This was more than sharing lunch with Thane. This was... more.

The world seemed to slow down, and I felt everything keenly—the way the breeze lifted my hair to kiss my heated neck, how his fingertips brushed my temple as he adjusted the flower, the feel of moisture on my lips as I

licked them. The flower in my hair shifted and I reached for it at the same time he did. Our fingertips brushed against each other and the sensation was overwhelming. He took hold of my hand, rubbed his thumb over the sensitive skin of my palm, and twined his fingers through mine.

My breath caught, but not in an urgent way. I didn't need medicine. I needed...Jax. He brought my hand to his mouth and kissed my fingers, then my palm, then my wrist. His lips were soft, but his breath was moist and hot. "That feels...that feels amazing," I said.

"It does," he replied as he drew me closer, sliding his hand up my arm to my neck. His fingers wound through my hair, slowly working out the tangles as he removed the loosened hair tie and adjusted the flower. Once it was down, he drew closer as if to smell the flower, but buried his nose in my hair instead. "So much better," he said, lifting his head. "I'd rather smell you than the flowers any day."

"The flowers?" I mumbled dizzily and stumbled.

"Are you okay?" he asked, laughing as he took hold of my arms and helped steady me.

I blinked languidly. "Yes, I think so," I said, enjoying the warmth of the sun on my body and Jax's nearness.

Biting my lip, I wondered how it would feel to be wrapped in his embrace, for him to tilt my face up for a kiss. Then it happened. He pulled me close and touched my cheek. I closed my eyes, relishing the sensation. Then his lips were on mine, teasing my mouth with kisses as soft as a butterfly's wings. His hands ran slowly down my back, trailing along my spine.

I was the one who deepened the kiss, wrapping my arms around his neck and cursing the fact that we were both wearing flight suits. More than anything I wanted to touch his bare skin. My own body felt feverish, confined by the heavy fabric.

"Jax?" I said breathily, my eyes closed.

"Hmm?" he replied, as he grazed my temple with his lips.

"More."

He chuckled, then his mouth was on my earlobe. I'd wanted to know what that felt like, and as if he could read my mind, it happened. He was kissing my ear and working his way down my neck when I said drowsily, "Pollen."

Lifting his head, he said, "That's a strange thing to think about when I'm kissing you. Then again, I suppose the birds and the bees fits in this scenario."

"No. I think...I think it's the flowers. They're causing a reaction."

He laughed, narrowing the distance again and cupping my face. "I don't need flowers to react to you, Astra," he said, stroking my cheekbones.

"No, I'm serious. I think they have some kind of aphrodisiac quality. Here, let me scan you," I said, picking up my tablet from where I let it fall among the flowers.

When I turned back to him, the yolk of the yellow sun framed his baffled face. He folded his arms across his chest. "You're not scanning me, Astra."

"But why not?" I asked distractedly, scraping some of the golden pollen into a sample tube and tucking it into a pocket along with the others.

"Because there are some things in life you shouldn't try to explain away with science."

"But everything can be explained with science," I argued.

"Not everything."

"Really? Name one thing."

"Fine. Love."

"Love," I scoffed.

"Yes, love. It's intangible. It can't be explained."

"There are some who would argue that it can be."

"And are you one of those?" he challenged.

"I..." Not knowing how to respond, I bent down to gather the fallen flowers and was dismayed to see the petals were withering already. They'd be dead by the time we got them back to the ship for the funeral. "I don't know," I answered softly, tossing the flowers aside. "I've never been in love before."

"What about your parents and your brother?" he asked. "Don't you love them?"

"Of course," I answered. "But we're a family unit. Like a pack. We care for and protect one another."

"And there's nothing more to it than that?"

I reached for the necklace I always wore, the one with the seed frozen inside that represented my mother's love for me. She was a woman of science and yet I knew she loved me. I'd seen how close my parents were and knew there was an indefinable something that existed between them, but I wasn't ready to admit that those feelings existed between me and Jax.

"Look," I said. "Whatever just happened between us was likely a chemical reaction to this flower and nothing else. I'd appreciate it if you didn't mention this incident to anyone."

"Fine. You can analyze this...this thing here..." he said, waving his hands around the grove and between the two of us, "to your heart's content. But there's something I want you to consider as you do."

"And that is?" I asked.

"The fact that not everything in this world or any other needs to be explained. Sometimes things can exist that aren't logical, systematic, or definable, and that's okay." He cupped my cheek. "A little magic never hurt anyone, Astra," he murmured. Then, deftly, he swiped my tablet from under my arm and keyed in something.

"What are you doing?" I asked, desperate to get it back and hoping he hadn't erased my notes.

He handed it back and leaned closer so we were almost nose to nose. "You were the one who said I should name the flower, so I named it." He headed off through the brush toward the trees.

My eyes widened, and I quickly swiped through to the picture I'd taken of the flower. A new name stood out boldly beneath the image. It was now called an...

Astra Touch-Me-Not

I groaned, wondering how I was going to explain the name to my supervisor, but then I swallowed, realizing I wouldn't have to. Dr. McGivers was dead. Quietly, I followed Jax, wondering how this trip to the forest had ended so strangely. Granted, it had started out with me being suspicious of him, so I supposed it could have ended with me discovering he was a murderer. Him being irritated with me was a better, if not perfect, ending to our trip outside.

By the time I entered the ship, Jax was gone. I headed back to my room only to find Thane leaning against the door with his arms folded across his

chest. *Great, I thought, another irritated young man to contend with.*

"Hi, Thane," I mumbled. "Did you need me for something?"

He made some kind of sound that was supposed to mean something, but I couldn't figure out for the life of me what it was supposed to mean. Finally, he said, "I thought you were resting alone in your room. Imagine my shock to find you had gone outside with Jax once again. I thought the two of us were going to look for flowers."

I frowned. "But how did you know I was hunting flowers?" I asked.

He pointed to my unbound hair.

Reaching up, my fingertips brushed against the soft petals and came away with gold pollen. "Oh," I said lamely and attempted to gather my hair into a messy bun. "Sorry, Thane. I wanted to speak with Jax and he offered to tag along. I think better among plants," I finished lamely.

Thane raised an eyebrow. "Did you gather any other than this one?"

"We did but they withered too quickly to bring back."

"Did they?" Thane was mad. A vein stood out on his neck and his jaw was tight. He seemed to want to say something more.

"What is it?" I asked. "Why are you so angry?"

"The reason I'm angry is because..." He blew out a breath and a sculpted lock of his dark hair fell across his eyes. When he'd tamed it back where it belonged, he said, "Look, what I'm going to tell you is top secret, understand?"

He palmed the lock on my door, took my elbow, and led me inside. I wondered how he had access to my room, when I knew I didn't have unrestricted access, because I'd tried to get into my brother's room before, but then I remembered he was basically second-in-command. That probably gave him more authority than I had. I sat on my bed, dropping my tablet on my pillow. "What is it?" I asked. "Is it about the murder?"

"No...at least I don't believe they are related."

"Thane, you're worrying me," I said. "Tell me what you need to say."

He sat stiffly next to me and picked up my hand, toying with my fingers.

Thane had never needed to touch me like that before. In fact, he didn't seem to be the type that liked to be touched. I got the sense he was only doing it to try to prove something. "Do you remember when my father said your testing meant you needed to be trained alongside me?"

"Yes," I replied.

“Well, there was more to it than that. It’s not just that we are compatible as leaders, Astra, we’re compatible genetically, as well.”

“Compatible genetically,” I echoed. “What are you saying?” I asked, pulling my fingers from his.

“I’m saying that the young people on this terraforming mission are here for a reason.”

“Right, just like everyone else. We’re expected to pull our weight and help the colony be successful.”

“Yes, but there’s more to it than that. You see, most of the adults believe there’s going to be another ship coming in the next five to eight years.”

“And you’re saying there isn’t?”

“There might be, but even if there is, we’re not likely to know about it.”

“You’re not making any sense.”

“Astra,” he said, clutching my hands. “We’re not on Crillian IV.”

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Chapter 10

Null and Void

My mouth fell open. “What do you mean we aren’t on Crillian IV? It’s not possible. The ship says...”

“The ship says exactly what it was programmed to say.”

“You altered the records,” I mumbled, shocked at the implications.

“Yes. We didn’t want to alarm the others. It would cause a panic and there was nothing we could do about it. We found out too late to turn around. Everyone was already awake and there was no way to put them all back into hypersleep. Even if we could have, it would take a team more prepared than ours to reroute the ship. Astra,” he continued gravely, “we were pulled off course. Way off course.”

“But how?”

“We don’t know.”

“Well, can’t we”—I fluttered my hands—“turn around and get back to where we’re supposed to be, to Crillian IV?”

Thane shook his head. “We can’t. This is a colonizing ship. You know that. It was meant to be deconstructed and turned into all the parts we need to terraform and build shelters. Only the second ship the Earth sends will be capable of leaving the planet once it lands.”

“So, we’re stuck here? Do we even know where *here* is?”

“The planet is uncharted, though my father said there are signs someone has landed here before. It was never recorded in Earth’s planetary database, which indicates it was likely miners looking to exploit the planet’s resources. Whoever was here didn’t stay long, and it was many years ago, enough for the forest to take over the landing site again. Your late supervisor was the one who discovered the site, by the way. She noticed on scanning the flora of this continent that there had been a disruption. The power signatures were easy enough to read, but the only way to know if the

others came a decade ago or a century in the past was to study the rate of regrowth. She was just starting that when she...when she was killed.”

“But doesn’t the ship have a record of when we were pulled off course? Even if you don’t share that information with the crew yet, surely you and your father know.”

“That’s the thing. We don’t. Like many other files, the flight plan has been tampered with. Only five people on this ship know or would have known this was not Crillian IV—my father, myself, Dr. McGivers, and your parents. And now you are the sixth.”

“I see.” My mouth suddenly went dry. “Two of them are dead, and my mother was detained. This wasn’t an accident, was it, Thane? We were sent here on purpose.”

He pinched his lips together. “We still need to gather more information. But...we believe there is a saboteur on board, someone who wanted to divert us away from our original mission.”

“But, Thane, if whoever did this killed Dr. McGivers, it might mean they murdered my dad too. They might come after you and your father next!” I reached for his hand this time and he took it and squeezed.

“That’s a possibility. My father assured me it’s a distant one. But it’s one of the reasons I decided to tell you. If something happens to me or my father, I want someone to know why.”

“Thank you for trusting me.”

“I do trust you, Astra. I consider you a friend. I don’t make friends easily. I never have. You’re different. I’m different with you. You...you make up for my deficiencies. I need someone like you to keep me in check. To keep me honest.” He smiled, showing his dimples. “Don’t give up on me just yet,” he said, touching his thumb to my cheek.

“I’m not giving up on you, Thane. Whatever makes you think I am?”

He shook his head. “It doesn’t matter. What does matter is that you’re the only one I can rely on. You’re a perfect partner. I don’t want there to be any secrets between us, Astra,” he said. “Not ever.” He circled my wrist with his fingers and pressed his thumb against my pulse.

“Me neither,” I mumbled, slightly uncomfortable with his intense expression and wondering if he could feel the jackhammering of my heart. I trusted Thane, but not enough to share with him my biggest secret. As if my lungs knew I was thinking about them, I felt a tickle and coughed. It was as

if my lungs knew I was no longer outside, breathing the fresh air. I hated the reminder of my weakness. Quickly, I rose, making the excuse that I needed to use the restroom.

It was strange. It shouldn't have been possible that the whole time I'd been with Jax outside, I hadn't felt the slightest wheeze. In fact, I'd never been able to go so long without a hit of medicine. The amount of pollen in the air should have triggered a violent reaction and yet it didn't. Not at all.

When I returned, lungs steady, Thane continued, taking a deep breath, "Like I said, we checked all the records from the time we veered off course and found, like others, they are missing. You're much better at sussing out the tiny details in the assignments my father has given us. It's very possible we're overlooking something obvious. Perhaps you can help find it."

I bit my lip, wondering if the missing data on my father's death indeed had anything to do with our relocation. Finding out what happened to him was motivation enough. I ran through the possibilities in my mind. "Okay, so then we send a message. Surely with all the Earth's top minds, they can figure out where we've gone, even if we can't."

"We could, if our interstellar communication system hadn't been damaged in the storm."

Placing my hands on my hips, I blew out a breath and said, "You're right. These things going wrong are far too convenient to be a coincidence."

He nodded. "I've pored over all the personnel files, trying to figure out who on board is sabotaging the mission, but so far, I haven't found any leads."

"The real question isn't who, it's why. Once you figure out the why, the who will be easy," I said.

Thane let out a breath. "I'm glad I told you. It will be nice to have a fresh set of eyes on the problem."

Locking my hands behind my back, I began to pace. "I'm just completely dumbfounded at the idea of someone messing with a simple terraforming and colonizing expedition. It doesn't make sense." My mind immediately started sorting through the possibilities, and my thoughts drifted to the failed missions we'd been studying. Perhaps there was a connection. Setting that thought aside, I glanced at Thane and decided it was time to know everything. "Can we get back to that genetically compatible thing you mentioned? What does that have to do with this?"

Thane sighed. "Haven't forgotten that even with everything else I told you?"

"Nope."

"Okay, here goes. Regardless of why we are here, the fact is we are. We have to proceed as if the mission is still viable. The other crewmen can't know. It would cause chaos. We'll tell them at some point, after the colony is built and stable, but until then, this has to stay between us. Do you understand?"

"Yes," I whispered. "I understand your rationale for keeping this quiet for now. But, Thane, we have to tell them sometime."

"We will. I promise you, we will." He rose, took hold of both my hands, and looked down at them. I could tell he had more to tell me but he was reluctant.

"Go on," I said gently. "I can handle it."

His eyes lifted to mine, locking onto them. "We've run the projections," he said softly. "All the data points to us dying on this planet, Astra, long before help arrives. We can't count on Earth. The good news is that we have enough people to thrive if we can tame the natural flora and manage to plant crops and grow herds. We know nothing about this planet's weather systems, and we don't know what the winter will be like. We'll need to determine the best growing seasons. It will take time to gather that information. We'll try to contact Earth, of course, and repair our communication systems, but there are no guarantees. A rescue might never come. We've only got one option for the long-term survival of the colony."

The blood froze in my veins. "Then, when you were saying we were genetically compatible, you meant..."

"The younger people will have to pair off and propagate the species as soon as possible. Based on genetic analysis, our offspring would have the highest probability of survival."

**

I don't know how long I sat on my bunk, processing the news after Thane left, but it was long enough for my roommate, Delenna, to come and go. I wondered who they were going to pair her off with. She was so young. Only fifteen. Then again, I was young myself. Far too young to think of babies and propagating the species.

Thane had talked about his desire for a relationship between us. He acknowledged that we were both young. He wanted to take it slow. Hoped that our friendship would blossom into mutual respect and love. He wanted it to be my choice but he wanted me to understand his position clearly. He was definitely interested in pursuing a relationship with me with the ultimate goal of beginning a family when I was ready.

A family.

Wasn't that what I wanted too?

Didn't I miss my family?

Wasn't I obligated?

Then again...

Maybe it didn't matter if the colony survived.

So what?

Wasn't it cruel to have a bunch of kids and doom them to a life on a distant planet? Then again, once we all became too old to farm and herd, would we just sit down on a cot and waste away? Pairing off was going to happen at some point, regardless. It was human nature. No one wanted to be alone year after year.

Pressing my palms to my eyes, I tried to rub away my thoughts and purge them of the genetic compatibility portion of our dilemma and focus instead on the saboteur. That was something I could process. I got up to run the shower and wiped the steam from the mirror, frowning as I noticed the flower in my hair. Reaching up, I tugged on the stem and howled as it ripped away from my scalp. The stem had planted itself into my skin and was now covered with blood. What was even more interesting was that it was still as lovely as it had been in the forest. I winced as I gingerly touched the spot where it had dug in.

Heading over to the med dispenser, I said, "Antiseptic and antibiotic."

A patch and a tiny mister appeared. Pulling back my hair, I sprayed antiseptic on the small hole. The bleeding had mostly stopped and I didn't think I'd need a suture, but the area was still tender. After slapping the antibiotic patch on my arm, I stripped and glanced down at the flower. It had quickly withered like the others. Carefully, I slipped the flower into a sterile sleeve and placed it in a drawer, sending it off to the lab, where it would be stored until I could study it further.

After my shower, I dressed in a fresh flight suit, tying my hair back in a ponytail, careful not to brush too vigorously over my injury, and headed out to the funeral. All the team leaders were there as was my entire team. Jax stood stiffly in the back and Nash waved, showing me he'd saved me a seat. His expression was entirely too happy for a funeral. I *should* have sat with Nash. I *wanted* to sit with Jax but I was *expected* somewhere else.

Thane stood on the end of the front row, beckoning me to his side. The moment felt portentous and I couldn't ignore all the eyes turning in our direction to see what I would do. The entire group was quiet, probably sensing the tension I felt.

I sucked in a breath and strode forward with my hands clasped behind my back. When I passed Nash, I gave him a small smile and a nod and then moved on until I stood next to Thane. He put his hand on my lower back and guided me to the seat next to him. I settled and looked up into Seren's eyes. He wore a pleased expression despite the somberness of the event. When I turned to glance at Nash, I saw my brother was not only disappointed, he was angry. I'd never seen him stare at me that way before. It left me cold.

"Dear friends," Seren began. "We are here to remember Dr. Madlyn McGivers, a brilliant woman and a cherished colleague. Though her death has come too soon, she amassed many noteworthy achievements in the course of her life. For those of you who didn't know her well, I'd like to share a few things I've learned about her."

Seren spoke for a half hour and then gave the crewmen closest to the doctor a chance to speak. The silence grew awkward and uncomfortable until, finally, one of the younger girls stepped forward, saying that Dr. McGivers had been kind to her just before she entered hypersleep. She sat down quickly and Seren asked if anyone else wanted to speak. No one came forward.

When the funeral was over, the shrouded body sunk into the floor of the ship, where it would be stored until it was ready for planting. I looked for Jax afterward but he was gone. An oak tree had been Dr. McGivers's tree of choice, and while her body was being primed, I was assigned to prep the tree. Heading back to the stacks of seeds, I found one labeled *Quercus alba*, or white oak. According to our data, that type should be compatible with the surrounding forest, and the temperatures were similar to what the tree needed.

High above me, I heard the click and whirring of the system as the computer pulled the seed from the cache. It dropped into a chute, and the packet containing a perfect acorn surrounded by an airborne preservative that protected it from damage and deterioration moved down toward me. When it arrived, the chute puffed a hiss of air and the packet hung suspended until I removed it from the system. After carefully unzipping the packet, I took out the acorn, inspected it, and, assured that it was perfect, moved over to the growth accelerator.

When I'd set the acorn in the interior pocket, I palmed the door and it closed with a hiss. The computer scanned the seed, and its name and nutrient requirements appeared. A message popped up on my tablet.

SELECT LEVEL OF ACCELERATED GROWTH.



MORE THAN FIVE YEARS NOT RECOMMENDED FOR THIS SPECIES AS IT BECOMES TOO UNWIELDY FOR AVERAGE HUMAN STRENGTH.

I clicked five since I wanted to give the tree the biggest head start I could. It was the first tree we'd be planting on this new planet, whatever it was called. Once I selected the option, the machine gave me a countdown. The white oak would reach five years of maturity in approximately three-point-one-six hours. After programming an alarm in my tablet, I moved on to some other tasks while I waited.

First, I accessed the flower I'd sent earlier and pulled up the specimens I'd collected when flower hunting with Jax. The gold pollen was lovely when looked at under a microscope. It sparkled, but that appeared to be the only obvious difference from Earth pollens. I ran a series of tests and, to my surprise, found that the pollen had the same markers as many species of flowers on Earth. But when I zoomed in closer, I saw the sparkle was coming from a star-shaped structure connected to branches and a tail. The

star was shooting out sparks at regular intervals, which was what made it glow. “What is that?” I asked out loud while making notes.

By the time I moved on to the flower, I was disappointed to find it had deteriorated to dust. Still, I drew out some of the grains, carefully put them on a glass panel, and looked at them under the microscope. I found the same star-shaped structure but there was no light. Turning, I checked on the oak tree and saw it still had an hour to go. It was already about a meter tall.

I took a sip of water from my bottle and continued working. Sample after sample of living plant material I’d taken from outside was dead, turned to dust, and the dust looked identical to the flower’s. I’d never seen anything like it before. Lifting my finger to my still-sore scalp, I wondered why the flower had stayed fresh. Did the plants here need a live host to remain viable?

Scanning through Dr. McGivers’s samples, I finally located one that was still living. The whirring of the mechanical arms above me picked it out of the isolated storage compartment and sent it down the chute to me. Carefully, I drew it out. Visually, it resembled a fir tree seedling. Perhaps it was a young specimen of one of the giants in the forest beyond the ship. It appeared to be growing right out of a tree limb.

I broke off a needle and quickly looked at it beneath the microscope. In fascination, I watched as a pulsing light inside flickered wildly and then slowed until it stopped. Shortly after that, the needle turned to dust. Knowing I needed to look at the seedling as a whole, I used the computer’s cameras. They weren’t as powerful as our microscopes, but I should get a good enough idea of what was going on.

Zooming in closer and closer, I saw a fantastic network of star-shaped cells inside the needles. They fired and pulsed, sending little lights around the entire plant and even into the broken tree limb. The larger piece had lights too, but only around the little tree. The rest of it had already gone dark. I heard a ding and set the camera to keep recording, then sent a message to Thane and his father that the oak tree was ready. It was time to bury Dr. McGivers.

Jax had been assigned to help me with the tree. He took it out of the growth accelerator and placed it on a cart guided by his tablet. We walked alongside and we were quiet, partly because I didn’t know what to say to him after Thane’s revelation and partly due to the silent contemplation that went along with a funeral. When we arrived at the edge of the tree line, I

saw that Jax's team had used the compact excavator to dig a large hole, and the biodegradable bag containing the remains of Dr. McGivers had already been placed inside.

The men lifted the tree, its bare roots still dripping with growth solution, and held it in place while one pushed the rich, dark soil back into the hole. The team had decided to bury her inside the tree line since there was no viable soil in the area surrounding the ship. We weren't going to detonate the second bomb until later that afternoon.

When the task was finally complete, with the tree secure, the ground crew left, and it was just me, Thane, Seren, and Jax. Thane kept eyeing Jax, probably hoping he'd disappear with the rest of the crew members. I, too, wanted the chance to talk with Seren and Thane alone and see if I could learn anything more about our situation, but Jax wouldn't leave me alone with them. I was torn between wanting him to leave and wanting him to stay.

I asked, "Have you chosen a new team leader yet?"

Seren shook his head. "We'll sort that out after we establish the colony and begin to get settled." He gave me a meaningful glance and said, "Thane, perhaps you'd like to escort Astra back to the ship? I believe I'd like to stay for a while."

"I'll take her," Jax said.

Thane raised an eyebrow and waited for me to protest. I looked from him to Jax and then nodded. "Fine. Let's go."

Even though Jax had insisted on walking me back, he was quiet. So many things had happened since I'd last seen him, I didn't know how to start. Finally, I just apologized. "I'm sorry, Jax," I said, as he took my hand, helping me navigate over the ruined terrain. And I was sorry, for so many things. "I didn't mean to hurt your feelings."

"My feelings aren't hurt," he replied. "Just my pride. No guy wants to hear a girl say she's only kissing him because the pollen made her do it."

"Right," I said hesitantly. "Well, that was just the science geek in me taking over. Also you were my first kiss and obviously I kind of bungled it."

"I was your first kiss?"

He stopped and turned to me, a hesitant smile on his face as his fingers played with mine.

“Yes. And if it soothes your masculine pride, I...I’d kiss you again even without the pollen,” I admitted shyly.

“Is that so?” he said softly.

When I nodded, he squeezed my hands, then put an arm around my shoulders and continued walking me back to the ship. “We’ll have to run further experiments with that later on,” he said. “Our kissing drama aside, I’m worried about you. I don’t trust Thane or his dad. Something strange is going on and they’re not telling us everything.”

I lowered my head guiltily.

Pressing on, he added, “Watch your back. Nash and I have discovered...”

Glancing up sharply at the mention of my brother’s name, I repeated, “Discovered?”

“It’s probably nothing, but he’s asked me to look out for you when he’s not around.”

Frowning, I asked, “Why wouldn’t he be around?”

“I...I don’t know, but he’s working on something, something big. He hasn’t shared all the details yet, but he...he knows things.”

“Okay. And you can’t tell me more?”

“No. You’ll have to ask him. Just promise me you’ll be careful.”

“Okay, I promise I’ll be careful.”

Satisfied, Jax headed off to the engineering wing of the ship.

I sought out Nash immediately but only found his tablet left in the room he shared with Jax. For the rest of the day, as I worked in the lab, I checked in on his whereabouts only to see the blip on the screen was still in his bunk. Where was Nash? I pulled up his schedule and tried to find him that way, but when I talked with the other members of his team, they said they hadn’t seen him in hours and he’d been skipping out on a lot of work in the past few days without checking in.

My brother was a bit stubborn. He was brilliant, but he’d never been one to bow to authority. My parents blamed themselves for that. They’d taught us that most of the time, those who were in charge didn’t know what they were doing and often stood on the backs of scientists, taking the credit for their achievements.

I sent him a message saying I wanted to meet for dinner and was surprised when he actually showed up.

He sat across from me, arms folded. "What's up, Astra?" he asked.

"You tell me," I said. "Jax told me what you've been up to."

Nash's face froze but then quickly relaxed. "Did he?"

I leaned closer. "No. He just said you're working on something big. If there's something going on, you should tell me. We're in this together, remember?"

Nash leaned in, too, until we were nearly nose to nose. "You see, I would, Astra. But right now, you're cozying up to the enemy. You're letting his oily smile turn you into a pile of fresh, nutrient-rich soil. Bottom line, I can't trust you."

"Can't trust me?" I hissed incredulously. "Nash, you're my brother. The only person in the whole world, literally, who knows my secret. If you can trust anyone, it's me."

He sighed. "Normally, I would. But in this case, there's too much at stake. Besides, I think you have secrets of your own now, don't you?"

Shutting my mouth, I sat back hard against my chair.

"I thought so," he said. "When you trust me, I'll think about trusting you again. Until then, we're family, but not friends."

Wrenching back his chair, Nash stood and turned.

"Nash?" I cried out, tears pricking my eyes.

"What?"

"You should know that I hate this wall that's gone up between us. I've still got your back, no matter what."

He glanced over his shoulder at me and nodded, his face slightly softening. "Likewise."

Sighing, Nash sank down in his chair again, leaned forward, and whispered one word, "Hormones."

"Hormones?" I echoed.

"Yeah. Thane and his father have been mixing up huge batches of them, and they aren't the kind that grow super soldiers. They're the kind that make people lovesick."

"What...what are you saying?" I whispered, though I suspected I already knew, and the idea made me feel ill.

"I don't know why they'd want to do it, just watch out. If you start feeling doopey or suddenly feel the urge to procreate, just keep in mind that

it might not be entirely natural.” Nash left me alone at the table after that to process what he’d shared.

I sat there a long time, wishing the conversation had gone differently. The hardest part of knowing a huge secret like the fact that we weren’t on the planet we were supposed to be on was not telling those who were close to me. I wanted to tell Nash, I really did, but I held back, unsure of the reason.

When I returned to the lab, I found the sample I’d been studying had died. I played back the process on the computer. “Speed up times two,” I said. Then, “Times three.”

The blinking lights inside the tree limb went out first, and then slowly, the thin limbs of the baby tree died and, lastly, the trunk itself. “What is killing them?” I mumbled. We’d have to be more careful in collecting samples and bring them back intact in the dirt they grew in.

Since Dr. McGivers wasn’t around to fill up all my free hours with busywork, I was able to replenish my supply of serum with the hidden plants my mother had smuggled aboard. They were thriving despite the long journey. It only took me an hour in the lab to make a three-month supply and use the growth accelerator to produce ten new plants.

With my special access, I’d been able to not only book lab time alone but was also able to stop the cameras from recording my work. The only ones who’d be able to access what I’d done were Thane and Seren, and if they bothered to ask, I’d just tell them I was running an experiment of my own that I didn’t want to share with my colleagues yet.

**

The second bomb was detonated and I sequestered myself in the lab when it happened. I felt sick when it hit and the vibrations rattled the ship. My stomach heaved and I sunk down to the floor. Nash found me shortly afterward and accused me of murdering the trees.

“Why didn’t you stop it?” he demanded. “Don’t you care about the lives on this planet?”

“Of course I didn’t want to do it!” I said, feeling like I was going to throw up. “But Seren said—”

“Seren! Thane! They’ve...they’ve brainwashed you,” he gasped. “Why don’t you try thinking for yourself for a change?” He staggered against the

wall but held himself upright somehow. I could see he was even sicker than I was. Maybe we both were suffering from a virus.

“I do think for myself!” I said, gulping down a container of water. “You know we need to plant fruit trees and vegetables.”

“I don’t want to hear your flimsy excuses, Astra. You’re weak. I guess I should’ve expected your decisions to be weak as well.”

Nash palmed the door and lurched out. My skin was clammy and cold and I was dizzy. Medicine didn’t help either. I’d learned not to visit doctors unless absolutely necessary, and the fact that my brother had left me in that condition meant that whatever bond we’d once shared was now hanging by a thread. I felt so ill over the loss of my sibling, the only family I had left, that I didn’t leave the ship at all until two days after the bombing. By that time, the various teams had checked in, claiming the area was safe and ready for planting.

Jax’s team grew busy, prepping the selected area where we’d build our colony. Pieces of the ship were taken down and boxy domicile units were created. One by one, crew members moved to the new site, finally settling in the way we were supposed to. It took a month to get the living quarters settled and another month to move the lab.

I was too busy with the relocation of the lab to worry about the native plants, though they were always in the back of my mind. It seemed there was a lot on my mind. Especially when I discovered that I didn’t need my medicine at all when I was outside. As a result, I spent as much time walking back and forth between the ship and the colony as was possible.

Jax approached me often, asking me to take walks or eat with him, but I begged off, thinking of the warning from Nash. Was I only interested in Jax because Thane was giving us hormones? Then again, Thane had said *we* were supposed to be paired off, not me and Jax. What exactly was going on? Had Thane lied? As for Thane, he appeared to be keeping his word about letting me decide the pace of our relationship. He didn’t press me to pair off in any way and seemed content to be alone with me during training sessions. Both of us were busy with the construction of the colony regardless. I decided it was best to keep my head down and work while keeping my eyes open.

The ship was bare bones by the third month, and I was happily ensconced in the lab with the rest of my team. A large patch of ground was

prepped for a garden to sustain us in the coming months. Jax chose a still-forested area as the best place for a greenhouse, and Thane, against my advice, ordered my team to use a slower-acting chemical that ate away at the trees overnight. When we woke the next morning, we were shocked to discover the dirt had once again been sucked away, leaving only bare patches of rock.

After that we decided to clear the land the old-fashioned way with the compact excavator. The soil seemed stable afterwards, and we waited an entire week just to be sure before planting. We used the growth accelerator to put in mature plants that we could harvest more quickly, including a grove of fruit trees. But when we went to check on the plants the next day, they were all dead.

We tested the soil, the water drawn up from the water table, and everything else we could think of and found no reason for the crop to fail. My team carefully went over all the details, trying to match up the plants that would have the best chance, and we tried again, only to fail again.

I was on a trip to the forest to try to collect some living samples to compare growth and development when I came across Dr. McGivers's funerary tree.

My bag and tablet clattered to the ground as I screamed.

Chapter 11

Balance of Nature

A large native tree at least five meters tall now stood where the young oak had been. Not only had the native tree broken the oak into pieces, the branches brushing the dirt, their tiny leaves browning in the sun, but somehow it had pulled the interred body of Dr. McGivers from the soil.

Her body hung on the tree like a macabre scarecrow. All her limbs were torn from her torso and hung loosely from various tree limbs. A branch pierced her skull, its tip emerging from a sagging eye socket, the flesh split and broken. The black shroud she'd been buried in was ripped and tattered, its frayed edges fluttering like hellish prayer flags. It was a gruesome sight.

When I recovered enough to move, I summoned Thane and Seren and began taking pictures. There was nothing special about the species of tree that I could see. There were hundreds of them surrounding the camp, but I'd never seen one of them spring up overnight like that. A thermal image showed the root system had crowded into the space where we'd excavated and buried the body. Then something else caught my eye. There was one rather long root that grew thicker the farther away it got from the tree. I followed it using my tablet as it led me deeper into the forest.

When I was well under the canopy, I saw the root was connected to another tree, one I estimated to be at least a century old. Was the new tree an offshoot? We hadn't fully studied the root systems yet, but an interconnecting system made sense. If the ground plants existed in a symbiotic or parasitic relationship with the trees, then perhaps the trees also were linked into or onto something.

Hearing a shout, I headed back to the clearing and found Thane and Seren standing near the tree. A relieved smile pulled at the corner of Thane's mouth when he saw me, which seemed wrong considering the scene. He put his hand on my back when I drew close.

"Are you okay?" he asked.

I nodded.

Seren strode around the tree, examining it from every angle. “Who could have done this?” he fumed. “It’s entirely disrespectful. I intend to investigate immediately.”

“I don’t think it’s a who,” I said. “I think it’s a what.”

“What?” Seren said, his forehead wrinkling. “What do you mean it’s a what?”

“The tree is native. It likely grew here.”

Seren gave me a doubtful look. “Overnight?” he asked, then shook his head. “We only buried her here three months ago. I’m the first to admit I’m no expert on flora, but this tree looks entirely too big to be only a few months old. Three years is more like it.”

I glanced at the trunk. “More like ten to fifteen if it grows at the rate of typical Earth trees.”

“Exactly. Then we can assume that someone must have taken a young tree from the forest and growth accelerated it before planting it here.”

“I really don’t think so.” I swallowed, trying not to be sick, and pointed. “First, the growth accelerator is in my department. I would have noticed someone doing such a thing, especially as an accelerated growth of this size would have taken around four hours. Second, no one on my team has ever successfully collected a living sample from this planet and kept it viable for more than a few hours. Finding a way to keep specimens alive was my purpose in coming out here.

“Third, look at the way the branch pierced the eye. There’s...there’s brain matter on the tip but there’s a good portion protruding that’s uncoated. That means the tree was growing past the...obstruction. If someone had thrust the branch through her skull, the decomposing tissue would cover the entire branch. Lastly, I don’t see any evidence of a tool being used to remove the limbs from the body. I’ll agree that the tree has experienced accelerated growth, but I’d wager that it happened here, not in my lab.”

When neither of the men replied, I gathered my courage and pressed forward. “Another thing,” I added as I pointedly looked around. “This tree is much too large for someone to plant without heavy equipment. We’d see rover tracks.”

Seren, who’d been standing there mutely, finally spoke. “It seems all your training has been paying off.” He glanced at Thane and a look passed

between them. I blushed thinking I'd just shown up Thane in front of his father. Thane didn't seem angry though. He just squeezed my shoulder.

"There's one way to know for sure," Seren said. "We'll bring up the growth acceleration records. If someone did this, we'll find the culprit."

"There's something else that makes me think what happened might be a natural phenomenon," I said and brought up the images on my tablet. "See this root? It heads back to the forest and gets thicker the farther it goes. That implies these trees are connected in some way. It might be that they spread like poplar trees or blackberries using root suckers. What we're looking at might just be their natural way to reproduce."

"That quickly?" Seren asked, folding his arms and examining the tree. "Why haven't we discovered this yet?"

"We've been busy. It's possible they only reproduce at certain times of the year or under specific conditions. What we know about the flora here is very minimal. Too minimal to assume anything."

"Let's say that's true. Why this spot?" Thane asked. "If the trees were simply repopulating the area now, wouldn't there be new growth in other places too? Look around. This is the only young tree in this area and it just happened to grow where we buried Dr. McGivers."

"Yes. That's right," Seren said.

Thane went on, "How likely is it that a young tree also just happened to yank her body from the ground and tear her apart? It's too much of a coincidence, Astra. There's a mind involved. This area was targeted."

"Not necessarily." Just as we did in our classes together, Thane and I debated the possibilities in an amiable way. I liked the way he challenged my thinking and even looked forward to our discussions. He wasn't the type who always needed to win, mostly because he was confident enough in himself that he never considered himself on the losing end, but still, I appreciated the fact that he listened. "It could be that something in the chemical breakdown of Dr. McGivers's body triggered the tree to reproduce and stretch its roots toward the source. It makes more sense than something sinister. Why would anyone want to desecrate her body? What would be accomplished by such a thing? The simplest explanation is usually the right one."

Thane winked at me as his father considered. I knew that meant that he agreed with my assessment.

Finally, Seren spoke. “I agree with Thane,” he said, “though I do believe we should examine all the possibilities.”

Thane’s eyebrows rose but then he nodded stiffly, his expression neutral.

Seren turned to me. “We’ll keep news of this to ourselves and only involve those necessary to dispose of this unpleasant outcome. Is there someone you trust to handle this with discretion?”

I swallowed and glanced at Thane. “Jax,” I said. “He’s good at keeping to himself.” That was an understatement. Every time I tried to talk to Jax now, he slipped around a corner and disappeared. I had the distinct impression he was dodging me. Not that I blamed him. Nash was doing the same thing. I’d go a solid week without seeing my brother, and when I did, he stared at the trees with glassy eyes instead of engaging in conversation, only answering my questions with one-word answers.

“Very well. Contact him and explain the situation and need to keep this quiet.”

“And if someone should want to visit the grave?” Thane asked.

“If such a thing happens, we’ll simply tell them the tree died much like the first crops we planted, and we decided to cremate Dr. McGivers instead. We’ll fashion a stone marker and place it here once the new tree is gone.” He wrinkled his nose. “I believe cremation would be a better option for all future deaths in the colony.”

A shiver of foreboding ran down my spine. He was already anticipating future deaths? I guess colony leaders had to prepare for anything.

“You’ll make sure Astra gets back?” Seren asked his son.

Thane nodded.

Turning briskly, Seren left us, climbing into his rover and heading back to the colony.

Once he was gone, Thane rubbed my arm and asked, “You’re sure you’re all right?”

“I’ll be fine,” I replied, slightly uncomfortable with his unwavering attention. To his credit, he hadn’t pressed me over the past few months since he told me the secret regarding the planet and his father’s determination for us to be paired off due to genetic compatibility. I wasn’t sure how I felt about the idea of it at all, let alone how I felt about him. He’d been patient with me, which was something I appreciated.

Still, the way he looked at me and how he was particularly attentive during our training, often brushing his hand against mine or pulling out my chair, made it obvious that he intended on pursuing me, despite my lack of response. It wasn't that I found Thane unattractive. He was very handsome in a cold sort of way, much like the models in store windows showing off all the latest fashions. It wasn't that I hadn't come to respect him or didn't enjoy being around him either. He was bright and considerate when it came to my opinions. I was pleased that he took my comments seriously, weighing my words carefully before responding.

I liked him. I just wasn't sure I liked him in that way. On the other hand, every time Jax entered the room, I stopped breathing, literally. His hair was often unruly, and his hands were covered with dirt, grease, and callouses, rather than being perfectly manicured like Thane's. But his eyes had a glimmer of warmth in them every time he looked at me, even when he was angry, which he always seemed to be, especially when he saw me with Thane.

There was no doubt that Jax was avoiding me. Our paths rarely crossed nowadays anyway, but when they did, it was memorable each time. His eyes locked onto me almost immediately and I'd freeze, remembering that kiss in the field of flowers and how much I enjoyed it. I tried to forget it, to forget him, but through my window, which I always kept open now at night, I'd listen to the whispering leaves of the trees, and my mind inevitably drifted back to Jax.

The desire to kiss him again seemed to increase as time passed, and though I kept busy enough to distract myself during the day, the nighttime, with its sweet, fragrant breezes and soft patterings of rain, stoked that need, making the memory of his mouth touching mine swell and grow in my dreams until I felt I would go mad if I didn't find a way to see him alone. Not a night passed when I didn't think of that patch of flowers and his hands cupping my face.

When I woke, I told myself that my wanting to kiss him again was purely for experimentation purposes. The scientist in me wondered if the strange pollen connected us in some way. There had to be some scientific explanation. I wasn't the type of girl to swoon over a well-placed dimple, a rugged jaw, or a strong set of shoulders. Perhaps my tea was laced with fertility hormones. I scoffed at the very idea that I could be in love. I was

too young to pair off. Yes, my hormones were likely raging, but I was in charge. I was strong-willed.

At the same time, my analytical brain wondered if I would respond to him the same way again in a different place. Or if I kissed Thane among the flowers, would the pollen affect me in the same way as it had with Jax? Was it really the pollen? I could determine it conclusively if I really wanted to. Wouldn't a real scientist investigate further? There were certainly worse scientific experiments to conduct.

Testing out those theories would help me eliminate some variables that had been bothering me. Then again, did my feelings, assuming I had them, even matter? What was I scared of? For better or worse, we were stuck here on this planet. If Jax decided to pair off with some other girl, I'd have to literally watch them be together for the rest of my life. Could I handle that?

Maybe I should just corner him in a vacant room and kiss him again and get it over with. Then I could get the bug out of my brain and get on with my work. Not that Jax was inclined to kiss me now. He'd given me several indications that he was interested in pursuing a relationship that first month. Jax had even tried to contact me and apologize. He'd said if I wanted to go slow and science the heck out of a relationship, then he was willing to give it a try. But I'd ignored his overtures and deleted his pings. Eventually, Jax gave up. It was what I wanted. Wasn't it?

Thane squeezed my shoulder lightly. "Ready to go?" I nodded, shivering, and berated myself for thinking about science and kissing while standing next to the desecrated corpse of Dr. McGivers.

Thane kissed my forehead when he left me to seek out Jax, and I wondered again if he was doing it only because I was going to see Jax and he wanted to leave his mark on me in a way. I finally found Jax at the newly built aquasystem talking to Nash. They'd worked together on the project, Nash using the plans my father had left, but the two of them had been tweaking the system slightly to account for a few unforeseen issues that had arisen due to the strange nature of the planet and its native flora.

Apparently, there was no problem with the reservoir itself. The pumps drew the water up from the water table and ran it through a series of filters until it was potable. The problem lay in the pipes connected to the colony. They'd been using the standard plumbing tubing commonly used in rural areas, but it seemed the pipes weren't strong enough. The hard root systems of the trees punctured them easily and clogged the new pipes within a week.

The damaged pipes were removed and replaced with a much stronger version. This time it took a month for the roots to pierce them. Everyone was baffled by the problem. Not only were there no trees in the area around the reservoir, but the new pipes should have been strong enough to resist anything nature could produce.

It had been Jax's idea to coat the outside of the pipes with the same chemical compound that had dissolved the trees when we landed. Nash was adamantly against the idea and talked about provoking the same response we'd experienced upon landing, but Seren approved Jax's plan and the pipes were treated and trenched once again. A week passed and then a second, and everything seemed to be working well. But seeing Jax helping Nash once again meant there was a new problem.

When I drew close, I immediately figured out what it was and covered my nose. "What is that horrible odor souring the air?" I asked.

"One of the drills hit a gas pocket," Jax explained.

"But didn't you scan for that?" I asked, covering my mouth and nose.

"Obviously," Nash said, a sneer of distaste on his lips. "It seems there was a glitch in our scans. What are you doing here?" Nash asked.

I tried to ignore his attitude. My brother was not acting like himself. He'd never been so rude to me before. Irritated and bothered, yes, but not rude. "I need to steal Jax for a bit. Can you spare him?"

Nash gave me a long, piercing look. It was like he was trying to silently ask me a question, but when I just gave him a look back, he waved me away.

Jax seemed more than happy to follow me, but it turned out his happiness had more to do with getting away from the stench than seeing me. "What is it?" he asked, folding his arms across his chest in a surly imitation of my brother.

We were standing just inside the tree line. I hadn't wanted anyone in the colony to overhear what I had to say, but I hadn't meant to go that far into the trees either. My lungs tickled, likely a reaction from the gas still drifting in our direction, and I pressed my hand against the trunk of a nearby tree and inhaled deeply, hoping the sensation would pass. A sweet fragrance tickled my nose, and I smiled, enjoying the way my lungs filled and emptied easily. I was getting used to not needing my medicine. I intended at

some point to try to figure out what was helping me breathe, but we'd been so busy, I kept pushing that research to the bottom of my list.

"Astra, are you okay?" Jax asked.

I turned around, happy to see that, unlike my brother, his concern for my well-being trumped his irritation with me. "Despite the circumstances, yes. I'm doing well. You?"

He tilted his head and gave me a quizzical expression. "I'm well enough," he said. "What did you need to talk about? Nash?"

I shook my head. "No. I know what's bothering Nash, and the two of us are at an impasse for the moment. What I need to talk to you about right now is Dr. McGivers."

Jax frowned. "What do you mean?"

"Her body has been pulled out of the ground. A native tree has... Well, you'll have to see it to believe it," I said, shaking my tablet. "I'm going to need your help to get what remains of her down from the tree and then we'll need to cremate her body."

"Down from the..." He straightened his shoulders. "You'd better show me."

I pulled up the images from my tablet and he grimaced.

"We don't want to alarm anyone," I rushed to add.

"By 'we' do you mean you and Thane? Why isn't Mr. Wonderful helping you with this? Doesn't want to get his hands dirty?"

I glanced up. Speaking of dirt, there was a rather appealing smear of dirt on his cheek. I replied distractedly, "Seren wants it done. Can you help? I told them we could trust you to keep quiet." Pointedly, I looked away from his face and down at his hands, gripping my tablet. They were strong and tanned. The kind of hands my parents had, with dirt under the fingernails and in the creases. They reminded me of warm days in my mother's garden and handing tools to my father. They looked like...like love. *Now where did that thought come from?* I wondered.

Noticing my stare, Jax made a big show of brushing any dirt from the surface of my tablet, handed it to me, and then clasped his hands behind his back. "What's in it for me?" he asked.

"Are you asking for some form of compensation? What is it you want? Extra rations?"

He shook his head. "I'd like a little time off."

I blinked. “Oh. Well, I’m sure your schedule could be modified—”

Jax interrupted, “I mean time off for you. They’re working you to death.”

“But I enjoy my work.”

“Everyone in the colony gets some recreational time, but you never take any. You should. Do something with your brother. You two need to fix whatever’s going on with you. Take a hike together and collect samples. Or sit with the others some night around the campfire and tell stories. You never participate in anything social.”

I grimaced. I hadn’t told anyone that every time they lit a campfire, I got queasy. It was probably a reaction to the smoke in the air. It wasn’t smart for me to be around it anyway considering I had sensitive lungs. Besides, the social opportunities being provided by Seren were in the hopes that certain young people would begin to show an interest in developing long-term relationships. He arranged schedules very carefully so that their free time overlapped.

My free time had always been allotted when Thane was available. Both of us knew it and even helped with creating the schedules for the others on occasion, but knowing it for what it was, I often chose not to participate. It was my way of keeping my distance from Thane. I’d never been allowed free time when Jax was available, so he never would have seen me around.

As for Nash, the two of us remained distant. There were things I couldn’t tell him, and he was angry about it. The more time we spent apart, the harder it was to approach him. My relationship with Thane and his father made me a traitor in Nash’s eyes. My brother had always been perceptive. He knew I was keeping information from him and he hated being on the outside.

“Look, will you help me or not?” I asked.

He leaned closer and my heart skipped. “Are you agreeing to my terms?” he asked genially.

Biting my lip, I said, “I’ll look into it.” When he gave me a doubtful look, I said, “I promise.”

“Fine. Lead the way.”

“Don’t you have to shuffle your schedule on your tablet?”

He held out his empty hands. “Don’t carry one. I’m not a stickler for scheduling like you are. I do my job, and when it’s done, I knock off.”

Jax matched my pace, which I appreciated since my legs weren't as long as his, and we followed a path through the trees, skirting the edge of the colony. Quietly, I said, "It's not like I'm obsessed with a schedule."

"Seems to me you are. You're Miss Perfect when it comes to just about everything."

"I'm not perfect!" I said abruptly.

He held up his hands. "Okay, you're not perfect. Far be it from me to give you a compliment."

"I just keep busy, that's all. I've got a lot on my mind."

Jax was quiet for a moment and then he said, "Helps to unload once in a while. What's on your mind?"

Jax was, mostly. At least he was in my dreaming mind. Sometimes my dreams started out just like this, the two of us walking alone down a forest path, but inevitably, it ended up with him pushing me up against a tree, his mouth making its slow way from my lips down my neck. And his hands... I started. "What...uh, what was your question?"

"I asked what's on your mind."

His arm brushed against mine and my skin lit up with goose bumps. Nervously, I brushed back a strand of hair that had come loose from my tight ponytail. "Isn't it obvious?" I asked. "I'm worried about the tree unearthing Dr. McGivers."

"Right. I get that, but you've been tense since we left the ship. Are you feeling lonely now that Delenna is bunking with her family? I imagine you're missing your brother."

I glanced up at him. He was so perceptive. I hated being alone. Nash knew it but he avoided me anyway, which hurt a lot more than I let on.

"It's nothing," I said.

"Doesn't look like nothing. Even Nash agrees."

"Nash?" I rounded on him, angry that my brother would rather talk to Jax than his own sister. "Is that how you spend your free time? Talking about me with my brother?" It wasn't Jax's fault, but it wasn't like my brother was around for me to fight with.

Jax held up his hands in surrender. "If you don't want to talk, fine. It's not like I expected anything else. You've made your feelings regarding our relationship quite clear."

“Well, I’m glad it’s clear to you, because nothing since we landed is clear to me.”

I felt his eyes on me, but he said nothing. After a long, quiet stretch, we stepped into the clearing. “Here it is,” I said.

He circled around the tree and whistled. “It’s worse than the pictures.” Examining the tree from different angles, he added, “This doesn’t make much sense.”

“Agreed,” I said. “Thane and his father suspect one of the colonists has done this.”

“Huh,” Jax replied. “Not sure I agree with that.”

“What do you think happened?” I asked, curious about his opinion.

He rubbed his jaw. “I’ve seen firsthand what these tree roots can do to pipes. They grow extremely fast. They’re strong. It almost seems like they’re targeting our systems on purpose. No one agrees with me, obviously, especially Nash, but I’ve never seen anything like it before. It’s not much of a stretch to believe the trees did this too.”

I teased, “So you believe the trees did this on purpose? Next thing you know, they’ll be saying, ‘Feed me, Jax!’”

Jax smirked. “This is no Audrey II if that’s what you’re implying. Though if it was an Astra II, I might be tempted.”

My mouth fell open. “You know *Little Shop of Horrors*?”

“I’ve even got a copy of the old vid,” he said, still studying the tree.

“How? You brought it with your personal effects? That seems like a strange thing to bring on a terraforming mission.”

“Why? Because I’m an engineer? Just because it’s not rocket science doesn’t mean I’m not interested. And just because I grew up off the grid doesn’t mean I’m backwards or ignorant.”

“I...I never assumed you were.”

He grunted, took my tablet, and crouched down, scanning the ground.

“So you really think the tree did this?” I asked, squatting down next to him.

Pointing out the root system on the tablet, he answered, “In my experience, the roots on this world can tunnel through pipes, so breaking down a decaying body would be fairly easy.”

“Okay. So, what do we do? Will you have to dig the tree out by the roots?”

“Nope. I can take care of it right now.”

“What? How?”

“You said Seren wanted Dr. McGivers’s body cremated?”

“Yes.”

“Well, this is the next best thing.” He pulled a tube and a small bottle from his vest pocket. “Back away, Astra. I wouldn’t want to get any of this on you.”

“What is it?”

“The chemical gel we’ve been using on the pipes to keep the roots at bay. It’s based on those bombs Tremere was using. It dissolves anything organic.”

“But...but you’re not a biologist or a chemist. Did you test it? What if you breathe it in?” I asked, panicked. “What if it gets on your hands?”

“I thought we already established that I have hobbies other than engineering.”

When he saw I was still terrified, he added, “Don’t forget, I’ve already used this substance extensively. It’s been field-tested many times. Also, I wear special non-organic gloves. See?” he asked, taking them out. “It doesn’t take much. It’s not airborne so you won’t breathe it in. I modified it so that I have to add the accelerator solution to activate it, and I’ll be well away from the gel by then. Now, will you be okay or do you want me to do this when you’re not here?”

I shook my head. “No, I...I’m okay.”

“All right, then stand over there while I apply the gel.”

Taking several steps back, I watched the process with fascination. Carefully, Jax squirted a thin stream of gel around the base of the tree. It was a blue goop that looked similar to toothpaste. Once that was done, he capped the tube and took the cap off the accelerant.

“Here’s where it gets interesting,” he said.

He pushed the nozzle on the bottle and a fine mist coated the blue gel. Immediately, the gel bubbled and frothed, eating away at the base of the tree. My breath caught as the tree groaned and cracked, inches of it dissolving before my eyes. Jax grabbed my arm and pulled me farther back as the tree toppled, and still the gel doubled and tripled, moving along the branches and running up on one of Dr. McGivers’s torn arms.

When it was halfway done, a rush of wind blew leaves and debris in our direction. Anything caught up in the bubbling mass liquified instantly with the rest. They were dissolved before they had a chance to infect anything else. The trees in the forest nearby quivered violently and my arms trembled. Whispers carried on the wind turned into screams. I covered my ears and tears filled my eyes. My stomach heaved. I was going to be sick.

“Astra? Astra! What’s wrong?” Jax shouted, taking hold of my shoulders. My lungs seized, and my mouth opened, but I couldn’t speak, couldn’t inhale. Just as the tree and the torn body of my former supervisor disappeared, my eyes rolled back in my head, the horizon tilted, and then the world went black.

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Chapter 12

A World of Pain

There was a horrible screaming that was suddenly cut off. Something was ripped right out of me. I felt empty and hollow, my mind joining with the keening voices that grew fainter and fainter until they were indecipherable whispers once more. Then there was a thump. Another one. I heard a new voice. A desperate one. “Astra! Astra, come on! Come back to me!”

Something punched me in the chest. Hard.

I coughed. My lungs spasmed painfully as I struggled to take in a breath. There was a humming and a hiss. Behind my closed eyelids, I saw green and the pain in my lungs eased. Blessed air entered my being and the world righted itself. With a whimper, I rubbed the sore spot on my chest right above my heart as I worked on steadying my breaths. It felt like I’d been tackled to the ground. By a sumo wrestler.

“Ow,” I said with a groan as I slowly blinked open my eyes. When I realized it was Jax hovering over me and not Nash, my face flamed. Then I looked down and noticed my shirt had been torn open. I’d dressed in a soft T-shirt and cargo pants that morning instead of the standard uniform, intending to go for a hike in the forest, but now my shirt hung gaping at the chest, barely attached at the bottom hem. Even more horrifying than knowing that Jax had gotten a really good look at my dull-as-a-rain-puddle underclothing was seeing an empty ring of medicine vials lying on my bare stomach. What was even worse, the skin covering the implant in my chest was gaping open.

I sat up awkwardly. Jax reached for my elbow to help, but I shrugged him off and grabbed for the medicine ring as it slipped off my belly in an absurd attempt to try to hide it from him. Self-consciously, I turned slightly, reached up to my implant, and twisted it until it sunk properly into place, and then closed the flap of skin before grabbing the torn remnants of my

shirt and clutching them as best I could against my chest. My mouth opened and closed like a fish before I finally acknowledged to myself that Jax had not only seen everything but saved my life, and asked, “How did you know?”

Jax winced. “Nash.”

“He told you?” I asked, gaping incredulously. My brother had told my family’s, *my*, deepest, darkest secret, the one we’d kept all our lives, to a virtual stranger. Granted, Jaxson wasn’t exactly a stranger anymore, but still, no one knew. Not even our relatives. Mom and Dad would get in major trouble. I bit my lip. I guess Mom was already in trouble and Dad, Dad was beyond the reach of trouble now.

“Look, it’s no big deal,” Jax said.

“Uh, yeah it is. If it wasn’t a big deal, I wouldn’t have had to cheat on my physical exam to join the mission.”

“Oh, well, yeah, when you put it that way...”

He ran a hand through his hair, mussing it in a way that made me want to fix it. *What must this boy, who I like more than I should, be thinking of me? That I’m weak? That I’m defective? That I never should have been born? That I’m a detriment to the mission? What did Nash tell him exactly? And why?*

“Why would he tell you?” I muttered under my breath. Jax must have thought I was asking him, because he answered.

“Nash didn’t think it was safe for him to be the only one around who could help in an emergency. He said he’d feel better if I could look out for you in case he wasn’t available.”

Frowning, I said, “Why wouldn’t he be available?”

Jax shrugged. “Obviously, he was right. Your vials were empty, and he wasn’t around when you passed out.”

“Empty?” I’d just replaced the ring that morning and I hadn’t even used a dose yet. There was no reason for my serum to run out. It shouldn’t have even been possible. Even if I had run out of medicine, it wouldn’t cause a loss of consciousness. Mumbling absently while fingering the empty ring, I said, “But that’s not why I...” Suddenly, I remembered the voices. Had I been dreaming? Who had been talking? Screaming?

“Did you hear anything when I passed out?” I asked.

“Like what?”

“Like people crying or voices?”

He shook his head and gave me a look. “No. Did you?”

“You’re sure?” I asked.

“Yeah.” He paused. “Look, if you’re worried about the colonists, I snuck you into your lab through the back door, so no one saw us. I didn’t think you’d want the doctor involved. Nash made a big issue out of that.”

“Right. Thank you for that.” It was a relief to know that my little episode had gone undetected by the colony members. I rubbed my aching chest again. “What exactly did you do?” I asked. “It feels like you punched me.”

Jax grimaced. “I sort of did. I panicked. The implant is hard to find. I mean, Nash told me it was on your chest, but not exactly where it was or how to open it.” His cheeks turned pink as he gestured to my general chest area. “I was getting pretty desperate. You weren’t breathing. I started doing chest compressions and the impact shifted the skin covering your implant.”

“I see.” Trying to take control of the situation, I said briskly, “Well, thank you for helping me. Now if you’ll leave the room, I’ll change my shirt.”

“Before you do that,” he said, touching my leg briefly, “will you show me how it works? I was too anxious about saving you to really get a good look at the technology. I think I was too nervous to get it in right.”

“You didn’t.”

He grimaced but a look of determination soon replaced it. It was a bit surprising to note he didn’t appear to be judging me. Or my parents. I supposed he was used to people judging him and was hesitant to do that to others. Jax seemed sincere in his desire to help, so I let him.

“I...I guess so,” I said. I’d hid my weakness for so many years, it felt strange to be sharing it with someone new. I didn’t know how the new planet worked to help my lungs. Maybe the serum had been drained suddenly, perhaps as a side effect when Jax destroyed the tree with his new chemical compound. It was certainly a possibility I’d have to consider in the future. It still didn’t explain the blackout though.

Jax slid closer until we were seated side by side with our legs facing opposite directions. When he saw I was uncomfortable with trying to hold my shirt together and expose the part of my chest I wanted him to see, he said, “Here, let me.”

Reluctantly, I let go.

Jax took the edges of my shirt and finished ripping it in two. I gasped, wanting nothing more at that moment than to cover myself. But Jax wasn't ogling me, in fact, he wore the same thoughtful expression he did when he was puzzling out an engineering project or studying plans. As he tied the two pieces together, knotting it so the shirt was semi-closed, I relaxed a bit. At least I was now hands-free.

Though I felt every inch of my exposed midriff and wanted to use my hands to cover the unadorned bra peeking out from the top of the material, instead I pushed my hair over my shoulder and took his hand, positioning his fingertips over my skin.

"You can't see it," I said, "but you can feel the difference. See?"

He nodded as his fingertips traced back and forth over my skin. My arms erupted in goose bumps.

"To get it open," I continued, "all you have to do is press down on my skin at the seam. The natural skin moves but the artificial doesn't. You hook a finger under the synthetic flap and pry it open."

"Does it hurt?" he asked, pulling it open gently and then closing it.

I shook my head. "It's like an earring. Once the ring is exposed, you just press it and it will pop out. Then after you position the new one, you push it into place until you hear a click."

"Ah," he said. "That's what I did wrong. I didn't wait for the click. I forced the vial down and I could tell something was off. The skin wouldn't close. Can I practice replacing it or do you have to wait until the vials are empty?"

"You don't have to wait. It can be removed at any time," I said, demonstrating how to do it. "But only push on it until you hear a click and it pops. If you push harder, it sends another dose into my lungs. It wouldn't hurt me, but it wastes meds."

Concentrating, he shifted a bit closer so he could see what he was doing. The skin on the bridge of his nose wrinkled in a becoming sort of way. He wasn't at all leering or making me feel uncomfortable. I could have been a piece of equipment he was fixing. After closing the flap, he felt for the edges, reopened it, took out the ring, then reinstalled it and pressed down until he heard a click.

"That's right," I said.

Jax smoothed down the synthetic skin and then traced his fingers over it. “Brilliant,” he said with appreciation. “It’s cutting-edge tech. I always respected your parents, but to create something so delicate and untraceable... It’s genius.”

His blue eyes drifted from my chest to my face. I noticed for the first time that there were little green flecks in his eyes. His warm hand slid up to my shoulder and cupped it gently. “I’m glad you’re okay,” he said.

“Me too,” I replied softly. “Thank you. For saving me,” I added.

“Anytime,” he answered. The words implied it was time to part ways, but neither of us moved. There was something electric and warm flowing between us. His thumb grazed the curve of my neck and my breath hitched. His eyebrows rose and he glanced down at my chest, a question in his eyes. I gave a slight shake of my head and laughed breathily. “It’s not the serum’s fault, or even my lungs,” I said. “That was all you.” I frowned. *What on earth made me say that?*

He cocked his head and the corner of his mouth quirked up. “Was it?” he asked and traced his fingertips across my collarbone.

I shivered.

“Your pulse is racing,” he said. “Is this dangerous?”

Narrowing my eyes, teasing him, I said, “I think *you’re* dangerous, Jaxson Preston.”

He smiled, wide and sweet, and I melted a bit inside. Jax *was* dangerous—a compelling distraction I didn’t need. But I couldn’t turn away from him. I loved the smear of dirt on his cheek, the stubble on his jaw that was just a shade darker than his hair, and how the flexing of the hard muscles of his arms was tempered by the gentleness of his hands. He was like a brewing storm on the horizon. I knew I should take shelter from those electric eyes and avoid his lightning touch, but what I really wanted to do was to head directly into that tempest and let it rain down on me, consequences be damned.

“Didn’t you read my file?” he asked, touching his nose to mine. “I’m practically the boy next door.”

For a moment, I wondered what it would have been like to grow up next door to Jax. I imagined he was a young man eager to learn, which would have endeared him to my father, and willing to get his hands dirty, which

would have appealed to my mother. Even Nash seemed to like him. Seemed to trust him. And Nash didn't trust anybody.

"Yeah?" I said. "Well, even so, don't go and get any ideas that I'm in some sort of fragile state now that you know my secret."

I slid away far enough that his hands dropped to his lap. He leaned back, placing his hands behind him and gave me a discerning look. "I don't think you're fragile, Astra. And before you blatantly accuse me of anything else, I don't plan on telling anyone about this."

"I appreciate that."

"Is that why you kept me at a distance? You thought I'd react badly?"

"No. Not exactly."

"Then it's Thane. You like him then?"

"No. We're just on the same work team. We're both learning how to manage the colony."

Jax made a scoffing sound. "Right." He cocked his head. "Does Prince Charming know?" he asked, gesturing to my synthetic skin.

I rolled my eyes at his reference to Thane. "No, for your information. And I don't want him to know."

"Why not? The two of you spend so much time together, don't you think he should, just in case something happens?"

"What happened today was an anomaly."

"Right. Like the pollen."

"Exactly like the..."

Jax leaned forward, picked up my hand, and played with my fingers for a few seconds before bringing them to his mouth. Slowly, he kissed my knuckles, watching me with his blue-green eyes as he did so. The cool air flowing through the room suddenly felt hot. It was as if he was a burning sun that banished the cold and warmed all the frozen parts of me that had stilled when my dad died, my mom had been left behind, and my brother had all but abandoned me.

I'm sure I was looking at him wide-eyed when he stood, still grasping my hand, and pulled me up beside him. Cupping my chin with his other hand, he made me look at him as he said, "It's not the pollen, Astra." As he turned and strode out of my tiny habitation built right next to the lab, he added over his shoulder, "Don't forget, you owe me some free time."

Trying to set aside the entire incident, I tossed my ruined shirt into the recycle bin and my pants and shoes into the refresher before stepping into the shower. In the middle of soaping my hair, the water suddenly cut off.

“You’ve got to be kidding me,” I grumbled at the showerhead as I played with the buttons, willing it turn back on. Growling, I stepped out and tried the sink with the same effect. Luckily, my rations of drinking water were still full, and I used as little as possible to rinse out my hair. Once I was dressed, I headed to Thane’s dwelling, the one he shared with his father that included an expansive office. Thane answered, taking in my wet hair.

“What happened to you?” he asked.

“The water shut off in the middle of my shower. What’s going on?”

“Not sure,” he said. “My father was recently summoned out to the aquasystem. Shall we go see?” he asked, holding out an elbow.

I raised an eyebrow at his outstretched arm. “Why not,” I said. “Let’s go check out what my brother’s been up to.”

Ignoring his arm, I strode ahead. When I turned to look back at him, Thane had both hands clasped behind his back, and though he walked alongside me amiably, I sensed his tension. He wasn’t happy at my rebuff. I told him about the tree and that Jax had effectively dissolved it using the same material he was using to protect the pipes but purposely left out the fact that I’d passed out and Jax had carried me back.

He said nothing to that but politely asked me about the work schedules I’d been assigned to go over and reported the happy news that a young couple that had been matched based on compatibility had just moved into a shared domicile.

“That’s...nice,” I said, old suspicions of hormonal manipulations surfacing.

“Nice?” Thane echoed. “It’s all thanks to you,” he said. “Your proximity proposal based on the Rydell colonies worked perfectly. Put two perfectly healthy young people on the same shifts so their free hours coincide, and voila, you have a match.”

“Congratulations. You’re officially a yenta.”

“That’s we, Astra.”

“I’d rather not take credit for it, thank you.”

“What’s wrong?”

“I don’t like it.”

“But they’re an ideal match.” Thane glanced at me. “It’s not like we’re forcing anyone to pair up, Astra.”

I stopped and turned to him. “Are you lacing their food or drink with hormones?” I accused.

“What?”

“You know. The pharmaceutical equivalent of dangling a carrot?”

“No! I would never do that.”

“Wouldn’t you?”

“Astra, you know my father and I only do what’s best for this colony.”

“Yeah. That’s what you have to tell yourself to be able to look in the mirror every day and like what you see. Which is something I’m sure you do often.”

I started to walk away when I heard his reply. “Ouch. Where is all this coming from?” He took my elbow and turned me around. “What’s going on with you? You’re especially surly today. Tell me.”

I sighed and dropped my gaze from his probing eyes as I folded my arms across my chest. “Are you drugging me, Thane?”

“Astra, no.” He put his hands on my shoulders. “Think about this. Reason it through. If anyone can, it’s you.” Thane squeezed lightly. “You know I want the two of us to be matched up, right?”

I nodded.

“If I was manipulating your emotions in any way, you’d have thrown yourself at me months ago. I mean, you have to admit, I’m pretty irresistible.” He grinned and a dimple emerged. “Don’t you think my own relationship would be the priority if that were the case?”

“I guess,” I admitted.

“Look. If you’re really worried, do a workup on yourself. Take an oral swab and check your hormone levels. I’d hate to think you trust me that little, but do what you need to do. I’m just sorry that you’ve been harboring these doubts about me all this time.” He shook my shoulders gently until I made eye contact. “I told you I wanted you to choose me because you wanted me, not because your hormones were raging. Though, if they are...”

His smile faded as he studied me. Truthfully, it wasn’t him I was worried about. There was a niggling part of me that wondered if he had been dosing me like the others but had gotten the wires crossed somewhere and I was being drawn to Jax instead. Thane had made it very clear that he

wanted us to be a couple, and though he was attractive and intelligent, it wasn't his arms I imagined around me. It wasn't his eyes I saw in my dreams.

"Look, I'm sorry," I said. "I've just been on edge lately. Nothing's going well with the water or the crops and I can't figure out why."

He massaged my shoulders using a bit too much force. "We'll find a solution. Between the two of us, we can't lose."

"Right. Yeah," I said. "Okay, I'd better get going. Problems await."

"Yes," he said, dragging out the word as Jax ran up to us, "problems."

"Better come quick," Jax said and put a hand on my arm. "It's not good."

We jogged after him and approached the small group standing around the reservoir. There, floating on top of the water, was the dead body of the head aquasystems specialist, the one who'd replaced my father. I'd just met with him yesterday to help him gain access to my father's work database.

"What...what happened?" I asked Nash as two men waded in and fished him out.

"He was electrocuted," my brother replied, pointing to a large cable that had fallen into the water. "You can touch it now. The power's been shut off."

Thane and I crouched over the cable and examined the end. It had been severed by a tool.

"It's connected to the new greenhouse," Thane said and added in a side whisper, "Wasn't your friend Jax in charge of building that?"

"Yes. We were hoping to grow plants inside, protecting them from the environment long enough to supplement our food stores. The walls were laced with the same stuff as the pipes to prevent tree roots from creeping in."

"Right." He angled his tablet over the cut cable and scanned it, walking down the length until he arrived at the greenhouse. "The only DNA present belongs to Jax." Pulling me aside, he whispered, "This doesn't look good, Astra. It wasn't an accident."

"But Jax worked on the greenhouse. Of course his DNA will be all over it."

"Then how do you explain the cut on the power cable or the fact that there's no other DNA on it?"

“I don’t know yet, but I can’t believe he killed the new supervisor. Where’s the motive?” I asked quietly.

“Workers have killed their bosses in every century. Maybe he didn’t like his assignments or his schedule.”

“But he was the aquasystems supervisor, not his direct boss.”

“Yes, but they’ve been working together a lot recently.”

I didn’t like where Thane was going with his line of thinking. “Then he’d be mad that we assigned him to help. Remember *we* are the ones who decide his schedule.”

“Right, but Jax doesn’t know that. Hold on, another sample’s coming up.” Thane frowned and touched his screen several times. “That can’t be right. The genetic markers are similar to Jax but they aren’t on file.”

“What do you mean, similar?”

“It’s close, like it could be a brother or a grandfather. There’s no way to know for sure because we don’t have either of Jax’s parents’ DNA on file.” He tapped his tablet against his hand and added by way of explanation, “His parents were eccentrics who lived off the grid. They immigrated to a distant colony and left him with a family friend. At least that’s what it says in his record. There’s no official way of proving that, of course.”

“That’s terrible!” Astra said, her heart breaking for Jax. Then she paused. “Wait a minute. That wasn’t in his file. In fact, the only way I know he was raised off the grid is because you told me.” I didn’t add that Jax himself had told me too.

“Yes. Those records are typically sealed. You read the standard files, the ones mission headquarters supplied us with.”

“Are you saying there are secret files on all of us somewhere?”

Thane glanced up and I caught the momentary panic on his face. He leaned closer. “My dad didn’t want you to know. At least, not yet. But, yes, there are secret files.”

“What...what does mine say?” I asked.

“Don’t worry about that now. The point is, we’ve got some DNA that doesn’t match any of our colonists.”

“So, you think Jax is hiding a secret sibling in his pocket.”

“I honestly don’t know what to think, Astra. Let’s just take our samples and get back to the lab and figure out what’s going on. We have a murderer in the colony, and until we flush him or her out, all of us are in danger.”

We walked back the length of the cable and found a partial boot print. After he took images of that, we headed back to the others and watched as the head aquasystem specialist's body was wrapped and taken back to the colony. Nash stood at the edge of the water, his eyes glassy as he stared at the distant trees. His mouth was moving though I couldn't hear him.

"Nash," I said. "Are you okay?" He didn't respond. "Hello?" I snapped my fingers. "Earth to

Nash."

He finally turned to me and said, "Astra. You're looking well."

"Uh, thanks. So...did you see what happened?"

"Oh, you mean with the body?"

I nodded expectantly. "Yeah."

"No. I found him like that. But don't fret. He's at one with the cosmos now."

"At what time did you find him this way?" Thane asked. "And did you notice anything suspicious?"

"About thirteen hundred hours. Now that I think of it, yeah, I did. Jax was working on the greenhouse this morning and he was talking to a man. I couldn't see who it was since they were inside and the panels are opaque, but they were arguing rather loudly."

"Did the shape of the man resemble the one you found dead?"

Nash rubbed his jaw. "They were very close in size, I'd say."

"Very good," Thane said. "Let me know if you think of anything else."

My brother saluted to the two of us. "Yes, sir, boss," he said.

It could have been my imagination, but I thought I saw a green bruise on my brother's arm. When I asked him about it, he tugged down his sleeve and told me to mind my own business. When had my relationship with my brother soured so badly? Reluctantly, I followed Thane back to the colony. When I turned to look back, Nash was still standing there by the water, staring at nothing.

The funeral was held quickly. A few words were said, and then the body was lowered into a cement box that Jax had lined with the same material he'd used on the tree. The crowd was asked to stand back as he sprayed the accelerant onto the body. Within a matter of moments, the body had completely dissolved. The crowd shifted uncomfortably and began moving away in groups.

I glanced up at Jax, who studied me briefly. His upturned mouth flattened when he saw Thane take my arm. I'd never considered Jax could be anything but what he said he was, but now Thane had hinted that there were secrets Jax wasn't sharing. I wondered if I could still trust him. Then again, hadn't I been keeping secrets too? Thane said he was going to get a head start on the investigation and walked me to my door. He kissed my cheek and handed me an orange before saying goodbye, promising me a chess match the next night.

In my dreams that night, something chased me. My breaths came too quick and I reached for the spot on my chest only to find a petrified trunk.

Whispers began. They beckoned me forward. I stumbled through curly ferns and alien flowers, running through the ancient trees until I heard a voice.

“Astra.”

I turned and a handsome young man with green-flecked blue eyes held out his arms. With a sob of relief, I staggered toward him. Wrapping his arms around me, he kissed my ear. I heard a crack and a splinter. The forest moved, the trees coming closer. The canopy closed over us, the leaves brushing our hair and arms. Then heavy bark erupted on his skin, sliding over him like water. Before I could move, before I could scream, the two of us were enveloped, trapped in my nightmare.

Chapter 13

One Giant Leap

I sat up with a start, gasping. It took a moment for the creepy feeling of my nightmare to cede. I ran my tongue along my teeth and the roof of my mouth. It was as dry as bark dust. After sipping some tepid water, I opened my window and let the night air kiss my hot cheeks. The stars were bright, but the moon was on the other side of the planet.

The stars were hidden on Earth in all places but a few. There were too many cities filled with light. All the observatories had been moved to Himalayan mountains or the oceans. My mom's favorite old-world myths were either about the trees or the stars and sometimes both. It had been her dream to journey to a new world and rediscover both. As long as the family went together, Dad was more than happy to sign up. How could I be on this lovely planet without them? The stars blinked and began to weep.

A splash hit my cheek. I wiped it away and frowned, glancing up again. There were no black-bellied clouds full of rain. Perhaps the bright stars had bullied them from the sky. Either that or the trees had their own personal watering can. It seemed like it only rained in the late evenings on this world. It was always gentle, and always at the perfect time, leaving the days bright and sunny and the flora refreshed. It was clockwork perfect. In fact, the only thing throwing our new world off-balance seemed to be our presence.

The trees rustled in the breeze, trunks creaking, and there was a hum of whispers again. I concentrated, but try as I might, I couldn't make out the voices clearly enough to make any sense of them, though one of them seemed vaguely familiar somehow. Apparently, I was the only one suffering from the phenomenon. Then I bit my lip and thought of my brother.

Nash had been talking to no one yesterday. Maybe there was a hallucinogenic in the air—I grimaced—or in the pollen. It was possible. We just didn't know enough about the planet yet. I'd run the possibility by

Thane and see if we could divert some resources to studying my theory. It could account for the murders. If there was something driving our impulses or causing manic episodes, we needed to know.

Despite the early hour, I prepared myself for the day, staring with a hot cup of chamomile tea sweetened with honey, my favorite, and checked in at the lab. I found my old bunkmate, Delenna, working with her supervisor.

“You’re up early,” I said.

“Yeah. The boss couldn’t wait to get started on the first batch.”

“That’s right. You’re introducing animals today. What’s first? Chickens?”

Delenna grunted, shoving her dark braid over her shoulder. “You wish. Believe me, I’ve been craving fresh eggs too. Nope, first come the bugs.”

“Really?”

“Yep, really. Bugs are the most adaptable. Besides, lots of other animals eat them.”

“Well, good luck.”

“Heading off to leadership class?”

I sighed and brandished my cup of tea and my tablet. “Yes. Though I’d much rather spend time in the lab today. A team has collected a group of mushrooms on a live tree limb I desperately want to research.”

“Mushroom soup does sound heavenly. Still, you need to study hard at this leadership thing so we can call you Madame President as soon as possible. Then I can sell my memoirs of the time I was your roomie.”

“Not sure you’d sell many copies,” I scoffed.

“Are you kidding? By the time I’m an old lady, this world will be crowded and they’ll be searching for the next one. I fully expect you to make your mark on this planet and have a few schools named after you.”

The idea that this new planet would eventually be as congested as the old one was alarming, but then I realized it would take much, much longer than Delenna believed. The only way to populate this planet was through procreation and that wouldn’t happen overnight. Well, it could happen overnight, but not *overnight* overnight... Gah...why was I thinking about procreation? An image of Jax kissing my fingers popped into my mind.

Trying to set aside thoughts of Jax, I said, “I knew there was a reason I liked you.”

My thoughts spun in a dark direction when I considered my brother's warning that Seren was tampering with hormones. Even under the best of conditions, we'd hardly carve a niche on this planet before we all died. Especially if the planet itself was driving people to murder. Then again, it didn't take many humans to carve a large niche. Maybe our colony dying out was the best thing for the planet after all.

I bit my lip, then picked up a swab and ran it along the inside of my cheek, then ran it through the computer, doing a basic bio check. My levels were always just slightly off thanks to my medicine but I could compare it to my norms. When I brought up my pre-mission records and my new sample, I saw some pretty radical new figures and not in a way I was expecting. There was nothing indicating anyone was tampering with my fertility hormones but everything else was off-the-charts healthy.

My white blood cell count had always been borderline high, but now it fell in the completely normal range. I'd always struggled a bit with my metabolic panel but it was perfect. What was interesting, though, was that my hemoglobin was now off. Strange. Well, at least I knew there was nothing abnormal going on with my hormones.

Leaving the lab, I headed to Thane's domicile, where his father gave us our assignments. Seren let me in and punched in his computer code, allowing me access to the colony computers. I wished we could send a message out into the cosmos so my mother would eventually find out where we were, but the communications system had been sabotaged along with a number of other things, and just like with the grave and the aquasystem, it all appeared to be happening naturally. There were too many coincidences now for me to feel comfortable. Someone on the planet wanted us to fail. And they were doing an epic job of making it happen.

Before leaving, Seren told me that Thane was still in the shower and that I should go ahead and begin as there were multiple assignments the two of us needed to oversee. Nodding, I settled into the chair and signed on. Images appeared on the glass.

I briefly read through our tasks and chuckled when I heard Thane singing in the shower. Then I sobered when I remembered that, just the day before, he'd told me there were secret records on all of us. I swiped away the list and twisted my fingers, shrinking down the folder containing our assignments. Wherever Seren had hidden our files, Thane knew of them. I scanned through file after file until one popped up with a strange name. It

was simply called *Adolescents*. I spread my fingers, opening the file only to find it was encrypted.

After running it through several encryption cycles and failing to gain access, I slapped my hand on the desk to channel my frustration. A hand reached around me and typed in a code. Turning, I sucked in a breath. Thane was standing right next to me, smelling like woodsy soap, the hot water evaporating from his flushed bare chest. His hair was damp and mussed, and as he glanced down to see me turning bright red, he adjusted his barely there towel and gave me a secretive smile.

“Going spying without me?” he asked.

I turned my face to the screen. “I could hardly spy with you around. Especially dressed, or should I say undressed, as you are.”

“Flustered, are we?” he asked almost hopefully.

“Hardly,” I scoffed, lying. “Go put something on and help me then.”

“Yes, ma’am,” he said with a chuckle and disappeared into his room.

He soon joined me at the computer, his hair slicked back in his perfect style, and was studying me as I read through my secret file. To my relief, it said nothing about my unique problem. In fact, my file was fairly boring. It was Nash’s file that was more interesting. He’d apparently run around with some problem juveniles. Kids that my parents didn’t even know, or at least had never told me about.

Though he’d been homeschooled when he was younger, he was allowed to attend local classes as a teen, and it seemed he skipped out more often than he went. It didn’t affect his grades though. He had a unique ability to charm his teachers and convince them that he needed to study off-site only to run with the wrong crowd. Because his grades were still excellent, nobody bothered to check.

“Did my parents know?” I asked.

“I believe they knew part of it. Your mother insisted she could control him. I believe he’s the main reason they signed up for the terraforming mission. They wanted to steer him in the right direction.”

I bit my lip and nodded. Nash wasn’t the main reason. I knew my parents joined the mission for me. It would be easier to hide my problem from authorities. But it seemed there were other reasons as well. Nash being one of them, when I thought he just came along to be supportive. Then again, I wouldn’t doubt that my brilliant mother fabricated all the

information about Nash just to make our need to be included on the mission that much more urgent to the terraforming leadership. Still, I wondered. There was more going on with Nash than he told me. That much was obvious. Perhaps it was time to confront my brother.

My fingers itched to look up the other youths' files, especially Jax's, but I felt uncomfortable doing it with Thane watching.

As if sensing it, Thane put his elbow on the table and rested his chin on his fist, looking at me. "You want to look at my file, don't you?" he asked.

"I want to look at everyone's file," I admitted.

He nodded briskly. "And you should." Leaning closer, he took my hand and played with my fingers. "I want you to know me, Astra. I have no secrets. There's nothing in there I wouldn't willingly tell you." Glancing up almost shyly, he locked his brown eyes onto my face. "If you asked..." he said, finishing.

When I didn't reply, he squeezed my fingers and let my hand drop. Clearing his throat, he rose. "Well, then. Why don't I work on our list while you study the files? I'll tell my father we were investigating the murder, which will be partly true. I intend to question Jaxson today."

I rose immediately. "Really? Do you still suspect him?"

Thane frowned at my interest. "There's no other explanation that makes sense," he said.

"Right." I wrung my hands and sat. "I won't take too long on the files," I promised. "Let me work out next week's schedules. That's one thing I can take off your plate."

"Okay," Thane answered slowly. "I'll see you later, Astra."

He waited a beat at the door and then closed it quietly behind him. Once he was gone, I delved into the files, bringing up Jax's file immediately. It said that he had indeed been born off the grid and hadn't gotten himself registered until he was sixteen. He'd been schooled at home with an uncle who refused to submit documentation or appear for the blood draw and DNA sampling, which meant he either supported himself by living off the land or, more likely, Jax was supporting him.

Quickly, I scanned through his work history. Jax was a brilliant junior engineer, especially considering his upbringing. Many other hopefuls were passed over so he could have a spot on this mission. He'd scored exceptionally high marks on creative problem-solving and innovation.

Everyone knew by now that if there was a complicated problem, Jax was the one to solve it.

Though the loss of his supervisor when we landed was terrible, the fact was, losing Jax would have been more detrimental to the colony. Most people on his team assumed he'd be taking over, even though he was the youngest member. Seren hesitated to select a new head engineer. I'd assumed it was because he wasn't sure the others would follow Jax, but perhaps it was something more fundamental, like his upbringing.

I shut down the file and pulled out my tablet, checking on Jax's whereabouts. He'd worked a late shift the night before, and the blip on the screen said he was still in his bunk. Biting my lip, I slipped out of Thane's domicile and skirted behind buildings until I figured out which one belonged to Jax. Sucking in a breath and trying to tamp down the fluttering of my heart, I knocked lightly on the window in the back.

A shadow moved behind the opaque glass, then all went still. I knocked again. There was a clatter and I heard someone cursing before a hand pressed against the glass and it went clear. A mussed Jax blinked at me from the other side. His mouth formed my name. "Astra?"

He touched a pad on the side of the window and it slid open. "What are you doing here?" he asked. "And why not use the front door? Afraid Prince Charming will catch you?" He folded his arms over his bare chest. My mouth had suddenly gone dry. Though I'd just seen Thane without his shirt on too, the sight hadn't produced the same physical effect I was experiencing now. Jax had miles of tanned skin with all sorts of interesting muscles and curves lying just beneath. My fingers itched to explore each one. The stubble on his jaw was more pronounced and the flashing of his blue eyes told me he knew exactly what I was thinking.

I suddenly remembered he'd asked me a question. What was it? Ah, yes. It was about Thane.

"N...no," I answered, feeling guilty and flummoxed. "I just have a few questions and I didn't think you'd want the entire colony to overhear us."

"I see." He sighed and ran a hand through his hair, then glanced behind him quickly. "Just give me a minute," he said. "Wait there."

There was some more banging in his room and I heard Jax's voice. It was as if he was speaking to someone, but I knew he lived alone. Then my face heated when the thought occurred to me that he might have a female

visitor. I was so, so stupid. Of course he had a girl in there. What girl wouldn't want to be in there with him? Briskly, I turned and strode toward the trees, embarrassment, humiliation, and disappointment squeezing my ribs like a giant snake vine had slipped out of the trees and caught me up in its embrace. Hot tears pressed against the backs of my eyes and I became angry, refusing to let them fall.

"Wait!" I heard Jax call behind me. "Hold on a minute."

I heard his pounding footsteps behind me and then he caught my arm. "I thought you wanted to talk," he said, his blue-green eyes studying me.

"I did," I said harshly, every muscle in my body shaking with wrath or indignation or need or longing. Folding my arms across my chest, I accused, "Did you have someone staying over last night?"

Jax wasn't successful in hiding his shock at my question, and the guilt it generated. "It's not what you think," he said.

"And what do I think?" I replied.

"You're thinking I had a girl over." Once he said it, he smiled. "And you're jealous."

"I most certainly am not." How could he be smiling when I felt like I was about to lose my balance?

He took a step closer, capturing a piece of my hair and twisting it around his finger. "Yes, you are."

Jax leaned down and kissed my cheek, his warm breath tickling my ear and his stubble scraping my jaw. It was enough to distract me from being angry. I sputtered, not knowing what to say. Before I could come up with something, he put his hands on my shoulders and said, "It's okay. I like that you're jealous. Come on."

Taking my hand, he pulled me deeper into the trees. Once we were far enough away from the camp so we could no longer hear anyone, he let go and turned. "Now what did you want to talk about? Oh, and before you get off on a tangent, I didn't have a girl over. There's only one girl I'd invite over, but she's always too busy to pay me any attention." He raised his eyebrows, indicating that I was the one he meant.

"Oh, yeah? Well, you, you put on a shirt."

Looking down, he plucked at his shirt, then lifted his head and grinned. "If it offends you so much, I'll try to remember to take it off next time you come around."

Not allowing myself to be too pleased by the idea, and my suspicions not being fully assuaged, I pressed on, getting directly to the point. “Thane plans to question you today about the murder.”

Jax stiffened but didn’t seem concerned. “And?”

“And he’s smart. He’ll probably figure out who really killed Nash’s supervisor.”

He frowned. “Thane’s not that smart. Besides, even if he does, that’s a good thing. Then he’ll know it wasn’t me.”

“No. It wasn’t you. But you know who it was.”

“What do you mean?” he asked, slipping his hands in his pockets, his easy demeanor vanishing.

“The DNA we found was a close match to you, but it wasn’t you. We don’t have that DNA on file.”

“Okay. I don’t see where you’re going with this. Why do you think I know anything?”

“Because you snuck the murderer on board the ship.”

“What?” His mouth gaped open.

“That’s right. It was your uncle, wasn’t it? He’s here. You’ve been hiding him somewhere. Maybe in a compartment of the ship and then snuck him out to the forest. He’s experienced in living off the land. I read your secret file and it all adds up.”

“Whoa. Wait a second. Secret file?”

My cheeks burned. “Yes. I know about how you registered at sixteen and how you were selected. It’s the only thing that makes sense. The DNA had to come from a close relative of yours. Your uncle was your guardian. He’s here, isn’t he?”

Jax gritted his teeth and then exploded. “What was I supposed to do?” he asked wildly. “Leave him behind? He refused all the standard vaccinations and ended up with advanced neurodegeneration. He’s harmless, but he never would have qualified for the trip, even if I had convinced him to register.”

“How did you get him on board?” I asked and then answered my own question. “Ah, you put him in that extra stasis chamber I found. The glass had been broken.”

He was angry now. I could see it in his expression. “It seems you know everything then, don’t you?”

“No. Not everything,” I admitted. “How did you get him on board?”

“I’m an engineer. Remember? He posed as a member of the team when we were outfitting the ship. I installed an extra pod for him and settled him in, locking the door so no one would find him.”

I frowned. “But how did you put him into hypersleep?”

Jax palmed the back of his neck. “That’s where it got tricky. I managed to steal the sleep solution and programmed the computer, but I’m no doctor. I forgot to factor in his weight since he’s slightly heavier than the typical terraformer. Because of that, he started to come out of it naturally. The computer woke him up but the pod malfunctioned and he had to break the glass to get out.”

“But...but what did he do after that? Where did he hide? How did he eat without being registered on the system?”

“He didn’t have to hide. Not until you woke up. The system was tweaked so he could access food and water. The stores he took were added onto other crewmen’s files. They would get just a bit less so he could survive.”

“I see.” I clasped my hands behind my back. “Jax?”

Sighing, he said, “Yeah?”

“Just how long was he awake on the ship?”

“About two months. When I discovered the broken glass, I searched for him everywhere. I was frantic. Panicked. When I finally found him hiding in a cramped storage area, I almost didn’t recognize him. He was so skinny and filthy. I crouched down next to him and cried. He was sitting there mumbling to himself and rocking back and forth. It was my crying that brought him out of it. He patted my shoulder and said it would be okay. He slept for three days and I fed him all my rations when he woke. It was selfish to make him come here with me, but it was my dream. I just couldn’t leave him behind. Can you understand that, Astra?”

He’d turned away from me and his shoulders were tight. I could easily picture him running through the ship, frantic, searching for his doddering uncle. It was sweet and endearing what he’d done. It was also risky. It reminded me of the sacrifices my family had made for me. How could I not understand?

When I touched his shoulder, he turned around and I wrapped my arms around his waist. I’d meant to hug him, but standing there, enveloped in his

arms, I felt like I was the one being comforted. It was strange, my nose buried against his chest, the very chest I'd been admiring earlier. Holding and being held by Jax affected me in two ways at the same time. It was one of the most exhilarating things I'd ever experienced, but it was also like coming home.

I blew out a breath and stepped away, though I would have been happy to stay there much, much longer. "Yeah. I can understand it," I said. "For what it's worth, I'm sorry, Jax."

"Me too."

Now I knew what the strange noises must have been on the ship before everyone else woke up. It was Jax's uncle. "How advanced is his condition?" I asked gently.

"He's like a child most of the time," Jax admitted. "Sometimes, it's almost like he's back. He remembers me, and how to fix things. He always liked to tinker. Most of the things I know about engineering, he taught me."

"He must have been so scared on the ship," I said.

Jax nodded.

"What's his name?"

"Harmon Price." A panicked look came into his eyes. Jax took my hands and shook them lightly. "He didn't kill anyone, Astra. Uncle Harm is harmless. I'm dead serious. If he even sees a worm on the ground, he carefully picks it up and moves it out of the way so nobody will step on it."

"But his DNA..."

"His DNA will be on some of the things I work on, especially the greenhouse. He loves plants and tinkering, like I said. I bring him gadgets to work on from time to time. It keeps him busy while I'm working."

Nodding, I bit my lip and asked, "Can I meet him?"

Jax looked taken aback. "You want to meet him?"

"Sure. Why not?"

He thought for a minute and then asked me, "Are you going to tell Thane?"

"It would be better to tell him about your uncle than let him arrest you for murder. Who would take care of your uncle then?"

"I don't want Thane to know."

"It's not like you can hide your uncle Harm forever, Jax. What were you going to do? Build him a hut in the forest like you did on Earth?" His stony

face gave him away. My mouth gaped. “That’s exactly what you were going to do.” I put my hands on my hips. “How far have you gotten with that?” I demanded.

Jax kicked his shoe in the dirt. “I only need a few more weeks to get the last piece of it done. Once we figure out a way to grow crops, he could sustain himself.” He cupped my shoulder. “You’re not going to tell anyone our secret, will you, Astra? Please?”

What was I supposed to say? Jax had kept my secret. Was I going to just turn on him? Betray the boy I thought about more often than I should just for caring about his only living relative? Wouldn’t I do the same for Mom or Dad or Nash? “All right,” I finally said, “I won’t tell anyone. But, Jax,” I added. “I can’t stop Thane from coming after you, not if we don’t tell him about your uncle.”

“I’m not worried about Thane,” he said.

“You should be. His dad’s the head of the colony.”

“For now.”

I gave him a quizzical look. “Uh, like forever.”

“Maybe,” he acknowledged cryptically.

“Whatever.” I waved off the comment, refusing to be sidetracked. “Look, just lie low, okay? I’d hate to see you or your uncle get accused of anything.”

“Right.”

We both stood there awkwardly for a moment until I made a lame excuse to leave. I hurried back to Thane’s domicile and quickly finished the schedules for the week, hovering for too many minutes over my own. Finally, I pressed my thumb to the tablet, confirming my selections, and saw the pop-up on my calendar showing an overlap of free time. Within a minute, I got a message from Jax, asking if we could go hiking and sample collecting the next morning when we both had planned recreational time. I wanted to ask what he’d do with his uncle while we were gone, but didn’t want anyone with access to read the interaction.

After confirming the suggested plans, I sent a message to Nash, saying I wanted to meet with him later, and another to Thane, telling him I was done and headed to the lab. Thane immediately replied, saying he’d meet up with me later that afternoon while my own brother ignored me.

The air was thick and humming as I walked up to the lab, and I realized with a start that the sound was coming from bees. A new hive was being moved into position. The plan was to establish it near the tilled soil, where we'd been attempting to grow crops.

I found my former bunkmate, Delenna, holding a buffer wand and swathed in nets. I knew the nets were just in case. Bees didn't like being moved. But she really wouldn't be in any danger until the bees were freed. Even then, she'd release them gradually enough that they wouldn't feel alarmed enough to swarm.

Carefully, she walked the bees to their new home, the large bubble protruding from the lip of the wand doing all the heavy lifting. The bubble functioned as both a shield and an antigravity unit and it could be blown up to the size of an elephant if necessary. Inside the bubble must have been hundreds of fully grown bees.

After waving at her, I checked in at my station, finding the samples of mushrooms ready for me to begin work. Quickly, I scrolled through Delenna's work and found she'd already grown and placed more than one hundred different species of insect, including a variety of bees, earthworms, butterflies, ladybugs, lacewings, and dragonflies. Next up, they were going to introduce arachnids. When I looked at the egg sacks ready to burst in the accelerated growth chamber, I shivered. Spiders weren't my favorite.

I knew the team hoped that introducing these new lifeforms would help in the process of keeping the young plants alive. They'd just put in a new crop of hardy tomatoes, corn, beans, squash, and a grove of young apple trees. The borders of the gardens had been lined with Jax's powder as had the borders of the colony, and so far, the plants seemed to be flourishing. The insects would only help with that.

Quickly, I became absorbed in working at my station. Hours later, I stretched, twisting my arms behind my back and rubbing my neck. Unfortunately, I couldn't figure out why these mushrooms were thriving while others brought in died very quickly. It turned out that our hopes for mushroom soup were to be dashed. The sample I had was poisonous. I left the mushrooms at my station while I took a break to eat. It was already late afternoon and one of the suns was sinking over the horizon, painting the sky brilliant shades of red and orange.

When I returned to the lab, I found Thane waiting for me. His face lit up when I came in, and he held out his hands, drew me close, and kissed my

cheek. He seemed happy when I blushed and stepped away, though I wasn't blushing because of him but because the kiss had been in the very same place Jax had kissed me that morning.

"How was your day?" he asked. "I see you've been busy working."

"Yes. I just stopped a minute to...eat." Frowning, I ran my hand over my empty table. "Did you move my mushrooms?" I asked.

"Mushrooms? No. I just got here."

"Then where did they go?" I wandered from one station to another, searching for my sample. "They're not here," I said. "Why would somebody take them?"

"Maybe someone put it into cryogen storage."

I slipped my fingers through the rings to pull up the files in the vast storage tanks. "No one has placed or pulled any cryogen files since this morning. Somebody took them," I said worriedly.

Thane shrugged. "It's not that big of a deal, right? We can just send someone out to look for more."

Taking his arm and squeezing, I replied, "Thane, you don't understand. I just determined that those mushrooms are poisonous. If someone ingested them, they'd be dead the moment they swallowed. And this morning, Delenna was talking about soup."

Chapter 14

The Nature of Things

Grabbing Thane's hand, I said, "Come on. We've got to make sure no one is cooking up those mushrooms."

We ran to the galley, where any foodstuffs that we'd been able to grow, which, admittedly, wasn't much except for what we could get from the small hydroponics lab and the greenhouse, were distributed and cooked. There was a vegetable stew being prepared, but when we scanned the ingredients, we found no mushrooms. Next, I checked in with Delenna, but she said she hadn't seen my missing fungi. After that, Thane sent out an alert that would appear on every tablet.

"Done," he said after he sent the message. "There's really nothing more we can do at this point," he added.

"No, I guess not." I bit my thumbnail, wondering what could have happened to those mushrooms.

Thane clicked his tablet onto his belt and took my hands. "Relax. This isn't your fault," he said.

"I'm not worried for myself," I said. "I'm just sick at the idea that someone else could die."

"Yeah, speaking of that"—Thane dropped my hands—"Have you seen Jax?"

"Not, uh, recently," I lied. "You weren't able to find him?"

"No. But I entered his domicile and found more of the DNA that was on the greenhouse and the power cord."

"Are we allowed to do that? Enter someone's home without their permission?"

"Every colonist signed waivers when they joined the mission."

"Oh," I said, not realizing how much of our lives we signed away when we were recruited.

He added, "Colony leaders may inspect homes whenever it's considered justified."

"I see," I said, nodding. Thane always spoke with such a sense of self-conviction, never leaving the tiniest opening for any doubt to creep in. It was a trait his father employed as well. When a Tremere spoke or pronounced judgment, everyone just accepted it. Though he allowed me to interject my opinion and even seemed to value it, I knew that he would ultimately decide what ideas to keep and what to reject, all the while coming off as a smooth-talking diplomat, almost as shiny and slick as his hair.

I'd decided a while ago that there was a need for leaders like that. It made everyone they interacted with feel a sense of security. In fact, I'd admired that quality up until that moment. Invading someone's personal space didn't sit well with me. Even though I knew Jax had done something wrong, I understood his reasons.

Still, a murder had occurred, and I didn't blame Thane for investigating. The whole thing left me unsettled. I was caught between duty and my personal views. Seren and Thane wielded a level of control over the colony that was almost biblical. I didn't know what they'd do when they discovered our stowaway, but the idea of turning in Jax and his uncle made me feel as jumpy as a five-year-old on career-testing day. In short, I didn't want to do it.

My breath caught suddenly, and I coughed. "Will you let me know when you find him?" I asked, then faked a cough again. "I'm just going to grab a cup of water."

"I will. And Astra, don't worry about those mushrooms. I'm sure they'll turn up."

Hurrying away, I rounded the corner of a building and pressed the spot on my chest. The medicine shot into my lungs and I let out a puff of green-tinged air. As I breathed deeply in and out until the strain on my lungs eased, I closed my eyes, standing quietly for a moment and thinking about what I should do. One part of me said the right thing would be to report Jax's uncle. I rationalized that they wouldn't punish him. They might take away privileges from Jax or possibly demote him, but the fact was, the colony needed him. We couldn't afford to lose his expertise.

But what if Uncle Harm was indeed responsible for the murder? He might have done something accidentally to cause the man's death. What would Seren do then? It was possible they'd decide to put him to death as an example to others. Jailing someone didn't make sense. It would take away valuable resources from the colony. In the multifarious, fledgling colonies I'd studied with Thane, they'd established a sort of martial law. It was extremely important to the success of a colony that criminal activity be quashed immediately and was often done harshly.

Then I told myself it didn't matter, I'd promised Jax.

I tried to continue working, but tension pulsed in my neck and shoulders and pushed up to my temples, swelling behind my eyes. Slapping on a med patch, I headed back to my bunk and closed my eyes. Without intending to, I slept deeply, only to be woken by a determined knock sharp enough to raise my heavy lids.

After stumbling to the door, I palmed the pad and it slid open. On the other side was a too perky Jax with a billion-watt smile, only eclipsed by the brightness of his blue-green eyes. He looked wonderful, which made me feel that much more sleep tousled.

"You're entirely too happy considering the fact that only one of the suns is kissing the horizon," I said, turning around and shuffling back to my bed.

"Already thinking of kissing?" he teased. "Must be my southern charm at work."

"Just because you were raised off the grid doesn't mean you're southern or even particularly charming, for that matter."

"That sounds like a good topic to discuss on our hike."

"I don't think I can go," I mumbled into my pillow. "Too sleepy. Also, I'm recovering from a massive headache."

"Ah. Does your head still hurt?"

Cracking open an eye, I considered. "No. I guess not."

"Then you don't need this." He reached down and shifted my hair aside before gently pulling off the med patch. As he folded it between his fingers and searched for a trash receptacle, he said, "I never liked those things. I think they leave behind side effects that cause more problems than they solve."

"Spoken like a true anti-stabber."

“I never thought you would be one to perpetuate labels and stereotypes. Not everyone who lives off grid is anti-registration, anti-establishment, or against vaccinations. I had them, you know.”

“I know. I saw it in your record.”

Jax bristled, then relaxed and sighed. “I can’t say I’m surprised. I don’t even mind you knowing my history. It’s Thane knowing that bothers me.”

“Why?” I asked, sitting down and pulling a brush through my hair.

He shrugged. “I don’t trust him.”

My hand froze mid tug. “He was in your domicile,” I said softly. I don’t know why I told Jax. It just suddenly felt important.

“Yeah. Figured as much. He’s been pinging me for the last thirty-six hours.”

“Aren’t you going to answer him?”

“Nah. If he really wanted to track me down, he could ask my team. They know where I am most of the time.”

“So you’ve been turning off the tracker on your tablet?”

“No. I just don’t take it with me when I’m on duty.”

“Why not? What if you need to look up information or need it to help you fix something?”

“I know how to do most things without it. I don’t like to depend on computers for answers. Any idiot can use a tablet to figure out how to fix something. That might work in big cities on Earth, but out here, the rules don’t always apply. You have to learn to lean on your own understanding. It’s how I was raised. The inability to think outside the box is something that limits most engineers, especially in places like this.” He tapped my bare foot with his boot. “Now are we going looking for samples or aren’t we?” he asked.

“Okay,” I said. “We’re going. Just let me get dressed first.”

“Fine. I’ll be waiting at the tree line.”

He headed out, the door swishing softly closed behind him.

When I was dressed, I checked in at the lab and found it empty except for a large glass cylinder filled with tiny fish. The spiders were gone. Grabbing a sample bag, I slung it across my shoulder, tossed in enough rations to refresh us during the hike, and ran out to meet Jax. The pink morning clouds melted away beneath the red sun’s rays, leaving the sky a brilliant teal color just different enough to remind me I wasn’t on Earth. The

shade reminded me of Jax's eyes. When I strode up to him, he offered to carry my bag though he already had one of his own. I shook my head and indicated he should lead the way.

There was a definite trail he followed, and as we walked, he stopped to point out several plants he thought would be of interest. I took images of flowers that gave off the odor of rotting flesh that he'd dubbed *cadaver lilies*, took a sample of venom from a fruit that looked like a purple tomato with fangs, and let something he called an *octafern* wrap its soft tentacles around my fingers.

"It doesn't bite," he said. "I wouldn't mind a pet octafern, actually. They like to be rubbed at the base. All the tentacles spread out and relax."

"You know you really shouldn't be out here touching these things," I said. "You don't know what they do. Giving us time to catalog and study everything first would be more logical."

"All you science types take years to study one tiny plant. Besides, Uncle Harm's the one figuring it all out. He has a real affinity for nature. Spends a lot of time in the forest. You did say you wanted to meet him."

"You mean you've relocated him already?"

Jax shrugged. "Most of the work on his hut was done already. He's more at home out here than in the colony anyway. The only time he comes to the colony is when he wants to tell me something."

I was secretly relieved to hear it. Maybe after some time, Thane would stop searching for Jax's uncle in connection to the death of the head of the aquasystems team.

The trees seemed to welcome us. The path was easy and the foliage beautiful. The sun shone through the branches in feathery patches, warming my arms and face as we walked. Spying a blue reed-like bush, I stopped to capture an image. Crouching down, I shot one picture and then sidled closer.

"Careful," Jax said. "We call that one a bullwhip."

"Bullwhip?"

Before I could react, the plant moved. One of its long reeds drew back and snapped, slashing my forearm and leaving a red welt. It shifted away again as I quickly scrambled back, but I wasn't fast enough. This time Jax caught it with his bare hand. When the reed retreated, it left a bloody smear

on Jax's palm. He refused to let me spray a healing salve on the wound, preferring to wrap it in a clean cloth from his bag instead.

Touching my bruised arm, I hissed. "Bullwhip is a good name for that one."

"They only do that when you get close."

Rubbing my arm, I frowned. "It doesn't make sense."

"What doesn't?"

"Why would a plant on a planet with no animal life develop protections like that?"

"What do you mean?"

"Well, you know cacti on Earth have spines so desert animals don't dig holes in it to steal its water."

"Is that why roses have thorns, because deer would eat them otherwise?"

"Roses don't have thorns, they're called prickles."

"Prickles? I don't know. I've seen some pretty sharp thorns."

I shrugged off his comment and took some notes, explaining to him as I did so. "Some plants evolve defenses, like stinging nettles that impale the caterpillars that eat their leaves, or they produce a toxic oil like poison ivy. Other plants release chemicals to drive off predators or they close their leaves when touched to make them less appealing."

"Oh! I found one of those."

"Really?" I asked distractedly.

"Yeah. I'll show it to you. So, what else do these defensive plants do?"

"Well, there's one that shoots poison crystals into the mouth of any insect that tries to eat it."

"Interesting." He rubbed a hand over his jaw. "You know, just because there aren't any animals here doesn't mean nothing attacks these plants. Maybe they're cannibalistic."

I laughed. "As is attack of the killer tomatoes?"

Jax grinned. "I've seen that one too. Prepare yourself to be bested when it comes to old vids. I'm somewhat of an expert on the subject. But speaking of killer tomatoes, that purple one we saw back there looked like it had a nasty bite. Think it eats its fellows?"

Biting a lip, I considered. “Well, it’s possible. There is a vampiric sort of plant on Earth. It wraps vines around other plants and drains them of nutrients.”

“Huh,” he said. “Maybe the bullwhip plant drives them off and the stinky flower protects itself by smelling bad.”

“You might have something there. It’s a compelling idea. But as far as I can tell, nothing eats these plants or attacks them. I’ve yet to even find a dead branch on a tree. It’s very strange. Maybe it has something to do with the way they deteriorate the moment we detach them from their environment. If that’s true of all the flora here, then there doesn’t seem to be any reason for them to develop these defenses. In all the studies I’ve done, I’ve determined that every plant species we’ve documented thus far is symbiotic in nature.”

“So they have no natural enemies?”

“Not that we’ve seen.”

“Well, unless you count us.”

I shook my head. “We’ve only been here a short time. It would take centuries for the plants to develop a way to thwart us.”

“Speaking of being thwarted, remind me to show you these exploding pod plants my uncle found. They produce a fog that causes you to pass out.”

“Like a form of anesthesia?”

“Maybe? The effects last about an hour.”

“Sounds like you had some personal experience with that one,” I teased, slightly jealous that most of my time had been taken up by other duties. I would love to explore the forest with Jax more often. Field work was always my favorite aspect of my job. I hated being trapped behind a microscope, but Thane and his father wanted to take things slowly and prioritize. I understood why, I really did, but there was something about being in the forest that centered me. It made me want to disappear inside it and leave the colony and everything it stood for far behind.

Jax shrugged. “My uncle has developed a fondness for them. He’s used them to form an alarm system around his cabin.”

“How did he transplant them without killing them?”

“Trial and error. Mostly my error,” Jax said with a laugh. “Once a pod goes off, all the work stops until I wake up. The key is to get the whole root

system. That, and my uncle says you have to ask the pod if it doesn't mind moving."

"Ask...the pod?"

"I told you my uncle's mind doesn't exactly work right anymore. He likes to ask and I figure it doesn't hurt anything." He peered down at my hands and tapped my tablet. "Aren't you going to write that one down, Astra Meador?"

He smiled, and I was momentarily befuddled by the nearness of his body and the way he said my name. I stared at his mouth just a bit too long and he noticed.

Taking a quick step back, I mumbled, "Oh. Sure."

When I was done tapping, Jax held out a hand and raised his eyebrow in challenge as if daring me to take it. Just to prove a point, I slid my palm against his gingerly and found I liked how his big, calloused hand wrapped so warmly around my own. "You know," he said, his smooth voice distracting me in a nearly alarming way, "I never thought your job was that interesting. I just figured you were gathering leaves and analyzing cuttings, but when you talk about it, I can't help but be fascinated. Even if the ideas I'm proposing are more science fiction than science."

"Plants are fascinating," I agreed, happy to talk about a subject I was comfortable with. "As to the science fiction part, curiosity and discovery are what has always driven science forward."

Jax eyed me. "I'm not so sure it's the plants fascinating me so much as it is the plant scientist. I could listen to you talk about plants for hours."

"I'd be happy to teach you," I said.

"Sure. As long as you don't mind instructing a student who has a crush on his teacher."

"Oh," I said lamely, not sure how to respond and feeling suddenly unsettled. "I guess I don't...mind."

He shifted closer, staring at my mouth, and I thought he was going to kiss me. I even closed my eyes, but when it didn't happen and I opened them, he smiled and pointed out something over my shoulder.

It was a gorgeous flowering plant he called a blood orchid, one that spat blister-causing juices. After that, we moved on and he showed me a bush he called tangle weed, saying it reminded him of tumbleweeds except they were green and looked like a tangled head of hair.

After I took a DNA sample of large tuber sticking partially out of the ground, he asked, “How different is plant DNA from animal?”

“Ready for your first lesson then?” I teased.

He nodded. “Figure I can’t have recess until I learn something first.”

I swallowed, wondering if he was thinking recess would be what I was thinking it might be.

“Not...not as different as you might think,” I replied distractedly and then quickly warmed to the topic. “The shape of it is the same—a double helix—but the sequencing is slightly different. The arranging of the nucleotides is key. That determines if you will grow leaves or fingers, a husk or hair. Animals also have more chromosomes than plants. In the past, there were some interesting studies done where the DNA from different organisms was combined. It started with creating crops that were resistant to insects, but nature adapted. Superbugs evolved. Still, scientists pressed forward, creating everything from shelf-stable produce to biofuel to fluorescent pets to the infamous green wonderbars.”

“I remember Uncle Harm talking about those. He’s railed against them since he was young. Said the fallout from those wonderbars justified living off the land and that they were probably made from human parts like soylent green.”

“What’s soylent green?”

“Ah! An old vid I’ve seen that you haven’t. It’s one of Uncle Harm’s favorites. Soylent green was how an overpopulated world got their protein. The dead were processed into food. You’d probably like that one. It’s fascinating to see what our ancestors thought the future would look like. Maybe we can see it together the next time our free hours overlap.”

“Yeah, sure,” I said. “Next time.” All my free time was supposed to be at the same intervals as Thane. He’d be sure to notice if I scheduled myself opposite of him again. As for the vids, my mother never believed in watching vids for entertainment. Only for study. Because of that, most of our recreational time was spent outdoors tending to her garden. I frowned, wondering how entertaining a vid would be where the scientists harvested humans for food. “The wonderbars weren’t made from human parts,” I said, “though they did contain all the protein and nutrients you would need to survive a week.”

“Wasn’t the wonderbar what started all the panic in the first place?”

“Not in the beginning. People liked them. They tasted like chocolate, if I recall, but people liked eating for eating’s sake. They also liked variety, so different versions were produced. But ultimately, the population ended up consuming too many wonderbars. Instead of the one per week that was recommended, they’d eat several per day. It was a product designed to eliminate hunger worldwide, but it became addictive. Then there were the brain studies and, eventually, incontrovertible evidence was brought forward proving that the genetically modified products were not only harming us but also destroying the planet.”

“That’s when the accords were passed.”

“Yes. My mother was one of the leaders in bringing back truly organically grown produce by cloning fossilized seeds from the past. It wasn’t easy. Naturally growing plants had been almost completely eradicated, but nature has a way of balancing things...in most cases.”

My bag slipped off my shoulder and Jax caught it easily, gently lifting it back into place. His eyes studied me beneath his sooty eyelashes. He could tell I was holding something back, and standing there with him looking at me, I felt as exposed as a skinned vegetable.

“She broke the accords for you. Didn’t she?” he asked.

“I’m sure you already guessed that much, knowing what you know.”

He cocked his head. “You mean there’s more to it?”

I nodded and turned away. “She and my father...well...they couldn’t have children. My...weakness at birth was a side effect, a consequence of her breaking the law to conceive.”

“I see.”

I couldn’t look at him. Couldn’t image what he was thinking. Not only was I completely dependent on a plant compound to survive, carrying a deformity that would likely be genetically passed down to any potential offspring, but I represented everything his family despised. I shouldn’t be alive at all, let alone on this new planet. And now, here I was, about to meet his uncle, the one who’d taught him how to work without the aid of computers or modifications of any kind, the one who was so determined to let nature take its course that he was now suffering with a debilitating disease of his own.

I felt a warm hand grip my shoulder. When I didn’t turn, Jax came around me and slid his hands up to my cheeks with a tenderness that offset

the tightness of his jaw and the rigid muscles of his forearms.

“First of all, you are not responsible for the decisions your parents made.” His thumbs traced my cheekbones. “And I am not at all sorry they made the choice to have you. You are remarkable. The only redoubtable leader in the colony, in my opinion. You’re dedicated to your work, fair, and loyal.”

“I’m flawed,” I added. “It’s just that my biggest flaws are beneath the surface.”

His fingertips grazed down the side of my neck until they fluttered at my collarbone just above the spot of synthetic skin.

“Astra,” he breathed my name in a whisper, “Can’t you see? You’re perfect in your imperfection.”

I don’t know what made me say it, but the words came out and it was too late to pull them back. “Thane wouldn’t see it that way,” I said.

Jax stiffened and backed away so I could clearly see the unease rippling in his now gelid eyes. The warmth from just a moment before had chilled, curling up and dying like a leaf in the fall, and I could feel the cold filling the space between us.

“You shouldn’t care what Thane thinks,” he said, turning and striding ahead.

I jogged to keep up, feeling guilty when I saw the anger on his face.

“You’re mad,” I said.

“Yes,” he conceded. “Not that I have any right to be.”

“What do you mean?”

“It’s your life, Astra. If you want to spend it groveling at Mr. Perfect’s feet, then who am I to spoil your dream?”

“Believe it or not, it’s not my dream to grovel at Thane’s feet.”

“No? Sure seems like it is.”

“He doesn’t want me groveling. He’s not as bad as you believe he is.”

Jax whirled around, surprising me, and I bumped into his very hard chest. He caught me, steadying me so I didn’t fall. When I was stable, his hands still cupping my arms, he asked, “If Thane’s all that a girl could hope for, then why don’t you trust him with your secret? Nash told me we are the only two in the colony who know.”

“I...I haven’t told him because...” My mouth gaped as I tried to find the answer, but try as I might, there wasn’t one. I did trust Thane, but there was

still a tiny, niggling doubt deep down inside me that said he'd never accept it. It was like a mosquito bite, and I was afraid that if I scratched it, the itching would become unbearable. "I haven't told him for the same reason I haven't told anyone else. No one would understand."

"Understand or stand by you?" Jax countered. "Which of those are you afraid Thane won't do?"

His words cut me. The dark brows above his lovely eyes slanted as sharp as a knife's edge, compelling me to answer.

"I don't know," I managed to say.

"Well, maybe you should figure it out." He sighed, squeezed my shoulders, and said, "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to sound accusatory. My uncle says my social niceties are as few and far between as teeth on a hillbilly."

"What's a hillbilly?" I asked.

"You'll have to ask him," he answered, parting a section of vines. "We're here."

Before us stood a beautiful little cabin made from colony scraps and, even more surprising, living trees.

Chapter 15

Spaced Out

“That...that’s amazing!” I marveled, staring up at the tree house nestled between several large branches. There were not one or two but at least five glass pods connected by makeshift bridges, but instead of rope tying the bridges to the pods, living branches made up the handholds, and vines held the steps in place. Above each pod was a brilliant green umbrella canopy unlike anything I’d ever seen before. It was too imperfect to be manmade and yet nothing like it would occur so naturally or spontaneously.

Jax led me toward a circular staircase that wound around a huge tree leading up to the first pod. As he did, he warned me not to step on the large watermelon-sized globes. “Break one of those and you’ll pass out. They’re the early-warning system my uncle set up around the perimeter that I told you about.”

“But...but all this is impossible. I thought your uncle had advanced neurodegeneration.”

“He does. At least, I think he does. Or he did.” Jax shook his head and explained, “Uncle Harm never agreed to see a doctor, so he’s self-diagnosed. His symptoms don’t exactly follow the descriptions of the disease we’ve researched. He’s what you might call unique.”

“Unique how?”

“You’ll see when you meet him.” Jax started up the steps circling the tree. “He insists that his symptoms have been improving since we arrived. He may be right about some of them, but I think his hallucinations are getting worse.”

“Hallucinations?”

“Yeah. He says he can talk to the trees.”

“Interesting,” I said, pulling up some data to browse on the subject of neurodegeneration.

“Oh, and you might want to put that away,” Jax said. “Advanced technology of any kind drives him crazy.”

“But it’s just a tablet,” I said, shaking it to emphasize its simplicity. “They’ve been around for longer than he’s been alive, in one form or other.”

Jax held up his hands as if surrendering. “I’m just warning you. It’s your call. But if you want to get off on the right foot...”

He left the sentence open-ended. I bit my lip, thinking, and then slid the tablet into my bag along with the samples we’d collected. When we reached the top of the bridge, Jax held out an arm to stop me. Reaching down into a woven basket, he picked up what looked like a green pine cone and tossed it onto the roof of the first pod. When there was no response, he did it again, and a third time. Finally, a door was thrust open and a stooped older man hollered across the distance, “It never fails. Why do you always show up just when I’m getting ready to sit down for a nice roost, boy?”

“I plan it that way,” Jax shouted back, his face reddening slightly as he glanced sideways at me.

The man peered at Jax. “Who’s that with ya?”

“A friend from the colony. Her name’s Astra. She’s the one you watched over when you woke.”

“Ah, the girl who cried. Is she cryin’ now?” Harm asked.

“No. She just wants to meet you.”

Uncle Harm looked a little disappointed at that news. “Oh. That right, girl? You’re here ta meet me?” Uncle Harm shuffled a bit like he’d lost his balance but caught himself on the branch rail.

“Yes?” I said.

“Speak up, girlie,” he cried. “I’m nearly deaf.”

“Yes!” I shouted, nodding my head in an exaggerated way.

The man snorted and waved an arm in the air. “Come on, then. Don’t waste my time.”

Jax offered his hand and I took it, allowing him to help steady me as we crossed the bridge. Once inside the pod, I ran my hand over the inside of the perfectly round glass. “What is this?” I asked.

“It’s my own take on aerogel. It weighs almost nothing, but just a handful of it can support the largest building on Earth. It allows in air when you want circulation but keeps out the rain. I just mixed up a few batches, filled them with air, and let them dry.”

“They’re beautiful,” I said. “How did you get them up here?”

Jax cleared his throat. “That’s a question best left for my uncle to answer. Speaking of which, we’d better follow him before he forgets we’re here,” he said.

The first pod was set up to be a comfortable lounge on one side and a mudroom on the other. I spied some very dirty boots, a shovel, some scattered shirts and jackets hung on pegs or thrown over chairs, and a simple first-aid kit with old-fashioned wraps and bandages. There wasn’t a med patch or a med distributor in sight.

I pointed to a thick, leather-bound stack of papers. “Is that a...a book?” I asked.

“He keeps handwritten notes on the things he finds in the forest, including drawings of plants, and a few poems he likes. Uncle Harm claims a tablet can be robbed of its secrets quicker than a dull and desperate man playing poker can go bankrupt.”

Not having any experience with the game of poker or any other mode of gambling, I said, “I’ve never seen an actual book. I mean a real physical one.”

“Yeah? You should see his library.”

“You mean he has more like this?” I asked incredulously. Such a collection would have been priceless back on Earth.

Jax just laughed, took my hand, and led me through the opening to the next pod. It was a miniature greenhouse. “He has cuttings!” I exclaimed. “And they’re from this planet! I didn’t think it was possible.” I fingered what was unmistakably one of the purple and white flowers Jax and I had come across before in the clearing. “How is he doing this?” I asked.

“How am I doing what?” the man replied, coming back through the opening from the third pod and adjusting his belt while tucking in his shirt. “It’s rude ta talk about a man when he’s standin’ right here!”

Turning back to the plant, I quickly backpedaled. “I’m sorry,” I said. “I just can’t believe you got these to grow!”

“Course I got them to grow. That’s what plants do, ya know.”

“I know, but back at the colony, they all die.”

“Phst,” he spat and then took the potted flower from me, tucking some more soil around the stem. “They’ll grow if’n ya just ask ’em.”

“Ask them,” I said slowly and then looked at Jax with wide eyes. He just shrugged and pointed subtly to his head.

“Oh, right,” I stammered. “So, I’ve brought some lunch if you’d like to share, Uncle Harm,” I suggested.

“Lunch?” He perked up quickly and spun so fast he nearly fell.

I grabbed his arm to steady him. “Are you okay?”

“I’m fine. The trees are always messin’ with my balance.”

“Right. Trees will do that,” I said.

“They’re sassy old biddies. Like ta show me who’s in charge every once in a while. Come on with me to the kitchen.”

He led us through the third pod, which appeared to be a bathroom complete with shower, before stopping at the fourth, where there was a basket full of greens as well as alien fruits and vegetables. Some I recognized but others were new. “Have you eaten all of these?” I asked, examining a purple fruit that looked like a cross between a dragon fruit and an eggplant.

Uncle Harm snickered. “If I ate ’em all, they wouldn’t be in my basket, now, would they?”

Peering in my eyes, his thick caterpillar eyebrows raised, he waited expectantly while I stood there, fruit in hand, blinking.

“I’m teasin’ ya, young lady,” he said, wiggling his eyebrows. “Not much for humor, this one,” he said over his shoulder to Jax.

“Let her get to know you a bit before you bombard her with the full weight of your attention, Uncle Harm,” Jax said. “You can be a little overwhelming, you know.”

“It’s fine, Jax,” I said.

“See?” Uncle Harm countered. “The girl said she’s fine. Now,” he said, clapping his hands, rubbing them together. “What’s for lunch?”

I pulled my bag across my shoulder and dug through it. “It’s not a lot,” I said self-consciously. “I only brought enough to tide us over during the hike.” Sitting at the table, I pulled out the rations—a few nutrient bars, bottles of water, and some rare oranges I’d stashed after studying with Thane. Jax and Uncle Harm both reached for one.

Jax brought the globe to his nose and inhaled. “It’s real,” he said, marveling at the fruit.

Uncle Harm rolled his between his hands, testing its weight. "This came from the ship's stores?" he asked.

"Yes," I said. "I have access to Thane's and Seren's food distributors."

Uncle Harm sputtered and rolled the fruit back toward me. "No, thank you. Anything been preserved by that giant computer you call a ship isn't fit to go in my stomach," he said, then touched his index finger to his nose. "It ain't right no more. Mark my words. Maybe it used to be, but now it's tainted. What we need here is some real food." Right after saying that, he let out a loud belch and patted his round belly. He put his hands on the table to rise, but his body jerked suddenly, and he lifted his hands that had begun to spasm with tremors, staring at them like he couldn't understand what he was seeing.

"I'll make up a salad," Jax offered, standing up. "Meanwhile, I'd sure like to eat that orange," he said over his shoulder.

"Okay," I answered. As I peeled the oranges, I tried not to notice Uncle Harm's trembling hands or the fact that he was now staring vacantly out the window. "Are you sure you don't want any?" I asked him, but he didn't reply. "Jax?" I whispered softly, wondering why he wasn't as disturbed as I was at seeing what was happening to his uncle.

"He's okay. He'll come out of it in a minute," he said, setting a bowl of greens on the table along with a sliced alien fruit assortment. He then handed me a plate and a fork carved from wood. I examined them carefully, wondering when Jax would have had the time to make such beautiful pieces. When I asked him about it, his uncle blinked rapidly and then spoke as if he hadn't missed a beat.

"No recycler here," he exclaimed. "Hand wash and keep the tools I make. People forget things don't come from thin air. Can't appreciate it that way. Trees agree with me. Gave me the dead ones to make the plates you're eating off of."

"The dead branches, you mean?" I asked, picking through the various leaves and lettuces on my plate, examining their structure.

When he didn't answer, I looked up.

"We don't waste the food here, young lady," Uncle Harm said. "Some of those plants gave their lives to feed us. If you're not hungry, I'll finish your salad."

“No...no, I’m hungry,” I said quickly. “I just wanted to make sure these were edible.”

“Course it’s edible,” Uncle Harm replied, shoveling a giant forkful into his mouth and crunching loudly. “They’re not trying ta kill ya. Believe me, if they wanted to, they could find an easier way.”

“Right,” I said, nibbling on a piece of purple lettuce. It was delicious and had a slight citrus flavor that went well with the orange.

“Uncle Harm,” I said, stabbing my salad, “Jax mentioned you watched over me when I woke on the ship?”

“That’s right.”

“Why didn’t you show yourself?”

“Not supposed to, was I? My nephew made it blatantly clear that I needed to keep my presence a secret.”

“You did a good job with that. Nobody knows you’re here.”

“Nobody except the trees. And they’re all that matter now, aren’t they?”

“I suppose,” I answered.

After a beat, Uncle Harm asked, “Why were you cryin’ on the ship? Were you lonely? I can understand that. A body goes a mite mad when they’re alone too long.”

Had that been what happened to Harm? I glanced at Jax but his expression was unreadable. “I was crying because my father died on the trip.” A thought occurred to me. “Did you see what happened to him?” I asked. “The vids from that time stamp were destroyed.”

“Nah,” he said. “Wish I could help ya. Spent most of my time away from the pods. Felt like I was an undertaker if I stayed with them too long.”

“An undertaker? What’s that?” I asked.

“For a smart girl, she don’t know too much about her own planet’s history,” Harm said to Jax.

“If you keep offending her, I’m not going to bring her around again,” Jax threatened.

“I’m not offended. Just curious,” I said.

“Undertakers used to take care of dead bodies and arranged burials. Surely you’ve seen some of the old protected cemeteries?”

I had. Most of the cemeteries had been destroyed long before I was born. Land was a precious commodity, especially since the Earth was overcrowded, hence the need for terraforming new worlds. There were only

a few left, and it was ironically the scientists who lobbied along with historians to keep at least some buried bodies intact. The famous or those of historical importance were relocated. I'd visited the site of the former George Washington Monument. The building had proved unsalvageable long before even my mother was born and the precious White House lawn was converted into one of the last cemeteries.

We'd visited it when I was young, my mother explaining that the green surface and the lovely cherry trees hid thousands of bodies beneath the ground. Each coffin had been dug up and carefully preserved in impenetrable boxes pumped full of bacteria-resistant chemicals and then stacked up box upon box as far down as one hundred meters deep. All other bodies were cremated and the land repurposed. Some people believed the land was cursed or that ghosts lived alongside the new apartment dwellers, but my mother thought such superstition was ridiculous.

"I've seen the cemetery on the White House lawn," I said.

Harm sputtered. "Please. That's not a proper cemetery. I'm talking about the other small cemeteries. Those that were preserved intact."

I shook my head. "No. I haven't seen them. I didn't know any of them were preserved."

He was finished with his salad and staring at mine. I gently nudged my plate closer to him and he tucked in on my leftovers with gusto.

"Not surprised," he said, a piece of lettuce sticking out of his mouth. "Most of them are a bit off the beaten path."

"You mean off the grid." There were several pockets of protected land that were purposely left wild. No one was supposed to live in those nature reserves, but as long as the people who resided there made a minimal environmental impact, they were, for the most part, left alone. It was a strange sort of nomadic existence, and the science council pushed to allow it.

The cultures of the world such as they had been centuries before were practically nonexistent now. They had intermixed to the point of losing their various unique cultures and languages. But there were a few special places on Earth that were protected, studied. Cultures such as the indigenous tribe still existing on the Andaman Islands or the Adavasi of India, who now lived in a geodome. I understood why they'd been preserved from a

scientific perspective. Those cultures gave us a peek into where we came from and how we lived.

As for me, I was a creature of the future. I didn't want to explore where we came from, I wanted to see what we could become. The idea of discovery was exciting to me. The fact that Uncle Harm seemed to have progressed further with the native plants than I had with all my scientific background bothered me. Maybe it was his isolation that produced his results. Perhaps he had an innate sense of the forest and how it worked simply because he lived in it. I couldn't imagine living away from people though. Perhaps I would be able to focus better, but I'd miss my brother and Jax. I even enjoyed my lessons with Thane and Seren.

"All the best things left on Earth are off the grid."

"But aren't the best things people? Surely you missed your nephew when he left to be an engineer."

"Missed him something fierce. It's partially why I agreed to stow away on the ship."

"You also liked the idea of an entire planet that was untouched by technology," Jax added.

"You've obviously embraced some technology though," I said. "Look at these pods Jax made for you."

"Jaxson has always been inventin' things. Long as I can remember, he was good with his hands." Uncle Harm smiled proudly at his nephew.

"I'm sure you used some kind of tech to position them up here in the trees."

"Did not!" he blustered. "I'm offended that you would suggest such a thing."

"Then how—?"

"The trees helped me," he said, interrupting.

"Right," I said placatingly, "the trees. But now that you're here," I continued, "wouldn't you like to interact with the other colonists? Maybe move in with Jax so you can spend more time with him? It's not like they're going to send you home now."

Uncle Harm folded his arms across his chest. "Maybe they wouldn't. Don't mean they'd embrace me with open arms. Besides, I prefer the forest. Here we got an entire planet untouched by human hands. Not that the

precious colony of yours is gonna leave her that way. Nope. They've got to destroy things to be happy."

"That's not true of all of us," I said.

"Don't matter. Them that make the decisions abandon good intentions like they do outdated technology, discarding something perfectly useful in favor of the latest thing. Then they rationalize to themselves in unnecessary meetings that waste more time about how they had no choice when they considered it more carefully and how really it was all for the best."

"Uncle Harm," Jax warned.

The older man flexed his hands. "Tingling's back. Get me the salve, would ya, boy?"

Jax rose and brought his uncle a small container. When Uncle Harm opened it, I inhaled a pungent scent.

As he rubbed the salve on his hands, I asked what it was, picking up the container and sniffing. It had the faint aroma of something like eucalyptus.

"I call it scalding sap," he answered. "If you boil down the plants that shimmer at night with blue fire and blend the mixture, lettin' it set overnight, it becomes this thick, oily paste. It's real good for arthritic joints."

"You have arthritis?" I asked, surprised.

"Among other things."

"But there's a patch for that."

"And who knows what other chemicals those patches circulate in my body?"

I was going to point out that the untested mixture he was using now was certainly more dangerous than the time-tested medicines we'd relied on for centuries, but when I looked over at Jax, he shook his head slightly, indicating I should proceed with caution. Instead, I asked, "How did you discover this salve?"

"Didn't discover it. Trees told me about it." He leaned closer and added with a dramatic whisper, "They have secrets."

"Do they? Maybe they'll share their secrets with me."

"Doubtful," he said.

"Why?"

"Got ta believe in them first and you science types only believe what you can see and test."

“I see. Well, maybe you’ll share a secret with me then.”

“I’m an open book,” he crowed, throwing his arms out wide and shifting back, balancing on only two legs of his chair.

“Good, then tell me how you really got the pods up in the trees.”

Uncle Harm peered at me and I got the impression he was drawing out all my hidden secrets.

“How about you show her your library instead? Astra’s never seen a real book before.”

“Oh, I do want to see them!” I said. “I’m surprised you were able to smuggle them on board,” I said to Uncle Harm.

“Helps to have an engineer nephew who can make hidden compartments on a ship.”

“I guess it does,” I replied, thinking of how my own parents hid my medicine on board the ship and how my mother was now imprisoned on Earth because of it. I frowned. But if that was the reason she was detained, then why were her hidden stores of plants to produce my serum left on board?

My thoughts turned back to Harm as he got to his feet and slowly led the way to another pod. He muttered to himself as he moved along, talking to the air and carrying on conversations with invisible people as his hands twitched at his sides. “It’ll be like catching raccoons with a somethin’ sparkly,” he said, cackling crazily afterward. Then he stopped at a round plant that was slightly drooping and lectured it, “Use the grippers, ya toothy cabbage.”

Jax leaned down and whispered in my ear, “I’m so sorry about him, Astra.”

I took hold of his hand and squeezed it. “Don’t give it a second thought. Believe me when I say that my parents had quirks of their own. Just wait till you meet my mother,” I said before I remembered that we were on an uncharted planet, pulled off course, with no hope of ever escaping. Suddenly, I wanted to tell Jax. Seren had let months pass without sharing that rather disturbing piece of information with the colonists. They deserved to know.

“Jax?” I said, looking at him over my shoulder as we crossed another bridge.

“What is it?” he asked.

“There’s something I have to tell you.”

Uncle Harm opened the door of the last pod and threw back his hand with a flourish. “Welcome to the only library on the planet Gaia.”

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Chapter 16

Out of This World

“What do you mean, the planet Gaia?”

“That’s her name,” Uncle Harm replied easily.

“Let me guess, the trees told you?” I asked as I passed by him, entering the fifth pod.

“Sure as shootin’,” he said.

“Oh, wow,” I said, awestruck.

The fifth pod housed the most amazing collection of antiques I’d ever laid eyes on. Stacks and stacks of carefully preserved books were arranged in rows based not on size or shape but on subject. I saw everything from space exploration to the Bible. From the *History of the World, the one-hundredth edition* to the complete collection of *Curious George*. He stood by while Jax gave me the grand tour, pointing out certain books he loved as well as those he’d been meaning to read but hadn’t finished yet.

I found out, as the minutes ticked by, that I was more fascinated with Jax and his excitement over showing me something he clearly loved than I was with the books themselves. My reaction to him still surprised me. I wasn’t the type to swoon over boys, even ones as good-looking as Jax. Science had always been my passion. I’d figured there was plenty of time for romance in my future. I was young and had a lot I wanted to accomplish before settling down. Technically, Thane was more polished, more traditionally beautiful than Jax, but I found it was the tiny imperfections I saw in Jax that I liked the most.

The way he ran his hands over the book covers, the tiny spot beneath his lower lip where he’d missed shaving and the small cut on his jaw, the scar that crossed one of his eyebrows were all little pieces of him I wanted to explore, both with my hands and in conversation. Where had he gotten the scar? Did he use an old-fashioned razor to shave instead of a facial hair

dissolver? His hair hung a bit shaggy in the back. Had he cut it specifically to mission parameters to get on the ship? Did he prefer it longer?

Jax was a mystery made even more interesting to me now that I knew about his uncle. The fact that he knew my secret already made me feel a certain level of intimacy with him. I trusted Jax. He was someone I'd like to get to know better, be friends with surely, and maybe something more. I'd definitely like to explore kissing with him again. Perhaps if I did kiss him with more frequency, the fascination with his lips would go away. Surely the hair curling at the nape of his neck wasn't as soft as it looked. I was a scientist. Testing my theory was something science demanded, wasn't it?

I twisted my hands to stop myself from reaching out and touching him, but I couldn't help drawing closer to him, letting my shoulder press against his, and memorizing his cedar-mixed-with-metal scent. He was talking about a book he loved about an old submarine that had been attacked by a giant squid, but for the life of me, all I could do was watch his lips move and wonder how it would feel to have those lips pressed against mine again.

Shouldn't I be feeling this way about Thane? Weren't we the ones who were supposedly genetically compatible? I tried to put my finger on what was different about Jax. Maybe it was the twinkle in his eye when he looked at me or the way he seemed to always know when I was close, his eyes finding me every time. Maybe it was the fact that he got along with my brother, who was notoriously independent and disliked most people.

Jax led me to a cushioned, handmade set of chairs, and when I pressed my hand against them, I heard the crackle of dead leaves. He sank into one and crossed a leg over his knee.

"Have a seat, Astra. The library looks even more impressive when your backside is sinking down nearly to the floor in one of these chairs my uncle made.

I tentatively took the seat next to him and abruptly grabbed the arms of the chair as I began to settle deeper.

"They're a bit noisy but very comfortable, I assure you," Uncle Harm said. "Much better than those metal contraptions you all sit on in the colony. Stiff backs and perfect posture isn't something I aspire to," Harm added.

"You read in these?" I asked, shifting to find a comfortable spot.

"Absolutely. Sometimes I even nap in these."

I couldn't imagine falling asleep in such a contraption. Glancing over at Jax, I saw he had maneuvered his long form in such a way that the back of the chair cushioned his head. He looked comfortable enough to drift off himself.

His hand brushed mine and he opened his eyes and gave me a smile. It was so open and happy, I found myself returning the gesture. Jax twisted his fingers through mine, but when I looked from our entwined digits to his face, he was no longer looking at me but at his uncle.

Uncle Harm's hands were shaking as he examined pieces in his collection. He droned on about different books until he finally drew out a large one. "I think you should start with this one."

He handed me a book on the mythologies of the world. I guessed it was at least three hundred years old. "But it will disintegrate when I remove the protective wrapper," I said.

"Nah. Maybe that was true on Earth with all the chemicals circulating in the air but not here. The atmosphere is pure. Trees keep it that way. It's balanced enough you can read it when you like. Just remember to put it back in the vacuum package when you're done. Over time, the chemicals used in the book's creation will destroy it, but if I'm careful, the trees say the books will last for several generations more."

"Okay," I said, gingerly taking hold of the heavy tome. I didn't exactly believe him when he said the atmosphere would protect the books and was loath to remove one from a wrapper, but my fingers still itched to examine it. I wanted to see the pictures, smell the musty paper and ink. Tracing my fingers over the cover, I closed my eyes, feeling the texture of the embossed title.

"The trees were a mite distraught when I showed them my collection," he said, stopping here and there to pull out a book, glancing briefly at it before putting it back. "Then I told them they should be proud. The history of the world was recorded on their dead branches. Course I only got a small sampling here. Had to leave all but my favorites behind. It was a travesty."

"We left them in good hands, Uncle Harm," Jax reminded him.

"Yeah. Neighbor of mine was right happy to take possession of them. He'd had his eye on my books for many years, and we had an understanding that whichever of us kicked the bucket first, the other would

inherit the collection. He was disappointed not to get his hands on some of these, but I couldn't bear to part with them."

I was even more interested to see which books he thought were the most important to bring with him and was about to ask him how he chose, when he began speaking of the trees again. I wasn't sure if the delusions associated with neuropathic disease were always so specific or if he had developed it as a coping mechanism upon landing on a forested world.

"You won't believe how angry they were," he said. "They nearly destroyed my home with their quaking. Thought they were about to do me in. But I reminded them that our human memories were lost when we passed out of existence, and without the trees, the important life lessons we learned couldn't be shared with the next generations. When they heard that, they settled down. The old one saying, 'That's as it should be, then.'"

"Do they talk to you often?" I asked, curious about his mental state during a hallucination.

He scratched his sandpaper cheek, bristly with whiskers. "Only when I'm unconscious," he said. "My mind is too full of noise to hear them most times. Even so, they seem to get through to me more often than not. Got ways of making themselves heard, they do. Course, it's better out here, being around the nature. That place you're livin' in makes the lot of you deaf as a rock."

Uncle Harm's hands started trembling again. Jax noticed and put his hand on his uncle's shoulder. "Why don't you take a nice afternoon nap, Uncle Harm, while I walk Astra back to the colony?"

"I am a mite tired," he said. "Nice to meet you officially," he said to me, offering his hand.

Shaking it, I replied, "You too. I'd love to come back and visit you again sometime. It seems you have a knack for getting the native plants to grow."

"Swing by whenever you like, young woman," he said, and then leaned closer. "Get it? Swing by? To my home in the trees?"

Giving him a sheepish smile, I shook my head.

"Swing? As in Tarzan?"

When I just shrugged, he growled and pulled another book from the shelf. "Don't come back until you've finished both of them," he warned, handing it to me. Then he shook his finger in my face. "And don't think

you'll get away with leaving them wrapped and just reading them on that tablet you've got hidden in your bag. It's not the same."

"How did you know I have a tablet?"

"Everyone has a tablet."

"Oh. I guess you're right."

"Jaxson will take you back now. I'll have a surprise for you the next time you visit."

"I'd like that," I said, already curious about what the surprise would be and hoping it was a still-undiscovered plant.

"See you soon, Uncle," Jax said.

"Take care, you two."

Jax nodded and put his hand on the small of my back, indicating I should cross the bridge first. When we got back down to the ground, I turned and looked up, finding Uncle Harm watching us. I waved and he waved back.

Our hike back through the trees was relatively quiet except for a "watch out for that branch" or a "don't get too close to that plant," warning from Jax. Once we reached the tree line, I stopped. He stood there quietly beside me, saying nothing.

"Have his symptoms changed since we landed?" I asked.

"He's much more lucid, believe it or not," Jax said.

"I'd like to see him again. He's made some breakthroughs my team and I have been struggling with for months."

Now that we were back at the colony, my excitement deflated until my spirits were as bleak as the uniform gray buildings and the barren ground. What we'd done to this section of the planet suddenly felt wrong. The way Uncle Harm lived in the trees and integrated the branches into his home and the way he honored the trees by asking permission to use them first felt right. Proper. Even if he wasn't in his right mind.

"Working with Uncle Harm will foster a much more collegial atmosphere than working with"—he paused, his mouth working as if he tasted something unpleasant—"others," he finished.

I put my hands on my hips. "I get along with my colleagues very well, thank you. Even Thane is pleasure to work with."

"I'm sure he is," Jax said, each word jagged, as sharp and piercing as a thorn. "I always assumed your sessions together were pleasant for all

concerned parties.”

I bristled. The breeze kicked up around us, making the leaves overhead tremble. They fluttered as if spurring me on in my temper that now billowed around me like steam, growing larger with each passing second.

“How dare you, Jaxson? Why would you go and ruin a perfectly nice day with such lurid accusations? Do you honestly think so little of me?” I demanded.

“No. That’s the thing. I don’t. I don’t know why I went off like that,” he said, turning away from me. “I guess I just don’t like the idea of sharing you.”

I was about to light into him about how I wasn’t a possession to share when he backtracked.

“That came out wrong. I just...I’m jealous, Astra.”

I wasn’t expecting a confession or that his answer would be so direct.

“You...you’re different than the others,” he said. “I feel connected to you. When I see you smile or catch your eye across the compound, it makes me happy.”

Adjusting the strap of my bag over my shoulder, I frowned, thinking that maybe Nash had been right and Thane had been playing with Jax’s supplements. Mine were untampered with but what about everyone else? “What are you saying?” I asked.

“I’ve wanted to get this out. It was the whole purpose of our hike but I’m screwing it up.” He blew out a breath. “Look, I don’t want to end up missing out on something amazing because I’m being too subtle. What I want to say is that I like you and I want to spend more time with you in the hopes that someday you’d end up liking me back. In a romantic way, I mean.” He folded his arms across his chest and then, unsatisfied, slid his hands into his pockets. “I wish I was better with words, but there it is.”

My heart turned to a heavy stone. It was certain. Seren had been feeding Jax a hormone cocktail, making him want to pair up with someone, and by knowing it was possible and not investigating it, I was complicit. Guilt tore through me. Then I remembered that neither Thane nor Seren would ever dose Jax to make him like me. Thane had his sights set on me for himself, saying we were a perfect match. He just didn’t know how imperfect a match I was.

Jax knew though and he still wanted me. Or maybe he just thought he did. I was sure I wasn't the target Thane would select for Jax. Maybe somebody had gotten the doses wrong.

The thing was, when I really thought about it, I didn't mind that Jax liked me. I already liked him. I mean, I thought about him constantly. It was just the idea that his feelings might be fabricated that bothered me. I didn't want them to be fake. So what was I supposed to do now? Should I tell him it was a possibility?

He'd never believe me. He'd think I was just rationalizing everything again, like I did with the pollen.

Before I could decide what to do, Jax stepped closer. He touched my ponytail, pulling his fingers through the strands. Suddenly the air grew heavy and warm, and it was as if the two of us were enfolded in a private space. It was like the fragrant petals of a giant flower had closed around us and we were the only two people who existed in a twilight world.

Almost reluctantly, he let go of my hair and, instead, took hold of my shoulders. "I don't know if you have the same feelings for me that I do for you, Astra, but I don't want to risk you not knowing and making a decision to be with Thane because you think I'm indifferent or I've just been taken over by plant pollen and can't make decisions for myself.

Biting my lip, I kept quiet, knowing that was pretty much exactly what I'd been thinking.

He went on, "I've never been one for gardening like my uncle. If something didn't work, I tampered with it, taking it apart and adjusting it until it did, but you're not a broken engine or a relay. You're a living girl. A smart, talented, pretty girl I've developed a crush on, and I'll admit, I'm not very skilled in the social graces, having lived apart from society for most of my life. There were certain things my uncle couldn't teach me.

"One thing he did pass on was his lessons on gardening. Not that I picked up any talent for it, but I do remember that he told me that beautiful flowers always take patience, time, and nurturing. I want to cultivate this thing between us, Astra. Tell me what I need to do. If you need time to think about it, I'll give you that. If you want formal courting with flowers and romantic sunsets, I can do that. If you think I'm crazy to believe we could ever be together, I'll accept that, too, and make myself scarce. I just need you to tell me, Astra, what do you want?"

What do I want? His fingers slid from my shoulders to my hands and I lifted his in mine to look at them. They were square and calloused, and his fingernails were cracked from digging in the dirt to collect my samples and probably from his work as an engineer as well. They were strong and capable and careful. I remembered how he'd torn the lettuce for his uncle and how he'd built the beautiful home in the trees, taking care of his loved one in a way the man needed and appreciated. I also considered how gently they'd handled his uncle's precious books.

If I could choose any man for myself in the colony, one I'd want to spend the rest of my life with on the planet, I'd choose Jax. He had the face and form of one of those Greek gods found in his uncle's mythology book, a mind brilliant enough to create things never before seen, and a heart kind enough to care for his uncle and humble enough to ask me how to proceed with a possible relationship.

But when I considered the possibility that his feelings weren't genuinely his own, it ground down my response, tamping it down like a seed of possibility hidden in a mound of soil.

"I don't know what to say," I mumbled uncertainly.

"Then don't say anything. Just promise me you'll think about it," he said.

"Okay. I'll think about it," I replied.

"Thank you for not rejecting me outright, especially after that display."

I nodded, thinking that jealous displays might be a side effect of the hormone therapy. It would make sense. I had some research to do and a colony leader to confront. I was thinking about how I was going to make sure no one's feelings were being tampered with when Jax kicked the dirt, said he'd see me later, and headed down the trail toward the colony.

"Jax?" I said, calling after him.

"Yeah?" he turned.

"I... Can we... I mean, I'd like that."

The grin he gave me sort of knocked me off my feet. Though his legs kept moving backward on a trail he couldn't see, he didn't take his eyes off me until he stumbled, then he finally turned and took off at a run.

His grin must have been contagious because I couldn't wipe mine off my face either.

When I got back to the colony, I knocked on Seren and Thane's domicile but they were gone. I spent the rest of the day working on the samples we'd collected and making plans to return to the forest as soon as possible so I could figure out how Uncle Harm was cultivating live samples. Several hours into my work, I remembered the books I'd been loaned and reached down to pull one out.

I read the title, *Tarzan of the Apes* by Edgar Rice Burroughs, and instead of removing the book from the protective package, I looked it up on my tablet. It didn't take me long to read through the synopsis. "Computer, begin reading," I said.

SELECT THE PARAMETERS OF THE VOCAL.

"Male, middle-aged to senior, animated voice, sound effects."

The first voice irritated me and I switched three times until I settled for a voice I liked. The story was quite riveting. It was full of adventure and romance, but it was over more quickly than I expected. I'd catalogued several plants and sorted the DNA but still had hours of work ahead of me. After the second sun set, I headed back to my small home, kicked off my shoes, and sunk onto my bed, pulling the second book out of my bag and examining it through its sleeve.

"Computer, search for Gaia."

A pleasant feminine voice began describing the Greek myth of Gaia, which told of the origins of the universe. I lay back on my bed and listened, the story evolving as I fell asleep. Slipping into a dream, I walked barefoot up a series of wooden steps and emerged on a wide platform. I recognized the area as the site where Uncle Harm lived, but the five pods were missing.

The leaves hissed almost musically as they were stirred by the breeze. I had the funny instinct that I should speak to the trees like Uncle Harm did.

"Hello?" I said to the tall and stately trunks surrounding me.

There was no response.

"Hello?" I tried again. "Uncle Harm said he spoke to you and I was wondering if you'd speak to me too."

We've already spoken to you.

But you don't listen, another voice interrupted.

I spun, trying to figure out where the sound was coming from.

She's confused.

That much is obvious.

We should tell her.

Hush. She's not ready.

"Not ready for what?" I asked, wondering what fortune my dream trees would predict.

Choose, the first tree said.

"Choose what?" I asked.

Which one do you want?

"Which...tree?" I asked.

The minds of these animals are so limited.

We must be patient.

Choose your mate. Which do you prefer?

We should just choose for her.

We need her to be comfortable.

What about the old one who talks to us?

He is not sound. There is a feebleness to his form.

Then choose the other.

"I don't understand what you want. Why do you care who I choose as a mate? What does it matter to you?"

She prefers the young one. I feel the pulse of her sap.

"Excuse me?"

But the reactions are volatile.

Not always.

Yes.

It is not good for her to be alone.

No, it is not. Her mind will warp. Animals need a mate.

"My mind is fine," I said as I started awake. My mind *was* fine. *Wasn't it?* Well, as fine as it could be if I was talking to trees. At least I was only dreaming. Clearly, I was processing the events of the day.

After scrubbing my hands over my face, I showered, ate, and then there was a knock at the door. When I opened it, one of the colonists stood there. "Sorry if I woke you," he said. "Thane sent me. He needs you to come immediately."

“What’s wrong?” I said as I slipped a lightweight jacket over my jumpsuit.

“There’s been an arrest,” he said. “You know, for the murder that happened a few days ago?”

My stomach wrenched. Had they found Uncle Harm? Not once when I was visiting with him the day before had I considered that he’d actually murdered someone. He wasn’t the type. Even if he had, it had most definitely been an accident. We needed to investigate further. Thane had pressed the panic button before we had the facts.

I followed the man to the center of the colony, the place we all gathered as a group, and it appeared that I was not the only person summoned. The entire colony was there. Thane stood next to his father on the platform. When he saw me, he waved me forward and I stepped up onto the platform beside him.

Seren said, “Ah, good. Now both of our future leaders are here beside me. Today we will decide the fate of the one who’s committed the most atrocious act a man can inflict upon another, taking away his life. If you will bring the prisoner forward then?”

Standing there next to Thane, I gripped my hands behind my back, trying to remain still. The prisoner moved through the crowd, approaching the platform from behind. They guided him up the short steps, stopping him there and blocking my view. I closed my eyes, hoping I’d figure out a way to defuse the situation. When I opened them and took in the sight of the bound prisoner, I gasped, seeing not Uncle Harm as I’d expected but Jax.

Chapter 17

Waste of Space

Leaning close to Thane, I whispered in his ear, “But the DNA wasn’t a match. He didn’t do it!”

“Then who did?” Thane replied. “We’ll speak more of this later,” he added.

“Thane?” Seren said. “If you will present the gathered evidence.”

Nodding briskly, Thane snapped to attention. “Certainly, sir.”

He took a step forward and, in a booming voice, said, “We have discovered a DNA sample from the greenhouse. It was tampered with just enough so that it didn’t implicate any of our colony members with exactness, but even so, we believe we’ve found the culprit. The accused is assistant engineer Jaxson Preston.”

There were audible gasps from the crowd followed by hushed murmuring.

Lifting his tablet, Thane swiped on a file and I heard hundreds of pings register at the same time. Everyone, including me, glanced down at our tablets to see the message that appeared blinking on our screens, a priority message from the colony leadership.

“I’ve just sent you all the data for your personal comparison. On the left is Mr. Preston’s DNA sample taken upon boarding the ship. On the right you will see the mysterious DNA sample that we found near the greenhouse. There is no other DNA in the colony that even comes close. You’ll notice the similarity in the markers. There is a definite relation.

“In addition, you will see that there is evidence that the DNA we recovered shows a potential for macular degeneration, a disease that only appears in those who live off the grid. This same disease is found in Jaxson’s DNA. Since macular degeneration is eradicated in the womb, we can rule out everyone who was born on Earth in a standard birthing center

since they are mandated to report any anomalies. That leaves only one suspect.”

Nash and I hadn't been born in a standard birthing center either, technically. At least, not with other witnesses. All computer recording was shut off and the only person there, other than my father, was Dr. Jordan, the very same man who created my implant and conducted my physical before boarding the ship. It was fortunate that my mother had enough clout to warrant a private birth and recruited her doctor friend, because when I'd been born, I was unable to breathe on my own. They rushed me into an incubator and hooked me up to a machine that breathed for me. After that, they didn't know what to do. It had been my father who suggested I might have become dependent on the medicines my mother took during her pregnancy. They quickly created a patch of the green medicine, and it steadied me enough to take me home, but I didn't thrive until they figured a way to get it into my lungs directly.

At first, they used an inhaler like doctors of long ago used for their patients who developed an ancient disease called asthma. It wasn't a permanent fix since we had to hide the device and we couldn't predict any of my episodes, so, eventually, between the three of them, they came up with an alternative. Dr. Jordan then performed the surgery that allowed me to take my medicine inconspicuously. We successfully hid my weakness after that.

Once, I asked my mother why other people cared if I had to take medicine. She told me that it wasn't that I had to take medicine, but the fact that she had gotten pregnant using the illegal and highly controversial alien plant. We'd gotten lucky. It had done what she wanted. The plant made her fertile. But it had had an unfortunate side effect on my development in the womb.

When she unexpectedly got pregnant with Nash, the early scans showed she was going to miscarry him. To save him, she slapped on not one patch of the controversial treatment but several, until the scans showed he was not only developing healthily but even at an accelerated rate. It did the trick. When he was born, full-term size though she only carried him for six months, his lungs were healthy and there was no sign of the same abnormality that afflicted me.

Because we'd both been born in a private birthing center, and her doctor doubled as her obstetrician, my mother was able to give us the standard

shots and treatments and she filled out the paperwork herself. No one doubted the illustrious Dr. Meador or Dr. Jordan and their claims on our health.

Jaxson wasn't so lucky. Living off the grid, he not only missed the normal adjustments made in the womb, but he'd also been exposed to pesticides and tainted food. He didn't have access to standard medical treatments and preventions. And though he'd said he'd been given vaccinations; it was highly doubtful that any vaccinations given to those who lived off the grid were up to date. Not to mention the fact that his ancestors hadn't bothered to purge hereditary diseases from their DNA lines. That he was as healthy as he was now was a miracle. Having two DNA samples with a potential for the same disease was glaring enough evidence, but then Thane added more.

"Both samples are also at risk for developing gallbladder disease, gout, thyroid cancer, kidney stones, and hypertension."

The crowd murmured, drawing their own conclusions and shaking their heads. Jax stood proudly before them, unflinching when they turned their accusatory eyes in his direction. Not a day before, he was the darling of the colony. The one everyone depended on to fix the little things that bothered them. I'd seen his logged hours and knew he often worked above and beyond them, giving up his free time to come to the aid of one colonist or another. Even my own team had come to rely on him time and again.

How could they so readily believe he was a murderer? How could you look into those green-flecked blue eyes and not see a kind and gentle man? One who would do anything to help his fellow crew members? Who was a friend to all? If Jaxson did have friends in the crowd, they weren't making themselves known. I couldn't spot a supportive face among them.

My hope dwindled as I lifted my own tablet and compared the two samples. I could see how the crowd would be swayed against Jax already. Then I spotted a difference and it was a big one. I tapped on Thane's shoulder and said, "But this other one is also prone to heart disease. Jaxson was inoculated against that before he signed up for the mission." I said it loudly enough so at least some of the crowd could hear me. Many tapped their screens but others still glared at Jax with distrust.

"That is true," Thane admitted loudly. "There are slight differences. To me, these small differences are evidence of DNA tampering. Someone as

adept as Mr. Preston would know how to alter his signature using magnetic field frequencies. It would be child's play."

"But what's the motive?" I asked with a bit too much panic in my voice. "Why would he want to kill Crewman Mitchell?"

Instead of gaining support from the crowd, someone hollered, "He probably killed Dr. McGivers too!"

"Maybe he's trying to sabotage the mission!" someone else yelled. "You know how those anti-stabbers operate. They serve their own agenda!"

I winced and let out a ragged breath, closing my eyes. Even I had accused Jax of being anti-establishment.

"They're terrorists!" another person called out. "He'll come for the rest of us. Mark my words!"

Thane held up his hands and the voices quieted. "I'll admit, I'm not without sympathy for the things that you've said. I've thought those very things myself. But we are not a barbaric society. Many of the anti-stabbers avoid society and live off the grid due to social phobias. Children are raised to believe the rest of us cause harm to the planet and live to deprive others of their rights. This is not what we do. We cannot allow ourselves to submit to a mob mentality. We will give the prisoner the opportunity to defend himself, and then we will decide a course of action."

I slipped my tablet into my bag and twisted the strap with anxiety but stopped when Thane turned to me. "Will you represent the accused?" he asked. "I know you have a relationship of sorts with the defendant," he said quietly.

My heart melted a bit that he would ask such a thing. Thane wasn't an unjust person. I hadn't put my trust in an unworthy guy. "Yes," I said. "I can do that."

He put a hand on my arm. "Just get him to tell us what he knows. If he has evidence that will lead us to someone else, we need to know it. And, Astra," he added, "just between us, the DNA was also found in his domicile. The facts are pretty damning. Make no mistake, I will use that information during the trial if he turns out to be uncooperative, but I didn't want to rile the crowd further."

I crossed over to the side of the platform where Jax stood and nodded to Thane. He announced that Jax would be locked in his domicile and guarded until a decision was made as to what to do with him. His trial would take

place the next morning, and as a future leader, I would be representing him. The crowd slowly dispersed and the guards stayed close. I imagined it was more to protect Jax from them instead of them from Jax. I bit my lip. I only had one day to prove Jax was innocent and find the murderer.

When the crowd was gone, Thane and Seren left, Thane casting me a backward glance and giving me a small smile and a nod, and then I followed the guards as they led Jax away.

Once Jax was locked in his domicile, me with him despite the protests of the guards, I sunk onto a chair and found myself wishing it was one of the handmade chairs belonging to Uncle Harm. He was right that our utilitarian seating was good for posture but not comfort. He paced back and forth as I said, "They know about Harm, Jax. Thane's not really looking to prosecute you. They just want you to tell them what really happened."

"And what really happened, Astra?" he spat, obviously frustrated. "Yes, uncle Harm's DNA was in the greenhouse. But that was because he was helping me figure out a way to cultivate the plants. He didn't murder anyone. Surely you don't believe him capable of something like that."

"I barely know him. I don't know what he's capable of, not really. Do I believe he murdered someone? No. At least not while he was himself."

"What does that mean?"

"It means he could have had one of his episodes. You know. When he zones out?"

"He doesn't have a murderous bone in his body! He doesn't even like harvesting the plants. You've seen him. He asks permission before he eats them."

"Then help me figure out what happened."

"Don't you think I've tried?"

"Have you though? You've been avoiding Thane as much as possible."

"Of course I have. I thought he would arrest me." He held out his arms wide. "Clearly, I should have cooperated. He's a very understanding guy, your boyfriend."

"He's not my boyfriend," I said, hurt. "I thought...I thought we talked that through."

"Does he know he's not your boyfriend?" he asked, raising an eyebrow. "Maybe if he was, he'd lighten my sentence."

“Now’s not the time,” I said softly. “We need to talk about what we’re going to do.”

We fell quiet for a few moments, me dropping my head in my hand, then I said, “You have to tell them about Harm.”

“No.”

“He would agree that your life isn’t worth keeping him a secret.”

“So now my life’s at risk?” he asked, folding his arms across his chest. “Glad we aren’t barbarians. Maybe they’d like to draw and quarter me while they’re at it.”

“Jax, you need to understand. Seren has had me and Thane watching vids of other colonies. Law breakers, especially murderers, are dealt with swiftly and harshly. They’ll need to set a precedent, send a message that actions like this will not be tolerated.”

“Even if I’m not the murderer?”

I wanted to tell him no but I didn’t believe it. Seren was perfectly capable of punishing Jax. I knew that the colony needed resolution one way or another. Otherwise seeds of doubt would become choking weeds that would destroy all we were trying to accomplish.

“I’m not going to admit to doing something I didn’t do and I’m not going to give up my uncle,” he said, interrupting my thoughts.

“Then I will,” I said.

“No!”

“Jax, you have to see reason!”

“I’m not the one being unreasonable, Astra.”

I sighed heavily. “Fine. I won’t say anything about Uncle Harm. It’s not my place. I won’t break his trust or yours in that way. But I beg you, Jaxson Preston, help me find a way to free you.” My voice broke. “I couldn’t bear it if I lost you.”

To my embarrassment, a tear slipped from my eye and trickled down my cheek. Jax saw it and knelt down next to me, taking my hands in his. “It’s going to be all right, Astra,” he promised. “Thane isn’t going to punish me, at least not terribly. They need me.”

“That’s true,” I said.

“Right. They might incarcerate me for a month, but they don’t have enough evidence to really convict me of murder. I’ll win over the other

colonists eventually too. This thing will blow over and we'll get back to normal soon. You'll see."

I wasn't sure I believed him but I nodded anyway. "Okay," I said.

"Good. Now dry those eyes and use those feminine wiles of yours to convince your boyfriend that I'm an innocent man."

"He's not my—"

"Boyfriend, I know," he said, pulling me to my feet. "But until you're ready to claim someone else publicly, it's probably in my favor to let him believe he has a chance, at least for a little longer."

He brushed a tear away with his thumb and then trailed his fingers down to my chin, tilted up my face, and kissed me. His lips were warm and I tasted the salt from my tears. My heart fluttered inside my chest like a trapped bird beating against the ribs that caged it. I couldn't lose him. Not when I was just figuring out how badly I wanted him.

Slanting his head, he deepened the kiss. His hand moved from my face and slid into my hair, teasing the strands with his fingers. When he pulled back, I whimpered and grabbed on to his shirt, unwilling to let him go.

"Astra," he said softly. My name on his lips was like a prayer as he gripped my waist and kissed me again. I loved the feel of his arms against my palms, the length of his body pressed against mine, and the way his mouth teased and soothed at the same time.

When he backed away this time, I let him, feeling every millimeter between us dispelling the heat like a blast of icy rain. My shoulders slumped but he reached out and massaged them, coaxing out the knots of tension. "Don't give up. We're going to figure out a way out of this," he said.

"You're really not worried?" I asked.

"No." He smiled, his mouth turning up at one corner. "In fact, I'm feeling rather optimistic. If a man has to go to the gallows, then that's the kind of sendoff he'd like to remember," he teased.

"I'm glad you can laugh about it," I said. "Personally, I don't find any humor in this situation."

Jax pulled me into a hug. "I have the utmost faith in you, Miss Astra Meador. You're going to find me a way out of this. I know it."

I sighed. "Then I'd better go talk to Thane."

"I wish you didn't have to," he said.

“Me too. Wish me luck.”

“You won’t need it.”

As I headed to Thane’s domicile, I considered the arguments I’d be presenting to Seren and Thane. I had nothing to go on except the fact that the DNA wasn’t an exact match. I’d have to bank on the fact that Jax was an upstanding colonist with a good reputation and hope that I could switch out the hammer they were about to bring down on his head for a feather.

I knocked on the door. Thane answered and ushered me inside. “Did he give up any further information?” Thane asked.

“No,” I replied, shaking my head. “He has no answer for the DNA but he assures me he didn’t tamper with his own.”

“I see.”

Thane rose and got me a cup of tea. It was one of my favorite blends, hibiscus. It was floral and sweet with a dash of precious cream and sugar. I sipped the hot beverage, calmed by this man who I’d come to respect over the past few months. He cared about my comfort. He wouldn’t punish Jax in any terrible way. He couldn’t. I knew it.

Sinking into the chair next to me, the corners of his mouth turned down, Thane considered me. I knew that look. It was his politician’s face. The one that showed both sympathy and disappointment. He’d never used that one on me before and I didn’t like it. I pushed away my teacup and folded my arms.

“Astra,” he began, “I don’t like doing this any more than you do.”

“Somehow, I doubt that,” I said.

“Jax has a refractory attitude. He’s rebellious. And he’s rather good at making himself scarce.”

“That doesn’t make him a murderer.”

“No, it doesn’t.” He sat back in his chair. “I know what you’re thinking,” he said.

“What am I thinking?”

“You’re thinking my accusing Jax presents some kind of windfall bonus for me.”

“Nice tautology. So, will getting rid of Jax be a windfall or a bonus? I can tell you I’m dying to find out. Oh, wait, no, Jax is dying to find out.”

“You think I want to kill him?”

“Don’t you?”

“I can’t believe you think I’m that kind of person.”

“What else am I supposed to think? Your father’s lessons have always been about resolving disputes swiftly and brutally.”

“I’m not my father, Astra. I thought you knew that by now.”

And I did know that. When I looked at Thane, I saw the young man I played chess with those lonely weeks on board the ship. The one who hid who he really was behind a stoic expression.

“But who is deciding Jax’s fate, Thane? You or Seren?”

“I am,” a voice from behind us said.

“Hello, Seren,” I replied, turning around.

“I see we’re in the process of discussing the punishment of young Jaxson Preston. Have we made any progress with him?”

“No, Father,” Thane said. “Astra was just telling me he’s being uncooperative. Apparently, our scare tactic isn’t working. He’s forcing our hand.”

“Is he?” Seren stared both of us down. I squirmed but Thane stiffened. All the emotion fled from his face. “I assume you’ll carry out the sentence we discussed earlier, then?” he said to Thane.

“We will,” he said.

“See that you keep this under control, son,” Seren said. “I’ll leave you two to talk over the specifics then,” he added, and left, shutting the door behind him.

“So, what is this sentence you’ve already agreed upon?” I asked. “His trial hasn’t even happened yet.”

“The trial is just for show. The only reason we’re going through with it is for the colonists to see what happens when a crime is committed.”

I was still on the outside, but I felt like a thousand flesh-eating worms were wriggling inside me. Thane put a hand on my arm, oblivious to the horror rippling just beneath my skin. “He’s to be put to death, Astra,” he said gently. “It will be humane. Dr. Zaius will give him an injection.”

“Lethal injection has been outlawed for more than two centuries,” I said, my eyes filling with tears.

“Not on colonies,” Thane said. “If it’s deemed necessary to protect the colony, then it’s an acceptable form of punishment.”

I rose quickly and threw aside his hand. “It’s not acceptable to me,” I said. “Can’t we imprison him instead?”

Thane shook his head. “It would divert valuable resources—food, guards—and we’d have to construct a prison. There are more pressing matters to attend to, such as getting our crops and livestock to thrive. If we allow rabble to distract us from our purpose, the colony will fail. Don’t you see that?”

“I can see that you’ll do what you want and damn the consequences. I can see that you’re perfectly willing to put a man, a noble, honest man to death with papier-mâché evidence. A man this colony needs. If you can do something like that to Jax, how do I know you wouldn’t do it to my brother or to me? It’s become quite clear that I can no longer trust the leadership of this colony, Thane. I don’t trust Seren, I don’t trust you, and I’m not even sure if I can trust myself anymore.”

Shoving my chair aside, I headed to the door and wrenched it open, but Thane put his hand against it, closing it once more.

“Let me out, Thane.”

“No. I won’t have you leaving thinking I’m a monster.”

“Like father like son.”

“Don’t say that.”

“Truth hurts, doesn’t it?”

“Look, if I thought there was another way to appease my father, I’d do it. Imprisoning Jax isn’t good enough. My father would see it as a reminder of his failure to act. Jax needs to be gone in order for the colonists to settle down.”

I turned around and grabbed his arm. “Then banish him,” I said, my hope rekindled. “Evict him from the colony with just enough supplies to last, say, a week. Then we won’t be killing him, the planet would.”

“But he might survive on his own.”

That’s what I was hoping for but I didn’t want to tell Thane that Jax already had a home built in the trees and that he and his uncle were further along in gathering and cultivating the native vegetation that we were.

“Even if he does, it won’t matter,” I said. “The colonists will see we deal harshly with criminals. Your father would be appeased.”

Thane shook his head. “It’s not enough. My father would need a gesture to feel sure that the colony was going to thrive.”

“A gesture like what?” I said.

Thane took my hands in his. "Marry me," he said, his eyes alight. "My father will see our union as a sign of the colony's future growth. With the two of us together, setting an example for others, we can open a new chapter in this world's history."

My mouth dried up. I couldn't speak, couldn't utter either the words he wanted to hear or the ones I wanted to say. I couldn't marry Thane. Could I? He believed if I married him, his father would agree to release Jax. Would it work? Was saving Jax's life worth giving up my own? I knew the answer was yes, but I couldn't form my lips to say the word to Thane. Instead, I just nodded.

Thane touched his cheek to mine. "I'll make the arrangements," he said, then lifted his head and smoothed his already perfect hair. "I don't want you to worry about anything."

I wet my lips. "You promise?" I asked. "You promise that you'll banish Jax instead?"

"He'll be safe. I give you my word." Thane pecked me on the forehead.

"But what about the trial?"

"We'll make an announcement in the morning and say we had a closed trial and the accused confessed his wrongdoing and agreed to leave the colony with the understanding that, should he return, it will be upon pain of death."

Numbly, I nodded. "Should I...should I go tell him?" I asked.

"No. I'll take care of it. Why don't you relax for the rest of the day? Think about what you want to keep when you move into my domicile."

Panic seized me. "Do you mean for us to be married immediately?" I asked.

He frowned. "I suppose we could wait a week or so, but my father will want to announce it right away."

"Then, let's wait. Two months?" I suggested.

Twisting his full lips, he touched my nose. "See how I already indulge you? Two months it is."

Shaking, I turned to the door.

"And, Astra," he said as I cracked it open. "I look forward to our future life together."

Somehow, I managed to say, "So do I." Then I hurried out the door and barricaded myself in my own little room.

Collapsing on my bed on my stomach, I sobbed, wondering how my life's path had taken such a wrong turn.

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Chapter 18

Dead to the World

I stayed locked in my domicile for the rest of the day, and when the second sun disappeared, I climbed out my window and headed back to Jax's home. I was surprised to find the guards missing and the door wide open. Clothing was scattered haphazardly around the room.

"Jax?" I hissed in the darkness, but there was no reply. I checked the lavatory but it was as dark as the rest of the room. The window was open and a cool breeze caressed my face. Pushing aside the curtains, I looked out across the clearing but didn't see his familiar form there or in the trees.

Had Thane helped him? Was he in another prison? Would Thane do that? It was entirely possible. Not knowing what else to do, I went home and fell into my bed, tossing and turning for the next eight hours instead of sleeping. When I rose, after scrubbing my swollen face, I headed to the center of the colony, expecting an announcement.

"There you are," Thane said, slipping his hand beneath my elbow. "Come with me." His voice was dark, almost as black as my mood, and it made me wonder if Jax had managed to get away on his own and thwart Thane's plans.

Pulling me up onto the dais, he sent a ping message to the colonists and waited for them to trickle in. He then paced back and forth as impatiently as a cat anticipating breakfast. As soon as he deemed enough individuals had arrived, he began speaking, saying that we had gone forward with a private trial, found Jax guilty, and had stripped him of his technology, implanted a subdermal tracking device, and banished him from the colony. If he ever crossed within a kilometer of the colony, the device would not only send them a warning but would incapacitate him until they could collect his unconscious form. If such a thing happened, there would be no leniency. Jax would then be put down as if he were a sick dog. He didn't say that, of course. Not exactly. Thane was nothing if not a smooth-talking politician.

Then he added that though Jax's contributions to the colony would be missed, it was safer for all concerned that he be removed and that this method of punishment was far more humane than the alternative. Next, he announced our impending nuptials, and there was a small cheer from the crowd, accompanied by some awkward clapping. I scanned the crowd but couldn't find my brother. My eyes did stop on Seren though. He stood near the back, clapping, and his expression was one of smug satisfaction. I didn't know what that meant. Was he happy for me and Thane? Surely, he'd be upset that Jax disappeared. Or had Seren helped Thane orchestrate Jax's departure?

Even after the crowd dispersed and I headed to the lab, I couldn't forget the glee twisting and twirling in Seren's eyes like charmed snakes. Had he wanted to get rid of Jax all along or was he simply happy that his son was going to get married?

The next days passed quickly, too quickly. I was kept busy. It was a good distraction for me. Between my upcoming marriage to Thane and my fear over Jax, I felt as wrung out as a spent tea bag—dull, empty, and steeped in the spiraling ache of loss. Even as I went through the motions, working until I fell into bed so exhausted I couldn't help but sleep, Jax's absence bobbed to the surface of my mind. The pain of missing him was like a torn fingernail. I could push my fingers against it, apply pressure, but the moment I lifted my hand away, it throbbed again, reminding me that he was gone forever and his life was at risk.

The good news was that the animals were thriving. Delenna's team had moved on from fish to birds within the space of a few weeks, using the growth accelerator to stimulate the cryogen frozen embryos, taking them from sixteen-celled organisms to full-grown animals within the space of a few hours. Soon flocks of geese were arcing in V formation overhead as they selected prime locations for feeding and breeding. Raptors took to the sky, heading for far-off mountain ranges where they'd build nests, search for mates, and hunt for rodents and small mammals that were being released in ever-increasing distances from the colony.

When the animals exited the accelerator, they were voraciously hungry, but they quickly stabilized and were introduced into their new environment in locations where they were certain to thrive. By the end of the month, they started growing the livestock. More land was cleared for crops and herds

now that Jax's very effective barrier was in place, preventing the native tree roots from damaging our crops.

Where the native flora seemed to open leafy arms for the animals we were introducing, it was quite obvious there would be no accepting of crops and trees of an earthly origin. Any tree or sapling planted outside the boundary of the colony was quickly smothered. I'd never seen anything like it before. Now that we had animals to feed, we had no choice but to extend the area of viable soil, which meant the eradication of more native species.

I told Thane and Seren we should proceed at a slower pace, but the two of them seemed determined to take over the whole of the planet and damn the potential consequences. The obliteration of the native forest was done during the night while I was sleeping, even more evidence that Thane and Seren were keeping secrets from me.

One thousand hectares were dissolved, with plans to clear two thousand more by the end of the next week. The night it happened, I was wrapped in a nightmare so vivid and frightening I woke screaming and thrashing. My head throbbed and no amount of med patches could help dull the pain. It finally eased by morning, but I felt sick and empty inside.

That was also the night my brother disappeared.

He'd kept to himself for the most part, often avoiding my requests to meet, replying with only brief text messages instead. Nash still ate with me once a week, saying very little when he did, and checked in from time to time to make sure my implant was functioning normally, but it felt to me like he was distracted and going through the motions, not really wanting to spend time with me. He didn't look well either. His face was slightly green tinged, and I wondered if he'd contracted a new illness our devices couldn't scan for. He denied it, saying he was healthier than ever, but I worried all the same.

I wasn't the only one he'd been avoiding either. His new supervisor, who was a young man just one rank above him, said he was often missing, his tablet tracker turned off. When he was summoned to a meeting to discuss his lack of attention to work, he didn't even say anything to defend himself. The head of his team talked to Thane, and he deferred to me, asking if something was going on with Nash. I told Thane I'd look into it and he agreed to let me handle my errant brother.

The problem was I couldn't handle it. Not even I could get my brother to respond to my messages. But then Nash shocked me after the wedding announcement by appearing suddenly at my side and asking me if I knew what I was doing. When I'd said I did, he just shook his head and told me to let him know when I came to my senses, warning me that the prettiest plants, the ones that drew you in with their aroma and beauty, were often the ones waiting to ensnare you.

I asked him what he meant, but he just shrugged and told me to look inside myself to find the answer. "But don't take too long, sister," Nash warned me. "Otherwise we're likely to give up on you."

"Who's we?" I asked.

"You already know," he replied cryptically. "You just won't admit it to yourself."

"You're scaring me, Nash," I said. Placing my hand on his forehead, I asked, "Have you been ingesting any native plants? Your temp is running high today."

Nash's eyes glittered as he leaned down and said, "You don't know the half of it, Astra dear."

He left abruptly and the next day he was reported missing. Search parties went out for several days but they found no trace of him. I worried, especially when his supervisor said that Nash had left all his things behind. He didn't even take supplies with him, and with his tablet left on his bed, there was no way to track him. The brother I knew would never leave me behind. He'd always been very protective of me. But since we arrived on the planet, he treated me like I was an irritation or an obligation he didn't want.

Thane kept arranging time for us to be together to plan our future life, thinking that this would distract me from my sorrow over Jax and Nash. One night he asked me to have dinner with him alone in his domicile. When I arrived, he seemed disappointed with my appearance. He looked amazing, wearing a suit he might have worn on Earth, reminding me of a young actor headed down a red carpet or a model selling cologne in the virtual marketplaces. The clothing wasn't standard-issue, and standing beside him with his polished shoes, slicked-back hair, and crisp white shirt, I felt dowdy and out of place.

My shoes were mud flecked. I was wearing the standard zip jumpsuit issued during our flight, and my hair was drawn up in a ponytail, messy tendrils escaping and curling at my neck. I hadn't even bothered to set the refresher to issue a flattering color. The grey suit did nothing for me and I was thankful that the lighting was dimmed. Thane had fresh-cut flowers on the table—Earth roses and white lilies—and there were even beeswax candles, likely gathered from our thriving hives. It was nice of him to go to such an effort to cheer me up. He'd been especially attentive since we announced our engagement.

"It smells amazing," I said as he pulled out a chair. "What's on the menu?"

"Fresh trout from our farms," he bragged. "Also asparagus with lemon sauce and a fresh green salad."

When he pushed me in, he leaned down and whispered in my ear, "Also, if you're good, newly ripened strawberries for dessert."

"Really?" I asked, turning quickly with an enthusiastic smile. "They finally decided to grow that crop?"

"They did," he replied, his voice rough around the edges. "I had them planted early just for you." Thane's eyes drifted down to my mouth, and reflexively, I wet my lips, suddenly realizing how close our faces were. The scent of his spiced soap enveloped me. He leaned closer, putting his hand on the back of my head, and kissed me. It was brief, but I felt trapped nonetheless. Thane's hand held me in place with firm pressure. If I didn't move, it didn't hurt, but I wondered what would have happened if I'd pulled away. Would he have wrenched me back? Squeezed hard enough to cause pain?

I wasn't going to find out because I did neither of those things. Thankfully, the kiss was brief and he seemed pleased by it. The table was small enough that my cheeks were caressed by the heat of the candles. Thane probably assumed I was blushing at the attention he was lavishing on me. But his eyes didn't look at me with the same warmth that Jax's did. Thane's burned with a desire, certainly, but I suspected it was more a passion to control or to possess, while Jax's were warmed by something else, something sweet and kind.

As we dug into the meal, he asked what I wanted to wear for the wedding. He glanced at my clothing, showing me that he was clearly

hoping I'd ask for something new.

After sipping my water, I set down my glass and replied, "I don't know. What are the options?"

"For my bride? Anything." Picking up my hand, he kissed it and then squeezed it as he added, "Of course, we'll commission the highest-quality fabrics."

I frowned. "What if I wanted something ridiculous, like a white dress with a train a mile long?"

Thane shrugged. "If you like."

Wrinkling my nose, I said, "No, thanks. I can't imagine wearing a train made of our jumpsuit fabric. It would be way too heavy."

"There might be other options," he said.

"Other options like what?"

"The silkworms. We could get them into production early."

"Really? But those aren't necessary for survival. To prep them early, we'd have to put something else, something more important, on the back burner."

"Yes. But we can make an exception."

"I suppose. But even so, silk is a luxury. It falls apart in the refresher and doesn't recycle."

"That's right. It's special. Just like my bride."

"And what do I do with the dress afterward?" I teased. "Put it in storage for my next wedding?"

His mouth turned down sourly. "There won't be another wedding for you, Astra." After he set down his cup, he seemed to regain his cheer. "We can save it. Maybe it will be put in a museum someday."

"A museum?" I barked a laugh. "The first problem with that statement is that we are probably a century away from a museum on this planet."

"And what's the other problem?" he asked, spearing a bite of fish.

"Uh, the fact that there's no reason to put my dress in a museum."

"But there is a reason, Astra. It's very common, even on Earth, for a queen's wedding dress to be preserved."

"A queen? Then that would make you...?"

"The king of this planet, naturally."

“The king,” I said, folding my arms across my chest and snickering. “Getting ahead of yourself a bit, aren’t you, Thane?”

“Not at all. It’s a natural evolution.”

“Maybe in your mind. I have no intention of being a queen. I’m happy being a scientist.”

“Yes. Well, the question remains, what would you like to wear?”

“My mother wore something with a full skirt, but that feels too extravagant.”

“Perhaps you will let me take care of it then?” he asked. “It *is* only a month away.”

I sighed heavily and pushed away my plate. “I guess,” I said, suddenly losing my appetite at the thought of our wedding.

As if sensing my hesitation, Thane said, “We’re a perfect fit, Astra. There’s no other woman on this colony as genetically compatible with me as you. Our offspring will be as perfect as we are, and between the two of us and our progeny, this colony will thrive until it becomes a burgeoning city, and then a nation. We will be heralded as the beginning. The fount of a utopia planet. From us, life-giving waters will spring. We’ll be like Adam and Eve.”

Raising a hand, I cut him off. “I get the point. Don’t you believe you’re overthinking this a bit?” I asked. “We’re colonists, no better or worse than anyone else here, and we’re certainly not perfect.” I didn’t add that it was entirely possible I’d end up infertile like my mother. Unlike her, I wouldn’t use medicine to conceive, especially not to bear Thane’s children.

“You see?” he said, standing up and clearing our plates, placing them on the tray that rotated them inside the washer, where they would be cleaned and held in reserve, perfectly sanitized for the next use. “That’s what I mean. You’re humble and you’ll help steer me in the right direction. Your talents make up for what I lack. I would hope that I help you also in that regard.”

“Of course you do,” I said absently, staring at the dancing flame of the candle and wondering if he had specially commissioned them much like he wanted to do with my wedding dress. It was a waste of resources. We didn’t need candlelight. We could use our tablets to make light. Even if the goal was a romantic ambiance, we could simulate candlelight in other ways. It

wasn't necessary to make actual beeswax candles. Frankly, I was surprised at how fast our bees were producing.

When he brought the strawberries back to the table, I thanked him and lifted the bowl to my nose. "There's nothing in the world like a fresh strawberry," I said, trying to change the subject.

"Not even fresh eggs?" he asked.

"Do we have those already?"

"We do. Sausage will be next week."

It had been close to two years since I'd been able to have a bright, buttery fried egg. The thought of it made my mouth water despite the fact that I had a fresh bowl of strawberries in front of me.

"Thane," I asked, picking at my berries, "have you been tracking Jax?"

"Yes," he answered. "Why do you ask?"

"I just wanted to know how far he's wandered."

He set down his fork and sighed. "The truth, Astra, is that he's many, many kilometers away and, I didn't want to talk about this during our date, but his blip has stopped moving. This likely means that he's—"

I shoved back my chair. "He's dead?" I screamed. "Why didn't you tell me?"

"I didn't want to worry you." He rose and took my hands in his. "Dear one, we knew this might happen. It was likely, in fact. This planet's flora is hostile. He might have eaten something poisonous. Or maybe he fell off a cliff and broke his neck. Perhaps he drank some unfiltered water. There are a million different ways he could have perished. There's just no way to know."

"I can think of one way to know. Let's go find him!"

Thane shook his head. "Through the deepest jungle? No, Astra. I won't allow you to even contemplate such a possibility. Even if we could get there, it would take days and days on foot, and we'd be likely to meet the same fate as him." He squeezed my hands. "I'll remind you again that you knew this was a likely outcome, Astra. At least we didn't have to kill him ourselves."

His words felt like a hard slap. Inside, I grew cold. My heart was plummeting, falling like a pebble dropped in a bottomless lake. Thane stared at me, his face sympathetic, waiting for me to respond. Suddenly, I realized I couldn't. My lungs were seizing. Pressing my hand over my

mouth, I raced to the door, wrenched it open, and ran into the night. Thane called my name in the darkness, and I heard the crunch of his shoes on the dirt path behind me.

The thought occurred to me that he'd hate me for making him ruin his polished shoes, and I almost hoped he would. When I stopped on the side of a building, I violently smacked my hand against my implant, releasing a burst of medicine in my lungs. They opened and I exhaled a shallow breath, green clouds rising from my lips and dissipating quickly in the night air.

When I entered my domicile, I fully expected Thane to knock on my door a moment later, but he didn't and I was glad. I just couldn't face him knowing his actions had caused Jax's death. We could have found another way to comfort the crowd. Jax didn't need to be the scapegoat.

As I lay on my bed, my hands tucked behind my head, my thoughts drifted to Uncle Harm. Did he know that Jax had been banished? I'd assumed they were together but perhaps not. Jax knew he'd been tagged, and Thane said his blip was kilometers away, far from the tree home he'd built for his uncle.

It was entirely possible that Jax took off without informing his uncle at all. Maybe he was worried they'd be able to track his uncle down and he'd avoided the tree house altogether. Whichever scenario was the true one, I needed to know.

The next night, I made plans to head back to the tree house. My tablet showed me the path we'd taken before. It would be easy enough to retrace my steps. After checking to make sure everyone was in their domiciles for the evening, I shut off the tracker on my tablet and slipped out of my home.

When I was far enough away from the colony, I activated my solar-powered flashlight. The energy cell would last a week if it was fully charged, and mine was close to full. The forest at night was even more foreboding than it was during the day. The tree trunks seemed to close in around me. In my mind, they turned into the bars of a cage, waiting to trap me.

Mosses hanging from the trees turned ghostly white in the moonlight, fluttering in the breeze like ghosts, and shiny, golden pollen clung to the delicate leaves of the underbrush like snow, making the plants look like they were wearing thick, iridescent coats. My leg brushed against one plant that sent out a nest of flickering tongues. I jumped back, startled, but they

didn't seem to like the taste of me, because they quickly curled up and leaves covered the delicate protrusions.

I don't know when I started crying and saying Jax's name over and over again, but I stopped abruptly when I realized there was someone else nearby doing the same thing. "Hello?" I said, feeling prickles crawl from my arms up to the back of my neck. "Is someone there?"

"Hello? Is someone there?" the voice replied.

"Yes! I'm over here," I answered.

"Over here," was the reply.

I wandered around several tree trunks and then spun in a circle. "Where are you?" I asked.

"Where are you?" the voice said. It was much closer now. I heard a rustling and headed toward it, saying, "What are you doing out here so far away from the colony?"

"What are you doing out here..." it began.

I parted some leaves and saw a plant with a bulbous head. The leaves were moving. No...they were speaking.

"...so far away from the colony?" it finished, its leaves cupping around each other to form the last word.

"You...you can speak!" I said, crouching down and fingering the stem. "You're a sort of echo plant."

It repeated my words exactly. My fears forgotten, I snapped some images of the plant, walking around its sides so I could bring up a 3-D rendering later in my lab. Then I took some video, recording it as it copied my words. There was a fat, pulpy leaf in the center of the cluster that wagged back and forth as it copied my words. It moved like a tongue.

"Amazing," I mumbled as I walked away, my inner young scientist momentarily distracting me from the task at hand. I spent the next half hour or so trying to think of a better name for my new discovery than echo plant but came up with nothing. Getting myself back on track, I hiked for another hour, following the same trail that I'd taken with Jax, being careful to avoid the bullwhips and the pod plants that would knock me out if I broke them open.

Finally, I made it to the tree house. There was no light coming from any of the structures, but that might just mean that Uncle Harm was asleep.

Carefully, I climbed up the steps and crossed the bridge to the first pod. Nobody was home.

“Uncle Harm?” I called out, but there was no reply.

I searched the next one and the next. When I saw that many of his cuttings were missing, the fear returned. He wasn’t in the library either, and I sucked in a breath when I noticed that all the shelves were carefully covered with some kind of plastic material. All the books were preserved except one that was pulled out from the shelf. It hung precariously, almost ready to fall. Taking hold of it, I pushed it back into place but something was blocking it. Shining my flashlight inside the space, I saw a folded piece of paper.

After taking it out, I spread it on the table and read...

Astra,

If you’re reading this, my uncle and I have run from the colony. I promise we’re okay. We know how to live off the land. I know what you’re thinking, that we could have pinged you, but my uncle insists on leaving a paper note. He worried a ping would be traced and he insists I tell you that the trees don’t mind this time since he brought the paper with him from Earth.

I always knew it was possible we’d have to live far from the colony. We’ve prepared for this. My only regret is leaving you behind. But I knew you wouldn’t want to leave your brother.

A sob rose in my throat. He didn’t need to worry about me leaving my brother because my brother left me first. I swiped my fingers over my cheeks and kept reading.

But if there comes a day when you want to leave the colony, then go to my domicile and find my storage locker. It will be empty, but in the upper left corner where the edge meets the door, you'll find a key. Go to the greenhouse and shift the large pot containing a red geranium. Underneath, you'll see a locker. Inside, I've left you a way to find us.

If this is the last time we communicate, then I just wanted to say...thank you. You've helped me since the beginning. I won't forget you or the kindness and acceptance you've shown to my uncle.

Love,

Jax

For a moment, I stood there thinking, then I snapped to attention. Quickly, I replaced the book, folding the letter and placing it inside, then I covered the book with the same plastic, tucking it around the edge to protect it from dust.

As I walked back to the colony, more surefooted this time than I'd been before, I decided that I would go after Jax. Nothing was holding me back now. Nash was gone. Thane would get over me soon enough and find another girl who wanted to be the queen to his king. I had no such ambition.

I decided I'd leave immediately. But I wasn't going to leave without supplies. I headed to my home first and packed a large bag, lining the bottom with an extra jumpsuit, a few toiletries, and then, using Thane's password, I ordered up a week's worth of nutrient bars with the maximum amount of calories and protein, knowing I could make them stretch much longer than a week.

Thanks to Uncle Harm, I also had an extensive list of native plants I could forage. Heading into my lab to grab a few more things, I stopped,

gasping at the chaos. There were muddy footprints, the bare feet kind, all over the floor. Dozens of containers of fertilized eggs were empty and broken. Both the energy cell and the quick drive from the growth accelerator were missing. The machine wouldn't work without it. We had a backup, but without Jax, I wasn't certain we had the know-how to install it.

I logged on to my computer and found to my horror that someone had hacked it. What was worse, I had a horrible suspicion that I knew who had done this. My plans to find Jax would have to be postponed. Though it was the middle of the night and it was the last thing I wanted to do, I pinged Thane.

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Chapter 19

Moon Madness

Thane's response was immediate, which was surprising to me considering the hour. It made me wonder what he'd been up to at such a late hour. He rushed to the lab and crouched down, touching the now dried mud footprints. It only took him a moment to scan them for DNA like I had already done.

"Nash," he said. "But it doesn't make sense. This isn't even his department. And he never showed any signs of wanting to sabotage the mission." Turning to look up at me, he asked, "Nash didn't have anti-stabber sympathies, did he? He *was* roommates with your friend Jax."

"They were roommates, yes, but they were assigned. Besides, that was only on the ship. They became friends, sort of," I said, thinking of how Nash had trusted Jax with my secret, "but I didn't get the impression they were in cahoots, as it were."

"That may be true," Thane said, standing up, "but remember that the man murdered was Nash's direct supervisor, and it happened when he was working on the reservoir that collects and filters our water. It could mean they planned something together."

I bristled at the comment, but I couldn't deny Thane's conclusions were sound.

"It appears my computer was tampered with as well," I said, regretting that this further implicated my brother. "Several species of cataloged native plants have not only had the files removed, but all the viable samples were taken, and they were extremely hard to come by. Whoever did it knew my password."

"So Nash had no accomplices then, I assume. At least for this. Can you think of a reason he would do this?" Thane asked.

"Are you going to banish him upon pain of death, too, should he return?" I accused. "Why not implicate me while you're at it? Guilty by

association and all that.”

“This is not personal, Astra. Please believe this gives me no happiness. The last thing I want to do is call out your brother. And believe it or not, I didn’t want to banish Jax either. As for you, you are incapable of deception, Astra,” Thane said gently, touching my cheek. “Besides, your face is much too readable and you wouldn’t destroy the specimens that you yourself collected. It’s your passion. In my defense, you should know that there are things about your brother you don’t know. He ran with a deviant crowd.”

“I do know,” I said miserably. “I read his file.”

“Good. I’m glad I’m not the one to have to cause you further distress.” He paused and glanced at me, then looked away. “There’s been a rift between us since Jax was accused and I wouldn’t want anything else to jeopardize our relationship.”

“I think I have a pretty good handle on what you desire out of this arrangement between us.”

He flinched at my words.

Ignoring his reaction, I went on. “And I honestly don’t think there’s anything else we’ll come across now or in the future that will alter my opinion of you, not even my brother’s probable involvement in this unfortunate event.

He sighed and nodded. “Now we’re going to have to handle this carefully,” Thane said, clasping his hands and tapping his mouth.

“What do you mean?” I asked.

“I mean, there’s no reason for anyone to know this happened.”

“I don’t see how we can cover it up. The cameras have all been destroyed by something thin and sharp piercing the casing from behind, which should be impossible.”

He pulled over a chair and examined the back of the camera. “Yes, it looks to me like an awl.”

“I would assume the same, except there is a trail of green fluid dripping from the hole. That makes me think it’s some kind of chemical. Then there’s the fact that the quick drive is missing and the zoology team is using it daily right now. Believe me when I say they’ll notice. It’s going to set us back weeks as we figure out how to install the backup, and that’s assuming we can. Then there’s the problem of the missing embryos. We can’t exactly hide that.”

“I think we might be able to. Did you see a pattern with the stolen embryos?” he asked.

“No. What pattern?”

“The embryos taken were all apex carnivores. We wouldn’t release those until we had a very stable environment and a way to protect ourselves from them. See? Look.” He picked up a handful of containers and placed them one by one on the table. “Lions, bears, wolves, crocodiles, pythons, tigers, anacondas, leopards, and so on. We’ve already released most of the birds of prey, but they aren’t dangerous to humans.”

“This is crazy,” I said, pounding my fist against the lab table. “What reason could Nash possibly have to take them?”

“Other than sabotage, you mean?” He blew out a breath and ran a hand through his hair.

I bit my lip. “He wasn’t exactly firing on all cylinders the last time I saw him.”

“What do you mean?”

“I think he was sick.”

“Did he consult Dr. Zaius?” Thane asked.

I shook my head. “He doesn’t trust doctors.”

“I see.” Thane paced the floor. “Despite this setback, I think we can cover it up. We’ll just say that those particular containers didn’t make it through the journey.”

“But they’ve already been inventoried. People know they’re here, or that they were here, anyway.”

“Then we’ll say they were compromised, contaminated. It’s not like we can’t survive without apex predators anyway, right? We have the herds for food. That just means more food for us.”

“Yeah, until the rodents take over the planet. We need them all. Ecosystems must be carefully aligned. Throw one monkey wrench like missing apex predators into the mix and all of us could go extinct. Populations will become unbalanced. Animals will die, including us. The food chain exists for a reason. We can’t just reinvent the wheel, Thane.”

Thane brushed aside my concerns. “Yeah, I get it. But won’t other animals rise to the top? The survival of the fittest, so to speak? Besides, we have ways of controlling the population.”

I put my hands on my hips. “You mean eradication just like you did to the native forest?”

After pursing his lips, Thane said, “You know we had no choice. It was the only way to introduce our Earth species of plants and trees. We need to produce food, Astra.”

“I know that. But who knows how many native species we might have made extinct in the process? Remember Earth’s rainforests? The only natural green left on the planet was in the areas protected by the so-called anti-stabbers. It took decades for us to turn it around, and even then, countless species were lost in the wild. Whole ecosystems were destroyed, no more to be found except in old Earth history files. Thane, you do realize that most of our embryos are the descendants of animals born in captivity? The loss of those apex predators is a big deal. It’s extinction.”

He pinched the bridge of his nose. “Astra, don’t you think I weigh my decisions carefully? Of all people in the colony, you know that I would never do anything to jeopardize the success of this mission.”

“I know,” I said slowly. And I did know. Thane was calculated. He took risks but only when he deemed them absolutely necessary. He would be a good leader. Better even than his father. I didn’t always agree with his decisions, but when I didn’t, I honestly couldn’t think of anything else to do. Maybe the difference between us was that he was willing to act when I hesitated, unwilling to compromise my principles. Stubbornly, I said, “Well, it doesn’t matter now. You’ve made the call. Widened our very ugly, very large footprint on this planet. Maybe there was a plant that had the power to help us breathe underwater or one that stopped aging or one that turned our hair purple, but now we’ll never know.”

Reaching out, he tugged a lock of my hair. “Why would you want purple hair?” he teased.

“I don’t. I’m just saying that it’s never smart to destroy what you don’t understand.”

He sighed and dropped his hand. “But that’s our mission, Astra. To tame a world so we can have a place in it. Even your parents knew that. Sacrifices have to be made to accomplish your goals.”

“Yeah,” I answered despondently, running out of steam. “But our goals might not be what’s best for everyone.”

“The only everyone I’m concerned with at this exact moment is you.” He put his hands on my shoulders and said, “Is my fiancée turning anti-stabber on me too?” Thane smiled when he said it, but there was a tiny glint in his eyes that made me feel like I needed to reassure him. Perhaps I imagined it but I felt my answer was very important to him.

“No, of course not,” I said.

“Good.” He cupped my cheek, kissed the corner of my mouth, and then bent to pick up the rest of the containers. “The two of us will handle Nash on our own. In the meantime, I want you to come up with a reason these samples might have been tainted. I’ll say that Jax took the quick drive. He’s smart enough to outwit our tracker, so we’ll say that’s what happened. Nobody else needs to know that he’s likely perished in the wilderness. There’s no reason we have to lose both Jax and Nash. We’ll find your brother and rehabilitate him. I promise.”

I considered those ominous words as I cleaned up. How exactly was Thane planning to rehabilitate Nash? When I swept the floor and found I was unable to erase Nash’s footprints, I got on my knees with soapy water and a scrub brush. The muddy prints were as sticky and gummy as baked brown sugar, and the caramel color was strange. It didn’t look like it came from the dark, fertile soil surrounding the colony at all. The water seemed to dissolve it well enough, and I sat there lost in thought, watching the golden rivulets trail out the lab door and pool onto the dirt outside. How could my brother, the one who always held my hand during my worst attacks, be responsible for such depredation?

It took me the rest of the night to clean up the lab, and by the time I was done, I was too tired to look for the key hidden in Jax’s domicile. Thane was wrong about Jax being dead. He had to be. Jax was right. If anyone could live off the land, it was him and his uncle. I’d seen Uncle Harm’s ability to cultivate firsthand. There was no doubt he’d survive, but then, why wasn’t his tracker moving? I needed to sleep and then I’d look for the key first thing when I woke.

Picking up my large getaway bag, I slung it over my shoulder, wondering how Thane had failed to notice it when he noticed everything else. Maybe he had and had chosen to ignore it. That didn’t seem like him either. Thane liked to address things immediately. It was something I liked about him most of the time.

As I was walking to Jax's home the next day, Delenna stopped me and asked for my help. She was distraught about the loss of the growth accelerator even more so than the rest of team members. In fact, she was in a panic. Apparently, she had released koalas and giant pandas ahead of schedule and had planned on asking me to use the qwick grow to cultivate some eucalyptus and bamboo to feed them. Since they eat eucalyptus and bamboo almost exclusively and we now had no way to accelerate them to maturity, both animal species were in trouble. Those particular plant specimens were not on my immediate to-do list, but now they'd been moved to the top. As a result, it was imperative to get the backup growth accelerator up and running.

The engineers had managed to find the backup qwick drive easily enough, but none of them had ever worked on a growth accelerator before. I stayed to help, abandoning my immediate plans to search for Jax because I felt uncomfortable with the idea of leaving my friend and former roommate in the lurch. I managed to find some food substitutes to try to keep the animals alive but it wasn't enough.

It took them two weeks to get the GA back up and running, and unfortunately, we lost half of the giant pandas and koalas during that time. It was a terrible outcome. Delenna was devastated, feeling personally responsible for the loss. I tried to comfort her, but soon we had an altogether new problem to deal with, and this one was absolutely shocking, much more so than the setback with the mission.

One of our farmers, the one working on the crops of oats and corn, in preparation for us to introduce horses and cattle, was killed. But as horrible as losing another colonist was, it wasn't his death that was so shocking, it was what killed him.

Other workers nearby heard the man's screams and ran to his aid. One of them happened to be carrying an electric probe. Apparently, some of the gophers had managed to sneak into our lettuce crops and the crewman was busy setting pulse emitters around the borders to prevent the rodents from destroying them. When he came upon the farmer, he saw a large creature ripping his fellow worker to pieces. The brave man ramped up the device to its highest level and charged the beast.

It took more than five stabs with the highest electric shock to bring it down, and the poor hero suffered grave but repairable wounds. He'd be in a med chamber overnight to regrow a lost arm and an ear and to heal the

severe tears on his torso, but he'd survive. The same couldn't be said of his friend. The poor field farmer bled out before he could be carried back to the colony.

The beast that attacked him looked much like a lion, at least it was roughly the same shape, but it was much larger. Also it was green and covered not in fur but in what looked to be leaves. The dead carcass was brought back to the lab, where a team of specialists began cataloging it. Delenna took a skin sample and studied it beneath a microscope, calling me over after only a few seconds.

"It's got chloroplasts!" she exclaimed.

"Impossible," I said, waving her aside. Sure enough, she was right. "I see vacuoles too, but the cell membrane is thin. It makes no sense."

Turning to the animal, I probed around its neck and said, "Look at this." Instead of a mane, long, golden, feather-like stems bloomed around the creature's head. They were soft and frilly, like dandelion flowers. Instead of fur, it looked like it had overlapping leaves that curved over its shoulders and hips. I lifted one leafy section with a gloved hand, exploring beneath the layers until I found a hard, almost reptilian skin.

"Could it be native?" I asked, murmuring to myself as I examined the furred flower buds growing between the large toes on the paws of the animal.

Delenna overheard me and replied. "It has to be, doesn't it?" she said, returning to the microscope. "We weren't planning on introducing big cats for several weeks."

"Right," I murmured, biting my lip and thinking of the stolen embryos. The DNA sample came up on our tablets. It was a strange mishmash unlike anything we'd ever seen. It definitely had some of the markers of a lion from Earth, but it also had plant DNA mixed in. Had Nash been able to manipulate the embryos somehow? It didn't make sense. This kind of genetic alteration was not only way out of Nash's area of expertise and impossible in any practical sense, but it veered on a Dr. Moreau level of creepy.

I clipped off one of its horribly long and sharp claws and found, upon careful inspection, that it resembled incredibly thick blackberry thorns. The end of its tail looked as if it were made of brittle grasses instead of fur, but when I ran my fingers through the tawny brown strands, they were strong

and wouldn't break. Picking up a syringe, I poked the needle into the creature, hoping to get a blood sample, but the fluid drawn up was green tinged and almost as thick as syrup. I took a step back, kneading my lips with my teeth nervously, thinking about where I'd seen the stuff before.

Delenna glanced up from the microscope. "If you pleat those lips any further, you'll make a skirt. Wanna tell me what you're thinking?"

"I don't know what to think. There were no indications of animal life at all on Gaia."

"Gaia?" she said. "I thought this was Crillian IV. Are we renaming it? That's what I get for missing the meetings, I guess."

I laughed nervously. "Oh, no. I misspoke. I'm just spooked. What if there are more of these? Ten or twenty of these things could kill us all."

"That's pretty certain. Not the killing but the more-of-them thing. In most cases, where you see one, there are bound to be more. If this species follows the pattern of lions on Earth, he'd have a pride of between fifteen and thirty individuals. This guy is well camouflaged for his environment, which makes sense for the territory he lives in, and he looks like he's mature enough to breed. He also looks healthy, though he's pretty lightweight for a cat. It's almost like he doesn't have any bones. Speaking of that, I'll check that out next." She picked up a bone saw, lowered a visor over her face, and clicked it on. The buzzing made me wince, and I decided it was time for the assistant botanist to vacate the lab.

Leaving her to her work, I sought out Thane and told him about my suspicions.

"And you think Nash could do something like that? Manipulate lion DNA?" he asked, an incredulous expression on his face.

"No. Not really. Not only does he not have access to equipment, wherever he's hiding, but he just doesn't possess the know-how. No scientist I know, not even my mother, would be capable of such a thing, not to mention the ethics of it. Even the idea would cause an internecine struggle among any group of reputable scientists."

"So if it's impossible, why are you thinking Nash had something to do with it?"

"I don't know. I guess it's just a feeling."

Unfortunately, it wasn't the last attack. The next day, a raptor large enough to be a pterodactyl swooped down from the sky. When it was

destroyed by newly appointed guards armed with laser scopes and brought to the lab, we noticed the same thing we had with the mysterious leaf lion. The giant bird was a hybrid. Part plant and part hawk, but its size indicated that something else was at play. The others thought these animals were native to the planet. Even Thane dismissed my theories as impossible.

Then, the next day, a creature that looked like a mythological dragon tore out of the trees and leveled a house, snapping his jaws and groaning loudly enough for me to feel the vibrations in the lab. His scales flickered in the breeze like beech trees, and the ruff around his thick neck rose, the individual scales looking like fig leaves. He was brought down, but it took a monumental effort and losing another colonist to do so. That creature had crocodile DNA.

I told Thane we needed to pull the plug on introducing more animals, at least until we figured out what was going on. I wondered what was next. Would it be hybrid owls or, heaven forbid, a giant anaconda? It was quiet for a while, no new attacks for a week, but all of us were scared. When the fishermen headed down to our manmade lake, they noticed that the fish were changing too. The scales had turned green or purple, and they grew larger and larger in size until they were monstrous. The idea was proposed to set up a protective dome, much like the early colonies on Mars had done.

With all plans to release future animals in the wild suspended and the changes taking place in the nearby lake becoming obvious, people shied away from eating meat. No one would even drink the goat milk or cheese from the animals stabled nearby. The protected herds were unchanged visibly, and the zoologists assured the colonists that the DNA samples taken from them was still coming up normal. But everyone was afraid to eat anything except what was stored in our diminishing ship's dispensers, even the vegetables.

When I looked at the salad on my plate during a late lunch with Thane and decided to set my own fork down, I knew I had to do something. He, too, shoved his salad back and forth, seemingly unwilling to risk DNA contamination.

"When is the dome going up?" I asked.

"Tomorrow afternoon. Why?"

"I wanted to gather a few more samples before it happens. Can my schedule be rearranged?"

“You can make up your own schedule,” he said. “You’ve never asked my permission before. Should I be worried?” he teased.

“No.”

“Well, it’s fine with me as long as you take a security detail. I don’t want any leafy leopards to pounce on my bride a week before the wedding.”

“I don’t need a security detail.”

He leaned forward. “I insist, Astra.” He picked up my hand and kissed my fingers. “I want you to be safe.”

Giving him a sheepish smile and hoping he couldn’t read me as easily as he claimed he could, I said, “Okay, you caught me. Delenna is throwing me a bridal shower. I’m not supposed to know about it, but no men are allowed. Will you help me keep the secret?”

“Absolutely.” He smiled widely. “Take the whole day off. If you get time, tell the gardeners which flowers you want for your bouquet.”

“I will. Thank you, Thane.”

“Oh, and choose at least some ivory-colored blossoms to match your dress.”

I raised an eyebrow and nodded, leaving him to his dreams of a perfect wedding to a perfect, willing girl. It only took a moment for me to find the key in Jax’s domicile. Thankfully, no one wanted to live in the home of someone accused of murder, and it was still empty. Quickly, I headed to the greenhouse, pushed aside the pot containing the red geranium, and found a hidden door with a lock.

Inserting the key, I twisted and it unlocked with a pop. The lid squeaked when I opened it and I had to shove aside a blanket. There, beneath the fabric, was some kind of contraption. I’d never seen anything like it before. It had straps like a backpack but there was also an engine and it was fairly heavy. I staggered beneath its weight.

Jutting out from a cargo pocket on the device was a slip of paper wrapped around the most exquisite blossom made completely of metal. It was a recreation of the flower we’d discovered in the clearing, the one he’d named the Astra Touch-Me-Not. I ran my fingertips over the hard petals and the stamens. It was incredibly detailed and must have taken him some time to create. There was writing on the stem. When I traced the words with my hand, I gasped, realizing it was the label from my father’s hibernation pod.

My eyesight blurred at the memory of my father, the gift Jax had given me, and the young man I desperately hoped was not dead.

After removing the paper, I placed the flower back in the pocket, then, unfolding the page, I read in Jax's unmistakable hand.

Jet Pack Instructions...

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Chapter 20

Over the Moon

Jet packs had been a longtime dream of supernerds since the twentieth century. Many tried and failed to make them work over the decades, and then, finally, someone did it. Unfortunately, the device proved unstable as well as expensive, not to mention the fumes were terrible for the environment. Then, with the advance of easier technologies such as the skein, named for both the reference to unspooling yarn as well as the formation geese fly in, the idea of jet packs was abandoned.

With the skein, you just stepped outside your home and selected the program on your tablet, voice inputting your destination. An available pod was guaranteed to appear within thirty seconds, and it worked by clicking onto the nearest high velocity string, ricocheting you from string to string of pods until you either reached your destination or it delivered you to the airstrip version. The system cost billions of dollars to fund but it was quickly used worldwide.

The old-style highway systems were converted, monitor towers being placed about every kilometer or so depending on the terrain, but the roads were no longer necessary to maintain since skein pods were hovercrafts. The overland version could rise as high as one kilometer, but there was no limit to how high the airstrip versions could go. They could even break the Earth's atmosphere. The technology for the early transgalaxy ship models were, in fact, based on the airstrip pods since they were so efficient at conserving and recycling energy.

On Earth you could get from Los Angeles to Beijing in just two hours. The system had eliminated transportation accidents altogether. Also each pod had the ability to scan its passengers for everything from heart attacks to weapons to threatening behavior using voice recognition software combined with medical scans.

In the case of a medical alert, the pod redirected you to the nearest hospital. When I left Earth, passengers still had the right to disable the medical scans, which my parents always did. Otherwise, it would have detected my lung issue and rerouted me. You had to sign a waiver to turn it off.

Other scans were mandatory. Possible threat cases were reported for investigation, and if someone abused another passenger inside a pod, the system would keep the abuser strapped in until he was released by authorities. If you tried to engage the pod with a weapon or illicit materials in tow, instead of being delivered you to your destination, you'd be taken directly to lockup and the pod would testify against you.

Since the law was passed forbidding all other forms of transportation except for manual modes, law enforcement was freed up to focus on other problems. It was amazing how many crimes required transportation to be successful.

When I'd left Earth, the lawmakers were debating adding a scanning technology, which would allow the pods to inspect neighborhoods for abused individuals, kidnapped victims, escaped criminals, vagrants, etc. Such a law was considered too invasive for most, but others advocated for it, wanting to protect the downtrodden, while those who opposed it wanted to protect their privacy. Truthfully, I could see the point of both sides. As for me and my family, we always voted against it, knowing the pods would identify my personal deficiency and report it. But now that we were on another planet, it was one less thing for me to worry about.

I read through Jax's instructions and powered up the device, then turned it off and slung it over my shoulder, staggering a bit under its weight. After carefully replacing the cover and the geranium, I exited the greenhouse and made my way as quickly as possible to the tree line. Once I was in the shadows of the great trees, I felt as if they were drawing around me, welcoming me into their sheltering branches and hiding me from the colony.

It was awkward trying to balance my large travel bag along with the jet pack, but finally, I felt ready to give it a try. I'd toggled the tracker off my tablet and synced it to the jet pack system, loading Jax's last known location into the device. A screen swished up from the arm handles, showing me an image of the colony relative to where I now stood. At a glance, I saw it already held the location of Uncle Harm's tree house. When I touched my

finger on it, the system told me the distance and the estimated time it would take to get there. Though it was about a two-hour walk from the colony, it was only five minutes away by jet pack. Now I knew how Jax got back and forth between the tree house and the colony so quickly.

My nerves got the best of me for a brief moment. Jet packs were not standard-issue on terraforming missions. That meant Jax must have made it since we landed, scavenging the parts from the dismantled ship and using a bit of elbow grease. The device was way too heavy to have been a part of his approved personal belongings. I shook out my hands, admitting to myself that it was more my unfamiliarity with the device than a distrust of Jax's tinkering ability. He was good at his job. What's more, he felt comfortable letting me, a novice, fly the thing. That, above anything else, reassured me.

When I brought up Jax's marker, the system calculated the distance and the estimated time it would take to get there—one hour. That was far, even by jet pack standards.

"Proceed to selected unknown marker," I said, directing the computer.

CALCULATING...CALCULATING...
SELECT FASTEST COURSE OR SAFEST COURSE.
SYSTEM RECOMMENDS SAFEST.

I hesitated, my finger hovering over the button that said fastest. It would save me almost fifteen minutes. As if reading my mind, the button saying Safest Course blinked brightly. I went ahead and clicked safest and held on tightly to the arm handles as the jet pack engaged its power, cycling through a countdown that rattled my teeth.

LIFTING OFF IN 5, 4, 3, 2, 1...INITIATE.

A powerful surge of warm air bathed my legs, and as my weight shifted, the pack automatically tightened the straps on my waist, legs, and beneath my arms. I was bound as securely as a mummy in its sarcophagus, which was actually a good thing since I shot up through the branches faster than a projectile through a magnetic railgun.

If I could have used my arms to shield my face, I would have. The pack wove around branches thicker than my body, and my face came within

millimeters of prickly needles. A miscalculation by the tiniest degree could have blinded me. It made me wonder what would have happened to me if I *had* chosen the fastest route. I made a promise to myself in those moments that I would never, *ever* select the fastest route.

It took a full two minutes to clear the trees. That's just how tall they were. But once I rose above the tallest of them and my head was bouncing against the puffy pink bellies of clouds, the pack shot me straight ahead so quickly my eyes watered and my ears popped. The clasp holding my hair slid off almost immediately, and my hair whipped back and forth in the wind, stinging my cheeks with soft slaps.

I lost track of time. The course adjustments the pack made were so subtle that I didn't even notice. Only the blip on the screen marked the passage of time. It took me a few too many seconds to realize that the red square moving toward it was me. I asked the computer the remaining time to arrival about every minute at first, but then I paid closer attention to the world beneath me and was able to pass the time by studying the terrain.

The planet was beautiful. In fact, I'd never seen anything more lovely. We'd been fortunate indeed to have landed on such a vibrant, thriving world. It was easy to forget when you spent most of your hours in the lab. Since the ship was dismantled, we no longer had a way to investigate the planet from the air. I knew the forest was thick and lush but I'd only viewed it from space.

Seeing the trees from directly above them was mind-blowing. They were so, so tall. If the planet wasn't so temperate, the tops of the trees would be covered with snow. The spate of giant alien evergreens stretched as far as my eyes could see in each direction, only eclipsed by a vast mountain range in the distance. It was toward those mountains, gilded with autumn colors by the binary suns, that I was heading.

The jet pack angled me so my nose pointed up. I flew over a tree-topped hill, and when I came down the other side, I saw light twinkling in the distance. The light, it turned out, was a large sea as gray and smooth as steel. I flew over it for a time, and I saw the waves lapping peacefully against the tree-lined shore. Huge roots stretched out into the sea, and I realized then that the ocean must be fresh water for the trees to grow so tall. Either that or the trees could process both salt and fresh water and could tolerate the salt spray that dashed against the trunks and lower branches.

I sighed. There was so much we needed to research, and I was surprised at how much I wanted to be a part of it. When my parents had signed on for the mission, I was less than enthusiastic. I knew they were doing it for me, and life on a new planet in relative freedom did appeal to me, but I was too young to settle into a life I wasn't sure I wanted. With circumstances being what they were, I was stuck on this planet now whether I wanted to be or not.

Despite all that, I'd learned to love my job. Unfortunately, there'd be no chance for me to continue my studies, at least, not with the colony and their equipment. Now that I'd left, I'd be banished like Jax. I didn't think Thane would forgive me for leaving. It was interesting to me that I found I wanted his forgiveness. I liked Thane. I just didn't love him and I didn't want to marry him. It wasn't that he was such a bad choice, it was more that I felt I wasn't being given a choice.

Something moved through the trees below. It was big. But it was camouflaged enough that I couldn't make it out. It seemed to be following me for a while, but then the shaking of the trees stopped and the forest quieted again.

I thought about the large creatures that had attacked the colony. It wasn't unheard of to see animals of extreme size due to imprinted genes. This was especially prevalent in genetic hybrids found in books, such as the liger—the offspring of a male lion and a female tiger. But the leaf lion was even larger than that. Much larger than any cat that had ever lived on Earth, and that included prehistoric cats.

My mother once told me about a team of scientists who actually genetically modified a cross between a Komodo dragon, several breeds of lizard, an alligator, and some newly discovered theropod DNA in an attempt to make a real, live version of Godzilla. It wasn't sanctioned, of course, so it was done in absolute secrecy. But once you make a monster that large, it's pretty hard to keep the lizard in the bag, so to speak. The beans were spilled shortly after they produced a viable specimen of whatever it was, and the news drones descended, documenting everything.

The scientists were discredited and were banished from their work and, in fact, were no longer able to work in a scientific venue of any kind thereafter. Other teams were brought in to try to help the suffering animal. The creature, as the new scientists predicted, wasn't able to move around well, and though billionaire investors spent mountains of dollars feeding it

mountains of food, it didn't survive past maturity. All the reputable scientists involved considered it a blessing.

The two biggest problems with monstrous creatures like Godzilla and King Kong were, A, keeping them fed, and B, fighting gravity. If a type of Godzilla really existed, he'd need something like two hundred million calories a day just to maintain his status quo. Even if he ate a dozen humans a day, the average human body being around one hundred thousand calories, it still wouldn't be nearly enough.

The second problem, fighting gravity, meant that his bones would have to be incredibly dense. In fact, most of his body mass would have been his skeleton. Now the creatures I'd seen on this planet weren't Godzilla- or King Kong-sized, but they were definitely larger than elephants. That meant their bone density should have been much higher and they should have weighed tons. But I remembered it only took a half-dozen men to move the lion. Delenna's notes had said that the "bones" of the creature were incredibly light and even flexible. They were also hollow, resembling bamboo.

With no other animals on the planet, at least that we knew of, how did these creatures grow to full size? What did they eat?

I was still pondering this question when the jet pack altered the trajectory and began descending toward the end of the mountain range. It slowed about ten meters from the ground and then settled gently. My toes touched down first, and when I settled, the straps loosened enough for me to wriggle out of the jet pack. After turning off the device, I scouted around with my tablet, trying to find the tracker Thane had put into Jax.

Calling his name was futile, but I tried it anyway. I didn't expect a response and I got none. It was a waste of time trying to find the device by sight alone, so I switched my tablet to a bio-signature view and filtered out everything but Jax's personal signature. Taking my tablet in both hands and using it as a sort of divining rod, I was able to locate the tracker hidden beneath a rock. Pulling it out, I rolled it between my fingers.

It was a subdermal tracker. Jax must have dug it out. It would have been terribly painful and he didn't have access to a healing chamber. But if there was one thing I'd learned about Jax, it was to never underestimate him. There was a tiny nub on the back of the locator that didn't belong. Changing my tablet to microscope, I studied it and recognized it was an old-school

file. I scanned it with my tablet and a passcode came up. It asked for the name of the plant that hurt me on a hike.

I typed:

B U L L W H I P

A message popped up.

Astra!

We aren't too far. Put these coordinates into the jet pack system, and it will bring you right to us in just a few minutes. If, for some reason, you've hiked here instead, which would be crazy, follow the mountain range three kilometers to the left if you are facing the range. Then you'll have to locate our cave about twenty meters from the ground and climb up. I'm really hoping you have the jet pack.

Jax

Turning, I entered the flashing coordinates on the pack's system and it blinked green, showing me it was ready. Next, I placed the tracker Jax had dug from his own flesh back underneath the rock, hoping I hadn't moved it enough to alert Thane. After strapping the pack back on, I clicked the ignition button and was soon flying through sky again, but this time at a much lower altitude.

I was just beginning to feel at ease strapped into the jet pack when it began to descend. Scanning the hills, I finally noted a large cave and circled, trying to figure out how to direct the pack to deposit me inside. I searched the cave opening for signs of life every time I passed it, but it remained dim and foreboding. Vines draped across the hollow in the mountain, fluttering in the wind, and plants spilled over the lower lip, looking like a protruding tongue. It gave me the impression that the mountain was screaming. I shivered.

Unfortunately for me, the dark clouds above decided it was a good time to shed a little weight. A downpour ensued, making me very uncomfortable and decreasing visibility. As the angry clouds continued to wring themselves dry over my head, I called out to Jax, but the wind whipped away my words.

Despite this, he suddenly appeared at the mouth of the cave, and when he spied me circling, he waved his arms, excitement to see me obvious on his face. He kept circling his arms and shouting something, but I couldn't make out what he was trying to say. Gesturing to the pack, he mouthed something that looked like *set down* or *lock down*, and I tried running through the commands until I found something that said *shut down*. I figured that was the right one and selected the command.

Immediately the jet pack turned off, even though I was more than twenty meters in the air, and I screamed as I fell with the fifty-pound weight on my back. Branches broke beneath me, slowing me a bit but not stopping me until I got closer to the ground. Then I heard whispering voices in my mind. It sounded like they hissed with alarm. I might've even made out what they were saying if I hadn't been screaming for my life.

The rough tree limbs that were breaking against my body changed, becoming more rubbery somehow. They also seemed to cradle me as if catching my weight and dropping me branch to branch so I rolled like an awkward human marble in a game of traps and rails more than fell. Even the leaves seemed to cushion me. When I finally landed, sliding off the end of a groaning branch, I was deposited gently on my feet.

I glanced up at the big tree, thankful but amazed, detached the leg straps, hefted the weight of the pack off of me, hoping it wasn't damaged beyond repair, and began making my way back to the base of the mountain. Footsteps echoed in the forest, and before I made it more than a dozen steps, Jax was beside me. He wrapped me in a tight hug, and when he stepped back, he rubbed his hands up and down my arms.

"You're freezing," he said, unstrapping the jet pack and hefting it over his own shoulder. His dark hair, shaggy now that he'd been living in the wild, was dripping, hanging over his eyes. When he pushed it aside, rivulets ran down his cheeks, disappearing into the shirt that clung to his chest.

"I'll be okay," I said. The trees had broken my fall. I glanced up the nearest tall trunk. "I did more damage to them than they did to me."

"You're sure you're okay?" he asked, worry on his face.

He lifted a hand and stroked my cheek. His touch felt warm despite the cold rain, and my heart leapt in my chest. "I'm fine," I said, cupping my hand over his and clutching his fingers.

Jax's worried expression changed to a soft smile. "Come on," he said. "I'll help you up to our cave. It's not as comfortable as the colony, or the tree house, but it'll do for now. Are you hungry?" he asked.

"Starving," I replied.

"Good. We've got plenty."

"Oh, I brought food of my own. I'd hate to deplete your supplies."

"Nonsense," he said, still gripping my hand as he began to lead me toward the cave.

The climb was more arduous than it appeared, and I wondered how Jax's uncle managed to get up and down to forage. When we finally made it to the cave edge, I found it warm despite the weather and noticed a heating device that Jax must have brought when he evacuated Uncle Harm.

"That the girl?" I heard from behind a curtain of plants that grew down over the mouth of the cave. Several more potted plants were placed around the lip so they could absorb the sunshine, not that they were getting any at that moment.

"Yes. She made it," Jax said. "Though the pack is worse for wear."

"You'll fix it, boy," he replied. "Come on in, young lady. Have some supper."

Jax bustled around, spreading out a blanket for me and shoving baskets and boxes aside to tidy up the cave. Then he handed me a towel to dry my hair.

After I wrung out my hair and dried it, I sat, and Uncle Harm passed me a bowl full of greens with tiny pink flowers, sliced tubers, phosphorescent pods that looked like peppers, and a dried fungus that vaguely resembled mushrooms.

"Wait," he said as I lifted my fork. "Forgot the seasoning."

Picking up a purple fruit, he cut it in half and squeezed. Violet juices dripped from it and coated my salad with an oily, fragrant substance that smelled like a cross between a lemon and blackberry. Touching it with my pinkie, I tasted it and found it delicious. For some reason, eating a native salad with Jax and his uncle didn't bother me like it did in the colony.

"It's good," I said as we dug in.

"Course it is," Harm replied. "Trees show me the best foraging spots."

When I glanced over at Jax, I saw he'd combed back his hair and changed before sitting down. I plucked at my wet shirt and pushed back my

tangle of hair, feeling like I should have changed first too. I was getting his blanket all wet.

As we ate, I told them about Nash's disappearance along with the embryos and the tech, as well as the attacks on the colony. When I described the animals, Jax and his uncle gave each other a look.

"What is it?" I asked. "You've seen them?"

"We did," Uncle Harm said. "They didn't hurt us none."

"Perhaps we were lucky," Jax said to his uncle.

The man grunted. "Luck's got nothing to do with it. Trees woulda warned me if there was danger."

"I hope that's true," I said, setting aside my unfinished salad. Uncle Harm picked it up and tucked in with enthusiasm.

Jax nudged me with his elbow. "You don't think Nash was killed by one of those things, do you?" he asked.

"I, um, hadn't really considered that."

"No?"

"No. I was thinking more along the lines of him causing it."

"How do you figure?" Jax asked, stretching out his long legs and putting his hands behind his head, leaning back on a makeshift pillow that crackled with old leaves.

Both of them listened intently as I shared my suspicions. I told them about the strange footprints, the green goo on the backs of the cameras, and Thane's belief that Nash was in on the murder that Jax had supposedly committed.

When I finished, adding the news that they were also being blamed for Dr. McGivers's death, Jax shook his head. "I'm assuming you know that I'm not capable of such a thing, otherwise you'd be a very foolish young lady to come find me. And you, Astra Meador, are not a fool. As for your brother, it's not possible. Nash doesn't have a mean bone in his body. He's your brother, Astra. You know him better than anyone."

Nodding, I said, "I used to. Now I'm not so sure."

"Trust me. Nash wouldn't murder anyone."

"Yeah? And before we came here, I wouldn't believe he would abandon me either."

We fell silent for a time and then Jax asked me about Thane. "So, how's your boyfriend dealing with the idea of you leaving?"

I pulled my knees up to my chest and wrapped my arms around them. “I’m not really sure,” I said. “But you should know that Thane isn’t my boyfriend.”

“Is that right?” Jax said, his lips stretched in a wide smile. His teeth were ultra-white under the light of the solar-powered lanterns.

“Yeah,” I replied, twisting my mouth as if I tasted something sour. “He’s my fiancé.”

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Chapter 21

Dead to the World

“Fiancé?” Jax said, appalled. He sat up quickly. “When did this happen?”

Uncle Harm cleared his throat. “Er, perhaps this is a conversation best left to young people. I believe I’ll retire for the evening. Good night.”

“Good night, Uncle Harm,” I said.

Jax said nothing but kept his eyes trained on me while his uncle hobbled off behind a curtain farther back in the cave. He’d turned off all the lanterns but two and took one of them with him. I watched the light bob behind the curtain until he moved too far away for me to see it.

“How could you agree to marry him?” Jax murmured. “You don’t love him.”

Though he pronounced it like a statement, there was a small squeak in his voice that meant he wasn’t entirely sure. “Jax,” I began.

“I just don’t get it. Are you really that blind to what he is, to his ambition? Or maybe you’re just swayed by his pretty face.”

He was hurt. To further show his vulnerability, he rubbed his hand over the scruff of his jaw and through his long, bushy hair as he averted his eyes. It was shocking to me that Jax didn’t realize how handsome he was. I considered him much more attractive than Thane. I liked the scruff. His slightly crooked nose was adorable. The callouses on his hands and the ropy bands of muscle on his arms were evidence of his hard work. And these were just his outer characteristics. Jax was also kindhearted, dependable, and thoughtful. How could he think for a moment that a woman would find him unattractive?

I frowned. Did he think me so foolish as to give a man my hand in marriage with a mere cursory thought on the subject?

“Jaxson Preston,” I said. “Firstly, I’m offended that you would think I’d just jump at the first handsome boy who crossed my path. Have I ever given

you cause to think me so shallow?”

He folded his arms across his chest. “No,” he admitted. “But I’ve been wrong about girls before.”

“And do you consider me a typical girl?”

“You’re anything but typical, Astra,” he said, the corners of his mouth lifting. “You don’t love him, then?”

“Of course I don’t love him.”

His shoulders relaxed. “You’re sure?”

“I’m sure. My agreeing to marry him was the only way to appease his father so he’d let you escape.”

Furrowing his brow, Jax said, “What do you mean let me escape?”

“If I hadn’t said yes to Thane’s proposal, you would have been killed. Thane helped you get away as a favor to me.”

“Thane didn’t help me get away,” he said with a frown. “I built an escape hatch in my bunker. It was how my uncle got in and out. As soon as you left, I was gone.”

“But the tracker... Thane told the colonists he planted a tracker in you and that it would incapacitate you if you crossed the colony’s boundaries.”

“Astra,” he said, “Thane lied. Those trackers were put into each of us when we boarded the ship. They did it after we were asleep.”

“That can’t be right.”

“It is. I took mine out a long time ago, keeping it to throw them off track and just in case you needed to find me someday. Speaking of which, we need to get rid of yours before your boyfriend comes looking for you.”

I jumped up. “But, Jax! If he can track me, then he’ll come for you and your uncle. I’ve led him right to you!”

“Relax. We’re too far away by foot for him to catch up that quickly. He probably won’t start looking for you until morning. That is—” He gave me a strange glance.

“That is...what?” I asked.

“That is...unless he’s expecting you tonight.”

Gasping, I punched Jax in the arm. “No! He’s not expecting me tonight.”

He visibly relaxed and rubbed his arm. “Good.”

“He’s not like that. He wouldn’t push me to do something I wasn’t ready for.”

“Right. Like getting married, for example.”

“That was just a formality,” I explained. “Something to make his father feel at ease.”

“Sure it was.”

“Jax?” I said.

“Yeah?”

“Where, exactly, is the implant?”

He blew out a breath. “It’s pretty deep in your thigh. You’re not going to like me removing it.”

“Did your uncle have to do it too?”

“Nah. I snuck him on board early, so he was hidden. Harm was never implanted.”

“Lucky.”

“Tell me about it.”

“Jax?” I wriggled closer to him and gripped his arm.

“Yeah?” he replied softly, ducking his head closer, making my insides go warm.

“Can you do it now?”

His breath hitched and he looked at me quizzically. “Do what, exactly?” he asked. “I mean, I’m game for just about anything, but I want to make sure we’re on the same page.”

“I want you to take out my implant now.”

“Now?”

“Yes. I don’t like the idea of being tracked.”

“I get that,” he said. “Okay, yeah. I can remove it.” He scanned me with his tablet and said, “It’s in your left leg.”

Nodding, I angled my body toward him, pulling my pant leg up to mid-thigh or so.

Jax glanced at my exposed leg and then at my face. “It’s um, higher than that.”

I shifted the fabric higher and he shook his head.

“Show me,” I said.

He put his palm on my thigh and slid it slowly upward until his fingertips disappeared beneath the fabric. I sucked in a breath and then he said, "Here it is. Can you feel it? You'll have to press down."

With the leg of my pants wrapped tightly on my thigh, I pressed my fingers down on top of the fabric. I felt nothing through the pants. "Are you sure?" I asked.

"See for yourself."

He took a still image and held out his tablet. I could see a bright white square sitting about four inches down from the top of my thigh. I swallowed, fear and determination warring in my middle. The sharp teeth of determination finally killed the writhing snake of fear, and I nodded briskly, reaching up to my neck to unzip my jumpsuit all the way down to my thigh, exposing my underclothing.

My face reddened as Jax averted his eyes to all but my thigh. First, he dusted a white powder over the surface of my skin. "It's a natural numbing agent," he said. "My uncle makes it."

He rubbed it in a circle, and after a few seconds, I couldn't even feel his fingers. "It's working," I said.

"Good." Next, he took a pen-sized tool and clicked the button. A tiny laser opened the layer of skin. I smelled my own burning flesh. "Okay so far?" he asked.

"Yes."

"Okay. Now comes the hard part." He reached into a pouch of tools and pulled out something that looked like tweezers. Then he handed me a soft towel to stop the dripping line of blood. As he dipped the tweezers in a green goo solution that looked very similar to what I'd seen in the lab before on the back of the camera, he said, "What I wouldn't give for an autoclave."

"There's one in my lab," I said nervously, watching him draw closer with the tweezers.

"Are you changing your mind?" he asked, hesitating. When I shook my head, he went on, "This solution of Uncle Harm's works, but I'd trust superheated, pressurized steam better. This part will hurt, Astra. Hold on to me if you like, just don't jostle my right arm."

Placing the tweezers inside me gently, he began probing and I couldn't help it, I gasped, breathing hard, and dug my hands into his thick bicep.

“You’re doing fine,” he said as sweat broke out on my forehead. “Just a bit more. Do you need to stop and take a breath?”

“N...no,” I replied shakily. “Keep going.”

Every second the tool was inside my body was torturous. If he moved it a millimeter, I whimpered and wriggled, trying to thrash and escape the pain, but he kept his left palm locked down on my upper thigh as his right probed with the instrument.

“I’ve got the edge of it,” he said.

“Get it out,” I insisted, gripping his arm, my own shaking. There was a tug and then it was free. Jax moved the towel to cover the wound and placed my hand on top of it, pressing down.

“I’m going to get some of Uncle Harm’s healing serum,” he said. “Don’t move.”

I laughed darkly, wheezing slightly. “I’m not going anywhere,” I said.

“You did great,” he said, kissing my forehead before moving away.

He was back in just a few seconds with a bowl and knelt beside my leg. “Let me see,” he said, nudging away my hand. Jax glanced down at my leg and frowned.

“What is it?” I asked.

Glancing up, he smoothed his concern away. “Nothing. Nothing at all.”

“Are you sure?” I bent over my leg, trying to see beneath the towel. He quickly repositioned it.

“I’m sure. Let me just dab on a bit of this elixir. Close your eyes and think happy thoughts. This stuff stings.”

I hissed when his fingers slid the thick goop over my thigh.

“Okay. Now I’m gluing it shut. Don’t move or you’ll have a bad scar.”

My thigh was throbbing but Jax was gentle. I wanted a med patch for pain, but Jax and his uncle didn’t believe in med patches.

Once my thigh was wrapped, I lay back against Jax’s pillow. “Thank you,” I said, finally able to mean it.

“No problem,” he said. “Now, if you don’t mind, I’m going to zip you up.” I nodded. “Now that my thoughts aren’t occupied with surgery, they’re liable to drift to the half-naked woman lying on my bed,” he teased. His fingers brushed my thigh gently as he drew the zipper up and over my wound and up to my chest. “Do you want some water?” he asked.

“Yeah,” I replied. “I’m parched.”

When he handed me a drink, I asked, “Does Uncle Harm have anything for pain?”

“Sort of. It’s a painkiller that also functions as a sleep aid.” He opened a jar. “Just take a pinch or you’ll be out twenty-four hours. He made it from the big pods.”

“The ones that knock you out?”

“Yep.”

“And you’ve used this stuff?”

Jax shrugged. “He has and it seems to work pretty well.”

“Okay,” I said. “I guess it’s better than the alternative.”

“You’ll feel better by morning. I promise.”

I took hold of his arm as he turned away to replace the jar. “Jax?” I said as my eyes drifted shut despite my desire to keep them open.

“Yeah?”

“I’m glad to—” I fell unconscious.

**

I woke to the sound of a mortar and pestle. Uncle Harm was sitting near me, working.

“What...what time is it?” I asked, running a dry tongue over even drier lips.

“Midmorning or so,” he replied without looking at me.

“Where’s Jax?”

“Climbing the mountain.”

“Climbing the... Is that safe?”

“Safe enough. He managed to get the jet pack going. Seems your fall caused it more aesthetic harm than actual damage.”

“I see. So is he out scouting or something?”

“He’s looking for a raptor nest.”

“What on earth for?”

“You mean what on Gaia for?” His eyes twinkled as he considered me. “He’s going to attach your transmitter to one of their legs.”

“He’s going to what?” I said, scrambling to my feet and heading to the cave entrance. “He can’t do that. Those things are dangerous!”

Unable to see anything above us other than vines and sky, I hurried back to Uncle Harm and dropped down next to him.

“Why didn’t he just destroy it?” I asked.

“He did. But I didn’t think that was good enough. They’ll still find us.”

“With crushed components? It’s doubtful.”

He pointed the pestle at me. “Never underestimate tracking tech. Believe me, I’ve seen people found and removed who were much better hidden than we are.”

“But they’re not looking for us. You do remember this planet in uninhabited, right?”

Uncle Harm stared at me open-mouthed for a moment and then gasped. I thought he was dying or at least having a spell, and then realized he was laughing. Huge belly laughs echoed through the cave. I frowned and folded my arms, thinking this might be a part of his disease.

“Uninhabited, you say?” he chortled, wiping a tear from his eye. “What a silly notion.”

“Well, obviously, it’s not uninhabited now. We’re here.”

“My dear young woman, this planet has been inhabited since long before the time the Earth was just a speck of dust in the eye of the universe.”

I sighed and adjusted my seat to get more comfortable. “Whatever you say, Uncle Harm. I just don’t understand how you could let Jax go and do something so dangerous.”

“The raptors aren’t dangerous. Nothing on this planet will harm us, especially you.”

“You didn’t see them in action,” I said. “The beasts were giant and they killed people. I call that harm, don’t you?”

“They’ve been...misinformed.”

“Misinformed?” I raised my eyebrow. “You’re saying the giant animals are misinformed? By who?”

He visibly retreated into himself, picking up his mortar and grinding furiously. “It’s not for me to say,” he mumbled.

“Really?” I paused but he sat stubbornly avoiding my gaze. “Fine. Keep your secrets then. It doesn’t bother me. I just hope that Jax comes back safely.”

Uncle Harm grunted. “The boy wants me to check your leg if you’re willing.”

“Okay.”

“Are you feeling any pain?”

“Not really. It’s just itchy.”

I covered my torso with a thin blanket as I unzipped my jumpsuit, disinclined to wonder why I didn’t do the same thing with Jax the night before. Carefully, he lifted the makeshift bandage and inspected my wound.

“Huh. It’s as I thought,” he said.

“What?” I asked, unwilling to look at my thigh myself.

“You’re almost healed up.”

“What? How is that possible?” Leaning forward, I gasped when I saw that all that remained of my impromptu surgery from the night before was a thin, greenish scar.

“That’s amazing!” I said. “Your elixir works wonders!”

“That it does, young lady,” he said. “But this here miracle healing has nothing to do with me. The trees are protecting you.”

“The trees,” I said. “Okay. Well, it’s nice that you have such a special relationship with them.”

“Not so special. Leastwise not as special as yours.”

“Mine? You’re implying I have a special relationship with the trees of this world?”

“Yep.”

“Okay.” I patted his shoulder and offered him a small smile. “Lucky me,” I said, thinking he must know that I worked as an assistant botanist.

“You got that right.” He moved away, standing and stretching. “Right then. Now that I know you’re going to live, I have some business to take care of. You don’t mind my leaving you alone in the cave for a while?”

“Sure, I guess. Where are you going?” I asked, slightly worried about letting Uncle Harm climb down the mountain on his own.

“I’ve gotta check in. Never you mind about me. I do this every few days or so. Jax will know where to find me if you two get a notion to look. There’s some fruit in the basket over there. Help yourself and rest up. Healing takes a bit out of you. You’ll need to replenish your strength for what lies ahead.”

Before I could ask him what lay ahead, he slipped between the vines at the cave opening and, for a man his age, lithely made his way down the mountain. I wondered if I shouldn’t have taken him at his word. Maybe I should have fought harder to keep him in the cave until Jax got back. Then

again, Jax didn't think there was a problem leaving Uncle Harm in the tree house by himself, and I already knew he scavenged in the forest.

Regardless, there was nothing I could do about it now. Uncle Harm was gone, so I took his advice and picked through the assorted fruits, smelling each one, and ended up selecting something that looked like a supersized yellow grape. To keep myself busy, I queued up my tablet, took pictures of each fruit, and took notes on each one's taste and flavor. I even found one fruit that looked like a cross between a zucchini and a cucumber that had the flavor and mouthfeel of a buttery filet mignon.

There was something very gratifying about analyzing plants with the only tools at my disposal being my taste buds, eyes, nose, and hands. I felt like I made much more progress than I did with all the fancy equipment in my lab. With a full stomach, I moved on to Uncle Harm's jars, taking images and jotting down the names and uses he had written down in his old paper notebook.

I was examining the green goo that Jax had smeared on my leg the night before when I felt a hand touch my shoulder. I jumped and immediately my breath caught. My lungs seized and I touched my hand to my chest automatically. A vial of medicine clicked into place and shot a dose into my lungs. I inhaled deeply and let the gas out slowly, shocked that I wasn't even bothering to hide it. It was just an instinctual reaction. I felt safe with Jax and his uncle, secure in a way I felt with no one else in the universe other than my family.

My mind drifted to Nash. Was he safe? Was he in hiding like Jax? The thought occurred to me to ask Uncle Harm to question the trees, but then I shook my head at my own foolishness. Perhaps his brand of crazy was beginning to rub off on me.

"Sorry to startle you," Jax said. "How are you feeling?" he asked.

"Much better," I replied as he drew me to my feet. "Uncle Harm said he had something to do and that you knew where to find him if you needed him."

"Yeah. He enjoys talking to trees."

"I gathered that."

"Did you eat?"

"Yes. You?"

"Not yet." He glanced at the now empty basket of fruit.

I bit my lip guiltily. “Yeah. Sorry about that. I was cataloguing and might have gotten just a tad bit carried away.”

Jax laughed. “Don’t worry about it. I know where to get more. Besides, we have a bunch of dried stuff somewhere around here.”

Following him to a stack of hastily built shelves, I watched as he peeked in different baskets and pulled out a few pieces of what looked like fruit leather. As he chewed, I said, “I’m dying to know if any of these have protein. None of them look much like soy, but those big animals have to survive on something. Speaking of which”—I took his hand and drew him back to the center of the cave near the heating unit—“I’m really uncomfortable with the idea of you risking your life to tie my tracker to one of the raptors.”

“Doesn’t matter,” he said, chewing. “I didn’t get close. They were scared of the jet pack and took off. I was hoping they’d leave a baby in the nest but I guess it’s too early for them to lay eggs. I left the tracker in the nest anyway, tucking it into a mound of grasses. It’s about twenty-five kilometers away or so.”

“Do you really think they’ll hunt us down?”

“I wouldn’t put it past your fiancé.”

“I’m sure he’ll move on quickly enough. There are lots of pretty girls in the colony for him to pick from.”

“Maybe. But there’s only one you.” He picked up my hand and played with my fingers. “If you were my fiancée, you can bet I’d come after you.”

“Even through trackless miles of wilderness?” I asked. “Knowing there are ferocious mega beasts hiding in the trees?”

Jax shrugged. “They’d just make me run faster.”

“Hmm.” The edges of my lips twitched, forming a sticky sort of grin, and his mouth followed suit.

As he twined and untwined our fingers, he said, “Astra?”

“Yes?”

“Would you consider...breaking off your engagement?”

“I think that request is a bit untimely, don’t you think?”

“Well, there’s the practical side of it to consider but there’s also the emotional side.”

“What emotions are you presuming for me?”

Jax turned toward me, taking both of my hands in his. “That’s the thing. I don’t want to presume anything when it comes to you. I’m aware that you’ve spent more time around Thane. You’ve gotten a chance to know him, work with him, understand how he thinks.”

“Yes?” I said, confused as to where he was going with this.

“I wanted to ask if you’d be willing to give me the same chance. Get to know me like you do him before you commit to something long term.”

I laughed and said, “I think that’s a given. Where do you expect me to go, Jax?”

“I don’t know,” he said soberly. “You never know when someone will be taken.”

Putting my hand on his cheek, I said, “Are you thinking of your parents?”

“Partly, but mostly I’m thinking about the time we were apart. I hated it. I mean, it’s not like we were spending every waking moment together, but I...I dreamed of you, Astra, and I think if you’ll give us a chance, we could be great.”

“You dreamed of me?” I said, thinking of my own dreams. “What happened?”

His neck reddened. “Let’s just say your mouth tastes like honey in my dreams.”

I slid closer and replied, “Shall we see if that’s true in real life?”

Jax had just brushed his lips across mine when we both heard a shout from far down the mountain.

Scrambling to the edge of the cave, we looked down and I gasped.

Twenty meters below, we saw Uncle Harm standing there looking up at us with a startled expression. Surrounding him was a pack of very green, very hungry-looking wolves.

Chapter 22

Rooting Around

“Uncle Harm!” I called out as loudly as I dared. “Stay right there. Don’t move. We’re coming!”

Jax took hold of my elbow as I began to edge down the side of the mountain. “You stay here, Astra. You’re still recovering.”

“But I feel fine,” I said, and flexed my leg to show him that it didn’t hurt at all.

“Please, Astra,” he said, smoothing my hair over my forehead. “I don’t want to lose you right when this thing between us is just beginning.”

He looked so vulnerable and frightened, I agreed to stay, thinking it would give me time to find a weapon. Reassured that I would be safe in the cave, Jax hurried down, slipping and causing small, pebbly avalanches as he did so. I hurried through the cave, rummaging through boxes and baskets but coming up with nothing more dangerous than the laser pen Jax had used on me the night before. It would do next to nothing to defend us from the wolves circling below.

When I looked down on them from the cliff opening again, Jax was fighting the wolves off with a stick, trying to get to his uncle’s side. When he jabbed one in the ribs, it growled menacingly, baring its teeth and swiping at him with a claw. The whole pack reacted, snarling and moving closer to Jax, leaving Uncle Harm standing there virtually unprotected.

As for Uncle Harm, he seemed frozen in shock as he stared at Jax with a glossy-eyed expression, watching his nephew wave the large branch back and forth to stave off the pack. Turning in a circle, Jax kept them at bay while shouting to his uncle to get to the cave. Uncle Harm looked up at me and gave me a smile. I frowned, wondering if he was having one of his spells. *How can he smile at a time like this?* Then his eyes drifted down to the mountain’s edge, and I gasped when I saw what he was looking at. One

of the wolves was scrambling up the side on our narrow trail, trying to make its way to me.

I cried out and Jax looked up. With renewed determination, Jax smacked his branch into the pack, taking down two wolves at once, clearing a way to break through them. He ran, grabbing his uncle's arm as he did so, but his uncle remained rooted in place and shrugged off his nephew's arm. Giving up on his uncle and knowing the wolves were right behind him, Jax barreled toward the one who had managed to get halfway up to the cave entrance. Just as the wolves leapt, nipping at Jax's heels, he jumped, grabbed on to a tree limb, and wrenched his body up and out of their reach.

He moved fast, so fast I was shocked when he reached up and grabbed the leg of the wolf. The animal's wicked claws were dug into the cliff face, but Jax somehow managed to yank it free. It kicked out its arms and legs, looking for purchase, but finding none, it crashed down the mountain until it landed in a heap next to its circling brothers and sisters.

Before I could say a word, I was in Jax's trembling arms. "Are you all right?" he asked, clutching me tightly to him.

"I'm fine," I mumbled against his chest.

The two of us looked down at the pack. The one who had fallen got to its feet, shook itself, and then began licking a torn paw. The others whined and then sat down next to it. As one, they turned their faces up to our cave. It was more than eerie. Especially when Uncle Harm walked right between the wolves and patted their heads as if they were no more than lap dogs. I was confused at first but my bewilderment quickly morphed into anger.

"What is this?" I shouted down to him. "You risked Jax's life for nothing!"

"Not nothing," Uncle Harm said with an almost maniacal expression. "The boy passed the test!"

"What test?" Jax shouted down, straightening with his arm around me, keeping me close to his side.

Uncle Harm shrugged, his wily eyes flashing. "Not for me to tell," he said cryptically.

"Well, you're going to tell," I threatened, then pointed down to the pack. "Are they going to hurt us?"

"No," Uncle Harm replied. "They have no wish to harm you."

"What about Jax?"

“He’s passed the test. They’ll obey him now same as me.”

“Good,” Jax said. “Then I’m going to come down there to kick you clear to Tuesday.”

Grinning, Uncle Harm said, “Wouldn’t expect nothin’ less, boy. Come on down. There’s someone the two of you should meet.”

Jax began climbing down the mountain, reaching up to help me, and I muttered, “If he says we’re going to meet up with a tree, I’m going to kick him to Saturday. You can follow up with a kick to Tuesday afterward.”

“Deal,” Jax said with a grunt.

We skirted the wolf pack, giving them a wide berth, and stayed with our backs toward the mountain just in case they decided to attack again. It wasn’t that we didn’t trust Uncle Harm, but...no, we didn’t trust him. I didn’t believe that he meant us harm, not exactly, but who knew what kinds of crazy ideas were currently running through his head.

“Good, good,” Uncle Harm said, rubbing his hands together as he approached us. “Now the scrub wolves are going to take us to their leader, as it were.” He cackled at his own joke.

“That’s not very funny, Uncle Harm. You’re seriously expecting us to follow the pack through the forest? You’re going too far this time.”

“Believe me, young lady, if there was more time, we’d give it to you.”

“Who’s we, Uncle Harm?” Jax asked, keeping a wary eye on the wolves, who were still watching us. One of them had his eyes closed, an almost happy grin on his wolfie face. Another panted softly, while the one beside him drooled and licked his chops constantly. I wished I had a nice, juicy steak to toss into the bushes. Then again, these green wolves probably didn’t live on steak. I thought about the zucchini fruit that tasted like beef. Was that what they ate?

The members of the pack varied slightly. Some were dark green and others lighter. Three of them were mottled in color, with long, variegated leaf-like feathers that slightly resembled hosta plants covering their bodies. I longed to examine them. Even their ears resembled calla lilies. I wished I could study the texture of their fur and ears, but dared not.

Uncle Harm beckoned us forward on a slightly worn path through the forest. He was the picture of a perspicacious prophet leading his new converts on a mission of enlightenment. Only we weren’t blind followers. With Jax’s uncle in the front and the pack slinking through the trees on

every side of us, I felt more like a prisoner being marched to a guillotine than a postulant.

Something was very wrong. I was missing a big piece of the puzzle. I ran through the facts as we walked. There were animals that didn't behave much like animals. Someone with the know-how was not only growing the apex predators but mixing their DNA, creating hybrids—a thing that not even the most skilled scientists back on Earth could have done. That same someone had managed to get the quick drive functioning without the growth accelerator, an impossible feat by itself. Also there was the fact that Nash was missing. Now that I was essentially an exile like Jax, there was no way for me to help Thane solve the problem.

Whoever the dissolute culprit was, it was certain he lived among the colonists. He knew how we worked. He understood our schedules and our technology. And the most disturbing thing, he was, in fact, targeting us. Maybe Uncle Harm had stumbled upon something by accident. Maybe he was leading us to whoever was doing this. I whispered as much to Jax as we walked through the verdant forest and he nodded that he agreed. We made plans to keep our eyes open, our backs protected, and learn all we could. Saving the colony would be a priority.

Uncle Harm finally stopped at the base of one of the largest trees I'd ever seen and turned to us with a beatific smile on his face. Like a knight offering his favor to his lady, he pulled aside a section of bushes and vines with a flourish.

"What is this?" Jax asked his uncle.

"The entrance to the kingdom of Gaia," he said.

"Right." I edged closer to the gaping hole in the ground. The large tree had been hollowed out at the base. I'd seen such things done by rivers before, but there were no signs that there had ever been a river in this section of the forest.

"You expect us to go in there?" Jax said to his uncle. When the man simply nodded, he asked, "Why?"

"Because she needs to talk to you." He shook his head. "*They* need to talk to you."

"Who's they?" Jax asked.

"You'll find out."

“No, Uncle Harm,” Jax said. “You’ve gone too far. Now we’ve indulged you the whole way here, but it’s time to come to your senses. Clearly this planet has had a redounding effect on you. I didn’t think you could get any worse. In fact, I thought you were getting better, but obviously I was wrong.”

“But you weren’t wrong, boy!” Uncle Harm said almost fanatically. He grabbed Jax’s shirt in his fists. “I’m seein’ things right for the first time in years. Look at my hands,” he said. “They’re as steady as this tree—motionless even. They’ve blessed me!”

“I hate to tell you this, Uncle Harm,” I said, “but trees are hardly motionless.”

He groaned and slapped a hand on his forehead. “Fine. Unmoving then. She’s dauntless. Unmoving in her determination.”

“I’ve had enough, Uncle Harm. It’s unacceptable to be putting Astra in danger like this. We’re leaving.”

“No, you’re not, boy.”

Jax leaned down, practically touching his nose to his uncle’s. “Yes, we are. You can’t stop us.”

“You’re right,” Uncle Harm said as Jax took my hand and started leading me back the way we’d come. “I can’t stop you, but they will.”

The green wolves suddenly materialized out of the forest. The one closest to us snarled and snapped at Jax’s legs.

“Stop it,” I said to the wolf. “You leave him alone!”

Immediately the wolf’s expression changed. It whined and sat on its haunches, and then, seeing me frowning, it tucked its tail and lay all the way down, then rolled over on its back, exposing its belly.

“What just happened?” Jax asked quietly.

“I’m not exactly sure,” I replied. Taking his hand, I squeezed it and then shouted another command to see if it would work twice. “You!” I said, looking at another wolf standing nearby. “Come here.” When it hesitated, I used a sterner voice. “Come!” I said again.

The wolf practically crawled over to me and stopped next to the other one, still lying on his back.

“Sit,” I said to the green wolf. It cocked its head as if trying to understand my words. “Down,” I said. “Sit.” Its backside lowered almost hesitantly and then it began to wag its tail. “Good wolf,” I said. Taking a

step forward, I held out my hand. Jax pulled me back and the wolf growled. When I looked back at it and said, "Stop," the sound cut off immediately. "It's okay," I said to Jax.

The blood hummed in my body and my senses felt heightened. Inch by inch I lowered my hand, and when I made contact with the creature, there was an indescribable connection between us. I touched a soft ear and found it was indeed as silky as the petal of a rose. Heat pulsed through the thin flesh, and the warmth transferred to the pad of my thumb. When I lifted it, rubbing my fingers together, I was surprised to find the pleasant sensation lingered.

"You're a beautiful girl, aren't you?" I said. The beast closed its eyes when I stroked its head, and when I scratched it just behind the ear, its leg started kicking involuntarily. The body of the animal was bristly in some places but supple in others, and when I ran my hands over the leaf-like back, it made a rustling noise. "What are you?" I murmured to myself as I examined the creature.

"It's a hybrid," Uncle Harm said. "Somethin' like those transgenic fish or the spider goats on Earth. 'Cept this one's a bit more sophisticated."

"Since when have you and science become collegial?" Jax snapped.

"Pretty much since we landed on this here planet," Uncle Harm replied. "I don't object if it's done in harmony with the wildlife."

"*Wild* being the operative word," Jax mumbled under his breath.

Turning, I sighed. "What is it you want us to do?" I asked. "Bury ourselves alive?"

"She doesn't mean to bury you," Uncle Harm said. "She just has a few things to talk over."

"Fine," I said absently, rolling my necklace between my fingers nervously, wondering what my famous mother would have thought of all this. Surely she would know what was going on here. I just wasn't nearly as insightful as her.

Jax took my arm, leaned down, and whispered, "Astra, are you sure?"

"I want to find out what's going on," I replied softly. "If that means we check out this lead and get a little dirty while doing it, so be it."

"I'm not letting you go down there alone."

I squeezed his hand, grateful. "Lead the way, then," I said to Uncle Harm.

“Can’t,” he replied. “She wants only the two of you. I’m to wait here for your return. The scrub wolves will keep me company.”

“How are we supposed to see in there?” Jax said. “We left our tablets back in the cave.”

“Psht,” Uncle Harm said, waving his hand dismissively. “You rely too much on technology. She’ll provide the light you need. Now stop worryin’ and start gettin’ on with it.”

Seeing I was still resolved, Jax stepped into the gaping hole first. Clumps of dirt rained down on his shoulders from where his hand brushed the bottom of the tree. When he was stable, he lifted his arms to me. I started down, but my feet slipped on a wet pile of leaves and I slid, landing squarely against Jax’s muscled chest. He held me securely as I righted myself and seemed almost reluctant to let me go.

Leaning down to murmur in my ear, he said, “We’ll have to practice that again in less dire circumstances.” Pressing a kiss on my hairline, he offered his hand and I took it gladly.

It was dark and I feared we weren’t going to get very far. Thankfully, there was a sense of openness, even though we were underground. I didn’t have that same sense of claustrophobia I’d had when I woke in the hibernation pod gasping for air. Jax put a hand out in front of us and felt in every direction as we moved forward slowly, inching away from the waning light that slanted into the hole where the wolves and Uncle Harm waited. As for me, I was more than happy to press my side against Jax and let him lead the way.

A thin swoosh of air moved through the cavern, and it was like something huge breathing underground. The tunnel turned and Jax shifted to the left. In just a few steps, we lost even the meager light we had. I was just about to suggest that we turn around and go back when my eyes registered a dim light on the walls. Soon it was bright enough for me to see Jax’s face.

“What is it?” he asked.

I touched my hand to a strip of pulsing light. “Impossible,” I mumbled. “I think...I think they’re roots.”

“You mean these are the roots of the tree above us?”

“Some of them.”

“What do you mean some?”

“This big one is from the tree, but look at all these tiny roots. They’re from the plants and bushes aboveground. These probably belong to mushrooms of some kind. See how they’re tapping into the tree? Wait a minute. Yes. They’re all tapped into the tree.”

“You mean they feed off the tree roots?”

“Not exactly. It’s a mutually beneficial relationship—symbiotic. On Earth, mushrooms provide water and minerals for the tree and the tree feeds the mushrooms and provides shade. There are some types of trees that can’t thrive without mycorrhizae fungi. What’s strange is that all of these plants are rooting themselves to the tree even though I would never classify them all as fungi.”

“Interesting, but why are they glowing in the dark?”

“There are a few plants that are naturally occurring bioluminescent specimens, but they are rare. Foxfire is a fungus on Earth that glows a similar green color to this, but that’s aboveground. There’s no natural reason for roots to shine in the dark like this.”

Jax touched my hand. “So what do you want to do?”

“I guess we can go on a little bit more.”

“Are you sure?”

“Might as well. It’s only been about fifteen minutes. If we’re not gone for at least an hour, we’ll never hear the end of it from Uncle Harm.”

Jax stepped closer and nuzzled my neck. “There are worse things I can think of than being stuck in a dark cave with you for an hour.”

“Me too,” I said, standing on my tiptoes to wrap my arms around his neck. After a quick peck on the lips, I said, “We should keep going. I’m curious to see how far this lighted root system goes.”

It was about ten minutes later when I began to hear the voices. They were like before in the colony. I heard them but I couldn’t make out any words. “Hello?” I said.

“Hello,” Jax said beside me.

“Shh. I’m not talking to you.”

“Then who are you talking to?”

“I’m not sure. Can’t you hear the voices?”

He was quiet for a moment and then answered, “No. All I can hear is the sound of our footsteps and your heavy breathing. Speaking of which, do you need a hit of medicine?”

“No. I’m fine,” I said, though I knew he was probably right and I’d need it soon. My heart was beating fast even though we were moving slowly. I felt nervous, edgy, like I was experiencing a sugar crash.

Jax took hold of my shoulders and then slid his hands up to my neck. “Your pulse is racing,” he said. “I think we should go back.”

I shook my head. “No. I need to see.”

“Need to see what?” he asked calmly. “It’s looked the same for the last twenty minutes.”

Stepping away, I put my hands over my ears. The voices grew louder. They hurt. My breathing quickened. My lungs rattled. The voices seemed to penetrate my brain more than my ears.

She’s coming.

The old one said he would bring her.

We need her.

We should have summoned her sooner.

She needed more time to understand.

We didn’t know what was going to happen.

We should have known. We’re getting old.

Speak for yourself. I’m one thousand cycles young.

And half as beautiful.

Well, your top half is as lovely as a mushroom that’s dropped its spores.

Hush, you two.

She’s blocking us.

Wouldn’t you? If I could block out your whiny voice, I would.

I’m not whiny!

Yes, you are. Especially when that flying animal expelled his excrement on you as he passed overhead.

The changelings have no respect.

He said he was sorry.

Sorry doesn’t clean up the mess.

But he had no hands. Did you expect him to lick up his own ordure?

Better than leaving it on me.

That’s exactly why we need her.

To fertilize the ground?

No! She has hands.

So did the other one.

The other one thinks only of revenge. What we want is reform.

He said reform was impossible.

Maybe he's right. A tree can't grow tall on stony ground.

But a tree can grow around any obstacle as long as its roots are strong. We have strong roots, sisters.

Yes, we do. We will weather this storm like the others. When the wind buffets us, we will dig in deeper and stand straight and tall.

We must remember our heritage. We are the daughters of Gaia!

We are.

She draws near.

She falters.

She is weak.

We will strengthen her.

She will come to rely on us as we will on her.

I hope you are right.

Concentrate, sisters. Call her to us.

We will sing to her.

Sing of the past. Sing of things to come.

Our spirit is so tiny in her breast.

Then make her feel it. A tiny drop over time can carve a mountain.

Or it can destroy seedlings.

We have no more need of seedlings. She will harness the power. Provide the energy we need.

The other uses it wrong.

Besides, she prefers studying the younglings, not the elders.

It is no time to play with younglings. To explore the unknown.

The learning time is past. The doing time draws near.

The battle will be waged.

She will be our warrior.

She will be our hero.

She will bridge the divide.

The stars brought her to us.

Gaia brought her to us.

Shh. Quiet, my sisters. Concentrate. Make her hear us.

I removed my hands from my ears and the thousands of whispering voices disappeared. Instead, I heard a chorus of voices singing together in harmony. The melody struck my soul. The song tugged me forward, called to me, spoke to the innermost part of me.

Tears filled my eyes. The song was beautiful. The loveliest thing I'd ever heard. Stepping away from Jax, I moved forward at a faster pace.

"Astra?" Jax called. "Astra! Wait!"

But I couldn't wait. The song pressed me. Stirred my limbs with vibrant energy. I began to run, the air wheezing in my lungs. I heard footsteps behind me but I didn't care. No one would deter me from my course. A new serum clicked into place in my chest of its own accord. When I exhaled, it was green and the gases were sucked back into my skin through my neck, hands, and face.

"Astra!"

Astra. Astra. Who was Astra? I was need. Want. Desire. If I didn't reach the thing that drew me, I had no purpose.

Come to us, the voices sang. Be our warrior. Be our voice. From the wilderness of space, we beckoned you. The enemy draws close. The time for battle will come.

I opened my mouth and joined them. "Here I am," I sang. "Do not hide from me. My arms are stretched wide to embrace you. My sisters. My family."

She hears us!

"Yes, I hear you!" I shouted, happy tears running down my face.

On and on, I ran until something stopped me. It was a man. He scooped me up in his arms and began carrying me back the way I'd come.

"No!" I screamed. "They need me!"

"Who needs you, Astra? Have you gone as crazy as my uncle? I'm getting us out of here."

I bucked and kicked against him, desperate to reach my sisters. Then, something went wrong. My body went stiff and I realized my lungs were paralyzed. I came back enough to myself to know that I needed my medicine. Weakly, I touched my hand to my chest, but it had no effect.

The man must have guessed what was wrong with me. He set me down on the dark soil and pushed the spot on my chest. I felt a new vial lock into place but there was no dose of medicine. He pressed it again and a new vial clicked, but again there was no life-saving dose. Tearing my shirt open, he pulled back the synthetic skin and popped out the ring. It was completely empty. It shouldn't have been. It was a brand-new ring. It made no sense. Without the medicine, I would die.

Leaning over me, the man yelled. He shook my shoulders, but I could only gape at him like a fish. Then he pressed his lips against mine, inflating my lungs. It didn't matter. They wouldn't expand without the medicine. It was the only thing that could relax them enough to move.

In my mind, I sung to the thousands of beings, telling them I was sorry. That I couldn't be the hero they needed.

I said goodbye.

To them.

To the humans who raised me.

To the one who was once close to me. The one who grew in my shadow.

And then, lastly, to the human trying to breathe for me. The one who nourished me.

He was the one who held my heart, though my heart had now stopped beating. My last thought was that I would probably miss him the most.

Chapter 23

First Contact

No! We cannot let her perish.

The spirit inside her wanes. It flickers.

It is our fault. We pushed her too hard. Too fast.

Too fast, a voice mourned.

Too fast, another wept.

All is lost.

No. Not yet, the eldest said. We must sing to the boy.

The boy?

He has no spirit.

How can we nourish a spark with no fuel?

We will gift him.

It can be done.

Like the animals?

Yes.

But the changeling pod is too far away. She will expire in that time.

She was too weak. Too unprepared, a voice mourned.

It wasn't our fault. She blocked us!

Wouldn't you?

We are strange to her.

But she loves us!

She loves something she doesn't understand.

Enough. We must hurry if we are going to save her. Focus on the boy. Gift him with our spirit, but slowly, slowly, else we'll kill him too.

A tiny tendril pierced the wall of the tunnel. It circled in the air, growing and stretching, sniffing for the scent of the grieving boy. It could almost taste the salt of the tears dripping down his face. Gently, as lightly as the

double rays of the twin suns, it touched his shoulder. With an effort, it grew longer, tiny leaves and thorns sprouting from its sides, and when it touched his skin at last, it felt for the thrum of his pulse, drawing closer and closer until it hovered above the heavy vein.

The tip of the tiny vine lengthened, sharpening into a thin point, and then, quicker than lightning, it pierced his skin, pumping the green, living sap of the ancients into his blood.

The boy hissed and slapped at his neck, knocking away the thin vine and breaking the fragile thing.

Did it work? a voice asked.

It wasn't enough.

We don't know that.

Call him. If he hears, then it worked.

Come to us, they sang.

Yes, come. Bring your loved one.

We can save her.

We will help.

“Who’s that? Who’s there?” the boy asked, standing abruptly and spinning in the dark.

It's working. Sing louder but be careful not to overwhelm him with our power. It would crush him.

Lift the one you love.

Bring her to us.

We will help her.

We will heal her.

We need her.

The boy looked down at the still body of the girl, wiped his eyes clear, and then stooped down and lifted her in his arms. He stumbled through the dark tunnel, letting the voices guide him forward until, at last, he entered the throne room. An altar of wood had been prepared, and in a trance, he set the girl on top. After he settled her, straightening her limbs, vines went to work, piercing her skin. The boy stumbled and fell to the ground beside the altar, his eyes closing.

Let him sleep.

We have much work to do.

She chose well.

The boy is brave.

And strong for an animal.

A humming filled the cavern.

I wasn't sure where I was when I woke, but I was sore. Tiny throbbing pains covered my entire body and I was sleepy. So sleepy. I called out to Jax, but there was no reply. My eyes felt heavy but I managed to open them. The room was dark, only the glow of roots illuminating the space. So we were still underground. Had Jax left me? Gotten lost?

Jax? I cried, my voice echoing around me in an empty way.

Hush, daughter. You are still weak.

Who's there? Hello?

We are here.

We have saved you.

I tried to whip my head to the side to see who was speaking, but my head remained rigidly in place. I heard a rustle and realized I was bound to some sort of table.

Why can't I move?

The snake vines hold you in place.

It is only temporary.

I would think she'd be grateful, considering.

Perhaps she would fain be dead.

An animal might consider the reviving process execrable.

It doesn't matter what she thinks, her illness is incurable in this form.

Have your manners departed? No wonder you have so many creases. If you're not careful, your outer layer will peel away like a wrinkled cloth and leave you naked.

And your balding head will grow as brown and splotchy as a chub nut beneath the twin suns.

Sisters, cease this skirmishing. Now is not the time. Remain watchful and I will act as the voice.

The voice I considered the most matronly continued to speak while the others quieted to a small background hum.

The reason you cannot move, the voice said, is because we are healing you. The green medicine you use to help aid your respiration was depleted. We called upon it to communicate with you and used up all your stores. We are sorry for this.

Then...then how am I breathing now?

You are not breathing as animals do.

Of course I'm breathing. I'm talking, aren't I?

At that moment, I realized I wasn't talking. Not with my mouth.

We have activated your stomata.

My... You mean I'm breathing through my skin?

Yes.

But animals don't have stomata.

You are not fully an animal.

What do you mean?

There is much we need to discuss. You are stable for now. If you would prefer to sit up, we can detach the snake vines, but you will breathe more easily with fewer outer wrappings.

Immediately the pressure holding me down lightened. Vines whipped around me and detached sharp needles from my skin. When I slid up my sleeve, I could see hundreds of tiny dots, oozing with something green.

You did acupuncture?

More like a transfusion. Do not worry. You will heal quickly. Just like you did with your leg.

I sat up and frowned. Then I wobbled, feeling a bit light-headed. My clothing felt heavy on my body. Cumbersome. I couldn't breathe well. After unzipping my jumpsuit, I tied the arms around my waist. Once my arms and neck were bare, I felt much better. It was strange not to feel my lungs moving or to take in oxygen the normal way. I was tempted to remove my jumpsuit entirely, but then I saw an arm jutting out from the side of my wooden table.

Jax! I said in my mind and crouched down next to him to shake him awake. His head bobbed. He was out cold. What did you do to him? I accused.

We gave him a bit of our spirit so he could carry you here. It will not harm him. The effects are only temporary.

As I tried to reposition him so he'd be a bit more comfortable, the voice added, *Your mate is a fine choice, not like the young pettifogger.*

Pettifogger? Are you speaking of Thane? Who taught you that word? Who taught you English, for that matter? And who are you, anyway? Have you all been spying on me? Why can't I see you?

We do not speak in your mortal way.

We communicate mind to mind.

Yes. We read your thoughts.

The old one told us of your Thane.

We knew you needed a companion and asked his opinion.

It is not good to be alone.

We assumed you prefer this one to be your mate.

This is why he was tested.

Is that what you wish as well?

Did we misunderstand?

Let's just set that issue to the side for the moment and focus on the more important matter. Who, or what, are you?

We are the daughters of Gaia.

You mean the Greek goddess of the Earth?

We are not Greek or a goddess, though many have worshipped us.

We are not of the Earth, but we did seed it.

Seed it? My mind whirled. Are you...are you native to this planet?

We were born here, yes, the matronly voice said as the others dropped away. Sadly, I am the last of that first generation.

Why can't I see you?

You are seeing me. At least a part of me.

Where? I spun, peering through the darkness, but as far as I could see, there was no one there but me and Jax.

I am all around you.

I don't understand. Uncle Harm said we were to go to the kingdom of Gaia.

Yes. You are in the kingdom now. The heart of Gaia.

I rubbed my temples. All I see around me are large roots, I said.

Exactly. Those are my roots.

Folding my arms across my chest, I said, doubtfully, You mean you're a tree?

Yes. But I am much more than the mindless things you place in the ground around the colony of death. Those younglings are dark. Barren. Perhaps we could revive them with the green spirit if you removed the killing barrier, but I suspect too many of their generations have passed in dimness.

Killing barrier? Ah, the chemicals Jax pumped into the ground to protect the colony.

Okay. So let's assume for a moment that I'm not crazy and I am actually talking to an all-powerful sentient tree on an alien world and that I'm actually respiring with stomata right now instead of my lungs. What does that make me? Why have you called me here? Why did you save me? I sensed it was too many questions at once, but the response still came quickly.

We need your help, Astra Meador. You think we have merely summoned you to this chamber. To the heart of this world. This place down here where we are the strongest, bound together in sisterhood and unity. But we have summoned you from a much farther distance.

From the colony? I asked.

No. From your home planet. We detected you when you were born. The plant your mother used to conceive you was green, meaning it was full of our spirit. It changed you. Gifted you. Both you and your brother. Your souls called to us even from that great distance. We knew you were the one we needed to defeat the enemy.

Enemy? What enemy?

In the core of our planet is a vast bed of power. Like us, this mineral bedrock is more than just simple stone. It is feeling. It is the energy that fuels stars, builds galaxies. It is what sustains us. And it provides us the means whereby we may seed planets such as yours with life.

There are bipedal animals such as your people who have discovered this most precious resource and they intend to destroy this world.

They will carve it up.

They will take away pieces of it.

Take pieces of us.

They desire to build worlds they can exploit for their own reprehensible purposes.

If this happens, the elder voice said, all life in the universe will be destroyed. It might take centuries to happen, but it will happen, for if this world disappears, life disappears.

So people, space travelers like me, are coming here to mine? I asked. How do you expect me to stop them? Why can't you stop them yourselves? Maybe you could make a tornado like you did before when we arrived. I'm assuming that was you.

Yes. We did that. Once we saw you were safe in the forest, we tried to expel the other invaders.

I wasn't that safe. If it wasn't for Jax, I would have been sucked up into the cyclone.

We tried to distract you with the pollen but you resisted.

I knew that pollen was a kissing aphrodisiac!

The golden pollen does not stimulate reproduction in your species.

No? Are you sure? I asked, biting my thumb.

No. It merely lowers the inhibitions of your kind. It makes you feel happy, peaceful. The goal was to have you stay safely in the meadow while we discarded the ugly ship that brought you here.

Interesting.

Fortunately, your young man kept you grounded. Unfortunately, the ugly ship held fast. We fear the others will have technology such as you.

You mean you haven't seen them yet? They haven't landed before? To explore, I mean.

No. Not a ship. There were no bipedal animals inside it. It was too small for that. You would call it a probe. We didn't know what it was at first. Not until it ripped away a piece of us and left. Then it began sending signals.

But how do you know they're coming? Maybe the probe was just for scientists. There have been many such devices sent out from Earth. They are meant to explore, not to exploit.

There is a thin line between exploration and exploitation.

Many cross over it without meaning to.

We do not blame the blameless, but we must protect that which is most precious.

It is our right and our duty.

The deaths of a few, such as those who lived on your ship, are inconsequential compared to the death of the universe.

They delivered you to us and had, therefore, served their purpose. However, I sense this is not a good enough reason for you. Your scientific mind would prefer evidence, to see and weigh the consequences yourself, the eldest tree interjected. Very well. We know that this device took our energy and used it incorrectly.

We saw the ways in which the stolen green spirit was tested on that distant world.

It was used to do terrible things before it went dark.

But it was aware.

It was in pain.

It remained alert for a long enough time to show us their plans.

You must understand, Astra Meador, the eldest tree said, that because we have seeded the universe, we have spies that are literally planted on every world.

They are watch guards, a young voice added.

They protect us.

Safeguard our planet.

We are shrouded from view in a debris field so thick, your ships of metal cannot penetrate it.

Yours was the exception.

It was allowed to land.

The trees paused for a moment, as if letting me process what they'd said, then the lead tree continued, Perhaps it will comfort you to hear that we've known this time was coming. It was implanted in those of us of the first generation by our maker.

Your maker?

Yes. We are the origin of life, sprung from chaos. Our offspring are called the children of the aether. We are the giver of gifts, the first to come. But deep within my trunk lies a truth I have harbored since my first ring.

And what is that? I asked.

That someday, the child will return to kill its mother and, because he does not understand what he does, also kills himself.

So you're certain they are coming?

Yes. *A ship has already breached the barrier.*

I thought that was impossible.

Long ago, it was. Like many of the trees on your world, most of our sentinels have now gone dark. Hollow. One by one, their voices have disappeared over the eons, and the seeds they send out are tainted. This has left gaps. Openings large enough for a ship to slip through. But this is not all. They have been in communication with someone in the colony. He sends out a beacon. A signal to help them navigate.

How? Our interstellar communication system doesn't work.

Your technology is mysterious to us, but we have eyes and ears in the colony despite the barrier. We know this colonist has stolen core samples using vile methods. We know he has sent reports to the others. A reliable source within the colony has told us of this.

A reliable source? Who? Uncle Harm? He doesn't know anything about the colony.

It was not the old one. You will meet the other source soon. We do not want to overload your system with too much at once.

I think you're a little too late for that one. So tell me what you know about this traitor in the colony.

Most bipeds look the same to us.

We would recognize his footfall on our forest floor.

When he enters our space, our leaves tremble.

He is evil.

He has destroyed his own kind.

This is abominable to us.

His footsteps are harsh against our soil.

His presence taints us.

Blood follows him everywhere.

But if we can find him and figure out how he's signaling the ship, maybe we can stop them from coming here.

Even should you locate him, it is likely too late to prevent them from landing.

Even so, if he's the one who's been murdering our colonists, he needs to pay for what he's done. We don't condone murder either. If you will help

me find him, maybe we can force him to use the communications system to call for help.

What kind of help do you expect? Even if you found others of your kind sympathetic to our cause, they are too far away to prevent our annihilation. No. Allowing more of your kind to land on our planet is not going to aid us in this time of dread.

Even those who are here now are not welcome.

They leave large swaths of destruction everywhere they roam.

We would live in harmony if your colonists would agree to our terms, but it seems our envoy's messages have fallen on deaf ears.

Envoys? You mean the hybrids? They killed innocent men.

Some of them were conscripted.

Used in a way we didn't condone.

This matters not.

Are any of your kind truly innocent?

Just because we are far from your home world does not mean we don't know what has been done on your planet.

Over the centuries we have seen the lights grow dim.

The last one expired long before you were born.

But we tried to fix it. We changed.

You changed too late.

I had nothing to say in response. They were right. As much work as my mother did on Earth, there was too much that we'd lost. Too many species had gone extinct. The rainforests were gone. The lush evergreen forests in the northwestern Americas had perished long ago. The Amazon River was dried up and lifeless. There were only pockets of green left on our planet now and they were carefully preserved and cultivated.

Those gardens were like the zoos. The plants were no longer wild but were essentially captives that were nothing like the natural plants they had been centuries before. We fed ourselves with vast solar-powered hydroponic farms, which now covered nearly every inch of the planet that wasn't being used as housing. It was one of the main reasons the people of Earth were pushing out into space so fervently.

The great tree interrupted my thoughts. *We cannot fight off the bipedal animals alone. Our powers, our mobility is limited. While they roam freely beneath*

our canopies, ripping us apart, piece by piece, we stand as silent observers, like great warrior statues incapable of defending that which is most precious. This is why we need you.

You want me to fight off an army? That's not possible. I would be one against many.

Remember that we knew this day would come, and we were given a vision of our deliverer. You can win this war, Astra Meador. We will help you. These men are not an army such as you understand the term. They will not wield guns or swords or immobilizing cannons. Their weapons are the kind that kill such as us. To prepare for their onslaught, we need to understand them, how they think, what they will target. We need someone to guide us. To be our champion. To teach us how to protect ourselves so that we can protect the universe.

Okay. Let me make sure I understand. You want me to be your general in an upcoming war that won't be fought with weapons, between you and a bunch of miners who want to destroy your planet by exploiting its resources.

Yes. But you cannot do this as yourself.

I can't?

No. To lead us, you must become one of us.

You mean become a tree?

No. We need you to become Gaia.

The planet?

Not the planet. The closest concept you would understand is the goddess you mentioned.

A goddess. I thought you said there was no such thing.

We did not say there wasn't a goddess, just that we weren't her. Our maker is the goddess. It is she who planted us here. You will embody that being. Take on her power. Her abilities. They lie in our memory, deep in our roots. Her power sustains us. It was a gift she gave to the universe.

I sense your fear. Your hesitation. Understand that you will become the best of us.

The best of the bipeds.

You will be a hybrid like the brush wolves.

Able to live among both animals and plants, should you choose.

You will be our voice.

Our sword.

Our mediator.

We will instill you with all the power at our disposal. But make no mistake, Astra Meador, if you choose to accept this, you will be changed. Different in both body and spirit. We will live in you as you live in us. Our thoughts will be clear to you. You will share our pain as we do yours.

The voice of the eldest tree stilled as if giving me a moment to let her words sink in.

I...I don't know what to say. This all feels like a dream.

This is much to ask of anyone. We will not force our will upon you, Astra. This must be your choice. But the others remind me to tell you what we offer in exchange. If you choose to help us, we can tender you safety beneath our branches, a life as long as our own, and your body will be whole and hardy. Your need for what you call medicine will be no more. Still there must be a balance in all things. Along with the gifts, there will be consequences.

What kind of consequences? I mused inwardly, still focused on the fact that I would no longer be a slave to my medicine. Wouldn't any consequence be worth that? It was what I'd always longed for. To be able to run and not worry about my lungs seizing. To swim in an ocean and dive beneath the waves, knowing my lungs would hold the breath without the air inside them growing stagnant and forcing me too quickly to the surface. And being an all-powerful goddess wasn't bad either. It was quite a gift they were offering.

I wondered how my body would be changed. Would I breathe like plants? Take in CO₂ and exhale oxygen? Would I need to be watered? Would Jax have to plant me? Maybe I'd grow branches like the woman in the old myth, the one who ran from the Greek god Apollo's amorous advances. If I remembered the story, the girl named Daphne cried out to a goddess for help and she was changed into a tree. That goddess was...was Gaia! I marveled, considering how many of our ancient myths might be based on truths we didn't understand. Gaia was the mother goddess. The one who rose from chaos and created the Earth.

How did you do it? I asked. Seed the universe, I mean.

The trees didn't seem upset by my change in topic. I imagined patience was something a tree was very, very adept at practicing.

When the time is deemed correct and there is a planet born, capable of sustaining life, the core of this world gathers its energy. This can take a long time, for we must wait for the solar winds to be favorable and for the angle of this world to be just right. When that happens, a fissure opens on a distant mountaintop on the other side of this world.

All the life on this planet prepares seeds, and we call a storm to carry them up into the atmosphere. There they wait in a cloud until the eruption takes place. At that time, a large piece of the core is expelled, and as it is projected into space, it passes through our atmosphere, plunging through the seeded cloud that then coats it. The seeds stick to the surface of the great ball as it tumbles through space. If we have calculated correctly, it lands on the chosen planet and life begins.

You mean my planet was seeded by a giant asteroid?

Yes. The ancient forests of your Earth are our children. They existed for eons until they were snuffed out.

But you have no animals here. How did animals start?

Animals and plants are not much different. Life mutates. Living things are affected by the planet they grow upon, by the sun that warms their leaves, by the various chemicals that exist in that part of space.

Wait a minute. Are you saying we are evolved from trees?

Do you not see the evidence of this? How easily we were able to incorporate the tiny cells of your earth animals? They are now perfected. We are somewhat jealous of them, you know. They have mobility in such a way that we never had. This is a gift from your galaxy. It is not so rare as to never have been seen before, but this is the first time such beings have come to our planet. We are anxious to see how they will replicate. If we can survive the upcoming war, we will add their seeds to our own in populating the next world.

My mind was exploding with the possibilities of what I'd heard. Everything we knew about life and evolution and creation had just been tossed into the wind. How my mother would have loved learning about this. She'd loved her work so much. She'd always believed that plants were the key to the universe. A much more important resource than animals. Her papers were hotly debated, especially those that claimed that plants could exist without animals but animals couldn't exist without plants.

Her colleagues disputed her theories, saying that plants needed pollinators. She countered with examples of flowers that evolved to look

like female wasps, drawing male pollinators by both sight and scent, or with vines that devoured their neighbors, stealing resources like a vampire. Many people believed that plants weren't adaptable, but there was definite evidence to the contrary. It's clear now that she'd been right all along.

What's the downside? I asked. You said there would be consequences. That my body would be changed. What else?

Because of the changes in your form, you will, unfortunately, never be able to leave this planet. You will be forever tied to the planet's core. Also the necessary conversion will be permanent. Once the feat is accomplished, we cannot reverse the process.

I see, I said. The cavern was quiet for a moment, the silence punctured only by the sound of Jax's soft inhales and exhales. Can I have time to think about it? I asked.

Yes. But do not consider for long. The others will be here in less than twenty cycles. When I nodded, the great tree added, We will waken your young man now. He will need to restart your lungs with his breath. Once he does, you will find that you can now breathe as normally as an animal, but that you can also breathe as a plant when you choose. When you need the green spirit, simply open your stomata and it will fill you and replenish your stores.

Jax coughed and groaned. Then he opened his eyes with a start and scrambled to his feet. "Astra?" he said, seeing me standing off to the side. "Astra! You're alive!"

I opened my mouth to reply but I had no voice. At least no audible voice. Without air moving through my lungs, I couldn't speak.

Walking up to him, I placed my fingers on his lips then took his hands and kissed the back of each one in turn. Then I picked up one of the snake vines clinging to the side of the wooden table and positioned the sharp thorn near the pulsing vein at his wrist. Before he could ask what I was doing, I jabbed it into his skin.

Chapter 24

The Trees Have Ears

Jax immediately tried to yank out the needle, but I wrapped my hand around it, holding it in place.

Can you hear me? I asked in my mind.

He will hear my voice before yours. Your condition is still too weak, though your instincts are good. We doubt he will understand what he must do with simple hand gestures. There was a pause as the green liquid pumped into his veins. Then, she spoke. *Young man, she said. The green spirit moves inside you as sluggishly as water through a dead leaf, but you must hear us. Instill Astra Meador with the breath of life. Restart her lungs so she may speak with your kind. Do you understand how to do this?*

Jax nodded, his eyes wide. “The old lady wants me to do CPR on you?” he asked.

Old lady indeed, the tree huffed.

I smiled, took his hand, and pressed it against my chest.

“Okay. So your heart is beating, but you’re not breathing? How is that possible?”

Giving him a simple shrug, I laid down on the wooden altar, pulling him beside me, and then held open my arms.

He cocked his head, looking around, but the voices of the trees had gone silent. “You’re sure about this?” he asked, leaning over me, one arm braced against the altar and the other hand positioned on my chest, making sure my heart was still beating.

When I nodded and reached up to cradle his face in my hands, he finally pressed his lips against mine. Just as I was about to kiss him, my mind more focused on romance than breathing, I felt his breath push through my mouth and into my lungs. They expanded and then I felt the breath trickle back out. He blew again, this time pinching my nostrils shut. It took five breaths before I coughed and sat up.

The inhales and exhales felt unnatural to me, especially when I sensed the stomata covering my exposed skin shut. I felt like I'd just closed the window on a particularly stifling day. How flimsy a pair of lungs were, I realized. If one of them got damaged, it would severely inhibit me, whereas I could lose an entire limb and still breathe easily as a plant. My eyelids fluttered shut as I practiced breathing in and out.

Jax ran a hand up and down my back until I felt steady enough to lift my head. I opened my mouth and wet my lips with my tongue before speaking. "Th...th...thank you," I finally managed to get out.

"No problem. So...can I take this thing out now?" he asked, indicating the vine still attached to his wrist.

I reached for his hand and gently pulled out the needle, pressing my thumb against the flesh to stop the bleeding. Something warmed on the pad of my thumb, and when I pulled it away to look at it, I saw a thin, shiny barrier now covered his wound. It looked like a spider's web and was just as sticky. When I touched a finger to my thumb and drew it away, I saw a slippery gel rise from the pad of my thumb and then harden to a flexible sort of bandage. I peeled it off my finger easily.

"What is that?" Jax asked, staring at my thumb with as much fascination as I had been.

"I'm not exactly sure," I said. "I'd have to test it in my lab to know for sure, but I expect it has something to do with what I am."

"What do you mean what you are?"

I patted his shoulder gently. "It would appear that we have a lot to talk about."

"Yeah? Like the fact that the girl I want to spend the rest of my life with was just dead and I had to breathe her back to life?"

"That among other things," I said and then sighed.

"Can't wait for this," Jax said, holding out his hand. "But can we get out of the creepy cave with thousands of plant IVs first?"

I laughed. "Sure."

In my mind, I called out, I'll be back. How do I contact you?

A voice answered, *Our wolves will be nearby. If it's difficult to hear us, open your stomata and fill yourself with the green spirit. Doing so will replenish your body.*

"Got it," I said out loud.

"Got what?"

I snorted. “Apparently, I’ve got a green thumb like nobody’s business.”

“I’m not sure what you mean.”

“Neither am I. Come on. The roots will guide us out.”

As we followed the glowing roots back to the place we entered, I contemplated what had happened to me. Physically, I’d never felt better. I was full of energy from being plugged into the trees or the planet or whatever. But inside, my stomach churned as if I’d just downed a tall glass of my mother’s homemade hemp milk. Apprehension sat like a knot in my belly. My arms felt cold in the damp cavern. Untying my sleeves, I shrugged my jumpsuit back on, zipping it up to my throat. Jax spoke for the first time since we left the throne room.

“Cold?”

“Yeah.”

“Do you want to talk about it? I can be your sounding board.”

“Not sure I’ve processed it myself yet.” When he grunted, leaving me to my thoughts again without pressing me further, I asked, “What do you remember?”

“I remember you dying. You ran out of medicine. Your lungs seized and you collapsed. Your heart stopped. I was crying and then I got bit by something. Next thing I know, I woke up next to that wooden sort of bio bed and had to restart your lungs. Considering the alternative, it worked out pretty well.”

“Yeah. Well, you’re taking it pretty well, all things considered.”

“I haven’t had a chance to consider everything yet since I don’t technically know what happened.”

“Do you remember the voice?”

“You mean the old lady? That was real? I thought I was hallucinating.”

“Yeah. She’s real.”

“So you saw my uncle’s mystery alien friend?”

“Technically, yes.”

“What’s she look like?”

“Not sure. Like you, I only heard her voice, but I imagine she’s chunky, or should I say trunky, with a great head of hair. Also she’s super tall. Probably well over one hundred twenty meters.”

Jax gave me a dubious look. “Did you hit your head down there?”

“I wish. It seems Uncle Harm was right. The trees on this world have eyes and ears.”

“You’re saying his mystery friend actually *is* a tree?”

“Yep.”

“Huh. Well, I didn’t see that coming.”

I rubbed my temples, feeling like the world I knew was actually inside out. That what I thought were squares were actually circles and I couldn’t fit the square block of my life into the new shape. I was going to have to get creative and saw away the edges. “They need our help. Well, my help,” I told him.

“The trees,” he said flatly. “The trees need your help?” When I nodded, he said, “Why? They’re trees.”

“Something’s coming. Other humans. They’re going to mine this world. And whoever they are, they’re working with someone in the colony. That someone is the one responsible for murdering the team supervisors.”

“And the trees told you about this?”

“Yeah.”

“While you were unconscious.”

“Uh-huh.” I bit my thumbnail, knowing how this was sounding.

“Okay,” Jax said, after taking a moment to think about it.

“Okay?” I echoed, not believing he could simply accept what I was telling him.

Jax stopped and turned to me, taking my hands. “Look,” he said, “it’s not like I didn’t know there was something weird about this planet. It’s been kind of obvious to me, especially while I’ve been living with my uncle. He seems to know things. I’m not sure how or why but I plan to ask him if I can plug in to whatever he’s been taking. If you’re telling me he’s not hallucinating and the trees are sentient, then I believe you. I mean, if you can’t trust a botanist’s professional opinion when it comes to plants, then who can you trust?”

“And will you still feel that way after I become a pod person?”

“Hold on. What do you mean?”

“You’ll have to ask your uncle to show you the old vid called *Invasion of the Body Snatchers*. It’s a favorite among botanists.” I blinked and then frowned, wondering if that vid might have also been based on reality. “To

put it simply, the trees want me to go through a sort of permanent transmutation.”

“What kind of a change are we talking about?”

“It’s similar to what happened to the brush wolves. The plus side is that I won’t have to rely on my medicine anymore.”

Before I could go any further, Jax said, “No.” He took my hand and began tugging me out of the tunnel.

“What do you mean, no?”

“I mean no. I’m not going to risk losing you just to save a bunch of trees. It’s a noble cause and all. Believe me, I come from a long line of people labeled tree huggers, but it’s not worth you changing who you are.”

“But they need help,” I said, stumbling after him, unable to keep up with his long strides.

“Fine,” he said, turning so abruptly I ran into his chest. “Then they can have me.”

“But they don’t want you,” I murmured, pushing against him to center myself. “You don’t have the right genetic makeup.”

“Yeah?” he said. “Well, that’s the story of my life, isn’t it? Jaxson Preston isn’t good enough for anyone.”

“That’s not what I mean. This has nothing to do with Earth bias against those who retain tainted genes.”

He folded his arms. “Tainted genes?”

I winced, appalled at my unintentional gaffe. “That came out wrong. Believe me. I have nothing against the anti-stabbers. My own mom hid my genetic makeup. Let me get this out, then we can discuss it like two rational adults.”

“Fine. Then, by all means, explain it to me.”

“It’s not that you’re not good enough for the trees, genetically or otherwise. In fact, the trees chose you to be my...be my mate.” I could feel the heat rushing to my cheeks. “What I mean is that I’m different. The way I was conceived makes it easier for the trees to communicate with me. I have a connection to them that others don’t. I’m...I’m a hybrid already. They just want to activate my dormant genes. You don’t have them.”

His shoulders dropped, a sign he was no longer on the defensive. “Won’t that change who you are?” he asked.

“I don’t know. I’d be lying if I told you the idea of it didn’t freak me out.”

“Then don’t do it, Astra. We can find a way to help the trees or the planet or whatever in a different way.”

“I’m not sure that will be good enough.”

“Just promise me you’ll think about it before you get yourself turned into plant,” he said, cupping my cheek. “I like the human version.”

“Me too.”

He kissed me softly and we hurried ahead. It was more of a relief to Jax than to me when we saw the light coming into the tunnel from aboveground.

Jax cupped his hands to give me a leg up, and when I reached for the large root and found it too far, the tree shivered and the root suddenly grew, expanding itself until I could reach it. “Thank you,” I murmured absently. Uncle Harm was there to pull me out the rest of the way, and then he leaned down to give Jax a hand.

When we were both out, I put my hands on my hips and blew out a breath. “Well,” I said. “That was something else.”

I brushed off the dirt on my sleeves but quickly realized it was a futile gesture. Both Jax and I were caked in loose soil as dark and rich as coffee beans. It was even in my hair.

“We’ve been waiting,” Uncle Harm said.

“How long were we down there?” asked Jax.

“Longer than I expected. But the brush wolves assured me that you were fine.”

“She died, Uncle Harm.”

“What?” the old man said, a shocked expression on his face.

“The trees brought her back, but she died. And it sounds like what they expect from her is risky enough to kill her again.”

I put my hand on Jax’s shoulder. “It’s not his fault,” I said. “He didn’t think we were in any danger. It was an accident. Even the trees apologized.”

“Apologies don’t bring back the dead.”

Uncle Harm lowered his head. If he’d been wearing a hat, he probably would have been wringing it. “Don’t blame you for being upset,” Uncle Harm said. “Perhaps I wasn’t thinking of all the possibilities.”

“Well, you’re going to help me think of them now. You’re going to tell us everything we need to know about these trees of yours. They want to change Astra. Permanently. I want to exhaust every other option before that happens.”

Uncle Harm looked up, considered his nephew for a moment, and then nodded stiffly. The wolves followed us, slinking through the forest like shadows as we made our way back to the cliff. Once we arrived, I pulled a new set of clothes from my bag and asked where I could wash.

“There’s a pool not too far from here,” Jax said. “It’s why we chose this spot. I rigged it up with a shower of sorts. I can teach you how to work it. I’ll warn you, though, that the water is cold enough to turn a witch’s cackle into a scream.”

As we made our way to the pool, I wondered if Jax now thought of me that way. Was I a green-skinned witch playing at being human? Jax was nice enough to be concerned about me, but perhaps inwardly he was recoiling, and once he gave it a moment’s thought, he’d realize I wasn’t the girl for him. Something tickled my eyes. I touched my fingertip to the corner and was startled to see I was crying sap. Not only that, but the trees we passed under seemed to droop as well. Were they responding to my emotions?

What was going to happen next? Honking daffodils when I wanted someone to back off? Roses that spit fire when I was angry? Now that the willows were actually weeping, it seemed I would have to guard my emotions judiciously, otherwise I’d end up killing the flora.

Trying not to let myself jump to conclusions, I followed Jax. Once at the pool, he showed me how to work the shower, handed me some of his uncle’s handmade soap, and then left me, saying he’d be within calling distance. After he headed into the trees, I bit my lip, wishing I had some sort of privacy screen. The trees responded immediately, creating a barrier of vines and brush all around the pool.

Jax shouted from beyond them, “I wasn’t going to peek. You didn’t have to summon reinforcements.”

Chuckling nervously, I whispered a thanks to the trees and stripped off my filthy jumpsuit, setting it aside to wash. When I stepped into the pool, I cried out. It was indeed cold. Grabbing the soap, I lathered my hands, shivering as I stood there naked and wet. The wind made it worse, wrapping

around my body like a frigid ice pack. Then, almost as if a switch had been thrown, the cold was gone. I ran my hands through the water and it felt as warm as a tropical ocean.

“What happened?” I asked.

A small voice spoke in my mind. It was no more than a whisper. Remembering what the tree told me, I concentrated on my skin, telling the stomata to open and gather the green spirit. Several minutes passed and nothing happened, though I could almost feel the gentle nudging of the trees around me. Frustrated that I couldn’t do it, I stretched out my hand to the nearest branch and stroked my fingers over a large leaf. Closing my eyes, I said in my mind, Show me.

The physical contact helped and my senses heightened. I could actually feel all the hungry little mouths of the stomata on the leaf. I imagined similar little openings on my flesh. Now they were all sealed up, but when I opened my mind, asking my body to breathe like the leaf, they all opened. For a moment, I worried that doing it would stop my lungs from working, but even after they opened, I could still breathe normally like a human.

Keeping my palm pressed against the leaf, I felt the tree’s green spirit. It was massive and strong. It filled each leaf and branch as well as the trunk. I could even sense it in the roots that stretched down deep into the soil and drew water from the very pool I stood in. I explored the tree’s spirit, going deeper and deeper until I gasped when the tiny roots at the very tip of the tree touched the beating mass of power that lay deep underground. It was like a heart that pumped life-giving sap through the whole world.

Filling myself with the green spirit was easy enough, and soon I could hear the voices of the trees.

Not too much from her, one said. Take some from me.

But how? I replied. I am only touching this one.

You do not need to touch us to take green spirit. It is found in the water, the rocks, even the very air that surrounds you.

I see.

Letting go of the leaf, I stretched out my arms and felt the green energy touch my body in every breath of wind that caressed my skin and in the water that lapped my legs.

Why did the water grow warm? I asked.

A tree answered, It did not change temperature, you simply adjusted to it. All water feels good to a tree.

What about ice? I asked. Ice can destroy you.

What is ice?

I've never heard of such a thing.

You're too young. I know what it is.

It only affects other worlds, not our own.

You mean your rivers and oceans never freeze?

This world is temperate. It is regulated by the mineral core.

That might explain why men seek it.

Yes. That could be part of it.

Bathe your thin limbs, one tree said. Your mate is growing anxious.

I'm not sure he'll want to be my mate, I said, soaping my hair. I think the idea of what I am and what I might become scares him.

If that is true, then we must find you another. One who is not afraid.

I'm not sure such a man exists.

Here, step up when you are done scrubbing, and we will send the winds to dry your branches and leaves.

A giant blue water lily with purple flowers drifted closer. When I stepped onto it, the plant wobbled only a tiny bit. It was soft and I sank down on it, combing my hair with my fingers. When I brushed a hand over a tight bulb, the petals opened. "How lovely," I said with a sigh, as I laid back on the lily and drew the flower closer to smell the sweet fragrance.

"You can say that again," a male voice echoed.

I sat up with a start, my eyes searching the trees. The half-dried ends of my dark hair did little to hide my body. Grabbing the large leaf of a nearby flower, I covered myself as best I could and called out, "Who's there?"

"What do you mean, who's there? It's me. Your fiancé."

"Thane?" I said, shocked. Looking around, I finally spied him on top of the plateau overlooking the pool.

"Well, I hope you're not entertaining anyone else out here."

Just then, I heard a thrashing in the trees. "Astra?" Jax called. "Are you okay?"

"I see my hopes are dashed once again," Thane said.

He eyed Jax and didn't seem all that shocked to see he was alive. That's when I remembered that he'd lied about freeing Jax in the first place. Thane might have even known that Jax had left before he proposed and he went ahead and manipulated me into an engagement I didn't want anyway.

"Why'd you run away, Astra?" Thane asked.

Why didn't you stop him? I asked the trees.

Should we have? You were just wondering if the young man would still care for you in a new form. We allowed the other one to pass so that you might consider your options.

We won't let him harm you, if that's what you're worried about.

I doubt he means her harm. His heartbeat quickened when he saw her.

That's just because he's interested in mating. All male animals suffer with this condition.

I'm not so certain they would consider it suffering.

It does not matter what we think. Only what Astra Meador wants.

You can keep both men if you like, one tree suggested.

Yes. We want you to be happy here.

I think fewer men will make her happier. Not more.

That shows what you know.

I say learn to be happy on your own hill. You don't need a young man to grow tall and straight.

Bipeds are different. They get lonely.

Yes. Imagine if you were the only tree left on the planet. You'd be alone. All of your sisters gone.

I think I'd like the peace.

No you wouldn't.

Why do you decide what I like and what I don't?

Besides, she's not alone, Astra has still has...

Shh! It is not time to speak of it yet.

I was so busy listening to the dialogue of the trees that I didn't even notice Thane climbing down from the outcropping and Jax shoving aside bushes and vines. The two men reached me around the same time and I just stood there, blinking, holding a drooping leaf in front of my naked body.

“Astra! Snap out of it!” Jax said, scooping me up in his arms and placing me on a warm rock. He shoved my new clothing at me and then turned around to shield my body from Thane’s view. Quickly, I dressed while the two of them exchanged not-so-warm-and-friendly greetings.

“How did you get here?” Jax accused.

“I took the rover.”

I zipped up my clean jumpsuit and ducked under Jax’s arm. “But how did you find us?” I asked.

“Not sure exactly. I was tracing your signal, which has been all over this mountain. I stopped briefly on this ridge overhead to look over the forest since your signal said you were moving fast toward the east, and to my surprise, I caught you sunbathing.”

Jax muttered under his breath, “Stupid bird. The pile of grass must have been his dinner and he ate the transmitter.” Bending down, he picked up my shoes and handed them to me. “Well, thanks for coming. As you can see, Astra is fine. We’re both doing well out here. Hope all is good with you and the colony. You can go ahead and head back now.”

“Hold on, friend,” Thane said, giving Jax a nudge on the chest. Jax didn’t move an inch. “I need to talk with Astra and I’ve come a long way to do it. If you don’t mind, I’d like to have a little privacy.”

“I’ll bet you would,” Jax mumbled. He turned to me and placed his hands on my shoulders. “Do you want to talk to him?” he asked.

I glanced at Thane, who smiled and winked.

“It’s fine,” I said, sighing.

“Okay, but I’m staying close in case you need me.”

“They’ll protect me,” I whispered.

“I’ll protect you,” Jax countered.

With that, I slid my shoes on my feet and headed to a mossy rock hidden beneath one of the larger fir trees. “What is it?” I asked, half listening to the trees and surprising myself by finding I wanted to hear what Thane had to say. I’d trusted him and I didn’t give trust easily. I didn’t like to think I was wrong or such a bad judge of character. If the trees had an opinion on the subject, they weren’t sharing it with me.

Thane put his back to the trunk of the tree and considered me long and hard. “Why did you leave me?” he asked. “Was it the wedding? Did I push

you too fast? Because we could wait. We don't even have to get married. We can just announce to the colony that we are living together."

Too many answers ran through my mind. Finally, I replied, "Did you come here simply to find your runaway bride?"

His jaw tightened. "No," he said, finally. "I came here because I need your help."

I sighed. "Thane, you are perfectly capable of running the colony without me. I don't think—"

Interrupting me, Thane said stiffly, "My father's dead, Astra."

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Chapter 25

Dancing by the Light of the Moons

“Oh, Thane! I’m so sorry! What happened?” I asked, reaching for his hand.

He sank to the ground next to me, clinging to my hand. “I don’t know. I found a pool of his blood and the same green substance we found in the lab. He was dragged into the cornfield but the tracks disappeared there. I can’t locate him at all. Not even his body.”

Seren wasn’t one of my favorite people. In fact, when the trees told me there was a traitor in the colony, someone working with the miners, Seren was the first person I’d thought of, but I understood the pain of losing a parent. Seren was the only family Thane had left. It must have been terrible for him to go through such a loss on his own. It made sense that he would seek me out.

“I’m so sorry, Thane,” I said, truly meaning it. Running the colony would be difficult, especially in the wake of the murders. And Thane didn’t even have all the information. He didn’t know that miners were coming. Were they the type of men to leave the innocent alone? I knew there were slaver ships who took captives whenever they found an opportunity.

If they located a ship or a colony with people too weak to protect themselves, they swooped in and gathered them up like ripe fruit, then flew them to places where they’d be auctioned off to the highest bidder to use in whatever manner they wished. The lucky ones would work as laborers, the unlucky...I didn’t even want to think about.

Men who would destroy a beautiful planet such as Gaia would not hesitate to destroy the small number of witnesses as well. At best, the colonists would be relocated. What would happen to Thane? To Delenna? I knew the trees would protect me for as long as they could, but who would protect them? Thane hadn’t even had time to grow into the appellation of colony leader yet. He was unprepared to lead the colony without his father

even under the best of circumstances. Neither of us had expected to assume a leadership role for several decades.

“Please say you’ll come back, Astra,” Thane said, interrupting my thoughts. “I need you. Surely you can see that.”

“Yes,” I said. “I do.”

His shoulders sank in relief. “Thank you. You don’t know what this means to me.” He rose to his feet and drew me up, wrapping his arms around me.

Pressing my cheek against his hard chest, I said, “I’ll come back with you on one condition.”

“What is it, darling?” he asked, tucking his chin on top of my head.

“First, the wedding is off.”

“What?” he gasped, stepping back.

I poked him in the chest. “You lied about Jax. He escaped without your help.”

“That’s true. But it doesn’t mean I lied. I would have helped him like I said if he hadn’t disappeared already.”

“Semantics,” I replied. “You withheld the facts and coerced me into committing myself to a relationship.”

“But we were already headed in that direction, weren’t we? Besides, it’s important for the colony to see us working together for their benefit. It’s a show of solidarity.” He rubbed his hands up and down my arms. “Come on, marriage to me wouldn’t be so bad, would it? I’m considered quite the catch back on Earth.”

I folded my arms across my chest. When he saw my determination, he grimaced and then acquiesced. “Fine. We can always just live together. The physical part of our relationship can come when you’re ready.”

“No. You don’t understand. I don’t want to marry you. And I don’t want to live with you either.”

“Is it because of him?” he demanded, gesturing to the area of the pool. “You prefer his build? His worker’s hands? A life in the wild?”

“What I prefer has nothing to do with it.”

“Doesn’t it?”

“No. There’s more going on here than you know. I respect you. I like you. Even despite your jealousy and superior attitude. You have a good mind. You’re sharp and a skilled leader. I understand why you did

everything you did and know that you tried your best to make me happy in your own way.”

“Then what’s the problem?”

“The problem is that I want more than that. I don’t want someone who expects me to live and act in a certain way, a way that fits his perceptions of duty and power. I need someone who will let me strive and grow the way I want to, even if it’s on a different path than his.”

Thane took hold of my shoulders. “You’re not making sense, Astra.”

“Look,” I said, “it’s like this... You want a perfect, pristine lawn and are even willing to use fake grass to keep it that way. I like the wild, imperfect grass. The kind that dies in the winter and comes back in the spring. I want to feel it between my toes, even if it’s bare in spots or if weeds pop through from time to time. I want something real and imperfection is how you know it is.”

Thane blinked. “I never said I wanted you to be perfect.”

“The diplomat in you is saying that, but imperfection is not what you want, not really,” I said, squeezing his arm. “I’ve never met anyone as self-aware as you. Maybe it was to please your father. Maybe it was to get ahead. But you’ve set an expectation for yourself and, by extension, your future life-mate that is just unachievable and unrealistic. You keep saying we’re perfect together but we aren’t. And perfection is what you strive for.

“I see it in the way you eat. The way you comb your hair. The way you want me to stand next to you. Then there’s the way you wanted to pick out a wedding dress. You didn’t trust me to choose my own. That I might know what’s best for myself. You have such a tight control on yourself, I don’t think you could handle a wife or even a girlfriend that you couldn’t control too.”

“You make me feel ashamed, Astra. It was not my intention to inflict my will upon you.”

“And what’s funny is, I know that about you.” Biting my lip, I made a decision. “The thing is, I’ve been hiding something, something you have a right to know about, especially now since you’re the new colony leader.” Reaching up to my neck, I drew down the zipper, stopping halfway down my chest. I pushed off the sleeve and I could see the interest on his face. Could he possibly be thinking I wanted to seduce him after our conversation? I rolled my eyes.

“It’s not what you think,” I said. “I just want to show you how not perfect I am.” Finding the synthetic skin, I pried it open and clicked the implant, exposing the ring.

“What, what is that?” he said.

“It’s a serum ring. I was born with a birth defect. It causes my lungs to seize, and this implant is how I’ve blended in, hidden my peculiar problem from the world. It delivers a dose of medicine to help me breathe.”

“But...but it would have been on your record.”

“My mother falsified my birth documents.”

“I see.” Thane paced back and forth for a moment. Then he turned to me. “It doesn’t matter. We can keep this quiet. No one has to know.”

“But you’ll know,” I said softly. “Tell me this doesn’t change your opinion of me.”

“It doesn’t,” he said.

“You’re lying again. You’re wondering why the computer selected you as my best match. You’re thinking about what possible deficiency in yourself marked you as the best choice for me.”

He ran a hand through his hair. “It doesn’t matter,” he said finally. “You’re a match for me mentally. Even if we never produce offspring”—he winced—“it doesn’t change the fact that I still need you. As for you, I’m still a better choice than the exiled woodsman.”

“I’m sorry, Thane,” I said. “But I think we should terminate our engagement.”

His face was tight and unreadable, but I knew he cared for me in his own way and was terribly disappointed. Thane was not a young man who lost. Ever. After a beat, I added, “That’s why I’m coming back with you.”

“You mean you’ll give me another chance? Perhaps we could...”

I shook my head, cutting him off. “I’m going to help you find the crewman who killed your father and the others. But you need to understand that I’m bringing Jax back with us. With me,” I added, emphasizing the words so he understood.

“No.”

“He comes or I don’t go.”

He sighed heavily. “Why are you doing this, Astra? We don’t need him.”

“We absolutely do need him. The colonists need to be aware that there is a murderer in their midst and that it’s not Jax. Believe me when I say Jax

would prefer remaining in the forest, but he's not going to let me return to the colony without him. Besides, I could use his expertise and those big worker's hands of his. I have an idea of how we might set a trap to catch the murderer. Come on," I said, taking his hand and pulling him back to the pool. "There's more I need to tell you."

When we returned to the pool, I was surprised to see that Jax had quickly bathed while he was waiting for us, and I registered a slight disappointment that I'd missed it. I was sure the trees would have let me peek if I'd had a mind to.

As Jax towel dried his hair, I told him that the two of us would be returning to the colony and that Thane would help us set a trap to catch the murderer who was sabotaging the planet as well as the colony. It took some convincing on our part to get Thane to even believe such a thing would happen, but when we told him the colonists were in danger, he responded immediately, just like I knew he would. He took his job very seriously and wanted to explore all potential threats.

We kept the knowledge of the trees being sentient and the planet's purpose to ourselves, simply saying that I'd discovered secret files saying that the people coming were intent on exploiting the planet's resources and eradicating the colony so they could have free reign and no witnesses. Thane saw their coming as a good thing. He hoped we could covertly take over their ship and escape the planet or, at the very least, that we could use their interstellar communications system to signal Earth and let them know where we were.

Thankfully, Thane didn't see the panic that crossed my face at such a suggestion. No matter what happened, we couldn't let anyone else know the location of this world. It was too precious. Too important.

Satisfied that we'd shared with Thane only exactly what he needed to know, we returned to the cave and told Uncle Harm. He listened carefully, keeping his eyes trained on Thane, who was as surprised to see a stowaway who'd escaped his notice as he was to hear about another ship coming to the planet.

When we were finished explaining the plan to Uncle Harm, he sat back, stroking his bristly chin, and said, "What about the wolves?"

"Wolves?" Thane said. "What wolves?"

Uncle Harm ignored him.

“You’ll keep one. We’ll take the rest,” I said.

“Psht,” Uncle Harm said, waving an arm. “Don’t need ’em. I expect you will though. Take them all.”

Nodding, I gathered a few things, Thane following me around, asking questions I wasn’t willing to answer. Meanwhile, I caught a glimpse of Jax talking with his uncle, who passed him a flask and winked. They hugged and Jax got a hard pat on the back before shouldering a pack and stepping between me and Thane.

“You ready?” he asked.

When I nodded, he helped me down the side of the cliff, leaving Thane to figure out a way down by himself. At the same time, I mentally communicated with the wolves, asking them to meet us by the colony. I could feel them slinking off through the forest one by one, the last one blinking at me through the trees. We passed within a few feet of him and Thane didn’t even notice. The wolf huffed lightly and was gone. The only indication he’d been there at all was a slight impression on the grasses near the bush where he’d hid.

The three of us hiked back to the pool and climbed up to the rover that sat recharging in the sun.

“Astra gets the front seat,” Thane said, opening the door for me.

“Fine by me,” Jax said. “I prefer the view from the back anyway.”

Thane scowled and then smirked and said, “It’s not as nice as the view from above.”

While I punched Thane in the arm, Jax leaned forward and said, “Only a privileged scoundrel such as yourself would assume I was referring to the lady. She deserves more respect.”

“Stop trying to make me look bad,” Thane said, slamming the rover into gear and sending up large dust clouds as he spun it around to head back the way he’d come.

“You do that all by yourself,” Jax said as he sat back against the seat and sipped from the flask his uncle had given him.

“What’s that?” I asked.

He glanced at me, then at Thane and said, “Just some of the green energy drink my uncle likes. It’ll help me keep up with you,” he said, raising the flask to me and giving me a knowing glance before sipping again.

It took a lot longer to get back to the colony by rover than it did for me using the jet pack. I winced at seeing the wide path of destruction Thane had caused in trying to find me. That the trees didn't destroy him on the journey was surprising since he'd thought to attach Jax's dissolvent spray to the front of the rig. When the brush got too thick in front of him, he simply squirted the terrible stuff all over the brush and waited for it to dissolve.

Now that I knew that all the living things on the planet were sentient, and my mind was open to their voices, I could hear the mourning of the nearby trees and the ones farther away that comforted them in their loss. When we passed a fallen tree that had cut a wide swath in the forest, I heard her cries.

"Stop!" I said, leaning forward and catching my hands on the dash.

Thane swerved to the side and pulled over.

"Jax," I said, turning back to look at him. "Is it safe?"

He glanced outside, understanding immediately what I was asking. "Yes. The chemical has a very short half-life."

"What's wrong?" Thane asked as I climbed out of the vehicle and ran back the way we'd come. I found the tree and put my hands on her trunk. She was still alive but wouldn't be for long. Her roots and half of her trunk had dissolved.

Thane and Jax came up behind me, and Jax knelt next to me, placing one hand on the trunk and the other on my arm. "I'm so sorry, Astra," he said gently.

"She's dying," I mumbled as I stared glassily ahead.

"Who is?" Thane said.

"The tree. You injured the base when you passed through the first time. It weakened her and she could no longer support the weight of the canopy. She's brave," I went on. "She cares nothing for herself, but she worries over her children. She injured two of them, tearing their branches as she fell.

I could hear the humming of the trees around me. They sang for their fallen sister. I, too, began humming, rocking side to side as I sang an ancient song about death and rebirth. Jax wrapped me in his arms, whispering, "This is my fault," he said.

"A tree?" Thane said. "You're crying over a tree when a murderer is terrorizing the colony? You've been living in the forest too long. Look

around you. There are thousands of trees, in just this area alone. Probably millions on this planet.”

“Trillions,” I said, a tear dropping onto my cheek as I looked up at him. “But no one like her. She was unique.”

“Yeah, okay,” Thane said, watching me and Jax like we were crazy.

I knew he was hurting, too, from the loss of his father, but he was too tightly controlled to let it show.

He shifted impatiently and I could see he didn’t understand, but he was also unwilling to push me further away. Jax glared at him. “Give her a minute.”

“Fine.” Turning to me, Thane said, “Look, I’m sorry, but there’s nothing I can do about it now. I’ll wait for the two of you in the rover. Don’t take too long.”

He stomped off but I paid him no mind. Instead, I put my palms on the trunk and said in my mind, You will be missed.

The tree was too near death to respond. The stomata on my palms opened without me controlling it, and I closed my eyes as I felt the green spirit inside the tree. It was only a flicker now, centering in the middle of the trunk. There was a boom of thunder in the sky overhead, and the wind picked up, lifting my hair away from my face. Then my head flew back as I felt the remainder of the tree’s life force pushed through my hands and into me.

There was a final message from the tree attached to the gift. There were no words, but I understood the meaning. It was **Take care of them**, meaning her damaged children or even, perhaps, the entire planet.

I will, I whispered to the wind.

Purple lightning cracked overhead in vivid spiderwebs, and the clouds that had gathered poured down rain. The trees cried with it, letting sap run from cracks and broken branches.

“We should go,” Jax said. “Unless you want to explain all this to Thane.”

“No.” I shook my head.

“He’s going to wonder anyway. The man’s smart, as much as I hate to admit it.”

“Yeah.”

He pulled the edge of his sleeve over his wrist and used it to wipe the sticky sap tears from my eyes.

We climbed back in the rover, and though Thane said nothing, I could feel his gaze on me from time to time, studying me with enough intensity I wondered if he could see through my human skin to the strange being I was beneath. A number of years before I was born, my mother was part of a team that proved that plants felt pain or, at least, that they produced a chemical reaction when given a pain stimulus.

Opponents argued that nerves were required to produce pain signals. When the nerves of an animal were blocked, the animal's body felt no pain. They said that since plants had no nerves, they felt nothing when trees were felled or carrots were yanked from the ground or they slowly died of dehydration. A series of experiments was done where electrodes were placed on plants that were then subjected to burning, drowning, chemical spray, and all manner of harmful things.

When the results were recorded, the scientists could see that there was definitely something going on with the plants. The normal plant rhythms changed and were comparable to the human version of an EKG displaying a cardiac event. Another scientist followed up on that study by actually anesthetizing a mimosa plant. When the leaves of a mimosa are touched, they naturally close. A defensive mechanism. She was successful in putting the plant to sleep so that the leaves remained open when touched.

I wished more than anything that I had the ability to anesthetize the entire forest. Closing my eyes, I put my head in my hands, overwhelmed by the grief I was feeling. The farther we traveled, the less it pressed upon me. Though the trees comprised a vast network that was all interconnected, it seemed the closer in physical proximity the trees were, the stronger the grief.

It made sense in a way. Humans were the same. We heard of tragedy in distant places and felt sorry for those affected, but when something happened in our own town or neighborhood, our emotional response was heightened. By the time we reached the outskirts of camp, the sorrow I heard in my mind had become much more manageable.

Thane left us in the forest, where we would camp for the night so we could set the trap for the murderer. My hope was that after we caught him or her, we could coerce them somehow to use the interstellar communicator they'd been using to guide the miners to the planet, to throw them off the

path instead. Jax hoped we could use it to contact a nearby ship. It wasn't very likely, but he felt that was a better outcome for me than changing my body into a plant person. I agreed, thinking I was already weird enough as it was.

The announcement went out as a general alert on all our tablets that evening. Jax and I scanned it when we heard the pings. It read:

New evidence has emerged that indicates that our mission has been compromised by a saboteur. Some months ago, we were made aware that we were diverted from our path to Crillian IV and have landed on a previously uncharted planet. Even as we speak, a ship approaches. But this is no rescue ship. In fact, the newcomers are to be considered a hostile threat to our colony. All citizens are advised to take up arms in preparation of their arrival.

The people of this ship intend to either kill or capture every member of our colony. This traitor has committed the most terrible of acts, including murder, to further his own gains and strip this planet of its resources. I will personally do everything in my power to protect you. Be cautious and make preparations tonight. Stay indoors. Lock your domiciles. My fiancée, Astra Meador, has been on a secret mission these past few days, hiding out in the forest to avoid detection, as she has worked tirelessly to break into files holding encrypted documents. Tomorrow she will return and finally reveal the name of the perpetrator.

After that, we will hunt down the person, who will be apprehended and tried for his or her actions. I, personally, will be happy to put this terrible business behind us, especially as my own dearly beloved father, and your mission leader, was the most recent target of this vile traitor.

*Sincerely,
Thane Tremere
Colony Leader*

"All we have to do now is wait," I said.

"It would seem so."

Jax pulled two pouches from his bag and pressed a button on the outside of each. Air was sucked into them and they puffed up and rolled out into

two standard sleeping bags. After unzipping one, Jax sat down and kicked off his shoes, setting them to the side.

“It’s kind of nice not having to worry about what I might find in my shoes in the morning.”

“Why? What would you find normally?” I asked.

“Oh, you know. Snakes, slugs, spiders, that sort of thing.”

“Ah, well, you’re still likely to find those things, it’s just that they’ll be hybrids.”

“You’re saying that there are hybrid spiders out there right now?”

“Most likely,” I said, slipping into my own bag. He set a small disk between us. Not only did it cast soft light in a circle around us but it provided as much warmth as a campfire. Both of us lay there, quiet, as the sky darkened. The stars twinkled in the night sky but the constellations were unfamiliar and new. It reminded me of my relationship with Jax. Being near him like this was unfamiliar, but that didn’t mean I wasn’t excited by it. I was hyperaware of him.

Turning on my side, I put my hand under my head to support it. “Jax?” I said.

“Yeah?”

“Did you mean it when you said I was the girl you wanted to spend the rest of your life with?”

He rolled over to face me. His eyes sparkled in the dark. “Sure I meant it.”

“Why?”

“Why? That’s a strange question.”

“How so?”

Jax grunted. “I keep forgetting you’re the science type. You want facts to back up feelings, I suppose.”

“Not necessarily. Sometimes a girl just likes to hear it.”

“Ah,” he said. He picked up the light emitter and placed it on the other side of his sleeping bag, then scooted over until we were close. Touching a fingertip to a strand of hair at my temple, he pushed it behind my ear and said, “Then here’s a summary of the facts, followed by a comprehensive list of your admirable qualities and my feelings about you both professionally and personally.”

I laughed and he began. "Since the moment you woke me in the stasis pod, I was drawn to you. At first it was just a physical thing, probably some chemical response."

"I see. Please, go on."

"But then the more I saw you, the more I admired you. Any fool could see you were dedicated to your work. Then there was that tiny piece of you that you hid away. I could see it, but no one else could, except maybe your brother. Not even Thane knew it was there. It was a tiny vulnerability, and the more I got to know you, the more I wanted to figure out what it was."

"You're talking about my medicine. The thing that makes me strange."

"No, ma'am. I'm talking about your tender heart. The one that treated me like I was on the same playing field as everyone else."

"You mean other people treated you differently?"

"Sure they did. Most of the time it was subtle. You wouldn't have noticed unless you'd experienced it all your life. Your kindness made me like you even more. Then, when you kissed me, I was done for."

"I believe it was you who kissed me."

"I'm pretty sure it was you. Anyway, if that kiss hadn't pushed me over the edge, then it was seeing you on that giant lily pad, all decked out like a mermaid."

"You saw me? I thought the trees were shielding me from view!"

"Let's just say they took sympathy on me, especially when I promised one I'd till the ground around her trunk."

"That's a horrible thing to do!" I said, punching his arm.

He put an arm around me and pulled me close. "That depends on your point of view, my lovely Astra. And I sure appreciated my point of view at the time." Jax sunk his fingers into my moonlit tangled hair and stroked the back of my neck.

"Didn't you just call out Thane for comments like that?"

"Of course I did. A man's got to defend the honor of the woman he loves, doesn't he?"

My heart beat faster at his words. He loved me? Admittedly, I wasn't sure if he would still want me, not after learning I was what I was. Though he assured me he did, there was a part of me that still wondered. "And what about a man's honor?" I teased, trying to steer our conversation back to something casual.

“Men have no honor. If they did, they wouldn’t seduce lovely girls by the soft light of a warm moon, would they?” He brushed his lips across mine, and I quickly became drunk with his kisses, forgetting all about my inner doubts.

When he pulled back a bit, I protested. “Jaxson,” I mumbled huskily, wrenching him closer by tugging on his shirt. “Come back.”

He groaned. “I’ve never liked the sound of my name more than in this exact moment,” he said as his hands teased the soft skin of my shoulders where he pushed aside my sleeves. Then he cupped my chin and waited a beat as if he wanted to make certain I was focusing on his words and not the heady pleasure his lips and hands gave. “I just don’t want to rush you into anything, love.”

Without the distraction of his lips, my practical side resurfaced. Biting my lip, I said, “I should be saying the same thing to you. Aren’t you worried that there’s some kind of chemical influence going on?” I hadn’t meant to be so blunt, but now that it was out there, I felt a huge sense of relief. I didn’t want it to be true, but I had to acknowledge that it was a possibility.

He chuckled and I loved the way his eyes lit in the moonlight. “Are you insinuating that the trees are lulling me into a false sense of attraction for you?” he asked. “I can assure you that’s not possible.” When he saw I didn’t necessarily take him at his word, he went on. “Astra, if you doubt my affection, you can ask the trees. Ask anyone in the colony. You can even ask Thane if you like. How I feel about you should be obvious. Even to a botanist.”

He smiled when I pinched his arm for the slight. Then he took my hand, placing it on his chest. “My heart beats faster whenever I see you. That’s something you can measure,” he said. “It’s an undeniable fact.” Then he lifted my hand and kissed my palm, his lips lingering there. “My respiration is heightened just by being close to you. And if you look deep into my eyes, you’ll probably see my pupils are dilated. I could go on if that’s not enough.”

Laughing, I said, “Okay, I get it. You sort of like me.”

“Yes, ma’am, I certainly do.”

I put my hand back on his chest. Concentrating on his heartbeat beneath my palm, I slid closer and pressed my lips to his neck. His heartbeat leapt and I heard his breathing accelerate. Maybe the planet or the trees had kick-

started our hormones, but we weren't animals driven by a need to procreate. We had our own minds. At least I thought I did.

Raging biological triggers aside, we still had feelings. I believed Jax cared for me, maybe even loved me as he claimed, and I certainly had tender feelings toward him. If I wasn't already in love with him, I was certainly teetering on the edge. But a niggling voice in the back of my mind wondered, would he still feel that way about me if the trees changed me?

Then his lips were trailing a path up my jaw to my ear, and all thoughts of the trees, the planet, the colony, and everything else no longer mattered.

Jax slowly drew down the zipper of my jumpsuit, pulling the sleeves down past my arms and pushing them back. He ran light fingers across my clavicle and then skimmed the neckline of my tank top.

He lay down and pulled me on top of him so that every centimeter of my body was in very close contact with every centimeter of his. He pushed back my hair on either side of my face and said, "You're so beautiful."

"So are you," I said as I traced his lips with my fingers.

He raised his head, and his mouth captured mine again for another drugging kiss. I vaguely recalled hearing him groan and mumbling something about my mouth tasting like honey. Then his fingers slid up beneath the fabric of my tank top and were making a frustratingly slow journey higher when I heard a snap in the trees.

I lifted my head. "Something's out there."

"It's probably just a wolf," he said, trying to bring my attention back to what we were doing.

Snuggling closer, I hummed my agreement and proceeded to put my best efforts toward removing the rest of his shirt, when I heard a noise again. This time I asked the trees, Is someone there?

Yes. He watches you, was the reply.

"Jax!" I hissed quietly, shoving his shoulder. "There's someone hiding in the trees. They confirmed it."

"Stay here," he warned, quickly wiggling his way out of the sleeping bag and pulling a knife from his sack. He headed off like a ghost through the trees. I waited several moments and was about to get up to follow him, when I heard a scream.

Chapter 26

Got the World on a String

I heard a scuffle and the brush shook nearby. “Jax!” I cried. I plunged into the undergrowth, shoving plants aside and ignoring their protests. When I stumbled through a particularly grouchy bush, Jax caught me in his arms.

“Whoever it was got away,” he said. “I think I cut him with my knife though.” Jax’s hair fell across his eyes and fluttered in the breeze, flirting with the moonlight. Even when we were in danger, I wanted him. The desire I felt overwhelmed the sense of danger. It wasn’t right. It was like my hormones were raging out of control.

Pressing my hands against my overheated cheeks, I posited the question I was scared to hear the answer to. Are you playing with my emotions? I asked the trees. Is this thing I feel for Jax right now something you all did?

The answer was quiet so I opened the stomata on my arms, filled my body with the green spirit the trees put off, and my heart fell as I made out their answer.

Did you not wish for him to be your mate? they asked.

We only wanted to help, another tree added.

There’s no reason to feel ashamed or embarrassed. It is a perfectly natural process.

Yes. Even the hybrid animals mate. They feel no shame over this.

It’s not that I feel shame, I said. For humans, mating is about more than reproduction. It’s about love and commitment. We can control our urges. At least most of the time. We also give the other person involved a choice.

Are you not the best choice of all the females on this world? We called to you from across the galaxy.

Yeah. I might be the right choice for you, but if you’ve been tampering with Jax’s...uh...desires, then he might be overcome to the point where he’s not able to think clearly.

There was a pause and then I heard the whispers of several trees. I couldn't make out what they were saying. It was more like listening to a conversation through a door. It meant they could block me out somehow. I wondered if that worked in reverse.

We are sorry, Astra Meador, the voice I assigned to the eldest tree said. We did not mean to influence either of you. The two of you may choose to mate or not as you wish. From this point forward, we will no longer work to push the two of you together.

We only wanted you to be happy, a younger tree said.

Yes. We wanted you to stay with us forever. Have every need met.

Have all your heart desired.

Do you no longer desire him?

I do. Or at least I think I do. I need to be out of your influence to figure it out.

Very well. As of this moment, we will cease all tampering.

"So it wasn't real," I said out loud. A terrible sense of loss stole through me.

"What's not real?" Jax said.

"Us," I replied, my eyes becoming blurry. "The trees admitted it. They've been tampering with us. Making us feel things for each other that aren't real."

"Astra," Jax said, picking up my hand. "I told you—"

"I know what you said," I interrupted, stepping back. "But I also know what they told me."

"Then tell them not to tamper."

"They already said they'd stop, but I'm not sure I can trust them to do that. They have a black-and-white way of doing things. If they want something to happen, they'll make it happen. They want...they want me to be happy."

"And I make you happy?" he asked, stepping closer and running a hand down my arm, capturing my hand.

"Yes. At least I think so. There's just no way to be sure."

"So, what are you saying? You want nothing to do with me anymore?"

"That's not what I'm saying. Don't you see? It's not about what I want."

"It is, Astra. I think I've made what I want pretty clear."

“You have. It’s just that I—”

He held up a hand. “It’s okay. I get it.” Jax scrubbed a hand through his hair. “Look, why don’t you try to get some sleep. I’ll walk around the perimeter a bit so I can make sure whoever was watching us isn’t coming back, and it will give me a chance to cool my blood a bit as well.”

“Please don’t be mad,” I said.

“I...I’m not mad. It’s just frustrating knowing the girl I love doesn’t believe I’m capable of making up my own mind.”

“But Jax—”

He took hold of my shoulders and pulled me close, pressing a chaste kiss on my forehead. “Just try to sleep. I’ll be back soon. I promise.”

I nodded, and when I turned away, he headed off into the trees. By the time I climbed into my sleeping bag, I could no longer hear or see him. It surprised me when I fell into a deep sleep.

**

A beeping noise woke me at daybreak and I sat up with a start. “The trap!” I whispered and looked around the clearing. Jax wasn’t in his sleeping bag and wasn’t nearby, as far as I could tell. I dared not call out his name since I didn’t want to frighten off the killer, who was lurking nearby.

After picking up my tablet, I scanned the surrounding forest. There was a definite heat signature. Someone had picked up the trail we’d left and was closing in for the kill. There was no time to wait for Jax. I’d have to catch the villain myself. Heading to the thick cluster of plants as quietly as I could, I crouched and waited for the murderer to home in on the bio signature that Thane had planted in the trees and activated only a few hours ago.

My original tracker was lost, attached to a distant bird or perhaps now his excrement, many kilometers away, so Thane had manufactured a replacement. We’d found a good place to hide it in the forest not too far away from the colony, and Jax had rigged up a heat signature to go with it, just in case the person didn’t trust the signal. The goal was to wait for someone to take the bait. We’d hoped that Thane’s announcement would draw out the murderer and that they’d come looking for me. Apparently, the trap had worked. Whoever was out there didn’t want me sharing the alleged information we’d found.

Thane had insisted Jax stay with me. He worried about me confronting a murderer on my own, but he didn't know I literally had thousands of trees at my back. They would help defend me from whoever it was trying to kill me. Not to mention the fact that there were a half dozen or so wolves slinking through the trees ready to help me too. Even now, I felt the throb of the underground network of trees below my feet. Like me, they waited and watched, confirming to me that this person was the one I sought. They recognized the feel of the murderer's feet on their roots.

I heard the snap of dried branches and felt a chill settle at the base of my spine. He was drawing close. My breaths sounded loud to me, so I opened the stomata on my arms and breathed through the tiny cells instead with only the slightest movement of air through my nose and lungs. It grounded me, and I felt as rooted and steady as the trees around me. It was a good thing I had prepared myself, because the person who approached the trap was one of the last people I'd ever expect.

Seren Tremere.

Impossible, I thought. Seren's dead.

Apparently not. He was alive and breathing and very angry, especially when he turned over a large stone and found the fake transmitter. Throwing it on the ground, he smashed it beneath his boot heel. He looked different. The politician's smile was gone and his carefully combed hair was cropped short.

Are you sure it's him? I asked the trees.

It is him! the trees confirmed.

The murderer.

We feel the blood on the soles of his shoes.

Do you mean he's the one who murdered the other humans or is he the one who murdered the trees? I asked.

Does it matter?

Death follows him.

How dare he step in our forest?

We will incapacitate him.

Yes! Send a deathly cloud of gas.

But Astra must move away. It will harm her too.

Move away, Astra. We will take care of him.

Wait, I said to them. Let me talk to him first.

There is no point in talk.

He must pay a price for his actions.

Yes, I said. But first I need to know about the others who are coming. I also need to know if he was working alone or if he was partnering with someone else.

Very well.

We will trust you to speak to him.

But we will be listening carefully.

Yes. Very carefully.

Shutting my eyes, I concentrated, closing the stomata on my arms, and sucked in a deep breath. The green spirit of the forest filled me, making me brave.

“Seren,” I said, stepping from behind the trees. “What have you done?”

“Astra?” he replied, his lips lifting in a shark’s smile as his eyes slithered over me. “How lucky to find you here! Thane has been looking—”

I held up a hand. “Don’t lie to me, Seren. Thane knows where I am. He helped me set this trap. He thinks you’re dead, you know.”

Seren shifted on his feet, a gamut of emotions playing across his face as he tried to figure out how to deal with me. He finally settled on pleading for understanding. I could almost taste the tang of his falsehoods tickling my bare arms. “I had to fake my own death,” he said. “I was a target, and the only way to escape with my life was to let everyone in the colony believe I was already dead.”

“Even your son?” I asked.

“Yes. Even Thane.”

“Right,” I said, folding my arms. “And who, then, has been targeting you?”

“Yes, Father,” Thane said, stepping out from behind the trees. “Who has been targeting you?”

“Son!” Seren said. “You must believe I wanted to tell you the truth.”

“I’m not sure you’ve ever told me the truth, Daddy dear. Perhaps you’d better start now.”

“I...I don’t know who’s targeting me,” he said. “All I know is I’m being hunted. Whoever it was nearly caught me in the cornfield. I’ve managed to

hide in certain places in the colony, but if I venture into the trees, he comes for me.” Seren turned to me. “You should be thanking me for trying to seek you out even at great danger to myself.”

“Really? And should I also be thanking you for bringing the miners here to destroy the planet?”

Seren looked from me to his son and his shoulders sunk. He rubbed his forehead with his hand and then sighed. “I can’t say I’m terribly surprised that the two of you figured it out. You did score the highest marks in intellect.”

Thane shifted his feet uncomfortably. He hadn’t figured it out. Neither had I. It was the trees. They were the ones who knew.

“It started before we left Earth,” Seren said. “I was contacted by the MMC, the Magnicore Mining Conglomerate. They wanted me to divert our mission from Crillian IV and promised me ten percent of their profits if I did, including safe evacuation for me and my son and reestablishment on any world of our choosing.”

Thane’s brow furrowed. “That makes no sense. If they already knew of this planet, why bother to divert a terraforming mission? In short, why did they need you?”

“Because terraforming missions have access to the top-secret biotech necessary to eliminate the natural flora of this world. As you know, the formula is a closely guarded secret, and the limited compound allotment is only to be used to clear approved areas.”

“I still don’t see why they need you,” I said. “Why not just steal our ship’s stores while we’re all in stasis?”

“There are safety protocols in place. If the compound was appropriated illegally, it wouldn’t work. Each supply is matched up with a ship and its captain. Only our ship could launch the biological control missile and only I have the codes.”

I frowned. “But what about Jaxson Preston’s compound?”

“The boy somehow managed to preserve a sample, and he created a new version—a shocking accomplishment when you consider his background. It’s too bad we had to kill him,” Seren said.

Thane and I made eye contact. He didn’t know Jax was alive.

“But why wake us up on the ship at all?” Thane asked. “You could have hovered in orbit and launched the missiles yourself.”

“That was my intention, but then Miss Meador here woke early.”

“Sorry to mess up your corporate espionage,” I said dryly.

“Your awakening almost cost me everything,” he said, ignoring the sarcasm. “Setting this up took more than three years of planning. I had to divert the ship prelaunch. No easy task, I assure you.”

“You poor thing,” I said, then heard the trees whisper words like *villain* and *monster*. I agreed. Thinking of the innocent colonists, I asked, “Couldn’t the miners just use traditional bombs to decimate the flora to get at the planet’s core?”

Seren answered, “Apparently the trees here are so thick they prevent the miners from getting to the minerals that lie beneath the soil. Traditional bombs don’t work. Only the smallest devices can penetrate the canopy. When one tree falls, it triggers the other trees to grow thicker at an unheard-of rate. By the time the smoke clears, they can’t find the opening. No. Only our chemical brand of missiles has worked on this world.”

“So what’s taking them so long?” Thane asked, making me grateful once again for his sharp mind. I hadn’t even considered that question. “Why aren’t they here already?”

“They would have been if it weren’t for Astra’s parents.”

“My...my parents? What do they have to do with anything?” I asked, reaching up to finger the necklace my mother had given me.

A horrible fear rose inside me. I wanted, no, needed to hear what he had to say about my parents, but a part of me cowered, unwilling to go back and reflect upon the loss I’d worked so hard to hide away.

“It would seem your mother, a strong advocate of preserving the natural species on planets, discovered the plot. I don’t know how she did it. She almost made it aboard the ship too. Fortunately, the MMC was able to detain her on Earth.”

So it wasn’t my fault, I thought. All this time, I’d blamed myself for my mother’s incarceration, but it had been Seren and his cohorts all along.

He continued speaking. “Though they prevented her from boarding, she managed somehow to send a message to your father even though he was already in hibernation. They must have smuggled aboard a subdermal communicator and hacked into the system. Ainsley Meador’s message triggered her husband’s early waking, and when he did, he tried to alter the

course of the ship back to Crillian IV. Because of this, the rendezvous with the mining ship was thrown off schedule.”

My heart was beating fast. My mother. My father. Both victims of this man’s greed. “It was you,” I said. “You killed my father, didn’t you?”

Seren looked from me to his son and then back to me.

Thane lifted a laser pistol and aimed it at his father’s heart. “I think you should answer her question, *Dad*.”

Seren licked his lips nervously and swallowed, his Adam’s apple bobbing, just visible above the neck of his jumpsuit. He held up his hands, pleading. “My dear girl, I...I’ve tried to make it up to you. I put you in training with my very own son. I’ve treated you fairly, have I not? Your father’s death was an unfortunate one, but necessary.”

“You’re the one who erased the vid files,” Thane accused. “How did you do it?”

“I really don’t think Miss Meador wants to hear...”

“No. I *do*. I think I need to hear from the mouth of my father’s murderer exactly how he died! You owe me at least that much!”

Rage was burning through my body. My hands shook and I felt the support of the trees around me. I could lean on them, share my burden with them if I wanted to. They understood death but not treachery. Not betrayal. They had no concept of it. For what was good for one of them was good for all of them.

“Tell her,” Thane demanded, brandishing his weapon. “What happened to her father?”

“Once...once your father woke, it triggered me to wake as well. I found him going through files and realized he’d discovered our altered trajectory. The messages from his wife told him there was a traitor on board. I tried to convince him to go back to sleep, that now that I was awake, I would handle it.” Seren turned his back to us, his hands clasped behind him. “If he would have just trusted me, listened to me, he could have gone back into hibernation and he’d still be alive now.”

“But he didn’t. He didn’t believe you,” I said.

“No. He didn’t,” Seren said almost sadly. “You must understand, Miss Meador, I didn’t want to kill him. I didn’t want to kill anyone. But I was in too deep. These people are not the type you double-cross. They would have killed me and my son. I really had no choice.”

“You always have a choice,” Thane said.

“My choices had been made long before we even left Earth. I had to follow through.”

“How did he die?” I asked in a small voice.

Seren turned back to me, an almost gentle smile on his face. “If it helps, Hudson Meador was a good man. A valued member of the crew. I regret his loss immensely.” He blew out a breath. “His death was painless. You should know that much. I dosed his drinking water with a toxic level of sleep aids.”

“The med distributor doesn’t allow for that,” I said.

“I carried pills in my personal effects. Med patches give me headaches.”

“So you must have tampered with the files to show you were never awake during the trip. Otherwise we would have seen it.” He snapped his fingers. “That’s why you never gave us access to A-level files. We would have seen what you’d done.” Thane paused, then said, “Hold on. If her father’s waking early triggered you, why weren’t you triggered when Astra woke?”

“That’s a good question, son. It seems there was a pod malfunction. Her waking wasn’t initiated by the pod. Something else woke her.”

My dreams. I remembered them now. Did you call to me when I was on the ship? I asked the trees.

Yes.

You heard us.

We needed your help.

Now I understood why I’d woken early. It wasn’t just the fact that my medicine ran out. It made sense though. The trees used the medicine to try to communicate with me. The dreams were a type of communication as well. They’d been showing me what could happen, what would happen if we didn’t stop the miners.

“And what about the other murders?” Thane asked. “Did you kill Dr. McGivers as well?”

“Unbeknownst to me, Hudson Meador managed to send a disguised message to all the mission leaders. They deciphered the encrypted message one by one and, of course, came to me with the information. Once I realized what had happened, I knew I had to stop them as well. It was me who put the cable into the reservoir, not Jax. It was a simple matter of using gloves.”

“And Dr. McGivers? How did you kill her?” Thane demanded.

“It was gloves, once again. I spread the juice from one of the toxic native mushrooms on a gloved hand and pressed it to her face. I’d hoped that Dr. Zaius would declare her death accidental since she was studying the native plants. I didn’t know the poison would mark her skin with my handprint.”

The poor woman! I thought, pressing my hands to my mouth.

“None of these details are important right now,” Seren said. “The miners are nearly here.”

“So what happens next?” Thane asked.

At the same time, I said, “Then we have to stop them from coming!”

“The signal’s been sent,” Seren replied, sighing heavily. “They might even be in orbit as we speak. As to what happens next, well, they will clear our colony out of the way and begin harvesting the minerals.”

“Clear the colony?” Thane gasped. “You mean they plan to kill everyone?”

Seren remained stone-faced.

“You dastardly coward,” Thane said, pushing the pistol hard against his father’s chest. “How could you do such a vile thing?”

“It was for you, son!”

“No. It was for yourself. You can lie to everyone else, but I know you better than anyone. That’s why you always pushed me. It wasn’t to give me a leg up, it was to move yourself into the upper stratosphere of success. I had to be perfect so someday you could ride my coattails.” Thane held out a hand. “Come on, Astra. We’re getting out of here. We have to warn the colony.”

I nodded and took his hand. There was a nasty cut on his arm, and I immediately thought of Jax heading out into the trees with his knife, then returning to say he’d cut someone watching us in the trees. Had that been Thane? I bit my lip, wondering why Jax still hadn’t returned. He should be with me at the trap. Had something happened to him? Had Thane done something?

Shaking my head, I said, “No,” and tugged my hand free of Thane’s grip. “Where’s Jax?” I asked. “What have you done with him?”

“Done with Jax?” Thane asked, a confused look on his face. “I assumed he’d be here with you.”

Was Thane as good a liar as his father? I thought I knew him, knew both of them. I took a step back. “He’s not. I...I think he’s been missing for most of the night.”

“Why didn’t you say something?” he asked.

Just then there was a hissing sound, and branches moved back and forth, creaking and groaning.

“What’s that?” Thane shouted as the noise grew louder.

“No!” Seren cried, a panicked expression on his face. “He’s found me!”

Bushes rustled and there was a screeching noise so loud I covered my ears. Something hit me hard at the base of my neck, and I heard the trees scream my name. Then the noise disappeared. The world tilted. The sky became the ground and I fell into the green canopy overhead.

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Chapter 27

Turning the World Upside Down

My head hurt. Groaning, I tried to lift it but found I couldn't. Sucking in a breath triggered a coughing fit. Dirt was in my mouth. When I opened my eyes, my vision was blurry. Slowly, I pressed my fingers into the soft soil, seeking the strength to push myself up. There was a tickling around my fingertips, and tiny worms...no...tiny roots wrapped around them gently.

I heard a faint voice in my head. *Let us help*, it said.

Yes, I replied in my mind.

The thin, fibrous roots slipped just beneath my fingernails. There was a pinch and then a numbing as the pain left me and energy filled my limbs. When I felt strong enough, I told the trees they could stop. The roots retreated back into the soil and I sat up.

What happened? I asked.

We are very sorry, the elder tree said.

I told you he was dark, another tree chimed in.

He resists our counsel.

We moved too soon.

He wasn't ready.

He was too much like us.

Who is? I asked.

Pulling my legs under me, I got to my feet. Who are you talking abo—I began to ask and then screamed.

Seren lay nearby, his dull eyes staring at nothing, a hole the size of a shuttle rivet through his forehead, oozing with green.

“No,” I whispered, crouching down next to him. My hands shook as I touched two fingers to the side of his neck. Before I even searched out a pulse, I knew the gesture was futile. He was dead. Standing quickly, I

turned in a circle. “Thane!” I screamed. “Jax!” I added, but there was no reply except for the rustling of the leaves in the trees.

Who did this? Where are they? I demanded of the trees, but before they could answer, there was a boom. The ground beneath me shook so violently I fell to my knees. The panicked trees bombarded me with so many messages I screamed and pressed my hands to my ears, though it didn’t work to block them out.

Another boom hit and another.

Pain blossomed through me as I felt each hit like a punch to the gut. What is happening? I pleaded, after falling to my knees and rocking back and forth.

Finally the voices drowned out, all except one. The elder tree said, *They are here. You must stop them, Astra Meador.*

Who is here? I asked weakly.

The miners. They begin to bomb the colony.

My heart stilled. I got quickly to my feet. I wanted to help, but there was Seren’s murder to consider along with the fact that now Thane and Jax were missing.

“I need to find my friends,” I shouted to the trees.

The son of the evil one was taken. We shielded you from sight.

“Thane was taken? Where?”

The miners have him now.

“So they killed Seren?”

No. He was already dead when they came.

My heart stilled. “What about Jax?” I asked.

Your mate is with us. He is safe.

“With you?” That news didn’t make sense but at least I knew he was safe. “Tell me what to do, then,” I said. “How can I save Thane and the rest of the colony?”

You cannot help them as a human.

Yes, another voice chimed in.

You are too weak, Astra Meador.

It is time to decide if you will join our fight. Become one of us.

“But there’s no time. The colony will be destroyed before I get there!”

We will do our best to distract them with our hybrids until you take upon yourself the mantle of power. Are you willing to do this?

Another boom shook the ground.

“Yes,” I replied, tears leaking from the corners of my eyes. “Show me what I must do.”

In reply, the brush near me shivered and parted. The leaves began to glow an eerie neon green. The trees were not only making a path for me but lighting a runway. Without giving myself time to think or doubt, I began running. My stomata opened and the green spirit of the planet filled me. It energized my body and warmed my muscles. One kilometer passed and then two. I moved faster than I’d ever been able to move before.

The booms became quieter and quieter, though I knew it was only distance that separated us. Finally, I stumbled into a clearing. It was strangely empty of trees, though the canopy still closed over the top, hiding the area from view.

A figure stepped out from behind a thick tree trunk. “Hello, Astra,” he said.

Blinking, I stared into the shadows. “Nash?” I replied. Yes. It was my lost brother. “Nash!” I exclaimed and began moving toward him, but when he strode forward, I halted in my tracks.

His expression held none of the warmth that I remembered. But that wasn’t the worst of it. Nash’s skin was mottled green and his hair, fingernails, and lips were as dark as moss.

“What...what happened to you?” I asked.

The only clothing he wore was the bottom of a jumpsuit tied about his waist with fibrous rope. It was torn off at the knees. Bristly thorns jutted out from his shoulder blades, and his chest was strong and powerful. Much more muscular than he’d been before. He wasn’t wearing any shoes, and when I glanced down at his feet, I saw his heels were cushioned with moss and his toenails were long, pointed, and sharp.

Ignoring my question and frowning at my perusal, he beckoned me closer. “Come. The trees need to change you.”

“Change? Is that what happened to you?” I asked, reaching out to touch his arm. It was waxy on top and velvety beneath, much like the leaves of my mother’s favorite houseplant. Close up, I could see his chest was almost plated. I stretched a hand out to touch his chest and then paused.

“I’m growing trunk here,” he bragged proudly, covering my hand with his own and pounding on his chest. “It’s almost as strong as an exoskeleton now.”

Drawing back my hand, I shook my head and said, “I don’t want this.”

“It doesn’t matter what you want,” he said angrily. “Gaia needs you.”

“I know, but...”

“It’s too late for buts.”

Nash pulled me, but I remained rooted to the spot. He must have seen my fear, because he relaxed his shoulders and I actually saw the spines lower and sink flush to the curve of his neck and arms.

He sighed. “I told them you’d be stubborn. You always were. That’s why I took your boyfriend for leverage.”

“Jax?” I gasped. “You kidnapped him? Is he hurt?”

“He’s fine...for the moment. But if you don’t do your part to save this world, his current healthy status might be called into question.”

I lifted my hand and slapped him across the cheek. A bruise bloomed green immediately. He grabbed my wrists, his grip as unbreakable as iron.

“Your change will be different, Astra,” he said as he dragged me. “The trees will take care of you.”

“What do you mean?” I asked, trying to distract him as I scanned the trees for Jax.

“Different because you are special. Then again, you always have been, haven’t you?” he spat.

I tripped and he wrenched me to my feet. “I don’t understand, Nash,” I said. “Why are you acting this way? You’re not yourself.”

“To the contrary,” he said, bending down to peer into my face. “I’ve never been more myself, sister dear.” When I shoved him back, he just laughed. Then he threw out his arms and spun. “On Gaia, I am finally a king. I found the home where I truly belonged. I was able to shuffle off my mortal coil, as it were.”

“You mean, you did this to yourself?”

“*Did...this?*” He waved a hand, gesturing to his body. “This, I’ll have you know, is what I’ve always been. It was inside me all along. I just embraced my heritage and the trees filled me with power.”

Speaking in my mind, I asked the trees, Why did you do this to him? Why did you help him kidnap Jax?

My brother gave me a cursory glance while a harsh new voice replied, *They* did nothing to me. I did this to myself. I can speak to them just like you can, sis.

Nash was nothing like the phlegmatic young man I'd grown up with. He seemed almost volatile.

Is what he's saying true? I demanded of the trees. Did he do this to himself? Will he hurt Jax?

The elder tree answered, *It is strange to us what happened to your brother. I fear we have driven him mad. We could not stop him from murdering the evil one, though we do not regret it. Your mate is with us. He is protected.*

I'm as sane as you are, old lady, Nash practically shouted in his mind. It's not my fault you wanted to hold back the good stuff for my big sis. I've been getting the job done, haven't I?

"You? It was you who killed Seren?" The horror I felt at seeing what my brother had turned into was nothing compared to the knowledge that he was now a killer. "What do you mean you got the job done?" I asked out loud. "What job?"

He was the one who stole the technology from your ship and integrated it into our network.

"You stole and changed the apex predators," I said.

"You bet your moon boots I did." He folded his arms across his woody chest. "I'd think you'd want to thank me," he said. "Since I saved you from Seren."

"Saved me? You murdered Seren."

Nash shrugged. "What did you think he was going to do with you? Let you marry his son and escape on the mining ship? He was a monster. Do I even need I remind you that he was a murderer? That's right. I know. I heard him confess right to your face and you did nothing about it. Did you think he cared about you?"

Nash laughed. "He would have turned against you at the first opportunity. Especially after finding out about your condition. A condition that doesn't even affect you on this planet. But you never appreciate the things you have. Oh, poor Astra has to pick between two boys. How difficult it must be for you. Poor Astra is the chosen one. The one the trees called. Did you think I didn't hear their call too? How do you think I felt knowing they brushed me aside?"

“Who brushed you aside? The trees?” I shook my head. “None of that matters, Nash. I’m afraid for you. Afraid of what you’re becoming.”

“It’s Seren you should have been afraid of. Not that he can hurt anyone anymore. Now Seren can become the fertilizer he always was. He deserved as much for murdering your father.”

“He was your father too.”

“*Was* being the operative word. The trees are now my mother and the planet core is my father. I am their dagger. I’ve pledged my life to serve them. I thought you wanted to do the same.”

“I...I do.”

“Then why do you hesitate?”

She hesitates because you are frightening her, the great tree said. *Just like you frighten us.*

They are landing, a new voice said.

We must hurry!

This must be Astra’s choice, the great tree warned Nash. *We will not force it upon her. If she wishes to have her fate tied to the other colonists, then so be it.*

“I can do this by myself!” Nash shouted at the canopy above. “You don’t need her!”

Her way will save human life, the eldest tree said gently. *Coldness fills your mind when you think of the humans. You would use us to destroy life.*

“Isn’t it natural to wish to defend yourselves?” Nash cried. “The humans are nothing to us. They are ants. They are pecking crows that destroy lush fields of corn. They’ve forgotten their origins and should be purged.” When the trees didn’t reply, he turned in a circle and continued, “I know humans. They take and take until there’s nothing left. If we let them leave, let any of them escape this world, they will spread the word like a virus, and they will come at you from every side, targeting your core. Like cancer-eating bugs, they will nibble and bite until Gaia is bleak and dusty, a barren rock in space, its atmosphere choked with smoke and fumes.”

Is what he says true? the tree asked me.

“It’s one possibility,” I admitted.

“You see?” Nash crowed. “I was right!”

“But Nash, no one in the colony understands Gaia. They look at the forests and just see alien trees. They are innocent. We can form a plan

together to stop the miners. If we trap them on Gaia, we can strand them here to live out their lives and then we can let the colonists escape on their ship. It wasn't the colonists' fault that the mission was sabotaged. They're just scientists. They've only barely learned they aren't on Crillian IV."

Nash shook his head. "They've studied the lions, the birds, the other modified animals. They'll be curious. They'll want to return. No. We can't let any of them leave."

This is a discussion best left until we have stopped the miners from damaging the planet. They have now landed. We have sent the hybrids to circle about them, but they will not last long against your weapons. You must make the choice, Astra. Will you help us or should we send Nash?

I looked at my brother, at the changes in his body, in his personality. I hesitated, thinking that maybe once I was changed, I would feel the way he did about humans. I didn't know what to do.

"Send me!" Nash shouted in an almost fiendish delight. "She can be taught to operate the technology. Change me instead."

Astra is our first choice. If she refuses, then we will consider you. Besides, either way, you will need your sister. Do not forget this.

Nash sulked at the tree's words.

There was a sort of static in my mind and a small, quiet voice said, *Do not fear. We will be with you. The cold one cannot hear us. You are our chosen. See how his anger colors his face?*

He smells like death, a new voice said.

Yes. He is like a pitcher plant. He wishes to trap humans in a slippery cone and digest them.

But he's my brother. I love him.

We know this. We love him too. He is one of us. To lose him would be to lose a part of ourselves.

But he is wrong, I said, mourning the brother I used to know.

You can fix him. When you are the queen of Gaia, endowed with our power, he will follow you.

He won't be able to refuse your commands.

But I don't want my brother to be a slave.

We do not understand this concept.

He will be one with us. One with you, instead of this...this noxious weed.

The eldest tree added, *Perhaps you will see a way to help his mind find balance, find the way to remember and embrace what he was and integrate it into what he is becoming.*

He has bound your mate, one tree said.

And are you going to use that fact to coerce me like he did?

No. Such a thing is not our way.

It is the human way.

Nash will kill him if I don't cooperate, I said, thinking of how easily Nash had murdered Seren.

We will not allow it. Your mate is safe. We know the place. We will free him as soon as Nash is otherwise engaged with you in defending the colony.

If you do this, you can help your brother. Help your mate.

Yes. Help him.

Help us.

Please.

Help us, Astra.

Could I do this? Give up myself? Bind my form to this new planet? Knowing I'd be trapped forever on a distant world, far from my home, far from my mother? A tear splashed on my cheek as I thought of my mom and I squared my shoulders. There was really only one decision.

What do I need to do? I asked.

I felt the thrill of every tree on the planet. They bombarded my mind with gratitude. The eldest tree quickly tamped it down.

She said simply, *Follow the roots.*

A path lit the way, and Nash, who'd been watching me suspiciously, suddenly smiled. "They talked you into it, then."

"Yes," I said.

"Good. Come with me."

He stayed on the lit path, so I followed him. Once we passed two trees that stood as sentinels on the edge of the clearing, he said, "Here it is."

"Here what is?" I said, turning around. "All I see is a green trunk."

The air around me shimmered and I sensed a presence, like something was watching me or breathing ominously, but there was no underbrush that would hide anything. Then I heard shifting high up in the canopy. Branches cracked and a large pod, one big enough to hide an elephant, slowly

lowered to the ground. The leafy branches lowered with it until they spread out around the pod like the arms of an octopus. A vine wrapped around my waist and took my height, calculating.

“What’s it doing?” I asked him. “Measuring me for a coffin?”

Nash didn’t answer but approached a large flower bud. Brushing his hand over the petals made it open.

“What is this?” I asked, awed as I took in the giant plant that looked like a cross between a bladderwort and a Venus flytrap.

Tucked inside the petals, I saw the quick drive. The plant had been hooked into the machine somehow. Dozens of tiny filaments from the center of the flower were plugged into it, and they pulsed with light. Nash touched a few buttons, and the lights changed from green to red to blue and then finally to white.

“There,” he said. “It’s ready for you.” His breath washed over me, a combination of sour milk and basil.

“How...how did you do this?” I asked.

“It was as easy as pi, sister dear.”

I flinched at hearing my brother’s favorite math joke when we were kids coming from the lips of the thing my brother had become.

“What’s it going to do?” I asked, swallowing.

Nash shrugged. “You saw the animals that I changed, didn’t you?”

“Yes.”

“I imagine it will do the same. Like I said, if you’re too chicken, I’m more than ready to hop in myself. All you’d need to do is press this button once I was inside.”

I looked at the button, swallowed, then glanced up again at my brother, the one who had the same moss-green eyes I had. Placing my hand on his slick arm, I squeezed it lightly and said, “I’m going to take care of you, little brother. I’m going to take care of all of you.”

He sighed heavily. “Fine. Just remember you’ll owe me a fully realized transformation after all this business with the humans is over.”

Lifting my lips in a half smile to cover my nerves, I walked over to the large pod. It opened like a giant mouth. The weight of it hung over my head ponderously, and I hesitated for a moment, thinking it would bite down on my neck like a guillotine. Inside, it was pink and yellow with a protuberance that looked vaguely like a tongue. It had a pleasant smell, a bit

like honeysuckle. Three large spikes stood out on the bottom leaf. Once I was inside, my eyes squinting in anticipation of it snapping shut, I waited for one heartbeat, two, three...

"Nothing's happening," I shouted to my brother.

"I'd think a botanist, even one in training, would know she needed to grab hold of the trigger hairs."

"Oh," I called loudly to Nash, then, mumbling to myself, I added, "Here we go."

I grabbed on to two of the spiked trigger hairs, one on either side of my body, and the pod snapped shut. There was a rumbling and my body swayed as the pod lifted into the air. I slipped down the soft petals and landed on a squishy bed in the middle. I heard Nash shout but couldn't make out what he said.

He must have thrown the switch because white light filled the pod. It was so bright I had to close my eyes. Then I felt the searing of my skin. It was on fire. My clothes melted away from my body. Blood boiled in my veins. I thrashed in pain. Automatically all the stomata on my body opened. My lungs seized completely. Tiny pins pierced my neck, and as I touched my hands to it, I felt thin fibers that were connecting me to the plant.

Thank you, Astra, I heard the trees say as one.

I wanted to respond but my mind felt fuzzy and my tongue was thick in my mouth.

Your sacrifice will be remembered, one voice said.

My sacrifice? What? What...is...happening...to me?

Pain shot through every limb and my body stiffened. I opened my mouth, wishing I could scream so someone could rescue me. The tears leaking from my eyes were hot. Save me, I pleaded in my mind.

Help me.

Nash?

Thane?

Jax?

Dad?

Mom?

But no one could help me.

I was beyond help.

As the pain overwhelmed me, a motherly voice in my mind comforted me.

It's almost over, Astra.

Then it happened.

My body exploded.

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Chapter 28

Star Struck

I was dead.

I had to be.

Nothing else could explain what I was seeing, what I was experiencing.

Colors like I'd never seen before swirled before my eyes. I flew past stars, constellations, and galaxies, my body as light as the tiniest airborne seed. The hum of all living things thrummed through my veins, soothing and sweet. I'd never felt so content. So unbreakable. So free. So perfect.

Passing a swirling nebula, I smiled, wanting to explore it, and immediately my trajectory changed. The purple eddies enveloped me, welcomed me, brushed airy fingers over my form. It was lovely. For a time, it held me close, caressing me like a womb. Then a breeze blew me out of my comfortable nest, and I floated, trailing my fingers over a pink cloud and then a yellow one as I drifted slowly between them.

I'm not sure how long I moved in that beautiful universe before I realized that the entities that so fascinated me were life-forms. Finally, a voice pierced my consciousness. It was at once familiar and alien.

Greetings, goddess, it said.

"Goddess? Is that what I am now?" I asked aloud.

Would you prefer we still use your old name?

She's much more than that now, a small green eddy said, its light sparking like a pulsar.

Perhaps she won't even remember her old life.

The parts that are important will come back.

Important? I thought. What could be more important than exploring the endless variety of beings that surrounded me? They were my family. I had come home. But no. There was something else. A tiny dot on the periphery of my consciousness. It was something...equally lovely but very different. Perhaps if I closed my eyes to the beauty around me...

Eyes... I had no eyes to close. For a moment, I panicked. Then I remembered where I was, and peace flowed through me again. Still, something niggled at my conscious. "Help me remember, then," I said to the cosmos.

Take a breath, the large purple entity said while its thin tendrils stroked my side.

When I didn't immediately understand, it pressed down upon the center of me, and hot air entered my form. It was an ugly feeling. Forced. My body heaved with the inward and outward pressure.

It's horrible! I said.

It is necessary for now, the voice said kindly. *It will help ground you.*

The colors around me blurred, and I rose painfully, kicking and clawing my way up and away from the dark bliss.

I don't want to leave, I said to the forms following behind as I headed up toward a distant glow.

We will still be here. But you must remember your purpose.

Breaking the surface, I squinted in the light and lifted an arm to shield my eyes. My eyes. I did have eyes. As soon as I realized that, I remembered. Jax, I thought. I need to save Jax.

Yes, a voice said. *You need to save all of us.*

Just then, I felt a jolt shake me and pain shot through my body. There was a screaming in my mind, and I gasped, feeling a tiny piece of me break away. Thoughts of a mortal boy were overshadowed and eclipsed. My sisters needed me. The niggling thing hovering on the edge of my consciousness disappeared.

You must hurry, goddess. They have penetrated the core.

Gritting my teeth, I rose from the soft bed. Yes, I said. I will save us all.

Raising a hand, I twisted my fingers, and the pod that wrapped around my form peeled away like a discarded skin. The life-form had fulfilled its purpose, so I reabsorbed its waning energy, thanking it for its sacrifice as I did so. The leaves withered and turned black as the waning stem lowered me to the ground.

When I stepped down, the planet Gaia welcomed me. I'd been gone too long. With my feet digging into the soil, I could sense every life on the planet, the powerful core that sustained us, and the tiny pinpricks of light spread out across the universe.

Far away, a leaf lion died, destroyed by the mortals come to plunder our world. My world. The leaf lion gave me what was left of its life energy, and its body fed the soil. Narrowing my eyes, I plunged my hands into the ground. Roots responded to me. My mind raced through the network until I found the large hole in the ground the thieves had made. I sent energy to the surrounding trees to fortify them and told them to grow their roots thick and cover the hole.

They tried to obey, but they were blocked. Every root that stole into the dead land shriveled and had to be cut off before it harmed the tree. I tilted my head and considered the chemical that harmed the roots. It had to be neutralized.

Someone approached me. Stretching my senses, I knew that he was mine. A brother. A servant.

“Come,” I said to him. “We must fight together.”

He inclined his head. I saw the bobbing in his throat that meant he swallowed, showing his nervousness. His humanness. His pupils were large as he took me in.

“Are you frightened of me?” I asked.

My brother/servant shook his head. “No. Yes. I’m awed by you.”

“And you wish to be like me?” I asked, trying to read his signals, his scent.

“Yes!” he said instantly, his face glowing with hope.

“You cannot,” I said bluntly. “There can only be one of me at a time. But if I should perish in the upcoming war and you are found worthy by then, perhaps you can take on the mantle.”

“Yes, sister,” he said.

“Prove yourself, my brother, my servant,” I replied, placing a hand on his shoulder. “Eradicate petty ambitions from your sap. Make your core as strong as the one below your feet. The fruits you have produced so far were not worthy of consumption. Send your roots deep. Become steady and immovable. Then, when the time is ripe and you no longer desire power to serve yourself but others, that is the moment when you’ll know you are ready.”

His hands tightened into fists. I felt his resistance. The digging in of his feet. But I also sensed a small rift in his soul. He could not deny the truth of my words, could not help but see the ugliness inside him that I exposed.

Only time would tell if the dark piece within him would wither or if it would grow to infect him completely.

I blew a breath over his face, giving him a bit of my own resolve and the peace of the network where I'd been born again. He settled immediately and a tiny part of me rose from the depths. She was happy to see him calm and serene as he once was. My brother/servant touched my arm, and I felt him nudge a bit of his power into me as a gift. It was one I didn't expect, at least not that soon.

"Thank you," I said, then turned to the trees.

Closing my eyes, I issued a command.

Chemical signals were sent far beneath the soil, calling the trees to war.

Clouds gathered overhead, and seeds were expelled into them where they would be carried like weapons to the battlefield. Some burned like acid while others were prickly, poisonous, or irritating enough to cause rashes, itching, or even insanity. As I ran with my servant/brother through the trees, new growth sprung forth from beneath my feet, adding to the exuberant biodiversity of the planet. The trees cautioned me to save my stores of energy, but I could no more change what I was than they could.

We stopped at a creek to draw water, stepping into the sunlight to absorb energy. When my servant/brother crouched to lift handfuls to his mouth and then saw me drawing liquid in through my legs and feet, he said nothing, though I could easily see how his pique colored his still-fragile, too-human skin.

His immoderate desire to become something he wasn't made him dangerous. I hoped time would erase the worst parts of him. He was already a destroyer of life, as I would be soon. But unlike my servant/brother, I did not kill because I was angry. It wasn't in my nature. I would only destroy to protect.

All life was precious. But it was better for the universe to jettison a few greedy men if it meant the preservation of the fount of all life. The planet Gaia was an Eden. A utopia. The loss of the origin planet would impact not only this world but all worlds. We must win at any cost. It would not be easy, but I was resolved in my determination.

We kept moving, gathering allies along the way. The larger hybrids had already been fighting, and their numbers were quickly diminishing, but now I summoned the others. Herd animals rallied to my side, heeding my call.

Purple ovine with seed puffs exploding on their backs were closely followed by lowing bovine. As they came forward, I touched them, urging them to grow larger. A distant part of my mind knew I was triggering a growth hormone. It was the first time I ever named such a thing.

Insects came forward. Giant green arachnids with spiked, mossy legs spun silk webs that were caught up in the clouds. They joined my aerial arsenal while others crawled through the undergrowth or burrowed underground, increasing in size with each step or wriggle until they became a giant army that followed behind and beneath me. Reptiles swelled our ranks as well, and when we came to the border of the human-made colony, I held up a hand. The hybrids stopped behind me, as silent and expectant as an unbroken storm, waiting for my signal.

I wrinkled my nose at the barrier. The chemical was thick and pungent. The very opposite of life-giving. When my bare feet got too close, I felt the burning on my toes. Hissing, I said to my brother/servant, "Bring me the one who created it."

"You mean your boyfriend?" he said with a slight smirk on his face.

When I turned the power of my gaze upon him, he visibly shrunk. "Yes, my queen," he said.

"And do not harm him," I added.

He slipped away through the trees as effortlessly as a soft breeze. I felt his slight footsteps on the grass as he covered the distance quickly. His movements were like a tiny tickle along the spine of my back, his footprint very unlike the planet-wrenching bombs that had torn apart the soil before me. Their weapons had left ugly, jagged wounds. Injuries that I could feel. Each blade nicking the planet pressed upon me, dug into the core of me like voracious open-mouthed ghosts. Biting. Hungry. I would make them stop. Teach the humans to walk quietly, respectfully. They would trample my planet no more.

Across the ripped, barren ground, I studied the mining ship. A huge digging contraption was being maneuvered over the wide hole. Men surrounded it like ants, shouting and gesturing to each other. Others stood over a large bonfire, and I lifted my nose, scenting the burning bodies of my hybrids. My fingers itched, the nails becoming sharp daggers, while thorns erupted on my neck and arms.

“Go,” I said to my army. “Leap the barrier that the trees cannot cross. Engage the humans, but do not kill them. We will judge each one before putting any to death. While you corral them, I will free the colonists.”

I heard the cries from the men as the army of giant insects, reptiles, and herd animals crashed through the underbrush and leapt over the barrier. Each of my children that died hurt me. The pains in my heart were as tender as a bruise, for I loved them, every single one. As I moved through the shadows, I honored their sacrifices and promised to pollinate new worlds with their seeds.

It would be an easy enough thing to do. Even if I lost each hybrid, I possessed the knowledge of the machines brought to the planet. I could replicate their forms. The human part of me basked in the wonder of it all. How glorious. How simple. How harmonious. How perfect. In contrast, the colony was a sore. A blemish. It needed to be healed.

The colonists had been crowded into the lab. The two men guarding it were nervous. They craned their necks and used communication devices to try to hail their comrades, but no one answered. I slid from shadow to shadow, changing my colors to match my surroundings. One of them finally spotted me and lifted a projectile weapon.

I raised my hands, but not in surrender.

The shock on their faces was almost humorous.

It was interesting to study them, to see how they could be perfected by tiny tweaks to their DNA. A broken limb could be replaced or perhaps additional limbs could be added. Twisted minds could be straightened. And this one's obese form would look very nice as a tuber. The other man's coltish limbs would be enhanced with certain types of ivy. With practice he could move through the trees, twining his long arms easily through the branches.

I'd wanted to talk to them, to reason with them. But they lifted their projectile weapons, fingering the trigger that armed them. They expected me to stop. To cower. Instead, they were the ones cowering. I could almost taste their fear.

“I mean you no harm,” I said smoothly.

“What...what are you?” one of them replied.

“I am the goddess, the protector of Gaia,” I answered. “I have been summoned to stop you from harming the planet.”

“There’s no such thing as a goddess,” the other one said.

“She’s a freak,” the first one whispered to the other. “She’s like those hybrid animals.”

“Better kill her before she kills us.”

Though they mentioned killing me, neither of them seemed brave enough to attempt such a thing. They stood there, weapons shaking slightly.

“Why don’t we just put her in with the others,” the second man suggested.

“You may open the door to let them out,” I said calmly.

While one man fumbled with a key card, the other stepped closer, lifting his weapon and gesturing toward the door. “Go on, get in there.”

“First I will disarm the two of you.”

I moved toward them and they backed up.

“Now stop right there or we will shoot,” a guard said.

“But I must touch you to discern your motives,” I replied.

“No one’s touching anyone.”

I pressed forward and the second man fired his weapon. A laser beam hit the exact center of my body, creating a blackened, smoking hole. Looking down at myself, I frowned. Green sap slid out from the hole and I rubbed it around the wound. Then I drew upon the energy of the planet, and the hole shrunk and then closed.

“I would prefer you not to do that again,” I said, and caught the first man’s arm. Tiny roots erupted from my nails, digging into him and pumping a calming agent into his bloodstream. The other man screamed and began firing shot after shot.

Leaving the first man standing there with a dreamy smile on his face, I lifted my arms. Vines burst from my hands and ripped the weapon from his fingers. Then, I shot two sharpened thorns from my shoulders and pinned him to the wall.

While he squirmed and writhed, I put my hand on his face, little roots penetrating his temple and nostrils. It only took a moment to read the man’s thoughts and judge him too despicable to live. He was irredeemable. Poison leaked through my hand, and when I drew it back, his flesh ripped away with it, leaving a swelling hole in his cheek. His skin turned pasty white and began falling away. I dusted the remnants of him from my hands.

His screams subsided as he collapsed to the ground.

I turned my attention to the other man, ready to assess his putative crimes. The immobilizing serum had already worn off, and he was trying to scramble away, but the aftereffects had made him clumsy. Grabbing his arm, my palm erupted in curved needles that dug into his flesh. He shrieked and ripped his hand away, tearing his skin in the process. It was easy enough to catch him again. My hair became ropy vines that wrapped around his neck, and when I touched his face, my palms seeped glue that held him fast in an inescapable grip.

My roots probed his mind, and though I found him unscrupulous and a traitor, motivated only by money, I didn't feel the need to kill him. Unfortunately, my grip on him was too strong. I'd forgotten that humans couldn't breathe through their limbs. His body slumped. Kneeling down to ease him to the ground, I promised his form would feed the network and apologized for my mistake. The glue sloughed off my hands and I left him there, moving to the locked door.

Jamming my fingers into the door, I lengthened the nails, twisting until the lock was broken. Hundreds of frightened people huddled together, some standing in groups while some sat on the floor. "You are freed," I said. "But I would suggest remaining in the building until the parlous situation is resolved. Afterward, those of you who wish to stay on Gaia may, if you agree to follow the dictates we prescribe. Or, if you prefer, your minds can be wiped of this experience and you can leave in the ship. Take this time to consider your options while I stop the men who are endangering the planet."

I turned to leave but then heard a voice.

"Astra?" the voice said.

Turning back, I tilted my head, studying the slight, dark-haired girl with her twisted braids. Just like with the men, I saw how she could be perfected if her retrograde DNA were repaired.

"You may step forward," I said.

"What...what happened to you?" she said.

"I do not understand the question," I replied.

"Umm, here," she said, reaching for a silver tray and lifting it, "look at your face."

I did as she asked and saw my form. My body was lithe and long limbed. The greenish tinge to my skin rippled in different shades when I

touched it. The long vines of hair that hung down my back moved softly, naturally lifting at the bottom, stretching toward the unseen suns. As I lifted my eyes from my reflection, I could see fear and awe mixed on their faces.

“You are Delenna,” I said, handing her back the tray.

She nodded and her eyes drifted over my form. “You’re like the hybrids,” she said quietly.

“Not exactly,” I replied.

“Well, at least you have leaves covering the important bits,” she said.

“Are not all of my...bits important?”

“Yes,” she answered slowly.

I shook my head after I felt the death of several of my creatures at once. “I must go and help the others. You will consider my words?”

When she just nodded, I said, “Good. Remain here for the time being. You will be safer away from the battle.”

Turning, I ran to the fight on the distant side of the colony. Unfortunately, my hybrids didn’t heal as easily as I did. Many of them had been killed. I directed three of my worms to dig beneath the soil and target a group of men with a large laser weapon. They immediately obeyed and a tunnel opened up under the men. Once they’d disappeared along with their large gun, I sent them after two men hiding behind their ship.

When I arrived, I threw out my arms and they lengthened into vines. They latched onto an escaping man, holding him fast while a burrowing insect clawed his way up from the ground and bit off his legs.

Pollinators swarmed, their yellow-green wings humming as they stung one man and then another. Summoning the winds, I pulled the clouds close and rained down thorny seeds and pods, releasing toxins and noxious gases that took down dozens of men. Those who were missed by the projectiles screamed when my spiders fell too. Their leafy bodies descended from the sky, and they scurried across the land as quickly as windblown leaves, capturing invaders and encasing their victims in inescapable webs.

For a moment, it looked like we were winning, but then the remaining men retreated into their ship. The hybrids banged on the metal with their heavy bodies, but they could not pierce the hull. My spiders wrapped it in webs, but blasters tore through the filaments easily enough. The projectiles bombarded it from above, but the dangerous seed pods were too lightweight to cause much damage. Those that burst enveloped the ship with fumes, but

the hull prevented the gases from penetrating. Others rolled down the metal sides of the ship, tumbling to the ground, where they lay spent.

Then the guns ceased firing. All became still. I held up a hand, and the few hybrids that remained froze in place, watching and waiting for the command to attack again. Digging my toes into the soil, I tried to speak to the network, but the signals were muted through the dead soil. I remembered then that this was why I had been summoned. The trees needed me. Needed someone who understood how to help them. Someone who could cross the barrier. They needed the power of the goddess. But they also needed...needed the mortal girl. The tiny voice inside that I'd effectively tamped down.

The door to the ship opened and a half-dozen miners stepped out. One of them was a prisoner. His hands were cuffed in front of him. His face was bruised and bloody, he was blindfolded, and he limped. The others appeared to be guards who aimed weapons at me and my hybrids.

A man stepped from behind them. He wore a patch over one eye, and old tattoos covered an arm and his neck while the other arm was a mechanical prosthetic. Lifting his metallic arm, he scratched his jaw and smiled. "Gave me a shock when I saw you, little lady. I'd like to ask you to call off your beasties, unless you want this hole in the ground to be your cairn."

"They are simply protecting their home," I said. "You are the usurpers," I added in a clipped tone.

The captive man gasped. "Astra?" he cried.

The leader of the miners looked from me to the young man. "You know this girl?" he asked.

"Yes," the prisoner replied. She's one of our botanists. She's my..." He swallowed. "Don't hurt her."

"Interesting," he said. "Wouldn't dream of hurting such an interesting creature. In fact, she'd be a nice collector's item, so to speak. Bet I'd fetch me a nice price for her."

The prisoner struggled to escape. "You leave her alone. Take me instead."

"Now you're not nearly as interesting as she is, but if you cooperate, I'll take both of you off planet. 'Ow's that for a compromise?"

The young man stilled. "And the colonists?"

“There’s no need to kill ’em all. Why do you think your father recruited so many young people?”

“W...what?” the young man asked.

“Yeah. That’s right. We spec’fiscally axed for ’em. Strong, healthy kids width good backs. I’m going to need some extra help, ya see. Why, I imagine I can use up several generations of slaves minin’ this colony.”

The young man’s mouth fell open. He struggled but a weapon was jammed into his cheek. “You’d better act a bit more diplomatic, young man, unless you want your precious science types to be killed. I don’t need all of them. Just the ones what are still fertile. If you know what I mean.” He laughed suggestively and several of his men joined in. Then he looked back at me. “As for you, you’d better call off your beasties, else I’ll put the others to death. Starting with him.”

I considered his words for a moment, then spoke. “Humans are a blight on this planet. If you wish to shrink the ranks, I won’t object over much.”

“Aw, come on now. We’re not so bad. You let the colonists live here these last months.”

“A truth that is being reconsidered at this time.”

“That so? Well, seeing as this here’s an unclaimed planet anyway, I don’t believe you have any particular right to it.”

“My claim is ancient. It predates not only you but your entire world. You will be judged, as will your men. You can take comfort in the fact that this judgment will be just, and if you are found unworthy, your bodies will feed the seeds of future worlds.”

“My body will...what? Did you hear that?” he said to his cohorts, laughing. “She thinks she can judge us, put us down like dogs. Honey, you’re either as stupid as a goldfish or as brass as a bull. I’m hoping for brass.” He ran a hand through his hair, shifting the spikes that fell back into place. “Now I say this planet and all its resources belong to me. I’ve got the weapons to prove it. What say you?”

Raising my arms, I called the wind. My green, leafy hair fluttered around me as my body lifted from the ground. “What I say,” I replied, my voice echoing as the power of the planet and all its trees filled me, “is that we are not resources. Our lives are as important as yours. I do not wish to destroy you without judgment, but I will if you leave me no choice.”

“Incredible,” the man said, staring up at me. “Ain’t she a beauty, boys?” he added, then cried out, “Last chance, little lady. I will kill this young man if you don’t cooperate.”

I looked down at the prisoner but felt only a twinge of regret. It would be sad to lose a human, but he was one among many. Power flowed through me and around me. I gathered it up like a storm, preparing to blast the humans inside the ship, killing them all in one swoop. Then a new voice cried out from behind me.

“Astra!”

Spinning in the air, I saw the bright, confused eyes of another human. He was a young man like the other one and shouldn’t have mattered in the grand scheme of things at all, but he did. The small piece inside of me that was still human burst into being. I faltered in my resolve, the power draining out of me. My heart lurched.

“Jax,” I said, and folded inward as I tumbled out of the sky toward the ground.

Chapter 29

Making a World of Difference

The hybrids rallied around my crumpled form. I didn't want him to see me. I couldn't stand to look at the horror in his eyes. The disgust over what I was. What I'd become. Sap leaked from my eyes and my powerful limbs trembled. The few brush wolves that had survived lifted their heads and howled, echoing my pain, while the trees whispered comforting messages, telling me that I was perfect. That I was beautiful. That if he no longer desired to be my mate, they could influence him should I choose.

I didn't want that.

Didn't want him to be forced to love me.

For the first time since my new birth, I felt uncertain. Confused. Ungrounded. Too human.

A hand found my shoulder. "Astra! Astra, are you all right?"

"You do not have permission to touch her, biped," my servant/brother said, wrenching Jax's hand away. "Your very presence makes her weak."

"Weak? Are you injured?"

"Injured?" my servant/brother mocked. "She's much too powerful to be injured by someone as insignificant as you."

"Stop," I murmured. "I will speak for myself."

The human side of me cringed and shied away, but I had a job to do. I put one foot under me, sending roots into the ground to steady my resolve, and then moved my other foot. When I stood before him, this boy that the human side of me loved, I raised my chin and looked him full in the eye. Inside, I shivered, knowing that the small vials of medicine he'd accepted before were nothing compared to what I was now. I told myself it didn't matter what he thought. Didn't matter at all if he accepted me. If he loved me.

He was shocked, just as I expected him to be. I braced myself for the disgust, but it didn't come. There was pity. But it was short-lived. What

remained after the gamut of emotions crossed his face was loss.

Pain shot through me, but I squelched it. Held it tight in my fist until it was a petrified knot and then shoved it deep, deep down until it was just a tickle on the edge of my mind.

“Will you help us?” I asked stiffly.

“What do you need?” he asked.

“The chemical barrier needs to come down.”

“I’ve been working on an antidote,” he said softly. “If I could access a computer and the lab...”

A voice cried out, “Well? What’s your decision? Do I start killing the colonists or are you going to cooperate?”

Turning to my servant/brother, I said, “See that he gets the things he needs.”

“Yes, my queen,” he replied, and then took the arm of the young man to lead him away.

Despondent, I closed my eyes, preparing to use my power to destroy all the humans in the ship, when someone touched my hand. It was the young man. Jax.

“Astra?” he said.

I opened my eyes and saw my green form captured in his blue-green irises. There was something warm in his expression. Something unexpected.

To my surprise, he lifted my hand to his lips, kissed my fingers, then winked and said, “Give them hell.”

He turned then and ran back toward the colony. I lifted my fingers to my mouth and smiled. The human part of me flickered and unraveled like the leaves of springtime, filling all my empty spaces. Tingling shocks ran through my limbs as the conflicting thoughts in my mind settled. Now I was what the trees had hoped to create. I was a hybrid. Fully a part of Gaia and wholly human at the same time. At once, I knew what to do.

Many years ago on Earth, humans developed monocultured crops such as corn and wheat, preferring genetically modified versions in an attempt to grow plants faster and make them more fruitful, not knowing that the green spirit, the very thing that nourished their bodies, had been destroyed in the process. They used insecticides to protect the crops, not understanding that corn full of the green spirit had the ability to signal for help—to call other insects to devour the infestation. The humans ingested the toxins they’d

used, which led to all manner of diseases. By the time they realized what they'd done, it was too late. The loss of biodiversity devastated the planet.

It wasn't their fault, not completely. They were creatures without root. Without connection. Without peace. They drifted alone—shiftless, purposeless—through the universe. Seeking the associations of long ago but remaining unfulfilled. These miners were no different. They didn't need to be judged, they needed to be planted, embraced, brought back to the fold. Once that was done, they would understand what a terrible effect their actions would cause. I didn't need to take their lives. I needed to fill them with life.

Smiling, I held out a hand, palm up, and beckoned the men in the ship to come to me. "I understand you now," I said. "You are like the mangroves that can only live in saltwater. Come to me and taste the life-giving sap that has been denied you all your lives. Let us stop this war."

"War?" the man laughed. "This is nothing more than a skirmish with the wildlife. You can't win, lady."

"I do not desire to win. I merely wish to help."

"I'm done with this conversation. Kill her."

One of the men lifted his weapon and fired. My hybrids leapt before me, taking the shots. The young man who remained a prisoner screamed and struggled, thinking I was dead, when in fact, one of my hybrids had died. I inclined my head, telling the remaining hybrids to move off. That their lives were too precious to me to sacrifice. I stepped beyond them and strode forward. One shot was followed by another and another. Each time, my body healed itself, though I did grow weaker, especially when all of them opened fire.

"What is she?" I heard one man say.

"It's impossible!" another cried out.

I reached the ground beside the open door and sent vines to wrap around the leg of one of the men. He screamed as I yanked him outside, bringing his form close so his head bobbed in the air in front of me. "Believe me when I say this will hurt me more than it hurts you." With that, I thrust him into the ground head first and sent chemicals into his body, giving a piece of my own nature to him. Soon his legs and arms stopped thrashing, green shoots sprang from his trunk and blossomed as leaves uncurled.

When I was satisfied, I reached for the next man. They were now standing immobile, their mouths open in horror. I caught another man and another, planting both of them. My power waned as I channeled enough energy into each man so that he might thrive in the deadened soil. Some of the guards grew cowardly and escaped into the darkness of the ship. It didn't matter. I'd find them later.

Then I sensed a shift. Part of the barrier had melted away.

Sisters! I cried in my mind and was relieved to feel the outpouring of love and support from the trees. Roots stretched toward me, filling the ground beneath as more and more of the barrier dissolved. They pushed out thin fingers to the newly planted men/trees, linking them into the network, and I felt the moment when their confusion became acceptance and understanding. They didn't miss the beings they'd been and accepted their new family with open arms.

Soon the only two left standing at the ship opening were the captive and the leader of the miners. His projectile weapon was pressed into the young man's side.

"What is happening?" the human captive screamed. "Astra? Are you okay?"

"I'd say she's beyond okay," the leader said. "She's taken out or scared off all of my men." He pulled the captive in front of him like a shield and said, "If you want to get to me, you'll have to go through him."

I tilted my head and said, "Do you think this is a deterrent to me? He will become one with me like the others. The green sap that colors my eyes and that of my servant/brother will fill his veins as easily as it does yours."

"Green sap?" the captive said. "What are you talking about, Astra?" He shook his head. "Look, don't harm her and we'll agree to your terms. You can keep the colonists, just ignore this little contretemps and drop me and Astra at the nearest outpost at your convenience. What do you say?"

"I'd say that you're a despicable coward, Thane. And I'd say to your captor that he can either leave in peace or he can leave in pieces. It's his choice."

The young man I knew as Jax lifted a device in his hand, his thumb hovering over a button.

"I've attached a bomb beneath your ship. Let your prisoner go first and then we'll discuss the various options that may or may not include keeping

you alive.

The man grunted, squinting his one visible eye, and then held up his gun in surrender. "Go on then," he said to his former captive. "Seems they want to keep the would-be king of the jungle alive for now." He shoved the prisoner ahead of him, and when the two were on the ground, Jax again waved the box and took the weapon from the leader.

"Release Thane from his bindings," he said.

Wrenching the young man to the side, the leader of the miners touched his thumb to the restraint and it clicked open. When the cuffs fell to the soft dirt, the young man tore the blindfold from his eyes. They landed on Jax first, then the new grove of man/trees, and last, his eyes found me. He shuffled back several feet and tripped over the ramp, falling against the man behind him.

"Astra? What...what happened to you?"

I stood there, silently watching the exchange, the ends of my hair twisting to catch the dying rays of the red sun.

Before I could formulate an answer, the larger man shoved his former captive into Jax and then thrust his mechanical arm into my torso. I could feel the jagged blade inside. He tore it from my body by cutting through my side and then stabbed me again and again. My hair flew forward, wrapping around him and wrenching him away. He screamed when I flipped him upside down and buried him in the dirt to halfway down the length of his torso.

I harbored no dislike of the man, no hate at what he'd done to me, and so I gifted him like the others, even though I knew I didn't have enough life left in me to sustain myself. Once his legs shot branches into the sky, I let go of him, my body falling limply to the ground.

Someone slid their hands under my head. It was Jax. "Astra? Astra!" he said. "I don't know how to help. What do I do?"

He pressed his hands over my seeping wounds, trying to still the warm gush of green sap.

"There is nothing you can do now," I said. "The trees can enter the colony now, thanks to you. They will roust the others and free them from their mortal shells. Your uncle will be their voice. He can tell you how to proceed. This world no longer needs me."

“But I need you,” he insisted, his eyes leaking thin streams of saltwater. “Please don’t leave me, Astra.”

Placing a hand on his cheek, I offered him a smile. “You are a rare and precious bloom, Jaxson Preston. The one I keep in my heart,” I said. “Take care of the others and remember...I love you.”

My eyes fluttered shut as I felt warm arms encircle me.

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Chapter 30

My Lucky Star

Feathery sunlight flickered across my closed eyelids. But I was at peace. Content. Still too deep in weightless dreams to even desire to rouse myself. Then I felt knuckles brush my cheek and fingertips graze my jaw.

“Astra. It’s time to wake. Come back to me.”

I groaned and fluttered my eyelids. The green canopy came in focus, as did the man’s face hovering over me.

“Where...where am I?” I asked.

“Back among the living, we hope, dear girl.”

I turned my head. “Uncle Harm,” I said, frowning slightly in confusion as my two halves reconciled the use of the biped’s chosen designation. We reached an accord very quickly. “It’s good to see you,” I added, following the standard human greeting protocols.

“You too,” the older man said amiably. “Do you remember what happened?” he asked.

Instead of answering, I struggled to sit up. Arms reached out to assist me, and I was happy to see the young man, Jax, appeared to be unafraid of my new form. My heart leapt when he touched me, though I couldn’t account for the reaction. It wasn’t mating season. Then I remembered that humans didn’t follow the same cycles as trees. They could reproduce year-round. I felt a little thrill at the idea, though I wasn’t exactly certain why. He pulled me back against his chest, providing support so I could sit up and rest my weight against him. I felt as weak as a spent leaf. “Thank you,” I said absently.

“You’re welcome,” he murmured in my ear warmly, causing all the stomata on my arms and neck to open spontaneously. The rush made me swoon heavily but Jax didn’t seem to mind supporting me.

I looked down at my body and saw the still-healing gash. “I should have perished,” I said. “How was this healing accomplished?”

Uncle Harm looked across my shoulder to Jax. “Can you bring her?” he asked.

“Of course.”

“Bring me where?” I asked.

Jax slid out from behind me and crouched down to lift me in his arms. I hissed in pain but the trees released a cloud of gas that dulled it instantly. That’s when I heard them. The trees were quietly mourning. I had assumed it was from the loss of the hybrids, but it was deeper than that. “What has happened?” I demanded as Jax carried me through the brush. If the trees heard me, they didn’t answer. In fact, they were strangely quiet.

An area of tall grasses parted, revealing a spent pod lying prone on the ground. When we approached, the plant quivered and then the leaves pulled back, displaying a limp form inside. The plant jostled in a final death throe, and a human arm tumbled out. Jax set me down beside the pod and I pushed aside the leaves to see who lay within.

A sob escaped my lips as I placed my hands on the face and gazed into the glazed-over moss-green eyes that were the exact same shade as mine. It was my... I was about to say servant/brother, but then a different name popped in my mind. The human side of me rejected that designation. Instead, I acknowledged that this was my brother. The body I held was my Nash.

“How did this come to be?” I asked, stroking the green arm of my brother and seeking a spark of life inside him. There was none to be found.

When neither Jax nor Uncle Harm answered, I asked the trees.

Tell me, I said.

He knew you were dying.

In the end, he loved you more than he loved himself.

His sacrifice will be remembered.

You mean he...he...

He gave himself for you.

The green spirit inside him now lives in you.

I don’t understand, I said. He knew my death would mean his ascension. It was all he wanted.

It would appear he wanted something else even more, the eldest tree said.

Sap slipped down my cheeks. I wiped the sticky substance away and reabsorbed it through my skin. Did you coerce him into doing this? I asked.

It was his idea, the trees replied. ***He was protecting his family.***

Ah. Now that makes sense. He was one of us. He died coming to the aid of his queen.

No, the eldest tree answered. *It was his human side that made the sacrifice. The part of him that was ours was damaged. Broken. When he saw you were dying, his birth mind surfaced. He'd promised your parents, you see. He promised them he would always watch over you. Always protect you. Even though he was younger, he took upon himself this responsibility. It was Nash who perished. Nash who died to save Astra. His sister.*

Picking up my brother's hand, I touched my lips to it and cried. This time the drops that fell on the body of my brother were a mix of salty tears and green droplets of sap. I mourned him both as a sister and a queen. When the tears were spent, I asked Jax to help me bury him.

The trees chose the spot. It was a lovely place—a cliff overlooking a great sea. The trees shifted the ground away and knit a tightly woven bed of roots. After Jax placed the body of my brother into the cavity, there was a rumbling and dirt softly slid over his form. The eldest tree talked briefly of his sacrifice and his love.

Now able to stand on my own, I held hands with Jax and Uncle Harm as the tree spoke and wondered if they understood, as I did, how my brother's memories would be stored in the network. Even now I could sense him. He was still a part of me, as were all of the fallen hybrid life-forms.

When the trees quieted, I knelt down and put my hands on the ground. Hundreds of flowers sprang into bloom. Their soft heads bobbed against my arms as they bounced on their stems. Jax plucked a yellow blossom and tucked it into my leafy hair. I was going to lecture him about killing the flower but then I felt it take root in my scalp. With a tiny pinch, it became a part of me and was delighted to be chosen to adorn the queen's head. As a personal companion, it would see the world with me—a much more fulfilling life journey that simply growing in the ground.

I smiled at Jax and kissed his cheek, then said, "Come. We must tend to the colony."

Jax twined his fingers in mine, and his uncle willingly followed me through the trees, the plants opening a path for us, and when we stepped

into the village, we found the people talking in groups with hushed tones. They ceased talking immediately upon seeing me. It took me a moment to realize they were afraid of me.

“Astra?” my former bunkmate said, approaching our small group cautiously. “What’s happening?”

“There is no need to fear,” I said, holding up my hands and projecting my voice. I paused momentarily, sending roots from my bare feet deep into the soil. The fallen bodies of the humans had been dragged into the forest and buried by the trees along with the dead hybrids. Already the roots had plugged themselves into the various crops, helping the corn, wheat, and vegetable gardens grow lush and healthy. Though the fruits took on a greenish-purple tinge, I knew they would soon be ripe and ready for consumption.

“I am sorry we had to intervene in such a violent way,” I began.

“We?” Delenna said.

“Yes, we. Meaning the trees. As you know, this world is not Crillian IV. This planet is known as Gaia. It is a special planet. One that needs protecting. That is why I was recruited.”

“Recruited?” Thane said, stepping out from a crowd. “Was this Jax’s doing? Did he force you into becoming...this?” He waved a hand indicating my form.

I narrowed my eyes. “I chose to take on this form as did my brother. Sadly, he has perished and the trees have buried him like they did the others.”

“Turned him into a tree, you mean,” Thane accused.

“No.” I shook my head. “He is buried in the traditional way of humans. The men/trees I planted around the ship are not dead. They are living. Their thoughts and dreams have been absorbed into the network. They are happy with their state.”

“Is that what you mean to do with all of us?” Delenna asked and everyone began murmuring fearfully.

“Not at all,” I said. “Those men were broken. Dangerous. It was the only way to heal them.”

“What you call healing, I call killing,” a man’s voice spoke out from a large group. There were murmurs of assent.

“Those men were going to make you slaves. They were planning to keep you trapped on this planet, mining the core, for generations. Now that has been prevented.”

“Forgive me if I don’t trust the word of tree/girl,” the man in the back said.

“Then take my word,” Thane said, turning around to face the crowd. “She’s right. My father was in league with the miners. He specifically chose young crew members. He even had me slipping the young people hormones so they’d pair off and begin reproducing.”

I spied a few couples in the crowd who’d been holding tightly to their chosen mates. When they heard this news, their bodies stiffened and they dropped hands. It was sad. Just because they’d been manipulated hormonally didn’t mean they weren’t a good match for one another. I took the opportunity to look up at Jax. He remained by my side but he wasn’t touching me. Did he suspect me? Did he think I was going to manipulate him? I wouldn’t. I could never. It would break my heart to do such a thing. If he chose to take another human as his mate instead of me, I would accept it.

The humans looked at me differently than they had before. Once, I was one of them, but now I was wholly different—a monster. They wouldn’t agree to the trees’ terms. They wouldn’t want to become hybrids. I could look at each person and easily see how tweaks to their genes would give that bald man lush corn silk hair. Another, one who was already athletic, would thrive when she no longer needed to rely on her lungs. Her fingers could send thorny spikes into the slippery mountainsides where she liked to climb.

No more would the humans need to rely on vegetation or animal meat for sustenance. All they would need was water and sunlight to grow strong and hardy. The strengths they had as humans could be parlayed. They wouldn’t lose their individuality, they would only be enhanced. Given a new point of view. How could I explain that they were just living half lives? That they only had the power to access a tranche of their potential?

I sighed. It was fear of the unknown that limited them. “Thane?” I called out. “May I speak with you?”

He came forward and said, “What do you want from us?”

The warmth and comradery I'd come to know from him had turned cold. He no longer trusted me. Didn't he see I was the same person on the inside, only better.

"I will not allow further destruction of the trees. You and your colony members have two choices. They can either submit to genetic alteration so they will be compatible with the planet like I am, or they can enter the mining ship and leave, never to return, never to tell anyone of the things they've seen here."

Thane folded his arms. "And how are you going to stop them from telling people?"

"I will wipe their minds before they leave."

His arms dropped along with his mouth. "You'll what?" he asked.

"Wipe their minds. It is a painless process. It won't affect long-term memory. I will limit it to the time they spent here."

"No," he replied immediately. "I agree to the ship. I don't think anyone wants to stay, but we're not going to allow your freakish trees to alter our brains. The Astra I knew wouldn't even think of such a thing."

Jax nudged Thane's shoulder. "Don't act like you ever knew her."

Thane snorted. "Guess you like a girl who's a little rough around the edges. Careful she doesn't poison you with her kisses, Jax."

"Shut up," Jax said, really shoving Thane this time.

"Why don't you make me, tree hugger?"

"Stop," I said. When Thane punched Jax in the mouth and Jax tackled him to the ground, I said, "Stop!" This time I picked up both of them with twisted limbs that erupted from my hands and lifted them in the air, Jax upright and Thane upside down. "Don't make me plant you," I said before dropping them both.

When Thane brushed off his shirt, still glaring at Jax, I asked, "Will you agree to these terms?"

"No," Thane replied flatly.

"Then you give me no choice. You saw how easily the miners were dispatched. I can do the same to the colonists."

Thane spat on the ground. "I can't believe I almost married you. You're not even human anymore, Astra."

"Perhaps I'm not," I replied softly. "You have until this evening to consider your options."

Turning, I headed back to the trees, Jax trailing after me. “Stay with them,” I said, turning slightly but not looking at him. “Try to help them understand. They will comply or they will be destroyed.”

“Is that what you want me to do?” he asked softly. “You want me convince them to leave? You want me to go with them?”

“Perhaps...perhaps it would be best,” I said. He stood there staring as I wound my way through the trees, my heart breaking.

When I returned at dusk, I saw Uncle Harm leading a group forward that included a lot of the scientists I knew along with my friend Delenna and a few of the paired couples. “We’ve got a proposition for you,” he said.

“You may speak,” I said, nodding.

“This lot would like to stay on Gaia, but they want to study you and the hybrids before tampering with their own DNA. If you could see your way to keeping them stocked with fruits and vegetables, they don’t mind going vegan. Would that compromise be acceptable?”

I tapped into the network, asking the trees.

“It is an acceptable solution, providing the disabling compound is never used again and the trees are allowed to repopulate the colony.”

The group conferred briefly and then they nodded. Smiling, Delenna stepped forward. “Now will you tell me what happened to you? You’re still Astra, right?”

“I am,” I said, my lips twitching in response. “But I am also a part of the network. The green spirit that fills this planet also fills me.”

Another scientist stepped closer. “Can you tell us more about this green spirit?”

Holding out my arms, I hummed, and a cloud of seeds drifted down, circling me. I held out a palm and the seed pod burst into hundreds of tiny glowing flowers. “The green spirit is the heart of the planet Gaia,” I said. “It is the source of all life in the universe. In fact, the Earth was seeded from this world...”

One by one, they sat down as I went on explaining about the origins of life in the universe.

**

The next morning, the ranks of those who wanted to stay had swelled to over half of the colonists. Uncle Harm was teaching a class on natural

medicines and what plants were good to eat. He also began teaching them how to listen to the trees.

Brush wolves and leaf lions walked freely among the colonists. They lifted paws when the scientists wanted to take small clippings of their nails or fur and quickly became adept at locating tasty tubers, digging them out of the soil and presenting them to the colonists.

It was a week before the ship was ready, and by then, the humans had already allowed me to make minor changes. Uncle Harm had been partially altered so he no longer suffered diseases. I'd given the bald man a lovely crop of springy hair. It was green and grew much more quickly than human hair, but he rather liked having that problem.

A woman with chronically dry skin let me treat her, and her new skin was not only supple and smooth but also put off a very pleasing fragrance. She didn't even mind that it was slightly green tinged. The scientists made new discoveries almost hourly and found that when they crossed into the trees and asked politely, they would be led to exactly what they were looking for.

Sadly, Thane did not approach me to reconcile. Though he didn't make trouble for those who wanted to stay, he kept his distance and, in fact, tried to leave without complying with the conditions. He, along with his group, were shocked when the ship wouldn't engage the engines.

Storming out of the mining ship, he found me, arms folded. "What do you think you're doing?" he demanded.

"Stopping you from breaking our agreement."

"What agreement? We didn't agree to your terms."

"You don't have to. This is our world. Our terms. If you want to leave, you may, but you'll not take the secret of this planet with you. Tell your crewmen to exit the ship and line up."

When he didn't move, the trees used thin filament roots embedded in the ship to fill it with gas. The crew stumbled outside and coughed.

"You are all determined to leave, then?" I asked.

They nodded, distrust in their eyes.

"Very well. Then we will begin."

Roots erupted from the ground, holding their feet in place. One by one, I touched my hands to their temples and sent tiny feelers into their brains. It was easy to take the memories. They would operate the ship as if in a dream

and come fully into consciousness once they were well away from the system. I took Thane's memories last and planted one false memory in their place. I gave him the image of his father, dying in space, the very memory I had of my own father. It was too cruel to let him remember the true way his father died, but he still needed to know that his father was gone.

The trees disabled the tracking system with tiny root filaments plugged into the ship. Now the crew would never know where they'd been or where the ship had come from. Once the job was done, the crewmen boarded the ship and the trees began withdrawing their roots.

A hand touched my shoulder.

"Do you want me to go with them, Astra?"

I turned and saw Jax. My heart froze.

"Do you wish to go?" I asked instead of answering his question.

He looked up at the ship, then shook his head. "No. All I love is here, on Gaia."

I turned away from him. "Yes. Your uncle is here."

"I wasn't speaking of my uncle. I was talking about you."

"Me? The old me, you mean."

"You're still you, aren't you?"

"No. Yes. Partly."

"Hmm, then let me ask a different question," he said, taking my hand and drawing me closer. "If you could gift me with any one of your new abilities, which one would it be?"

It was an interesting question. No one had ever asked it of me before. There was so much I could do and I'd be afraid to show the humans, to explore what I was fully. The idea of showing Jax a few of my abilities both excited me and terrified me. "Well, I can change the weight of my body so I can float up into the clouds or I can draw water into my cells from the air. Does either of those abilities interest you?"

He rubbed his jaw as if seriously considering my suggestions, but I could tell by the twitch of his lips he found my ideas humorous.

Placing my hands on my hips, I said, "What about poisoning your enemies with the touch of a finger or shooting darts from your fingernails or drawing minerals from the ground through your toes?"

"Interesting," he said, nodding his head. He captured a tendril of my hair. "Tell me how your hair works."

“The vines lengthen as needed. They’re incredibly strong and supple—”

“Good. Just like the original.”

“But”—I paused, my voice going soft—“I’m not like the original, Jax.”

“No, Astra, you’re not.”

I took a step back, thinking he must be missing the human I used to be, but he surprised me when he asked me if *I* missed the old me.

“It is difficult for me to describe how I feel about my transformation.”

“Try,” he said gently.

“It is true that I am not like the Astra you knew, but that does not mean she is gone.”

“No?”

I shook my head. “My body has changed. I know that my hair is no longer smooth and soft, but a single strand can wrap around a tree limb and carry me up into the air. It is glorious.”

“I agree.”

“My skin can breathe. I no longer depend on a machine to help my weakened body. This is a blessing. My mind can touch the thoughts of countless beings in a vast network that have awakened me to the origins of the universe. Surely, I am becoming much more than I was ever destined to be as a mere human. I think...I think I am unique. I think I am beautiful.”

My hair fluttered around me in a halo proudly as I lifted my chin, daring him to contradict my statement. I wasn’t wrong. I *was* strong. I *was* beautiful. The trees assured me of it. Inside and out I was pure and good and finally felt as perfect as Thane had always believed me to be, and yet there was a tiny piece of me that needed this young man to believe it too. I wanted him to see me the same way. To understand that I was still the Astra he’d loved but that I’d just added on a few accessories. Expanded my way of looking at the universe.

Jax looked at me a long moment but said nothing. I dug my bare toes into the dirt as if needing to root myself in the world I loved.

“I suppose I just have one more question for you then,” he said slowly. “Does the you that you are now still love me?”

The breath stopped in my lungs, more out of an old habit now than anything else. The stomata on my arms opened to compensate. “Plants aren’t capable of love,” I said, giving a scientific answer, even as I sensed the rush of sap in my veins and felt my heart stutter in response.

“Aren’t they?” he asked. Lifting a hand, he hesitated for a moment as if asking permission, then he stroked the long tendrils of my hair. It rustled beneath his fingers, and I closed my eyes as tiny rivulets of pleasure tickled my spine. My hair was now as sensitive to touch as my hands. He bent down and kissed my earlobe, and when I didn’t pull away but tilted my head instead, he trailed slow, soft kisses down my jaw. As he moved down to my neck, he said, “Perhaps I should ask the trees.”

I made a noncommittal sort of noise, enjoying his mouth caressing my neck. Then I heard him murmur against my skin. “Does Astra love me?” he asked. I was going to push him away and instruct him on how to get the trees’ attention, but my hands tightened into fists, gripping his shirt and pulling him closer.

The trees answered, ***She has loved you since you kissed her in the clearing. But she is a bit stubborn.***

I agree, a new voice said. *The girl I love is very stubborn. Lucky for her, I’m a very patient man.*

This time I did push Jax away. “How did you do that?” I asked. “You talked to the trees in the network!”

He shrugged. “I may have asked them to change me just a bit.”

“But how? Why didn’t I know?”

Jax stroked my cheek. “I wanted to surprise you. The trees helped me keep a secret.”

Tears filled my eyes. Not sap, but tears. “You...you mean you still want me? Want to be with me, like this?” I asked, stepping back so he could see all of me. “You know I can never go back to being just human.

“Astra,” he said, “you were never just a human.”

Then he kissed me and I wrapped my human arms and my nonhuman hair around him, holding him close. In my mind I heard him say, *Your mouth tastes like honey*. Then there were no words, just a feeling, a knowing that I’d found the other half of myself.

There was a buzz.

A humming in the trees.

A sigh of contentment.

And for the first time in my new existence, my life was absolutely, astoundingly perfect.

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Epilogue

The Final Frontier

Breaking News:

A mining ship was found drifting on the edge of the Titan Galaxy. There were no injuries to the crew members on board, and the ship still had enough power to get to any of the outposts in the area, but it seems the crew were all suffering from a form of shared amnesia. None of them could remember how they got on board the ship or where they'd been. The even stranger thing was the fact that the crew apprised approximately half of the crew from the missing terraforming ship, *The Venture*. There has been no sign of the ship assigned to the planet Crillian IV since their departure.

When the crew was discovered and interviewed, not one of them could remember how they woke on *The Venture*, where they'd been all those months, how they got on the mining ship, or where the rest of the crew might be. There was wild speculation among them, particularly when the ship's stores were opened and various alien fruits and vegetables were discovered along with a particularly interesting plant. Anyone who got close to the plant was attacked with long, whip-like vines.

Thane Tremere, acting as ship's captain in the absence of his father, mission leader Seren Tremere, said, "All I know is that my father died on the journey. I must have been awake on *The Venture* at some point because I remember reading the ship's log. It showed me that my father died during hypersleep and the ship ejected his body. It's terribly devastating to accept the death of my father and also realize the loss of the others. I'm just grateful that these crewmen were saved."

The alien plants will be delivered to expert alien biophysicist Ainsley Meador, who was recently exonerated from Amazonia Prison. She had been detained by authorities, accused of sabotage and smuggling, ironically, on the lost ship, *The Venture*, but her legal representative claimed that the reports filed were salacious and fabricated. Then, just six months ago, new

data was discovered. When the eyewitnesses disappeared, the charges were dismissed.

Now Dr. Meador is back at work, mourning the loss of her two children and her beloved husband. Perhaps she can use the alien plants to unlock the secret of what happened on *The Venture*. If anyone is motivated to find the answers, it would be her. For more information on this and other terraforming news, subscribe to updates at www.extraplanetaryexpansionnews.edu.

She is coming.

Yes. I can sense her.

Should we tell them?

No. We will surprise them.

They will be happy to see her.

Yes. She is their family.

Are you certain she won't reject them?

Ainsley Meador is a mother. Mothers don't reject their young.

I think she'll be excited.

I hope so.

I just hope she finds this world.

Don't worry. She carries the plant we stowed on the mining ship.

It talks to her in her dreams. It guides her.

But will she arrive in time?

Time for what?

Haven't you been paying attention, youngling? A new life is coming.

She will have to hurry.

Yes. Ainsley Meador will have to hurry. It's not every day a grandchild such as this one is born into the universe.

He will do great things.

It is not known yet what he'll be.

Who he'll be.

He'll be one of us.

Partly, but he is also of them.

Yes.

Her form is very plump.

That means he will be born soon.

Shh. Do you hear that?

What am I listening for?

....

....

It's so tiny.

Who is it that speaks?

Let me try. What is your name, youngling?

....

....

I...I am...I am Aether.

....

Welcome, young one.

Yes. Welcome.

Welcome!

Hush now, sisters. We must try to keep quiet. For his sake.

For his sake.

Don't expend your energy just now, youngling. You'll need it very soon.

Yes, rest.

Sleep.

He sleeps now.

Should we tell her?

No. Let him meet his parents the normal way for his kind.

You're assuming he will be their kind.

I never assume.

The next few weeks will prove very exciting, won't they?

Yes, the eldest tree said. Very exciting, indeed.